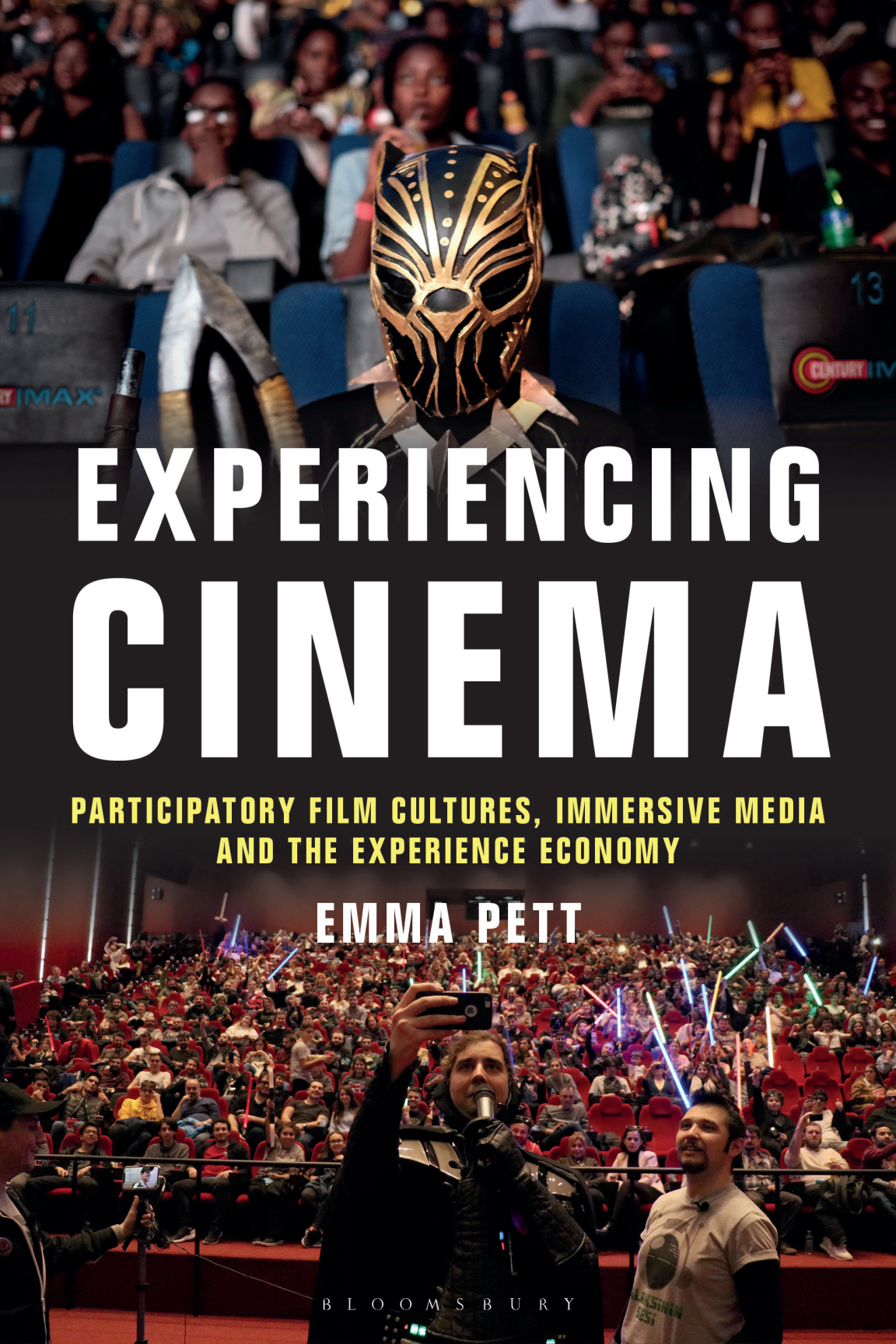


EXPERIENCING CINEMA

PARTICIPATORY FILM CULTURES, IMMERSIVE MEDIA AND THE EXPERIENCE ECONOMY

EMMA PETT

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Experiencing Cinema

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Participatory Film Cultures, Immersive Media and the Experience Economy

Emma Pett

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Introduction

Experience, immersion and participation

To posit that cinema provides audiences with an experience might seem like a truism that requires no further discussion, let alone merits an entire book. There already exist countless studies of cinema-going experiences across a diverse range of historical periods, geographical locations and sociopolitical contexts. This book, however, does not offer a study of cinema-going culture within the conventional context of a daily or weekly film programme screened at a purpose-built cinema or theatre. Instead, it examines people's experiences of engaging with a range of unconventional, bespoke forms of film exhibition that proliferated across the global north during the years immediately preceding the COVID-19 pandemic of 2020.[1] From the growth of grassroots screen cultures to pop-up cinemas and high-end interactive productions of blockbusters, the diversification of the film exhibition sector during this period is a notable phenomenon that merits further investigation of its audiences. This book argues that the concept of an exceptional, alternative or unique 'experience', be it social, sensory, embodied or cultural, was central to this development in the exhibition sector. It therefore investigates what this 'experience' means to audiences across six key sites of participation, analysing primary and secondary data gathered across a spectrum of twelve principle case studies, ranging from highly commercial productions to non-profit community cinema networks. This investigation is framed by a wider consideration of how the concept of an 'experience' has been discursively constructed and circulated, in marketing materials, industry reports, online reviews of events, cultural policy documents and manifestos within the non-profit sector.

The six key sites of investigation within this book are indicative of the diverse range of exhibition spaces and practices inhabited by contemporary forms of immersive and participatory cinema. Part One of the book investigates immersive cinema produced within a commercial context, and the case studies have been selected either due to their status as popular texts or because they

were exhibited at high profile venues involving prominent marketing campaigns. Chapter 1 examines audience responses to commercial forms of experiential pop-up cinema, focusing primarily on case studies within a British context. These include big-budget blockbuster productions staged by Secret Cinema (*Back to the Future, The Empire Strikes Back* and *Blade Runner*) and seasonal immersive productions such as *The Snowman Experience*. This is followed by an investigation of audiences for VR, AR and MR cinema in Chapter 2, focusing on three case studies which exemplify the diversity of experiences within this burgeoning sector of the entertainment industry: The Void's *Secrets of the Empire* (a *Star Wars* VR experience), the Taiwanese CVR feature film *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2019) and the Canadian AR animation *Draw Me Close* (Jordan Tannahill 2017). In Chapter 3 the analysis shifts to the art gallery, and an investigation of visitor responses to the blockbuster moving image installation *The Clock* (Christian Marclay 2010), a live art installation offering a participatory form that was exhibited at Tate Modern, UK, from September 2018 to January 2019.

The second half of the book primarily examines not-for-profit, grassroots exhibition cultures and practices, which I am terming the alternative screen experience economy. Chapter 4 examines the growth of experiential cinema in a rural context, focusing primarily on case studies in the global north as this culture is not well established elsewhere. This is followed in Chapter 5 by an examination of activist exhibitors, and participatory cinephilia focused on two case studies: the Scalarama film festival held every September in the UK and the cinephile scene centred around Scala cinema in Bangkok, which both involve activist cinephilia in contrasting ways. Finally, Chapter 6 explores cosplay and crossplay culture as a form of embodied experience, or lived cinema, across a range of specialized and everyday cultural contexts.

The analysis of these twelve case studies is informed by a reconsideration of Pine and Gilmore's 'experience economy' model (1998, 1999), alongside a range of intersecting theoretical approaches for investigating neoliberal cultural policy and its impact on film exhibition cultures. These are introduced later in the chapter and are followed by a discussion of some of the key terms used throughout this study. The diversification of exhibition practices outlined earlier has brought into circulation a vocabulary for describing audience engagement with cinema that now frequently displaces the more traditional descriptions of 'viewing' or 'watching' films; cinema-going can be 'immersive', 'interactive', 'participatory' and, perhaps most frequently, 'an experience'. This chapter

therefore sets out to identify and unpack some of the discourses surrounding the use of these terms, as a preliminary to investigating what these cinematic experiences mean to audiences, participants, performers and users alike.

First, it investigates *cinema as experience* in two ways: by considering discourses circulating around the live/mediatized experiential binary and how these can be understood in relation to immersive media; and by investigating the implications of cinematic experiences moving out of designated auditoria and the formal exhibition circuit into non-theatrical spaces and alternative exhibition sites. Following this discussion of cinema as experience, there is an examination of *cinema as immersion*, identifying the apparently contradictory range of experiences that are most frequently categorized as 'immersive', and investigating these in three ways: their contexts of exhibition, the kinds of technology they employ and the experiences of their participants. Third, there is an examination of *cinema as participation*, which charts the way that historical forms of participatory cinematic experience have evolved and considers some of the key issues emerging around motility, privilege and civic engagement. Finally, this chapter offers an overview of the data collected for this study, the methodology employed to gather and analyse it and some brief chapter summaries.

Rethinking the experience economy

When economists Pine and Gilmore developed the concept of the 'experience economy' (1998, 1999), their primary objective was to theorize a model for selling products and services as experiences. This was framed as a historical shift away from a service economy towards one in which experiences are understood as a distinct and primary form of economic offering (Pine and Gilmore 1999: xi). As a theoretical approach developed by business studies scholars, it is unsurprising that *The Experience Economy* advocates the selling of experiences within a neoliberal economic framework. The model centres on the concept of staging an experience, and their initial explanation is littered with examples from film, television and theatre. This is, as they acknowledge, because the entertainment industry is already part of an experience economy:

> Experiences have always been at the heart of the entertainment business – a fact that Walt Disney and the company he founded have creatively exploited. But today the concept of selling an entertainment experience is taking root

> in businesses far removed from theaters and amusement parks. (Pine and Gilmore 1998: 99)

In this respect, cinema and other similar cultural forms predate and complicate Pine and Gilmore's notion of a historical shift from service to experience economy; the film industry has always been an experience economy and was not a new development in 1998. While Pine and Gilmore's theory explains changes in the market for ordinary 'non-experiential' products and services, it does not fully account for those which have, historically, been marketed as experiences. Furthermore, Pine and Gilmore do not fully interrogate the creative production of what adds value to the marketing of those experiences, namely the production of creative content. However, putting these issues to one side, the timing of the initial publication of *The Experience Economy* (1998) is significant, in that there are a number of parallels between Pine and Gilmore's model and the 'creative industries' policies ushered in by governments within the global north, such as the UK's New Labour administration of 1997. While the experience economy is an economic model rather than a set of cultural policies, both developments have evolved within an emergent neoliberal culture and are exemplary of many of its instrumentalist characteristics.

Situating cultural policy within a neoliberal framework is problematic, in that neoliberalism is an evolving ideology which informs a wide and highly differentiated range of policies, cultural initiatives and economic strategies. In *A Brief History of Neoliberalism* (2007), David Harvey defines neoliberalism as 'a theory of political economic practices that proposes that human well-being can best be advanced by liberating individual entrepreneurial freedoms and skills within an institutional framework characterized by strong private property rights, free markets and free trade' (Harvey 2007: 2). Definitions such as this have been critiqued as essentialist and problematized for the way in which concepts such as deregulation, privatization and globalization are often taken as monolithic 'givens' (Jessop 2013: 65; Springer 2015: 5). The slipperiness of neoliberalism as a concept thus creates some significant challenges to any analysis of the creative industries or the experience economy within this context. However, this does not mean that such an analysis should not be attempted. This chapter now briefly maps out two key moments in neoliberal governance that have shaped the creative industries in the global north, and how these intersect with the experience economy and issues pertinent to this study.

The first of these moments is the coining of the term 'creative industries', denoting an instrumentalist approach to state funding of the cultural sector. In the UK, this was introduced by New Labour's creative industries mapping documents, published in 1998.[2] These documents define specific sectors of the creative industries within an economic framework, identifying their potential to boost the British economy. New Labour's creative industry policies were published in the same year as Pine and Gilmore's *The Experience Economy*, and the parallels between these two publications are substantial. Both focus on the commercialization of creative talent to increase profit, whether it is for individual businesses or the national economy. Nicholas Garnham contends that the introduction of the term 'creative industries' in 1998 signalled New Labour's embrace of the neoliberal transition from state to market in relation to the funding of the cultural industries; he argues that the creative industry policies were firmly focused on job creation and potential export earnings within the global marketplace (Garnham 2006: 28). This shift in government policy is also evident in other countries across the global north. In a 2008 study, Sofie Birch examines the relationship between academic and political definitions of the terms 'experience economy' and 'creative industries' in six countries (the UK, New Zealand, Singapore, Norway, Sweden and Denmark), establishing a set of correlations between the use of the two terms in a range of policy documents (Birch 2008: 35). Birch notes the imprecision and overlap between their uses and observes a tendency for policymakers to use 'creative industries' in relation to production and 'experience economy' in relation to consumption (Birch 2008: 15).

A second key moment and policy shift in the evolution of neoliberal cultural governance in the global north was the implementation of austerity measures following the global recession of 2008. The instrumentalist approach towards the creative sector developed by New Labour continued to dominate government policy until the economic crash of 2008, when austerity politics were introduced, and the sector was subjected to widespread cuts. Cultural geographer Jamie Peck has coined the term 'austerity urbanism' to problematize this situation in a North American context (Peck 2012, 2014). For some working in the community sector there was an inclination to view post-crash cultural politics as an opportunity to move beyond being positioned as 'the third sector' and to become a more prominent player; these arguments are evident in the case studies explored in Chapter 4.

Despite the flaws identified in Pine and Gilmore's model, its zeitgeisty resonance means it has increasingly been taken up both within the academy

and in the public discourse of popular media commentaries. Unsurprisingly, it has gained most traction in the overlapping fields of tourism studies and museum studies, where the concept of staging an experience has proved 'very valuable within the context of visitor economy' (Dieck, Jung and Rauschnabel 2017: 44–5). Scholarship on film festivals has also drawn widely on Pine and Gilmore's economic model. In their study of visitors to the Pusan International Film Festival in October 2009, Park, Oh and Park employ Pine and Gilmore's model to interpret their empirical data gathered on the event, constituting 510 questionnaires and a number of personal interviews. They conclude that the 'tourist experience is not pre-framed by certain destination attributes, but dynamically interplays with destination offerings. Thus, tourist destinations or attractions including festivals should diversify offerings to make the tourist experience multi-faceted' (Park, Oh and Park 2010: 49). Studies such as these highlight the significant role played by distinctive geographical spaces within the experience economy, which is investigated in relation to museums and rural locations within Chapters 3 and 4.

Beyond these fields of research, scholarship within film and media studies has been slower to take up the Pine and Gilmore's model in a meaningful way. Atkinson and Kennedy briefly outline the experience economy in their introduction to *Live Cinema* (2018: 7), as does Lesley-Ann Dickson in the same volume (2018: 83), but they tend to acknowledge the contemporary relevance of Pine and Gilmore's model rather than applying or expanding it in new ways. More pertinent to this study is the emergent field of transmedia tourism, an area of scholarship developing around the intersection of popular culture and the tourist industry. This scholarship combines debates surrounding fan studies and convergence culture (Jenkins 2006) with Pine and Gilmore's economic model. Ross Garner defines transmedia tourism as 'the range of processes and practices by which media(ted) content flows into the tourism sector and involves special attention being paid to how myriad media forms, platforms and technologies are harnessed to assist in the production, consumption and negotiation of these experiences' (Garner 2019a: 1) and argues that, as a theoretical development, transmedia tourism offers an approach for analysing both physical and digital spaces derived from media franchises alongside each other (2019a: 2). The analysis of these co-existent physical and digital spaces in the context of an established media franchise forms one of the three case studies analysed in Chapter 2, which investigates participant responses to The Void's *Secrets of the Empire*, a *Star Wars* VR experience.

Another significant take up of Pine and Gilmore's model is in the sphere of marketing discourse; this is particularly notable in the context of the cultural experiences of the millennial generation.[3] A post on lifestyle website *Refinery29*, for example, observes that

> they call it the Millennial Experience Economy, or MEE, a very on brand way to describe the larger phenomenon that keeps building on itself. According to a recent Eventbrite study on the topic, nearly 7 in 10 (69%) millennials experience FOMO. In a world where life experiences are broadcasted across social media, the fear of missing out drives millennials to show up, share and engage.[4]

This article is one of many that highlight how the experience economy is apparently booming among the millennial generation.[5] The data underpinning this discourse is derived from two surveys[6] of US millennials which establish that

> millennials (ages 18-34) now represent one-third of the national population, and continue to be the driving force behind the growing attendance at a diverse range of live events. This generation looks to live experiences for solidarity and as a form of expression; 9 out of 10 Millennials (89%) have attended at least one live event within the past 12 months, significantly up from just three years ago (82%) . . . when deciding how to spend their money, 3 out of 4 choose to buy an experience rather than something desirable.

These findings resonate with a similar set of data gathered by a report on Live Cinema conducted in 2016, which indicates that experiential cinema was most popular with under-thirty-fives.[7] The traction this term has accrued within a specifically generational context suggests it might have some newfound currency, albeit in a reconfigured form.

By investigating these current uses of the experience economy model, this book therefore makes sustained use of Pine and Gilmore's approach, considering, first, its relation to commercial immersive cultures and, second, identifying the way its essentially neoliberal concept has been appropriated and reconfigured within the non-profit sector. Taking this as a lead, the second half of the book maps out what I am calling the alternative experience economy in relation to two intersecting fields: community or grassroots cinema networks and a reconfiguration of alternative film exhibition, investigated through the case study on Scalarama.

Through an analysis of the empirical data gathered in relation to these exhibition sites, the second half of the book argues that cinephile cultures within the non-profit sector can facilitate an experiential exhibition space where

contemporary forms of political engagement flourish, thus constituting an alternative experience economy.

Cinema as experience

The concept of liveness is central to the experiences discussed in this book and is increasingly relevant in a (post-)pandemic society reconfigured around virtual spaces and forms of communication. The pre-pandemic case studies investigated here blur the boundary between live and mediatized experiences in multiple ways, not least in complicating the distinction between audiences and performers. Scholarship investigating audience experiences in relationship to discursive constructs of the live/mediatized binary is therefore a key focus throughout this study (Atkinson and Kennedy 2016, 2018; Auslander 1999/2008; Barker 2003, 2011; Hills 2015). In *Liveness* (1999/2008), Phillip Auslander addresses the issue of live performance within a mediatized culture. Drawing on Baudrillard's definition of mediatized, Auslander discusses instances of 'mediatized performance', understanding this to mean performances that circulate as recordings, on television or via other forms of technology, as opposed to the live performances in theatre and on stage. Auslander proceeds to complicate this reductive live/mediatized binary by interrogating the nuanced ways in which these two frequently overlap, for example, at rock concerts, in law courts and other contemporary environments. His study is useful in the way it acknowledges the coexistence of live and mediatized performances in many cultural spaces, and the co-presence of audiences and performers in producing the live experience (Auslander 2008: 61). However, because the study is limited to a consideration of historically dated and conventional performance formats (theatre, film, music concerts, etc.), Auslander does not address the multiple ways in which this binary has been further complicated, for example, in the different degrees of liveness now offered within virtual spaces. Other cultural developments have also extended the parameters of this debate, for example, the way in which audiences appropriate and 'make real' mediatized performances and characters, at live events or through established performative practices such as cosplay; very often, these live performances are then remediatized and recirculated online, and in some cases, the images are once again translated into a live performance. This cultural productivity

around (re)mediatized performances is analysed in the context of cosplaying cultures in Chapter 6.

In an audience study of a 2001 theatrical production of David Cronenberg's *Crash,* Martin Barker observed that, for his respondents, 'the meaning of "liveness" is made apparent by its opposite: for those who take up this position, it feels natural and inevitable that screened images should leave you "distanced", while staged ones make you feel part of the event' (Barker 2003: 26), and concluded that one of the ways audiences value the liveness of theatre is in comparison with the mediatized experience of cinema. While various developments in the entertainment business (live streaming to cinemas, VR theatre, experiential cinema, etc.) have since rendered this distinction dated, the analysis of audience data in the book remains highly significant in identifying a specific public discourse that continues to circulate. A recent industry report on the event cinema sector in the UK examined the ways audiences value this kind of cinema and concluded that

> the key themes identified are: liveness, participation, appreciation of excellence, specialness, and involvement. Notably, 'liveness' and 'specialness' are attributed more so, but not exclusively, to the theatre experience. In this context, 'liveness' relates to physically being in the same space as the event, whereas for cinemas it is associated more with having a shared experience with other audience members, either within the cinema or the theatre being viewed.[8]

These conclusions echo Barker's 2003 findings, suggesting that many audiences continue to equate liveness with theatre; the analysis of data in this book will therefore be attentive to ways that this live/mediatized valuation of experiences manifests, and how this frequently resonates with high/low cultural distinctions. Barker also critiques Auslander's conception of the term 'liveness' for the way it devalues 'technological intervention, rather than as, for instance, a mode of participation, a sense of shared purpose. It denies the possibility of heightening participation through technological means' (Barker 2003: 35). These observations usefully highlight the implicit value Auslander attributes to a particular iteration of liveness. Barker's intervention here, and contention that technology can be understood differently, through notions of participation and technological innovation, is particularly pertinent to the case study on Christian Marclay's *The Clock* in Chapter 3.

The concept of liveness in relation to the moving image remains a shifting terrain in film and media scholarship. Barbara Klinger argues that 'liveness

penetrates the mechanical and otherwise mass mediated arts [and] cinema has always included it as part of its medium specificity and of the experiences it offers audiences' (Klinger 2018: xv); this is discussed in relation to liveness and presence in Chapter 2. In their introduction to *Live Cinema* (2018), Atkinson and Kennedy outline the various ways the term 'Live Cinema' has been understood and circulated, both within the academy and the industry. In this context, they argue for a broad conception of the term that includes extensions 'such as shifting from live to "living" cinema' (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 3), thus opening up the category to encompass participatory cultures such as cosplay. A more nuanced interpretation of liveness is also advocated by Matt Hills in relation to television, in which he argues that live broadcasts of television shows in cinemas, framed by live Q&As with the audience, confer an 'auratic value' on these events (Hills 2015: 95); this form of liveness has become increasingly visible in pandemic media culture and the marketing of repeats through live introductions or tweetalongs.[9] Hills's argument is also relevant to the contextual framing of many pop-up cinema events as live experiences, as discussed in Chapters 1 and 4, where analyses of audience responses to Secret Cinema productions, *The Snowman Experience* and the Scalarama festival highlight the complex interrelationship between the live and mediatized components illustrated by these case studies.

Pop-up cinema exhibition culture offers a contradictory pattern of co-existent live and mediatized experiences that, in part, acknowledges recent cultural shifts towards demediatization. Academic analyses of this trend have mainly focused on discourses around unplugging and digital temperance movements (Rauch 2014; Brennen 2019). Practices associated with these discourses include digital fasting, which Rauch suggests 'spring perhaps from a sense that humans are guilty of impure mediated actions and must periodically atone through cleansing, like the prescribed remedy for Original Sin' (Rauch 2014: 246). These discourses around demediatization are particularly relevant to some of the live experiences discussed in this book, such as the events organized by Secret Cinema which do not allow mobile phones into the exhibition space, as already briefly discussed by Atkinson and Kennedy (2017), and which are considered in Chapter 1.

Understanding the live/mediatized negotiations involved in experiential media consumption is further complicated by the fact that, in many respects, cinema has already relocated itself outside of the designated auditorium, on public screens, mobile devices, computer screens and tablets (Klinger 2007: 282; Allen 2012: 42). It is for this reason that Francesco Casetti argues that 'cinema is

not only a "machine": it is also an experience in which other factors – cultural, social, aesthetic – play a role' (Casetti 2015: 24). The recent proliferation of non-theatrical and alternative cinematic experiences that cater to an increasingly fragmented film-going market have been linked to technologically driven changes in media exhibition, circulation and consumption (Kehoe and Mateer 2015: 100; Aveyard 2016: 2; Hill 2020: 3). These 'roaming audiences' (Hill 2020: 1) include a diverse, intergenerational range of participants, from early-adopter urban hipsters to DIY rural communities. The rapid expansion of immersive cinematic events in the global north can therefore be understood within wider discussions circulating around the de-centring of the film text and the shifting dynamics of the experience economy and its technological enablers. However, as Annette Hill notes, there are significant economic constraints involved in this emergent culture, and 'not everyone has the resources (money, time, skills, support) to experience a streaming, play all mode of engagement' (Hill 2020: 4). This study therefore attends to these contemporary shifts in modes of film consumption and how they intersect with different cultural and geographical spaces, generational aptitudes and economic restrictions.

Many of the case studies discussed in this book (though not all of them) take place outside of conventional auditorium spaces and, from an industrial perspective, belong to the non-theatrical sector. The study of non-theatrical exhibition sites has, to date, been considered in four distinctive ways that are useful to this study, many of which have been researched within the field of new cinema histories (Maltby, Biltereyst and Meers 2011). First, in a historical context, some studies have focused on the diverse locations film was exhibited in its early history before the development of purpose-built cinemas and theatres. Experiential cinema can be understood within the context of early film exhibition cultures located at amusement parks, where many 'novelty' films of the era were exhibited (Dobryden 2014; Gunning 2004; Wasson 2007). Film scholars such as Alison Griffiths and Haidee Wasson have considered how these para-cinematic sites of amusement were forerunners of today's immersive, transmedia worlds in relation to a range of issues surrounding new technologies, film genres, social class and audience protocol (Griffiths 2003, 2008; Wasson 2007, 2011). Much of this research can be broadly situated within the academic field defined as new cinema histories (Maltby and Stokes 2007; Maltby et al. 2011). It has been well documented that non-theatrical exhibitions are not limited to cinema's early history and have continued throughout the twentieth century until the present day (Chanan 1976); Ella Harris's recent study of contemporary pop-up cinema,

for example, draws out the parallels between the Floating Cinema's boat and historically mobile sites of pre-cinematic and cinematic exhibition (Harris 2018: 66). This historical approach therefore offers a useful way of understanding the subject matter of this book, from the investigation of the role played by distinctive spaces in shaping audience experiences in relation to pop-up cinemas in Chapter 1 to the evolution of art gallery installations in Chapter 3, and the alternative spaces inhabited by participatory cinema-goers in Chapter 5.

Second, and perhaps most commonly, 'non-theatrical' is a term applied to the non-profit exhibition sector, which is discussed in Chapters 4 and 5. A third form of non-theatrical exhibition which has recently become the focus of a renewed scholarly interest is research undertaken on rural and community cinema-going (Bowles 2012; Aveyard 2015, 2016) and discussed in Chapter 5. Finally, non-theatrical exhibition sites are often taken to mean 'bedrooms, living rooms, kitchens, automobiles' (Allen 2012: 42) and are framed within discussions around the consumer shift to 'roaming audiences' (Hill 2020: 1) viewing films on mobile devices. As Barbara Klinger notes, 'for audiences, ambient [non-theatrical] exhibition settings operate very much like their theatrical counterparts, acting as "signal systems", environments that shape audiences' dispositions towards media texts through various cultural and institutional cues' (Klinger 2007: 282). This approach is useful for examining the mediation of live events through mobile devices, discussed in Chapters 1, 4 and 6.

Through investigating the expansion and diversification of the non-theatrical sector alongside the contemporary reconfiguration of the live/mediatized binary, this book therefore repositions the experience economy within the global north as a bespoke, living culture that spans the commercial, mixed model and non-profit sectors, and is characterized by a sociable, often interactive or immersive character that holds a strong appeal for the millennial generation. This chapter now turns to consider the concept of the immersive in relation to contemporary film culture.

Cinema as immersion

Concepts of the immersive are invoked to categorize and market a wide range of contemporary cinematic experiences, and their contexts of usage therefore vary greatly. Cultural policy reports and industry documents in the UK tend to employ the term 'immersive' to technologically enabled encounters involving virtual or augmented reality, as discussed in Chapter 2.[10] In this context,

immersive media is frequently framed within a discourse problematizing the social use of emergent technologies, as evidenced by the *Immersive and Addictive Technologies* report published by the UK's Department for Culture, Media and Sport (DCMS) in 2015.[11] This report defines immersive media as technologies 'which integrate virtual content with the physical environment, thus "immersing" the user in a simulated experience. The term often refers to technologies such as virtual and augmented reality, which offer varying levels of immersion in digital worlds.'[12] Similarly, Immerse UK, a non-profit network whose membership includes organizations from the industry, academia and the public sector, defines immersive media as that involving 'high-end visualisation, virtual, mixed, and augmented reality, haptics and other sensory interfaces with data'.[13] While there is a marked contrast between the tone of these two reports, the first cautionary and the second celebratory, they both nonetheless situate immersive media squarely within the tech industry. Furthermore, a parallel field of academic study mirroring this industry-policy usage of the term has evolved, and is discussed in Chapter 2 (Bucher 2017; Lombard and Jones 2015; Jones and Dawkin 2018; Mateer 2017); collectively, these technologically framed definitions constitute the most common current usage of the term 'immersive media' across the intersecting spheres of industry, academia and cultural policy.

Uptake of the term 'immersive' within the commercial sphere, however, is much more varied and includes the interactive blockbusters staged by Secret Cinema, as discussed in Chapter 1.[14] This case study draws on parallels with immersive theatre, in which participants are invited to break the 'fourth wall' and enter the fictional space of the play; scholarship on this theatre genre is most frequently discussed in relation to productions staged by the British theatre company Punchdrunk (Alston 2013, 2016; Biggin 2015, 2017; Machon 2013). In this context, Rose Biggin defines an immersive experience as 'a graded, fleeting and intense and necessarily temporary state defined by an awareness of its temporal and spatial boundaries' (Biggin 2017: 1). While these differing contexts for understanding cinema as an immersive experience might, at first glance, appear to be quite distinct, Biggin's definition of theatrical immersion bears many similarities with those discussed in Chapter 2 of this book, which investigates encounters with technologically enabled immersive experiences. Furthermore, both forms of experience involve participant 'interactivity' with the fictional word, in that they make creative choices determining the way the experience unfolds, and both use technological enhancements, albeit in significantly different ways. This introduction therefore seeks to establish the

overlaps and commonalities between these two common usages of the term 'immersive media', as well as the key differences and points of contestation in the discourses surrounding them.

A feature common to both VR/AR experiences and Secret Cinema productions is their interactivity, and the discourse surrounding this textual feature of immersive storytelling is a contested one. Cultural policy documents problematizing immersive media frequently focus on interactivity as the key feature of these virtual reality technologies that poses a social risk. For example, the DCMS report states that

> we have considered the links between immersion and the power of a technology to capture people's attention or influence their behaviour. In evidence to us, representatives of the games industry repeatedly drew parallels between gaming and other absorbing hobbies such as reading or watching television. However, we would argue that games are inherently more immersive than such activities because their interactivity means players actively shape their own experience.[15]

The report thus conceives computer games and associated media to be more inherently interactive than other 'absorbing hobbies'. It is worth investigating, then, what is meant by the term 'interactive' within this discourse. In her research on interactive documentaries (i-docs), Sandra Gaudenzi contends that 'interactivity is a way to position ourselves in the world, to perceive it and to make sense of it' (Gaudenzi 2013: 70), thus equating it with concepts of user agency. Scholarship on digital storytelling tends to be more specific, most frequently conceiving interactivity as a two-way form of communication. Chris Crawford, for example, defines interactivity as 'a cyclic process between two or more active agents in which each agent alternatively listens, thinks and speaks – a conversation of sorts' (Crawford 2012: n.p.). For this reason, an affective response to a film, however powerful, constitutes a reaction rather than an interaction. Marie-Laure Ryan expands on this basic definition, contending that

> the two sides can be two human minds, as in conversation or oral storytelling; they can be, more metaphorically, an agent and the world as a whole, because the world 'kicks back' when the agent performs an action; or they can be a human and a programmable machine, because such a machine can simulate a mind or a dynamic environment. (Ryan 2011: 35)

Ryan then outlines five levels of interactivity according to the degree of user agency that can be identified within digital narratives; these offer a useful

model for assessing the forms of interactivity offered by different kinds of immersive experience and will be discussed in Chapter 2 in relation to the three case studies. There is a broad consensus across literature in this field, however, that interactivity is not inherently digital, and functions within storytelling formats beyond the spheres of computer games and VR/AR technologies; it is this meaning of the term 'interactive' which will be employed throughout this book.

The discursive position adopted in the 2015 DMCS report also points to another key debate in the study of interactive media. Having conceived interactivity to be a quality primarily associated with digital media and the games industry, the report then quotes a computer programmer who states 'I strongly believe that games are an interactive medium because of the way that we engage with them and they are a lot more active than TV or movies or whatever that are a bit more passive'.[16] Through invoking an active/passive model for understanding audience interaction with fictional worlds, the discourse articulated throughout the DCMS report thus conflates the active/passive model for interpreting audience engagement with fictional worlds with the interactive/(re)active dichotomy adopted in digital storytelling research, which scholars within this field observe to be a common misconception (Crawford 2011: n.p.). The implication of this reductive approach is that because most television programmes are not interactive (*Black Mirror: Bandersnatch* offering one obvious exception) they therefore constitute a passive form of entertainment, rather than a potentially (re)active one.

The recourse to a passive/active model of interpreting audience behaviour is also invoked more broadly around discussions of immersive media. Existing theoretical frameworks for understanding forms of immersive cinema have frequently theorized them from an historical perspective. Grau (2003) and Griffiths (2003, 2008) both contextualize the recent phenomena of interactive media and its associated technologies within a broader framework of developments in panoramic spectatorship. Early cinema scholarship offers an alternative history of moving image narrative and storytelling techniques, interpreting them as a series of technological advancements in the quest to create the perfect illusion of an all-encompassing fictional space. In this respect, technological developments such as 3D and Smell O' Vision are valued as important steps towards this primary goal, rather than being dismissed as gimmicky anomalies (Grau 2003; Holmberg 2003), and VR technologies are a logical next step towards achieving this aim.

A final set of debates around immersive media examines the processes of mental absorption and emotional investment in the film's narrative world. Grau argues that immersion is a mentally absorbing process of transformation, from one state to another, which is characterized by a decreased sense of critical distance, and a corresponding increase in emotional investment (Grau 2003). The concepts of critical distance and closeness are both pertinent to the discussion of presence in relation to VR/AR technologies, as discussed in Chapter 2. However, while Grau's definition might sound convincing, there is minimal empirical data on this subject. As Victor Nell observes,

> neither attention studies nor psychophysiology have been able to distinguish between absorption and entrancement or to show why some reading merely absorbs us while other kinds of reading matter work the far stronger spell of entrancement, transporting us to other places and transfiguring our consciousness to make other people of us. Entrancement exercises this power not only through reading but through many other everyday experiences, such as dreaming, being lost in one's waking moments, going to a movie, or listening to a story. (Nell 1988: 199)

Differing forms of mental absorption have also been discussed by several scholars in relation to the 'distraction' of 3-D and 4-D cinema which, although designed to enhance audience interaction and immersion within the film's narrative, can sometimes produce the opposite result (Sandifer 2011: 69; Klinger 2011: 424; Griffith 2008; Ross 2015). These debates raise issues around the question of how audiences immerse themselves in technologically facilitated narratives; a further area this research sets out to consider, then, is whether spectacle functions as a disruption to narrative immersion for the audiences attending The Void's *Secrets of the Empire*, the CVR film *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2019) and the AR animation *Draw Me Close* (Jordan Tannahill 2017).

To date, audience research on VR, AR and MR experiences has primarily been undertaken in the field of psychology. These studies frequently focus on concepts of presence, empathy and agency as approaches for understanding and interpreting audience experiences of these technologies. In Chapter 2, I consider a range of recent empirical studies and data generated by research on the uptake and use of VR, AR and MR, and problematize the way in which participatory and social forms of immersive cinema have been understood as being distinct and separate from technologically enabled forms of immersion, such as those typical to VR experiences.

Cinema as participation

Early studies of participatory cultures within the intersecting fields of media and cultural studies focus on pre-digital fan cultures (Bacon-Smith 1992; Jenkins 1992) and are often characterized by an almost utopian concept of participatory cultures as those 'which transforms the experience of media consumption into the production of new texts, indeed of a new culture and a new community' (Jenkins 1992: 46). Since the 1990s, the growth of participatory cultures enabled by the internet has facilitated a broader field of research, encompassing the involvement of 'average citizens' in 'the archiving, annotation, appropriation, transformation, and recirculation of media content' (Jenkins 2003: 552). A white paper proposed by Henry Jenkins and colleagues at the University of Southern California in 2006 identifies a number of key characteristics common to participatory cultures, which include (i) relatively low barriers to artistic expression and civic engagement, (ii) strong support for creating and sharing one's creations with others, (iii) some type of informal mentorship whereby what is known by the most experienced is passed along to novices, (iv) members believing that their contributions matter and (v) members feeling some degree of social connection with one another (Jenkins et al. 2006: 7). These characteristics, particularly (i) and (v), are examined in relation to both the commercial and grassroots participatory cultures investigated throughout this book.

While it might seem obvious to describe engaging with film as an *experience*, to undertake an investigation of *participatory* cinema may seem an equally contradictory endeavour. Watching a film is often considered to be a solitary, personal experience, whether at home or in a darkened auditorium. In her study of film as installation art, Catherine Elwes contends that

> If artists hope to induce in their audiences an embodied knowledge of their situated place within a gallery, then the medium of moving image would appear to be the natural enemy of installation. Moving images are moulded to the shape of absent or imaginary beings signalling from elsewhere in time and space, from a dream world with no obvious causal link to the setting in which they are presently manifest. (Elwes 2015: 1)

For Elwes, moving image appears to be intrinsically antithetical to the aspirations of installation art, in that it transports audiences to a different spatial and imaginary dimension. While acknowledging these discourse circulating around spatial determinism, this book instead investigates a development

in cinema exhibition that functions in almost precisely the opposite way to Elwes's definition of the moving image. Participatory cinema forges innovative connections between the moving image, the audience and the exhibition environment; participants are invited to interact and engage with the liveness of the cinematic experience.

Alison Griffiths sounds a note of caution about over-emphasizing a linear or causal relationship between historical antecedents and current forms of participatory and interactive cinema, arguing that they have always coexisted historically and 'talk about one spawning the other is ridiculous' (Griffiths 2008: 41). Instead, Griffiths outlines an extended history of moving image spectatorship which moves away from established models involving the seated spectator in the darkened auditorium, focusing instead on ways in which audience mobility within the viewing space is a key factor shaping the interactive. This issue raises a key paradox in relation to participatory cinema, in that it constitutes an inherently privileged exhibition format that frequently excludes certain social groups. As Kirsty Sedgman notes in her research on immersive theatre, 'those with increased "motility capital" are able to capitalise on the value of such experiences, while others inevitably lose out' (Sedgman 2017: 166). These issues are also relevant to issues of audience engagement with participatory cinema and will be considered in Chapters 4 and 5.

While the physicality of certain viewing protocols offers one approach to investigating participatory cinema, modes of resistance provide another. This section of the chapter looks at recent developments in participatory culture and how they are shaping the contemporary exhibition landscape. These are framed within a brief reconsideration of cinema as both counterculture and subculture, and the significance of the distinction between the two. In the latter half of the twentieth century, participatory cinema has frequently been associated with cult cinema and the midnight movie phenomenon. Cult favourite *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* (Jim Sharman 1975) continues to be screened as an interactive event for cinema audiences, albeit in a more commercialized manner than was the case in 1970s New York, and often as part of a themed experience.[17] E. W. Nikdel argues that exhibitors such as Secret Cinema successfully draw on the cultural heritage of cult cinema as a means to revitalize aspects of participatory behaviour that once characterized midnight movie audiences. However, while there are clearly commonalities between Secret Cinema and participatory forms of cult cinema in terms of alternative viewing protocols, I contend that the intrinsically commercial nature of the brand is fundamentally at odds with

the low-budget economics, transgressive politics and resistance to 'mainstream' culture which more frequently characterizes the cult cinema exhibition circuit.[18] In this respect, community-driven festivals such as Scalarama offer more resonant parallels with the participatory legacy of cult cinema, and these are discussed in Chapter 5.[19]

The collaborative organizational structure of festivals such as Scalarama highlights the recent revival and growth of the community sector in cinema exhibition. This revival can be framed within a broader shift towards the expansion of community media across the last two decades. Recent scholarship on participatory media has often focused on digital culture and social media (Jansson 2017; Jenkins et al. 2016; Milner 2018). Milner examines the importance of internet memes in participatory culture, arguing that while memes once circulated primarily among subcultures and niche interest groups, they are now a mainstream form of participatory culture. Bridgette Wessels, however, critiques this focus on digital culture as a primary site for participatory culture and problematizes the observation that 'the transition from an industrial society to a digital networked society means that many forms of civic engagement from the industrial period no longer seem relevant' (Wessels 2018: 1). Wessels contends that neoliberalism has resulted in a less centralized and directive form of government that is disengaged from the realities of daily life, and that as a result many people feel it no longer represents them. However, rather than dismissing digital culture completely, Wessels balances her critique with a discussion of the ways that social media enable civic participation, for example, through community action groups who organize using social media, such as 38 Degrees and Occupy Wall Street. However, Wessels argues that while these groups have multiplied online, it doesn't follow that civic engagement has increased; rather, it means that there is greater diversity in the types of participatory action, and that meaning of 'civic' is obviously shaped by particular communities and their agendas. The case studies investigating participatory and community-driven forms of immersive cinema in Chapters 4 and 5 address many of these concerns, offering new insights into the ways that digital culture can enhance and facilitate contemporary forms of civic culture and community engagement.

While Wessels and others consider the role and reach of digital culture in facilitating participatory cultures, Bart Cammaerts argues that alternative and community media has been overlooked and displaced by an over-emphasis on the significance of the internet. This has, he suggests, often led to a blurring of distinctions between alternative channels of distribution, alternative content

and alternative forms of organization. The internet, Cammaerts argues, offers alternative distribution channels and platforms, but these are not always utilized for the distribution of alternative content and are more frequently co-opted to promote mainstream content. Instead, Cammaerts suggests alternative forms of community media such as print cultures, visual culture such as street art, and more established media forms such as radio and film can continue to sustain a grassroots ethos. Thus, Cammaerts advocates the need for more research focusing on the enduring significance and role of non-internet media that functions to produce and distribute alternative, counter-hegemonic content (Cammaerts 2016: 1–2). Nico Carpentier similarly draws attention to collaborative organizations and social movements that use a range of media to advocate their end goals and calls for further research in this area that positions community media as a link between state and market (Carpentier 2016: 5). This is explored further in Chapters 4 and 5, which investigate community media within the context of rural, community and cult film exhibition networks.

The recent upsurge in grassroots and community organizations can also be considered in a more overtly political context. Jeremy Gilbert contends there is a long tradition of writers and thinkers on the left who have argued that radical politics can be invigorated and energized by forms of cultural collectivism, such as festivals and raves. Such cultural forms, Gilbert argues, can promote a 'collective joy' that is effective in 'overcoming the alienating individualism of capitalist culture'.[20] This ethos informs the politics, arts and music festival *The World Transformed*, which has run in tandem with the annual Labour Party Conference since 2016 and is part of what Gilbert describes as 'acid Corbynism', a movement with 'a radical democratic agenda promoting a vision of a twenty-first century socialism based on principles of co-operation, collaboration and experimentation' (Gilbert 2017, 2019). The evolution of new forms of creative collectivity, alongside a celebration of countercultural experimentation of the 1960s, forms a significant broader context and backdrop for the 2018 Scalarama season, as discussed in Chapter 5.

These community-driven grassroots contexts for understanding contemporary forms of participatory culture offer an alternative perspective on the development of immersive cinema-going, which is more frequently located within the commercial sphere. By examining facets of immersive participation across a spectrum of commercial, mixed model and non-profit exhibition models, and considering audience engagement with high-end participatory VR experiences alongside low-budget or no-budget community cinema-going

cultures, this book therefore identifies and analyses a broader experiential turn in contemporary cinema exhibition across the global north.

Data and methods

The idea for this book originated in the audience research I started in 2014 on Secret Cinema, which was chiefly preoccupied with the way that the brand had commercialized a participatory form of cinema-going previously associated with the cult cinema circuit (Pett 2016). As this commercial form of immersive cinema became increasingly popular, however, I simultaneously became aware of similar developments in film exhibition emerging within the non-profit sector, partly through my involvement with Community Screen Forum from 2015–16.[21] This, in turn, led to an interest in the way that cinematic 'experiences' were being discursively constructed, valued and marketed across a range of cultural contexts, in both the commercial and non-profit sectors. While this book is ostensibly concerned with cinema exhibition and reception, it moves beyond the confines of the black box to consider the intersection of cinema-going cultures with theatre, art galleries, the heritage sector and fan conventions. In doing so, it offers an interdisciplinary approach to the study of experiential cinema that draws on scholarship from theatre studies, cultural geography, economics, tourism studies, politics, art history and fan studies.

The object of this study is primarily the audiences, users, consumers and performers of an increasingly diverse sector of the industry, that of immersive or live cinema. To develop a singular methodological approach for investigating this subject would be to overlook the multifaceted ways in which these audiences engage with, participate in, interact with and immerse themselves in experiential cinema. For this reason, the study adopts a pragmatic and flexible approach to the subject matter and draws from a wide range of primary and secondary sources in order to undertake this investigation.

First, there is the primary data gathered directly from the audiences, users, visitors and cosplayers who were interviewed and surveyed between 2014 and 2019, in the years immediately preceding the worldwide closure of cinemas during the 2020 global pandemic. This takes the form of 96 semi-structured interviews (appendix 1) and 452 survey responses (appendix 4), as well as my own auto-ethnographic accounts and participant observation at most of the events discussed. The methodological approach involves participant-orientated

and context-dependent tactics for gathering a broad range of material, and as a result interviews are conducted at the exhibition sites, in nearby locations and via telephone following the events. The interview data set does not attempt to offer a representative sample of audiences engaging with these forms of immersive cinema cultures but reflects a cross section of participants which correlate with larger surveys conducted on audiences for live cinema.[22] While the case studies selected for this book do not map onto the remit of these surveys precisely, they offer an approximation of the audience composition; for example, as in the larger survey, there is a higher percentage of female interviewees than male, though this varies across the case studies and reflects the gender composition of the audience at events attended during the field research (appendix 1, figure 1). The age range of the interviewees is presented as percentages of four generational categories: generation Z, millennials, generation X and baby boomers (appendix 1, figure 2).[23] This approach to categorizing the age of the research participants is primarily adopted to enable a clearer investigation of the millennial experience economy and of the way broader shifts in audience behaviour are frequently framed in relation to generational consumption habits within public discourses.

The qualitative material drawn from these interviews is selected, first, to reflect a demographic cross section of the participants and, second, to illustrate the key discursive patterns that emerged through their 'talk'. The quotations identify the interview schedule and question number.[24] The primary data is supplemented by a range of secondary sources, including 403 reviews, 18 interviews and 8 industry reports. Together, these sources are analysed to investigate what an 'experience' means to participants, how they understand the concept of 'liveness' and how they value these events. Alongside this study of audience responses, there is an examination of how discourses around the concept of an 'experience' are circulating across a range of promotional and industrial texts. The methodological approach for gathering data therefore constitutes a layered analysis across multiple sites of distribution, circulation, exhibition, performance and audience engagement as a means to facilitate a complex, multifaceted investigation of the subject.

Six sites of audience engagement within this sector have been selected, as outlined later. These were chosen to create an intersecting range of case studies, from the most commercial forms of immersive cinema, such as Secret Cinema Presents, through to the most rudimentary, DIY iterations of the sector. The spectrum of exhibition and performance sites chosen heightens the potential for this study to capture the complex ways in which these discourses circulate across

and between different economic models of immersive cinema. These materials will be analysed using a moderate social constructivist approach to discourse analysis (Höijer 2008), with the aim of developing insights into people's values, experiences and identities through the language they use.

Chapter summaries

Part One of the book investigates immersive cinema produced within the commercial context of the experience screen economy. Chapter 1 examines audience responses to commercial forms of experiential pop-up cinema, focusing primarily on case studies within a British context. The primary data is comprised of twenty-six interviews with participants and five interviews with industry personnel. Analysis of this data focuses on issues around nostalgia, seasonality and the significance of the millennial experience economy. These are interpreted within the broader framework of the neoliberal environment, which I contend facilitates the pop-up screen sector in three distinctive ways. In doing so, I argue that this development forms part of a broader experiential turn in cinema exhibition, extending beyond the parameters of the millennial experience economy established in the 2016 Harris Report, that can be characterized as intergenerational rather than generational.

Chapter 2 examines audiences for VR, AR and MR cinema by focusing on three case studies which exemplify the diversity of experiences available in this burgeoning sector of the entertainment industry. The data examined includes 14 interviews, an auto-ethnographic account and 226 reviews. The chapter examines issues of presence, empathy and agency as approaches for understanding and interpreting user experiences of these immersive technologies. It argues that participatory VR experiences can facilitate social interactivity and intergenerational bonding and draws of the parallels between liveness, or simultaneity, and presence.

In Chapter 3 the focus shifts to the environment of the art gallery, and an investigation of visitor responses to the blockbuster moving image installation *The Clock* (Christian Marclay 2010). Marclay's cult montage is a live art installation that cannot be watched online or purchased for domestic consumption; it exists only in the form of a hard drive in tandem with a computer program, which synchronizes the projection of the film with the time zone of the art gallery it is located in. As such, this case study offers a

live, participatory form of cinematic experience within a specific institutional context. The research analyses four principle sources of data: an online quali-quantitaive survey which captured 452 responses from visitors to *The Clock* at Tate Modern; a set of twelve semi-structured interviews, conducted with people who participated in the survey and volunteered themselves to be interviewed; my own participant observations drawn from three visits to the exhibition, including the twenty-four-hour screening in December 2018; and thirty-four of the many professional and citizen-critic reviews of *The Clock* available online. This case study, I argue, demonstrates an appetite for cultural events that reconfigure or subvert established viewing protocols for watching films across a range of cultural spaces.

Part Two investigates immersive cinema and participatory culture in the non-profit and community sector. Chapter 4 examines the growth of experiential cinema in a rural context, focusing on case studies in the global north. This is considered in three principle ways: first, at a grassroots level, where mobile and community cinemas have developed participatory film nights that attract cross-generational audiences; second, in the context of the heritage sector, which capitalizes on a mutually beneficial relationship with the local tourist industry to produce pop-up cinema in a range of unusual locations; and third, through an examination of the more upmarket, festival-inspired aspect of the rural sector, focusing the case study of Picnic Cinema. This is achieved through the analysis of a set of twelve semi-structured interviews and several comprehensive industry reports on the sector. The case studies suggest that rural immersive cinema attracts cross-generational audiences, both familial and community-wide, in a way that more traditional rural cinema-going cultures have not experienced in recent decades. This chapter thus offers further evidence of the experiential turn within the landscape of contemporary cinema exhibition, echoing the findings on pop-up cinema in Chapter 1.

Chapter 5 examines activist exhibitors and participatory cinephilia by focusing on two case studies: the Scalarama film festival held every September in the UK and the cinephile culture surrounding Scala cinema in Bangkok. Drawing on over sixty interviews (both primary and secondary) with exhibitors and participants involved with the two case study institutions, it interrogates how contemporary cinephile culture facilitates political activism in these two case studies from the global north and global south. This chapter argues that these specialized, participatory forms of film exhibition can facilitate a lively, dissident space where contemporary forms of political engagement thrive and

activist cinema is sustained and promoted, thus constituting an alternative experience economy.

Finally, Chapter 6 explores cosplay and crossplay using a mixed-method approach that includes participant observation at a number of fan events, a reception study of cosplay at Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back* and twelve interviews with crossplayers in the United Kingdom and the United States. The data is used to investigate three key areas. First, it considers how the practice of cosplay has become increasingly visible in wider cultural contexts, focusing on the concept of everyday cosplay, and argues that the degree of participant engagement with costuming does not, as some scholars have argued, reflect the depth of emotional investment in the practice. Second, it considers how cosplayers negotiate the live/mediatized divide, mediating and remediating their performances both on and offline. While amateur cosplayers are preoccupied with their performative identities and interactions with other cosplayers, I argue that professional cosplayers are more likely to embody the entrepreneurial tactics associated with neoliberal experience economy. And third, this chapter examines gender-flipped and gender-bent crossplay culture and contends they offer a politicized form of cosplay in three distinctive ways.

Through investigating these six key sites of audience engagement, this book interrogates the concept of an exceptional social, cultural, sensory or embodied 'experience' within the film exhibition sector. The analysis identifies an experiential turn in cinema-going cultures, primarily across the global north, whereby commercial and alternative screen experience economies have both flourished, facilitating the development of a diverse range of bespoke exhibition practices. While an experiential turn has been discussed at length in the fields of art history, sociology and economics (Hantelmann 2014; Pine and Gilmore 1998, 1999; Schulze 2008), it has received relatively minimal attention from film and television scholars. Dorothea von Hantelmann argues that 'art's "experiential turn" – and the new focus on the perceiving, experiencing subject that comes with it – resonates with the fundamental economic and cultural transformations of Western bourgeois-industrial societies in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries' (Hantelmann 2014: n.p.). More specifically, she argues that an increased wealth and leisure time mean that 'for the individual in the advanced affluent society, aesthetic criteria, such as quality and intensity of experience, have become a main point of orientation' (Hantelmann 2014: n.p.). Taking my cue from Hantelmann, this study situates the experiential turn in cinema as emerging primarily in the global north from

the late twentieth century onwards, and developing in tandem with neoliberal cultural policies.

This experiential turn is charted and analysed across the twelve case studies as a means to establish the primary characteristics and commonalities between them. The study investigates the extent to which this is a generational phenomenon, particular to millennial experience-seekers, or whether it can instead be situated within a more substantial cultural shift, characterized by a preoccupation with unique experiences as markers of a meaningful existence within affluent societies. Finally, in the Conclusion, I reflect on this now historical, pre-pandemic moment of cinematic culture, and contemplate the unexpected ways in which the concepts of liveness, immersion, participation, simultaneity and the broader audience experience have been disrupted and reconfigured by the 2020 global pandemic.

Notes

1 Examples of these bespoke events are documented in detail in relation to the UK market in the 2016 report produced by Live Cinema, found at: http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf (accessed 12 July 2018). Academic research also indicates some parallel developments in North America and Europe (Klinger 2018; Levitt 2018; Vivar 2018). Although I include some case studies of experiential and immersive cinema from Thailand and Taiwan, it would be misleading to position these as central to this study, which primarily focuses on this culture in the global north.

2 These are comprised of thirteen separate documents for Advertising, Antiques, Architecture, Crafts, Design, Fashion, Film, Leisure Software, Music, Performing Arts, Publishing, Software and TV & Radio, found at: https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/creative-industries-mapping-documents-1998 (accessed 27 October 2018).

3 Three key reports on this phenomenon are Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf, Eventbrite's 'The Experience Movement: Research Report' on 'How Millennials are Bridging Cultural & Political Divides Offline' (2017) found at: https://www.eventbrite.com/l/millennialsreport-2017/ and Big Red Group's 'The "Experience Economy": Riding a Rise Tide' (2019), found at: https://www.thebigredgroup.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2019/05

/The-Experience-Economy-Riding-a-rising- tide-white-paper-by-the-Big-Red-Group.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).

4 Article by Mariah Smith, 'Dog Party Planners & Bridesmaids For Hire: Meet The Operators Of The Millennial Experience Economy' found at: https://www.refinery29.com/en-us/2019/06/229287/millennial-experience-economy-trend-jobs (accessed 16 August 2019). See also the concluding comments in https://www.theguardian.com/business/2019/sep/29/experience-economy-peaky-blinders-friends-stranger- things (accessed 22 February 2020).

5 This was first widely reported following the 2016 study by Eventbrite/the Harris Group: https://www.cnbc.com/2016/05/05/millennials-are-prioritizing-experiences-over-stuff.html; https://relate.zendesk.com/articles/millennials-driving-experience-economy/; https://www.eventbrite.com/blog/academy/millennials-fueling-experience-economy/ (accessed 12 February 2020).

6 See Eventbrite's 'The Experience Movement: Research Report' on 'How Millennials are Bridging Cultural & Political Divides Offline' (2017) p. 4: https://www.eventbrite.com/l/millennialsreport-2017/ (accessed 12 February 2020).

7 Data available at The Live Cinema website: http://livecinema.org.uk/about/what-is-live-cinema/ (accessed 20 September 2019).

8 'Understanding the Impact of Event Cinema: An Evidence Review' (2015) found at: https://www.bfi.org.uk/sites/bfi.org.uk/files/downloads/bfi-understanding-impact-event-cinema-evidence-review-2015.pdf (accessed 2 September 2019).

9 These live tweetalongs were popular during the initial stages of lockdown in April 2020, for example: http://www.david-tennant.co.uk/2020/04/doctor-who-lockdown-live-tweetalong-for_24.html (accessed 12 May 2020).

10 The Void markets their company as 'the most immersive virtual reality experience ever' at https://www.thevoid.com/ (accessed 16 January 2020).

11 https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184602.htm (accessed 24 February 2020).

12 https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184604.htm#_idTextAnchor003 (accessed 24 February 2020).

13 Reference taken from the Immerse UK website found at: https://www.immerseuk.org/ (accessed 22 February 2020).

14 Secret Cinema market their company as specializing in 'immersive cinema experiences' at https://www.secretcinema.org/ (accessed 16 January 2020).

15 See report *Immersive and Addictive Technologies* report, no page numbers on document: https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184604.htm#_idTextAnchor003

16 As above.

17 An interactive sing-along screening of *Rocky Horror* was recently part of the Halloween 2018 programme at the Prince Charles Cinema in London, and was also marketed as a pop-up experience at the Rivoli Ballroom in South London.
18 For a more detailed discussion of the characteristics of cult cinema and its relation to mainstream film culture, see Mathjis and Sexton's *Cult Cinema: An Introduction* (2011), pp. 2–3.
19 More information on Scalarama can be found at: https://scalarama.com/about/ and is it is discussed as a case study in Chapter 5.
20 Jeremy Gilbert, 'Psychedelic Socialism' in *Open Democracy*, 22 September 2017. Found at: https://www.opendemocracy.net/jeremy-gilbert/psychedelic-socialism
21 Community Screen Forum (CSF) was set up in 2017 to represent organizations that promote, support and enable community screen experiences in rural and under-serviced parts of the UK. Members include Arts Alive, Flicks in the Sticks, Carn to Cove, C Fylm, Creative Arts East, Village Screen, Driftwood Cinema, INDY Cinema Group, Live & Local, Big Picture Show, Moviola, Cine North, NEAT Flicks, FilmLincs, Open Cinema and Regional Screen Scotland. While not all organizations are exclusively rural, collectively they are the largest organization to represent the rural film exhibition sector in the UK. For further information please visit: https://www.uea.ac.uk/community-screen-forum/home
22 For example, the audience data collected for the 2016 Live Cinema report found at: http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf
23 None of the interviewees fall into age categories outside of these four generational brackets. The parameters of each category, determined by date of birth, were developed after consulting various mainstream contexts of usage in order to capture the way the terms have been broadly adopted. For example, at: https://www.pewresearch.org/fact-tank/2019/01/17/where-millennials-end-and-generation-z-begins/ and https://www.independent.co.uk/life-style/generation-definitions-what-am-i-millennial-generation-x-y-z-baby- boomers-golden-age-young-old-a8679741.html (accessed 23 February 2020).
24 For example, if an interviewee responds to the first question on the interview schedule for pop-up cinema (appendix 2), they are referenced: Interviewee 1; A2, Q1).

Part One

Live cinema, pop-up media and the experience economy

1

Immersive cinema-going and the pop-up economy

And then she saw that there was a light ahead of her; not a few inches away where the back of the wardrobe ought to have been, but a long way off. Something cold and soft was falling on her. A moment later she found that she was standing in the middle of a wood at night-time with snow under her feet and snowflakes falling through the air.

The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe, C. S. Lewis, 1950

Introduction

Cinema as a cultural form is always already temporally limited and thus lends itself well to ephemeral spaces and transient exhibition formats, such as festivals and pop-up film experiences. While open-air and drive-in cinemas date back to the early twentieth century (Levitt 2016; Nowell 2016; Church 2020), pop-up cinemas incorporating participatory elements into their event design have become increasingly ubiquitous throughout the cities of the global north in the early twenty-first century (Lashua 2013; Harris 2016, 2018). In London, the prototype pop-up exhibitor, Secret Cinema, began operating in 2007 with a screening of Gus van Sant's *Paranoid Park* (2007) staged in the vaults of London Bridge.[1] Several academic studies have already documented how other pop-up exhibitors quickly followed suit, incorporating elements of spectacle, interactive performance and participatory theatre into the exhibition of films (Atkinson and Kennedy 2015, 2016, 2018; Pett 2016, 2018). Indeed, the sector expanded rapidly in the UK, resulting in what Atkinson and Kennedy dubbed the 'Summer of Live' in 2015 (Atkinson and Kennedy 2016: 140), and shows little sign of abating. Secret Cinema's global multi-title partnership with Disney, along with their recent foray into immersive television, indicates that screen experience

economy is still expanding.[2] This chapter examines the contemporary pop-up screen sector in the UK and argues that it constitutes an 'experiential turn' in cinema exhibition which extends beyond the parameters of the millennial experience economy established in the 2016 Harris Report.

In the UK, pop-up cinema forms part of a recent trend within the exhibition sector for one-off, unconventional cinematic events, in what has variously been described as 'event cinema' (Follows 2018) and 'live cinema' (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018), and within an industrial context, 'immersive cinema'.[3] An independent survey of the event cinema exhibition market in 2017 revealed that

> In the early 2010s, the UK event cinema business grew at breakneck speed. In the five years between 2008 and 2012, the sector grew fourfold. However, over the past few years, we've seen a levelling off of revenues, at around £33m a year. . . . In 2017, event cinema releases grossed £32.4m, more than crime movies, thrillers, biopics, romances and documentaries. (Follows 2018: 1–2)

While this survey also includes the screening of live-streamed events to cinemas, which complicates the data, it nevertheless establishes a rapid growth in the bespoke exhibition sector of the market during the post-crash years of 2008–12. This has continued, as evidenced by Secret Cinema productions, consistently making high entries in the annual UK box office from 2015 to 2019.[4] The two categories of 'live cinema' and 'event cinema' are used differently by the industry and the academy to refer to overlapping forms of exhibition. However, an industry report on audiences of live cinema found that 'consumers do not recognize a difference between event, live and outdoor cinema, seeing the brands as a type of cinema, rather than a unique product'.[5] For the purpose of clarity throughout this book, I will use 'event cinema' to refer to live broadcasts of opera, theatre and so on that are streamed to cinemas, and 'live cinema' or 'immersive cinema' to refer to experiential cinema, whereby the exhibition of a film is combined with aspects of interactive performance, spectacle and other extra-textual features to create a 'live' experience.[6] Atkinson and Kennedy (2016) have proposed a typography of live cinema for categorizing this sector, whereby film events are either enhanced (site-specific and outdoor screenings), augmented (involving an added dimension, such as performance and music) or participatory (including direct audience engagement). These types are useful for thinking about how the sector has evolved and for capturing the range of events that live cinema encompasses. The UK, in particular, has witnessed a plethora of new pop-up cinema businesses offering experiential cinema of

varying types in non-theatrical locations. In 2018, UK-based pop-up cinema businesses included Secret Cinema (founded 2007), the Luna Cinema (founded 2008), Nomad Cinema (founded 2010), the Rooftop Film Club (founded 2011), Backyard Cinema (founded 2012), Picnic Cinema (founded 2012), Edible Cinema (founded 2012), Hot-tub Cinema (founded 2012), Vintage Cinema, the Floating Cinema (founded 2016), and Neighbourhood Cinema (founded 2017). This is not offered as an exhaustive list but gives some indication of the exponential growth in this aspect of the live cinema sector.

This chapter primarily focuses on audience experiences of pop-up immersive cinema in the UK, where the sector is particularly buoyant. While there is some indication that pop-up cinemas have started to emerge in the global south, in cities such as Bangkok, Hyderabad and Kolkata, the evidence is limited.[7] Although these developments might indicate that the pop-up trend could potentially become a more globally ubiquitous feature of late capitalism, the live cinema culture that has become pervasive in the first two decades of the twenty-first century has predominantly been located in the global north. This has been understood by some scholars within the framework of austerity politics (Lashua 2013; Harris 2015). This chapter therefore begins by outlining the spaces and economies of pop-up cinema and evaluates the extent to which both neoliberal entrepreneurialism and the cultural policies of austerity governance have facilitated various developments in film exhibition over the last decade. It then offers a five-part investigation of audiences for commercial forms of experiential cinema, considering some of the key characteristics of this emergent sector such as nostalgia, seasonality, participation, economics and generational engagement. In doing this, the analysis also identifies a number of aesthetic features that characterize this exhibition sector, such as 'the Narnia moment' that frames many immersive events, and the implications this has on audience evaluations of their experiences.

Austerity culture and pop-up cinema's entrepreneurs

Pop-up culture has become increasingly pervasive in the twenty-first century, manifesting most conspicuously in the retail sector, but also in the form of pop-up restaurants, hotels and cinemas.[8] This trend for temporally limited versions of the established cultural markers of capitalist society reflects the inherent instabilities of neoliberal politics. In her study of pop-up cinema in London, Ella Harris argues

that the pop-up category needs to be understood in the context of austerity politics (Harris 2015, 2018). The economic crash of 2008 resulted in austerity budgeting across the public sector in many countries in the global north, most notably in Europe and the United States. While the piecemeal erosion of the welfare state is a long-established policy of neoliberal governance, it was pursued with a renewed vigour in the post-crash period and had a particularly marked impact on the urban landscape. In particular, the increased prevalence of disused retail outlets and run-down urban areas reflects an economic downturn and decrease in public spending. Harris identifies three characteristics as pop-up's 'key spatiotemporal imaginaries': flexibility, interstitiality and immersion. She contends that these ways of imagining and distributing space-time have a particular instrumentality in recessionary cities. Of these, the concept of interstitiality is most pertinent to claims regarding the relationship between pop-up cinema and austerity politics, in that it is understood as pop-up culture's tendency to occupy 'the cracks of neoliberal space–times' and carries the potential to 'smooth over those cracks and perpetuate the dominance of neoliberal ideals' (Harris 2015: 592). There is some evidence of pop-up cinemas emerging in these insterstitial spaces. Secret Cinema's *Paranoid Park* was staged in an old railway tunnel under the arches of London Bridge, while *The Empire Strikes Back* was housed in a disused warehouse in Canary Wharf. Pop-up cinemas have also fleetingly manifested in heritage sites earmarked for regeneration, such as Marshall's Mill in Yorkshire (Lashua 2013). The transformation of these neglected or abandoned spaces into exhibition venues illustrates the versatility of pop-up cinema and a certain entrepreneurial creativity on the part of the exhibitors.

North American cultural geographers adopt a similar perspective to Harris in their research on pop-up culture in the United States. Jamie Peck coins the term 'austerity urbanism' to problematize the impact of post-crash neoliberal policies on urban planning and regeneration in North American cities (Peck 2012, 2014). Peck investigates the uses made of abandoned and derelict spaces in recessionary cities during the period immediately following the economic crash of 2008. This scholarship tends to focus on the activities of two oppositional groups: the city planners and big architectural companies on the one hand, and the multiple groups of guerrilla activists working at the margins on the other. Other scholars usefully interrogate the multiple ways in which 'the promised magic of pop-up, interim and meanwhile uses has rapidly become a panacea for many urban ailments, shifting from the margins to the very centre of cities' (Ferreri 2015: 183).

However, the relationship between pop-up cinema and austerity politics is not simply about the availability of disused urban spaces or heritage sites where pop-up cinema can be staged. Recessionary cities are also characterized by widespread redevelopment and gentrification. Indeed, many pop-up cinemas in the London area are located at established, well-maintained venues such as bars and restaurants, and the food industry also has a thriving pop-up culture of its own. These two industries frequently engage in collaborative ventures as a means to maximize their profits and reduce risk. In this respect, pop-up cinemas offer the 'generation of a form of capital flow, which does not come into conflict with the immobility of real estate' (Bishop and Williams 2012: 25) and promote the 'innovation, fluidity and flexibility' needed in twenty-first-century cities (Bishop and Williams 2012: 220). Pop-up's imaginary of a flexible, future-orientated city therefore intensifies both the fast capital turn over and the ideals of individualized risk, which have long been prerogatives of capitalist development. Post-recessional geographies, typified by empty properties, forestalled development, and funding cuts are reimagined as a landscape of opportunities.

The creative range of pop-up enterprises emerging across the cities of the global north also illustrates an opportunistic entrepreneurialism associated with neoliberal deregulation and short-termism. Pop-up is now a fashionable choice for creative start-ups and a commonplace marketing tactic for global brands. However, while it has found success as a business tactic, pop-up is also recognized as a 'compensatory or diversionary urbanism in the face of political retreat and economic recession' (Tonkiss 2013: 316). Aneta Podkalicka and Dominika Potkańska's study of Polish austerity cultures 'reveals and theorises a curious mix of economising practices distributed along class lines and based on choice or necessity, while morphing "old" socialist into "new" aspirational and trendy lifestyles associated with "collaborative", "low-budget", "value-led" or "eco-consumption" aspects' (Podkalicka and Potkańska 2015: 95). In this context, pop-up also offers a model of reduced economic risk for entrepreneurs, promising short-term profits without the long-term investment needed to regenerate areas of deprivation. Harris contends that pop-up culture should be understood as part of a broader response to the economic recession that characterizes the era, arguing that it

> normalises precarity for artists, charities, welfare services and creative entrepreneurs, while keeping the city open to development. Pop-up emerges

> as a mechanism through which to mobilize the turbulence of recession and austerity towards a new normal characterised by profitable flexibility and a related precarity. (Harris 2015: 596)

However, it is difficult to assess with accuracy the extent to which recessionary politics facilitates pop-up culture. Although much less visible, the existence of pop-up cinema before the onset of austerity politics suggests that, while the recession has clearly shaped and facilitated pop-up culture in cities particularly affected by the economic crash, that it already featured on the consumer landscape of the twenty-first century.

The thriving business of pop-up cinema has been characterized by the emergence of a new generation of entrepreneurial exhibitors, keen to capitalize on the popularity of this innovative form of cinema-going while it lasts. Many of these emergent pop-up exhibitors, such as Luna Cinema and Backyard Cinema, appear to adopt a similar business model, thus exemplifying Burkett's model of bottom-up entrepreneurship powered by self-reliance (Burkett 2011: 119). Atkinson and Kennedy also observe that pop-up exhibitors 'emerge from within a model of the lone entrepreneur, starting with a modest one-screen venture and then experiencing and sustaining fast and significant growth' (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 5). The business model facilitating pop-up cinema is therefore a complex one. On the one hand, the risks taken by many exhibitors in relying on outdoor weather conditions make it a hazardous sector to work in. As one pop-up exhibitor explained, 'as a seasonal, outdoor cinema, we only screen at sunset, we can only screen once a day, and in the UK we are greatly limited by weather conditions' (Interviewee #24). However, despite these risks, it is a business that remains highly popular and lucrative, with insider-industry reports noting,

> they recently found that regular cinemas are running on average at 20% capacity. We run at 90%. When you look at our venues in the States, we run at 100%. It's a little beyond me as to why a lot of the major distributors can't overlook our shortcomings, . . . and not look at what a sociable cinema we are, how much people talk about us, how much press coverage we get.[9]

While the opportunistic character of the pop-up business model clearly appeals to those entrepreneurs accustomed to taking risks, the sector also attracts those looking to turn a quick profit. One exhibitor, for example, describes the way he had 'transformed a London venue into winter wonderland' to screen Christmas films over the festive period (Interviewee #17). However, further

research revealed that it was, in fact, the venue owners who were responsible for creating the festive décor, and the exhibitor was simply renting the space for a few evenings a week.

While pop-up culture clearly resonates with neoliberal economics, Atkinson and Kennedy argue that the current popularity of live cinema also has its cultural roots in earlier historical endeavours and cannot be fully accounted for by the current neoliberal economic climate. They contend that 'the contemporary drive in the UK to fund the opening up of high cultural offerings such as national theatre, orchestral performance and opera to a wider audience also has its own roots in particular historical practices' (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 7). Indeed, there are many examples of early and classical forms of cinema exhibition which foreshadow pop-up cinema. Harris notes that 'as a mobile site of spectatorship, the Floating Cinema's boat is reminiscent of historical itinerant sites of pre-cinematic and cinematic exhibition. It recalls, for example, the peep show boxes which itinerant showmen in the seventeenth century and onwards would carry to towns and villages, bringing images of distant lands to relatively immobile populations' (Harris 2018: 66). Furthermore, the parallel growth of pop-up cinema-going cultures in the non-profit sector, discussed later in this book, implies that the current popularity of this form of cinema-going might not simply be due to the recessionary spaces opened up by austerity politics. More recently, pop-up culture has been employed to further non-commercial community-building enterprises and reconfigured as a tool with the potential to enhance civic values and participation at a local level (Fredericks et al. 2015). There is an implication, then, that while the current consumer interest in pop-up cinema has been partly facilitated by the conditions created by austerity politics, that it has also become part of a wider shift in media consumption across the global north that includes schemes within the non-profit sector. The issues these debates raise about how audiences experience live cinema are now addressed in the analysis of the empirical data.

Pop-up cinema's audiences

This section of the chapter focuses on empirical data gathered in relation to the attendance of pop-up cinema events staged in the UK between 2014 and 2019. The primary data is comprised of twenty-six semi-structured interviews with participants (appendix 2) and five interviews with industry personnel. Of these

twenty-six interviewees, fourteen are female and twelve male; six are generation Z, fourteen are millennials, four are generation X and two are baby boomers; twenty are university educated, two are currently studying at university and four finished their education when they left school, aged eighteen. This sample offers a slightly younger cross section of interviewees than is evident across all twelve case studies (appendix 1), and thus reflects the younger demographic recorded in the Live Cinemas Report (2016). The qualitative material is supplemented by the secondary data, which is drawn for a survey of eighty-seven online reviews of the events, three empirical studies by other academics and two industry reports. The interviewee sample was selected to represent a range of socio-demographic profiles and to reflect the findings of the larger survey conducted on audiences for Live Cinema.[10] The data analysed relates to events staged by Secret Cinema, Backyard Cinema, Luna Cinema, Neighbourhood Cinema and Nomad Cinema, all of which operate as commercial enterprises, and it is organized into five key sections that examine responses around (i) commercial nostalgia, (ii) seasonality (iii) participation (iv) economic factors and (v) generational considerations.

Commercial nostalgia, sociability and repeat screenings

A key characteristic of the commercial pop-up events developed by Secret Cinema, Luna Cinema, Backyard Cinema and similar exhibitors is their appropriation of blockbuster films as live experiences as a means to appeal to a mass market. In recent years, Secret Cinema has created immersive screenings of *The Empire Strikes Back* (Irvin Kershner 1980), *Back to the Future* (Robert Zemeckis 1985), *Blade Runner* (Ridley Scott 1982), *Moulin Rouge!* (Baz Luhrmann 2001) and *Casino Royale* (Martin Campbell 2006). Likewise, Luna Cinema's offerings include *Dirty Dancing* (Emile Ardolino 1987), *Pretty Woman* (Garry Marshall 1990) and the *Harry Potter* films, while Backyard Cinema launched *The Snowman Experience* in November 2018. Although contemporary film releases are also occasionally transformed into pop-up experiences, this range of blockbuster films suggests that exhibitors are targeting mainstream audiences and families with repeat screenings of favourite films which generation Xers and baby boomers watched in their youth. As Barbara Klinger observes in relation to television, this is not a new marketing practice, and yet 'despite its significant presence in daily life, the non-theatrical Hollywood film has not truly entered the mainstream of academic research. Often dismissed as an inferior version of

a big screen original, the Hollywood non-theatrical hides in plain sight' (Klinger 2007: 276). Auslander's treatise on liveness confidently asserts that 'there is no question that live performance and mediatized forms compete for audiences in the cultural marketplace, and that mediatized forms have gained the advantage in that competition' (Auslander 2008: 6). The success of Secret Cinema Presents, and its many imitators which similarly combine live and mediatized film experiences, however, suggests that this might not be the case.

The small-scale study I previously published on Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, concluded that 'there is a sense, therefore, that Secret Cinema events serve as nostalgic renderings of childhood fandom where adults can 'step into' the fictional world of their childhood' (Pett 2016: 158). Drawing on this research, E. W. Nikdel analyses the participatory and communal aspects of the Secret Cinema brand and argues that a consideration of historical cult film audiences can inform our understanding of immersive cinema's popularity. While acknowledging the commercialization of Secret Cinema, Nikdel nevertheless concludes that

> we can see how Secret Cinema events revitalise notions of community, public performance and social cohesion. We must remember, then, that despite the proliferation of on-demand access and the persistence of physical domestic media formats, this insular culture has also induced a broader appetite for live and experiential events that redefine the cinema experience and capture the social essence of cult fandom. (Nikdel 2017: 120)

This first strand of the empirical research therefore investigates the communal characteristics of immersive cinema and their relations to a form of commercial nostalgia facilitated by repeat screenings of blockbuster films from the 1980s and 1990s.

Attending an immersive cinema event is, in most cases, a sociable occasion rather than a solitary activity. While conventional theatrical venues invariably attract a certain number of cinema-goers who attend on their own, often because they are keen to watch a new release or a specific title, the majority of immersive events involve the restaging of familiar, mainstream films that have often been broadcast multiple times on terrestrial television channels. It is the innovative presentation of familiar and much-loved texts, then, that forms one of the key attractions of these pop-up events, and the interview data suggests this is frequently facilitated by intergenerational bonding within families. In this respect, specialized repeat screenings can provide an opportunity for

participants to indulge in nostalgia for both a favourite film and the social context in which it was originally viewed, as already evidenced in previous audience research on *Back to the Future* (Pett 2013: 189). Nostalgia in this context does not imply a straightforward wistfulness for a bygone era. In his analysis of the commodification of nostalgia in American culture, Paul Grainge contends that nostalgia is a cultural style that has emerged within a specific cultural moment and 'that has generally disjoined nostalgia from any specific meaning located in the past' (Grainge 2000: 33). Grainge argues that the development of nostalgia as a cultural style reflects a new ability to review and renegotiate media texts that evolved in the late twentieth century. Analyses of the current trend towards 1980s nostalgia have focused on its popularity with generation X cinema-goers (Cook 2005). However, for the millennial fans born in the 1980s, the nostalgic value associated with *Back to the Future* and *Star Wars* appears to be linked to childhood memories of watching the film on television or video, often with their families. One interviewee explains that 'it was really important going with my Dad, he introduced me to *Star Wars* when I was a kid, he's a big *Star Wars* fan' (Interviewee #02; A2, Q2).

Another interviewee discusses a similar kind of familial nostalgia in relation to Secret Cinema's production of *The Empire Strikes Back:*

> I know this probably sounds ridiculous, but it was like going back to my childhood, but with my two sons with me. So, we were in Tatooine, sharing the excitement together of being in place all three of us knew so well, but for the first time . . . just completely mind-boggling, really. It's hard to describe how much that meant to me, and I don't expect other people to get it, I'm a very sentimental person. (Interviewee #12; A2, Q2)

This mother's enthusiasm for sharing the *Star Wars* universe with her children is remarkably common and is already established in other studies (Gunnells 2009; Pett 2019). Her appreciation for the liveness of the event involved 'walking through the set with the boys, you were just there' (Interviewee #12: appendix 1, Q5). Indeed, a reviewer for *Junior* magazine, who watched *Star Wars* for the first time just one day before attending the Secret Cinema event, concurred that it was 'a brilliant way to introduce your family to a series of films you may have watched growing up'.[11] Other pop-up exhibitors have followed Secret Cinema's suit in selecting films that have a broad family appeal and are likely to generate childhood nostalgia, such as the *Harry Potter* films. As with the *Star Wars* universe, the *Harry Potter* films lend themselves well to the immersive experience

because of their distinctive and detailed fictional world. One interviewee said of her experience of Luna Cinema's production at Warwick Castle:

> I would say the most important part for me was the shared fandom, really. I saw *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* with a childhood friend at Warwick Castle. It was a bit cold, it was September, but completely brilliant to sit together under the stars, share a beer with my Potter friend who is also a massive fan, thinking everyone around us felt the same. That was the magical bit . . . that sense of community, we all love the same thing, we got talking to some other fans and had a great night out. So yes, it really felt like being a kid again. (Interviewee #11; A2, Q6)

This *Harry Potter* fan frames her enjoyment of the pop-up screening not only in terms of the shared fandom and 'sense of community' but also, as with the *Star Wars* fans, with the affective response of returning to childhood. Her sense of the 'liveness' of the event is identified as 'being outdoors, with other people, like a gig' (Interviewee #11; A2, Q5) and is captured in her description of sitting under the stars. The response also echoes the findings of the Harris Report on millennial culture, which suggested that '79% of millennials feel that going to live events with family and friends helps deepen their relationships. In fact, 30% of millennials say they met someone at a live event that became a good friend.'[12] As with the findings of the Harris Report, audience evaluations of the appeal of pop-up screenings suggest that the experience of the event resonates most with millennial cinema-goers, rather than the film being screened.

The affective nostalgia for *Harry Potter* films also occurs with interviewees who recall watching films as teenagers. One describes attending Secret Cinema's production of *Back to the Future* and frames her experience of the interactive Hill Valley set in terms of nostalgia for watching the film in the 1980s:

> So, I went with my partner, and we were like teenagers dating all over again, but in Hill Valley. I felt like I was about fifteen. Seeing the actor playing Michael J. Fox at the Enchantment Under the Sea dance was amazing . . . brought back memories of my teenage crush, all those feelings, but I was sharing them with my 44 year old partner, so it was a bit of a head trip really. Watching the film was the least enjoyable part, actually, because I was quite uncomfortable. (Interviewee #04; A2, Q2)

For this gen X respondent, her understanding of 'liveness' is identified as 'just the whole set, Hill Valley come alive' (Interviewee #04; A2, Q5). All four of these responses share some similar discursive features that are also reflected

in a number of other interviews. First, use of the words 'shared', 'community', 'together' and the references made to who they attended with (family, partners or close friends) indicates that the sociable appeal of these events appears to outperform other aspects of the pop-up experience; this is also evidenced in other empirical studies undertaken by film scholars in the field. Lavinia Brydon and Olu Jenzen's research on pop-up cinemas staged on seaside piers in the UK offers a similar conclusion, in that, in keeping with the pertinence of the location,

> pop-up cinema is more about the social or communal activity of enjoying a film in a familiar space that resultantly is thought about and appreciated in a new way. It is not driven by the cineaste's desire for consuming avant-garde or rare films in a quirky location; rather, it is rooted in popular culture entertainment, both in terms of content and the deliberate appeal to a wide audience. (Brydon and Jenzen 2018: 48)

The emphasis on sociability and popular culture emerging from Brydon and Jenzen's survey suggests that, while pop-up cinema staged within a heritage framework might seem more worthy and meaningful than a commercial enterprise such as Secret Cinema, the experience of the audience focuses on the social and communal characteristics of the event in much the same way. However, while it might seem fairly unremarkable to conclude that immersive film screenings are designed and experienced as sociable, communal events, it does not follow that none of the participants attend on their own. The commercial director of one pop-up company operating in London explains that while the majority book as groups or couples, some people do attend on their own and offers one recent example to illustrate this, recalling 'I had an email from a lady who said I'm coming along to *Frozen* sing-a-long and I'm single, is it possible for me to sit next to some young men?' (Interviewee #03). However, this kind of anecdote suggests that even for those who attend alone, there is an expectation of sociable contact, unlike the darkened auditorium of a conventional cinema.

While qualitative research provides ample evidence that these events promote a form of collective sociability, a second discursive characteristic of the interviews are the references made to their fandom of the films, which some make directly, and others infer. This characteristic is the element that most clearly invites parallels between this development in film exhibition and historical forms of cult cinema, alluded to in a previous study (Pett 2016). Nikdel's fairly strong claim that Secret Cinema captures the essence of cult film fandom (Nikdel 2017: 120) is echoed in other analyses of the Secret Cinema brand that focus on the

construction of exclusivity (Atkinson and Kennedy 2016b: 254; Moulton 2020: 208). However, while analysis of this marketing discourse points to shared characteristics with the cult film experience, the economic models they illustrate could not be more different. In this respect, the Secret Cinema brand, soon to be partnered with Disney, is seemingly at odds with the low-budget economics and aesthetics which often characterize the cult cinema exhibition model.[13]

While parallels between mainstream, experiential cinema-goers and cult film fandoms are contested, interviews with pop-up exhibitors suggest that the binary between the diversified home entertainment sector and the live cinema sector has become a dominant discourse. One pop-up exhibitor operating in the London area offers his theory as to why immersive cinema has become so popular:

> We're in a situation where access to media is just phenomenal, so you can see anything you want, you've got access to Now TV, Netflix, whatever you want . . . whereas previously even watching a movie with your family at home was like a special event, you'd have to go to Blockbusters and rent a movie, and get a bucket of popcorn, and get all that home. So, what's happened is that everything has become so accessible, which is great, but at the same time it takes away what makes these things special, what makes them a unique experience to share with your family and your friends, or your boyfriend or girlfriend, or whatever it may be. So, I think what's changed is that companies like us, what we're doing is we're putting back in that unique aspect that you've lost watching films at home, we're making it special again. (Interviewee #10)

This exhibitor explains the continued popularity of experiential cinema in the context of technological and cultural developments within the home entertainment industry, drawing on the demediatization discourse and positioning the pop-up phenomenon as a 'special' alternative to domestic consumption. His views echo those of Fabien Riggall, founder of Secret Cinema, who contends that Secret Cinema's success is due to its 'ability to offer people "a sense of unity", by coming together in experiences that relate to real-world issues . . . there's a disenchantment in the world and people are lonely because of technology. We're facing a mental health epidemic and people really like to connect with each other.'[14] Riggall's positioning of Secret Cinema's cultural offer as oppositional to technology frames it within a nostalgic anti-digital discourse that romanticizes the pre-digital era and can be understood within a 'general trend of nostalgia: the longing for what is assumed to be lost in the continuing process of digitisation that accounts for contemporary media culture's

widespread romanticising and fetishising of analogue media' (Schrey 2014: 27–8). Additionally, Riggall's claims that interactive productions of Hollywood blockbusters relate to real-world issues speak more directly to his profile as a celebrity entrepreneur who also styles himself as an activist; in this respect, his public persona echoes that of entrepreneurs such as Richard Branson and Mark Zuckerberg. The discourses employed by Riggall and the other pop-up entrepreneurs interviewed here function to mask the commercial nature of their respective businesses. In this respect, I argue that while technological developments within the home entertainment market are clearly important considerations for understanding the rise of experiential cinema, it is an overstatement to interpret this as 'cult fandom', in that these events attract an extremely wide range of participants, including those who have never seen the film before (Pett 2019: 174).

A third discursive characteristic of these interviews are the references made to their emotional responses, evidenced by words such as 'sentimental', 'feelings' and 'felt'. In part, this affective response has already been explained by the significance of attending with close friends and family members, and the experience of re-watching a favourite film. Another aspect of the affective, sentimental quality many interviewees demonstrated is a consideration of the extent to which the consumer-participants of big-budget, experiential blockbusters adopt or display the nostalgic, anti-digital era discourse promoted by Riggall and other entrepreneurs in their discussion of the events.

When asked what the main attraction experiential cinema held for them was, one interviewee responded: 'Well, it gets you out of the house. There's so much good TV now, but going to an event like this [*Blade Runner*] takes you to a different world, and you can go with your friends' (Interviewee #19; A2, Q7). This interviewee clearly appreciated the live, interactive element of the experience when compared to the domestic alternative; her point of comparison was television rather than social media. Other interviewees also compared the experience favourably to being at home, but this did not involve any nostalgia for a pre-digital age. Indeed, while most respondents accepted that they could not take their mobile phones into the event, most were very happy to be reunited with them at the end of the evening, and as established in a previous study, for some participants their activity on social media facilitated a continuation of the fictional world after leaving the venue (Pett 2016).

A final discursive characteristic of these interviews is the references made to their past, evidenced by words such as 'kid', 'childhood' and 'teenage'. While

there is minimal evidence of nostalgia for a pre-digital era, a more nebulous form of nostalgic dominated many of the interviews. The design of many of the Secret Cinema sets facilitates this, with a marked theatrical cross over into the immersive worlds. Several interviewees discussed what I describe as the 'Narnia moment' associated with immersive cinema, when they enter through a doorway or fictional portal into the set. One interviewee recounts her experience of entering Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, recalling,

> the best bit is when you come off the ship and enter Tatooine. Just amazing. Walking into this fictional world that is so familiar, and everything is tangible, the smells, the sand. That was the moment I remember most vividly. It's kind of strange, returning to a familiar world, but one you've never been in before, if that makes sense. (Interviewee #22; A2, Q7)

Another interviewee discusses his Narnia moment when he describes entering the Secret Cinema *Blade Runner* set as being the most memorable aspect of the experience, particularly 'the point you step in, rain sprayed on my face, the neon lights' (Interviewee #23; A2, Q5). While the big-budget design of Secret Cinema events is clearly intended to enhance these Narnia moments, I argue that smaller, low-budget pop-up enterprises have imitated this design in a calculated attempt to replicate the success of the Secret Cinema formula.

Several of the pop-up cinema businesses that have developed in the last decade hinge the marketing of their events on a 'Narnia moment'. In the online promotion for their *Winter Night Garden* experience, Backyard Cinema draws directly on this trope, inviting customers to 'be among the first to push through a magical wardrobe, and set off on your own adventure! Inside the wardrobe you will find a world full of mystery, explore the enchanted forest, and rediscover your favourite films.'[15] Responses to Backyard Cinema's events are mixed, both online and in the interview data. While some who attended loved the Narnia moment, describing it as 'magical' and 'as good as I had anticipated' (Interviewee #08; A2, Q7), another said of the event that 'the experience on entry is a bit of joke, a cynical nod to children's fantasy fiction and some awkward interaction with out-of-work actors. Not really worth the ticket price' (Interviewee #18: A2, Q6). While these seasonal forms of experiential cinema thus directly invoke a childhood sentimentality for beloved films and texts of the past, employing a formulaic rhetoric to produce a commercialized form of nostalgia does not always translate into a 'magical' experience for those who attend.

Experiencing seasonality

Seasonality has long been a key feature of the tourist industry, and increasingly many commercial pop-up exhibitors are mimicking well-established marketing strategies centred on Halloween, Christmas and St. Valentine's Day.[16] Films set during or on these annual holidays have been categorized as 'seasonal cult' (Mathijs 2010; Middlemost 2020). Ernest Mathijs describes the reception of seasonally broadcast films as 'fervent cultism around specific, recurrent periods and dates in the year linked to cultist receptions – and to specialist television programming' (Mathijs 2010: 2), and, in this context, commercial pop-up exhibitors are taking their lead from both the cult film circuit and the well-established broadcast scheduling practices. Capitalizing on consumers' propensity to spend more during these seasons, thematic pop-up events are mirroring television schedules by screening films that chime with consumer expectations and thus offering a unique way to celebrate key seasonal moments throughout the year.

Alongside this established tradition of watching 'seasonal cults' at Christmas, there has also been a perceived shift towards giving 'experiences' rather than material gifts as presents. Heiner Evanschitzky observes that

> the trend towards spending money on experiences, such as having fancy home-cooked dinners, has become ever more apparent over the holiday period. Credit card transaction data shows that we might have just reached 'peak stuff', meaning customers realise they've basically got everything they need and can use their extra cash on experiences, rather than simply buying more stuff. We are evolving into an experience economy.[17]

This consumer turn towards spending on experiences can be observed elsewhere, for example, in the 'Hierarchy of Giving', a guide published by the ethical consumer website *Just Little Changes*.[18] The website advises consumers to 'give memories' as presents (which in practical terms translates as event tickets, experience days and memberships) in order to have 'a more waste-conscious Christmas'.[19] These trends in the retail sector indicate how discourses around the value of 'experiences' inform a wide spectrum of businesses and organizations, from high-end entertainment providers through to small-scale ethical entrepreneurs.

Backyard Cinema's 2018 production of *The Snowman Experience* offers a pertinent example of the way commercial nostalgia is successfully fabricated

and marketed within the screen experience economy. Launched to mark the fortieth anniversary of the Raymond Briggs book, *The Snowman Experience* is situated in Hyde Park's *Winter Wonderland*[20] in London, which is open every year from November through to January. The experience capitalizes on the popularity of the 1982 animated version of *The Snowman* directed by Dianne Jackson and originally aired on Channel 4. Now screened every year on British television, Jackson's animation is frequently cited as a programme that people watch every year at Christmas.[21] One online review of the Backyard Cinema event opens with the observation that 'as a child of the 1980s, I found *The Snowman* enchanting and moving and continue to watch it every Christmas as a tradition' and concludes that 'the experience made me feel like a little girl again and I am highly tempted to go back again I enjoyed it so much'.[22] Similarly, one interviewee commented: 'We used to watch it together as a family, at home, so it made sense to make it a family outing. We were all looking forward to it' (Interviewee #05; A2, Q2). These findings echo Ernest Mathijs's observation that 'seasonal cult' films scheduled at Christmas have 'enabled television audiences to create imagined, fabricated, yet real communities; communities who utilize films to construct or reshape shared memories and, hence, nostalgias to confirm their sense of . . . community' (Mathijs 2010: n.p.). As an immersive experience, *The Snowman* thus capitalizes on a combined audience nostalgia for the original book, the 1982 animation, the annual repeat screenings of the animation on terrestrial television, and the familial or communal childhood memories of Christmas associated with them.

The event is designed to heighten feelings of childhood nostalgia and begins with a Narnia moment in which visitors enter the experience by walking through a snowy forest, thus directly drawing on Backyard Cinema's established trope. To accentuate on the unique 'one-off' nature of the experience, a photographer then captures the participant in a flying pose as a means to 'make memories'. Participants are taken through to a screening room that has been created to replicate the set of the house in *The Snowman*. Throughout the first part of the screening, a number of sensory effects are employed to create a haptic illusion of being inside the family's house. The second part of the screening takes place in a space designed to resemble a forest under a night sky. Finally, in the third screening space, which has a celebratory theme featuring balloons, streamers and hats, the Snowman enters and greets the participants. While this is ostensibly an experience created for children, the nostalgia invoked is also effective in attracting older customers.

Interviewees who visited *The Snowman Experience* invariably commented on the way it made them feel, and the affective qualities it provoked. One observed that 'it was the perfect outing to get me in the Christmas spirit, it made me tingly and excited' (Interviewee #06; A2, Q4), while another described it as an 'uplifting, joyful' experience (Interviewee #05; A2, Q4), and that her sense of the liveness of the event was 'the party bit at the end, and meeting the Snowman' (Interviewee #05; A2, Q5). As with many immersive pop-ups, *The Snowman Experience* trades on a nostalgic appreciation of the animation feature, often combined with an individual tendency to enjoy Christmassy aesthetics. One interviewee discussed the broader significance of her emotional investment in Christmas as a time of year, saying, 'I've had a terrible time, and Christmas means everything to me this year. It's about putting all the stress to one side and just getting into the Christmas spirit, having a good time, being a kid again, really' (Interviewee #26; A2, Q6). However, one interviewee expressed disappointment with the interactive component of the experience, describing it as 'a bit rudimentary' (Interviewee #09; A2, Q6). These responses suggest that seasonal experiences such as these partly depend on affective attachment to festive activities in order to be appreciated by audiences.

Issues around seasonality also play a key role in the experiences of those who attended events in the summertime. Many pop-up exhibitors, such as Picnic Cinema, Summer on Screen and Pop-up Screens, are seasonal and only operate in the summer months. Interview material suggests that a key factor in their popularity is the opportunity to enjoy a film outdoors and 'make the most of summer' (Interviewee #11; A2, Q7). One described her experience of seeing an outdoor screening of *Dirty Dancing* as 'a great way to enjoy a lovely summer evening. I liked being able to bring a picnic and enjoy a bit of fresh air. The film was fun but not the main point, I've seen it so many times before' (Interviewee #07; A2, Q7). The live aspect of the event was 'being outside in the summer, hanging out with people' (Interviewee #07; A2, Q5). Another said that 'the ambience on a summer evening, it makes a nice change to watch a film outside' (Interviewee #20; A2, Q4) was her rationale for attending, while another said the most enjoyable aspect of the event she attended was 'being outdoors with my friends', and that it 'made a change from going to the pub. Yeah, that's how I would describe it as live' (Interviewee #15; A2, Q5). These responses suggest that seasonal cinema-going in the summer months appeals to many audience members as a special, one-off kind of night out, rather than a regular evening in a familiar setting like a pub. One notable feature of all the

interviewees who discussed outdoor screenings is that they were all female. This corresponds with data collected for the Live Cinema report (2016), which established 'predominately female responses to both the online survey and in person interviews at events, totalling 68%, are far above the industry average breakdown of 47% for national cinema attendance'.[23] The report also establishes that the highest percentage of attendees were under thirty-five years old.[24] The seasonal character of many pop-up immersive experiences indicates some of the key features about the growth of the screen experience economy. As with seasonal television schedules, it is an exhibition practice that draws on nostalgia and familial or communal viewing habits to attract its audience, and in this respect can be interpreted as a contemporary iteration of the way screen media functions socially rather than individually, on portable screen devices.

Participation and economic constraints

While the sociability of pop-up cinema is generally discussed in favourable terms by the interviewees, a more complex picture emerges in relation to productions that include a convoluted participatory design. Virginia Crisp and Richard McCulloch's study conducted at the Prince Charles Cinema in London concludes that the culture of engaging in participatory behaviour while watching the film is not greatly valued by urban cinema-goers. They note that 'our respondents consistently told us that the single greatest threat to the cinema experience is that the "wrong" audiences might attend and behave "badly" – laughing or talking during the film and breaking the reverential silence' (Crisp and McCulloch 2016: 207). Their study implies that, within this specific exhibition context, metropolitan audiences at alternative or specialist film venues are more inclined to adopt a deferential, text-centric attitude towards both the film and the exhibition space. However, this is not the case with all urban models of immersive cinema and points to an important distinction between participatory cinema screened at theatrical and non-theatrical venues.

Scholarship on immersive theatre offers a useful comparison in this context. In her study of theatre audiences, Helen Freshwater raises the possibility of an idealized relationship between immersive text and audience (2009). Similarly, Matthew Reason (2015) argues that theatre practitioners and scholars often romanticize the emancipatory potential of immersive performances without

considering how participants themselves feel about these theatrical events. Kirsty Sedgman's study of National Theatre Wales audiences usefully interrogates these utopian ideals surrounding participatory theatre and questions their potential to liberate audiences from codes of behaviour:

> Although the specific action possibilities available to participants may be left deliberately open, audiences frequently walk away aware of the limits of the encounter overall. In this manner, the potential for agency is sometimes palliated by the knowledge that the performance is a game to be played, whether or not the rules of that game are made clearly and immediately manifest for audiences. (Sedgman 2017: 159)

Sedgman's study raises questions around the perceived protocol of immersive theatre, and audience anxieties linked to the possibility of missed opportunities. What differentiates this from mainstream immersive cinema is that participation within devised theatre often presents an unknown text and unfamiliar characters to the audience, such as a Boer war veteran turned apple seller handing out apples, as described by Sedgman. However, Secret Cinema Presents, Luna Cinema productions and many of the other pop-up cinemas already discussed in this chapter enable audiences to engage with familiar figures from blockbuster movies such as *Star Wars* and *Harry Potter*, thus offering reassuring points of navigation. In this respect, there is less potential for narrative uncertainty and greater opportunity to display cultural capital.

These issues highlight the importance of the event design. Secret Cinema and other pop-ups are designed to facilitate relaxation and offer multiple food outlets, drinks vendors and so on. Sedgman argues that successful immersive theatre experiences are dependent on clear guidelines for the audience that enable them to participate and 'feel they are capable of taking up that role' (Sedgman 2017: 166). At Secret Cinema events, while it is made apparent that participants are supposed to be relaxing and enjoying consumables, there is also a ludic element to the event design. One interviewee evaluated her experience of *The Empire Strikes Back* in terms of the extent to which she was presented with opportunities to engage with the interactive elements:

> I enjoyed it much more than *Back to the Future* because I was given a mission, I had to deliver an object to another character who would identify themselves to me in a particular way. It was really exciting, although I failed in my mission! The sets were amazing, I was actually scared when the Stormtroopers marched past in case I got arrested . . . but luckily I didn't . . . the only aspect I wasn't so

> keen on was the stalls and the extent to which we were encouraged to spend money. (Interviewee #01; A2, Q5)

This interviewee valued her Secret Cinema experience in terms of the level of her participation in the narrative and the way in which it functioned to enhance her emotional investment in the event. This is also the aspect she identified as being 'live'. Her description of this emotional investment, and the feelings of excitement and fear, is combined with a more critical evaluation of her experience as a consumer. Another interviewee makes a similar comment, focusing in particular on the sophistication of the interactive elements and noting that 'the missions I was sent on were complex and well-constructed, much more engaging than I had anticipated' (Interviewee #09; A2, Q6). These participants' discussion of engaging in the interactive elements of the narrative before the screening of the film implies that it heightened both the immersive qualities of the event and audience enjoyment of them. However, there is no suggestion that emotional involvement in the characters and set precludes their ability to critically analyse the event while they are immersed within it. Another interviewee who had not been to a Secret Cinema event before discussed her particular enjoyment of the Tatooine set, stating that

> well, I loved the two suns projected on the walls, that made me smile and feel like I was on a film set! Yes, Luke's house . . . that was pretty good.
>
> Wandering around it, bumping into people, that was when it felt like a live experience. (Interviewee #07; A2, Q5)

Many of the interviewees had very positive experiences of the Secret Cinema Tatooine set, with several discussing its authenticity and attention to detail as being central to their enjoyment of the experience. One interviewee spoke enthusiastically about the interactions with the actors on Mos Eisley set, wandering around the shops and the cantina 'like I lived there, that was pretty cool' (Interviewee #13; A2, Q7). This was echoed by an interviewee talking about his experience of wandering around the set 'just hanging out, eating noodles at the bar, pretending to be Deckard. That was the most enjoyable bit, inhabiting the film. That's what made it feel live' (Interviewee #16; A2, Q5).

Only one of the interviewees expressed some frustration at not having been able to see all of the re-enactments that were staged in Tatooine, commenting that he was 'disappointed to have missed some bits out . . . one of my friends said he met Han Solo, so I'm not sure I got the most out of the whole thing, really' (Interviewee #14; A2, Q6). However, despite this sense of disappointment at

'missing out' on some aspects of the experience, he cited the sets, particularly on the Death Star, as being the most enjoyable aspect of the experience, noting that 'it was really impressive, the way they had re-created the ships and the details of the set within this disused warehouse' (Interviewee #14; A2, Q5). The utilization of space and appreciation of the sets emerged, then, as a prominent factor in the interviewees' enjoyment of the immersive event. Their appreciation of the way in which the film sets were re-created elicited a display of subcultural capital and suggests, as Griffiths has argued, that the pleasures of immersive media are linked to 'embodied modes of encountering visual spectacle' and audience mobility within the viewing space (Griffiths 2008: 3).

This set of audience responses contrasted, however, with discussions of the staged spectacle that took place during the screenings of the Secret Cinema events, when participants were seated in a more conventional cinema space. One interviewee commented that

> I found it distracting when parts of the film were re-enacted during the screening, at the side of the auditorium. I wanted to watch the film, but I didn't want to miss out on the extra stuff . . . so I ended up trying to watch both, which was kind of uncomfortable, and I ended up just sort of losing track of the narrative. (Interviewee #04; A2, Q6)

This response bears some similarities to Sandifer's discussion of 3-D technologies and their potential to disrupt mental absorption in the narrative by highlighting the self-consciousness characteristic of the viewing context for the audience. However, what is notably different is that the action is taking place in two separate physical spaces, and the interviewee feels uncomfortable about having to choose which action to focus on. Another interviewee notes that 'the screening was fun, but that's not what I paid my money for . . . it was the bit beforehand that really made it' (Interviewee #11; A2, Q7). What emerges from this small sample of qualitative material, then, is a tendency among those interviewed to show greater appreciation and enjoyment of the immersed experience while mobile and able to traverse freely around the set.

Economic considerations play a significant role in the way some interviewees participate in and access pop-up experiences. As commercial ventures, ticket prices for these events vary, the most expensive tending to be those for Secret Cinema Presents. Tickets for this series, which has included *Back to the Future, The Empire Strikes Back, Blade Runner* and other big-budget immersive productions, are generally upward of £75 per person. Although the events are

longer in duration than many pop-up screenings (approximately five hours), these are nevertheless ticket prices that require participants to have a significant disposable income, and they have generated notable income at the box office. *The Empire Strikes Back* sold 100,000 tickets each at £75, generating over £7 million at the box office and making it the forty-eighth highest-grossing film in the 2015 UK annual box office, a higher position than the mainstream, award-winning cinematic releases such as *Birdman* (Alfonso Cuaron 2015) and *Carol* (Todd Haynes 2015).[25]

However, in reconceptualizing Secret Cinema as a big-budget income generator within the screen experience economy in 2014, the brand simultaneously reconfigured its audience. Whereas Secret Cinema once traded on secrecy and subcultural capital, attracting an early-adopter hipster elite to their events, Secret Cinema Presents repositioned its audience as gullible consumers, plying them with merchandise and overpriced refreshments. A preoccupation with ticket pricing, or the 'fun/money ratio', emerges as one of five key themes in a reception survey of seventy-three articles reviewing Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back* (Pett 2019: 171).[26] One interviewee commented that 'I wanted to enjoy the Mos Eisley cantina but, quite frankly, I couldn't afford the drinks prices. After paying so much for a ticket, this felt like exploitation, and tarnished the whole experience' (Interviewee #21; A2, Q4). As with interviewee #03, referenced earlier, this interviewee objected to the pricing of the consumables and recalibrated her assessment of the experience accordingly. This development of the Secret Cinema brand and its consumer base, I argue, has generated a particular set of responses in some audience members, leading them to focus their assessments of the events on notions of economic value. In this way, the heightened commercial character of the Secret Cinema Presents model of pop-up cinema has repositioned its audience as neoliberal subjects.

Other immersive pop-ups have also attracted criticism from some of the interviewees on economic grounds. *The Snowman Experience* received a very mixed response online, and one interviewee commented that it 'was ludicrously expensive for a 45-minute experience. You watch a film you've seen before, and there's very little spectacle added on to it, just some lighting and smoke. We were left feeling very disappointed' (Interviewee #09; appendix 1, Q6). Another complained that 'it was too cold and there was nowhere to sit down in the second room, so the children were very fractious. Not what I would expect for that ticket price' (Interviewee #15; A2, Q4). These responses reiterate evidence

suggesting that the commercial model of pop-up cinema generates a response among some consumers that reflects its economic imperative to create a profit.

One pop-up cinema operating with a different economic model is Nomad Cinema. Founded in 2010, this is a non-profit pop-up that donates all proceeds to a sustainability project in Africa. While not ostensibly the subject of this chapter, Nomad Cinema offers an interesting comparison with the more commercial pop-ups. Some interviewees who attended Nomad Cinema screenings discussed participation in a different context, as an aspect of environmental activism. One interviewee who also attended many other pop-up cinema events reported that

> It felt great being there and contributing to the sustainability project. There's something quite special in knowing that, as people enjoy a musical in London, the entrance fees are supporting budding film-makers in Africa. Yes, definitely made it very different to the other events I've been to. (Interviewee #18; A2, Q4)

This response suggests that the economic model of the event can play an important role in shaping the participant's perception of the event. Rather than positioning the participant as a neoliberal subject, however, they are being interpellated as a benevolent charity supporter. This form of branded altruism was appealing to the younger interviewees, who appreciated the added value to an otherwise low-key pop-up experience; one observed that she 'got a good response on Instagram' (Interviewee #21; A2, Q7). The significance of mediating cinema-going experiences through mobile technology is a recurrent characteristic of responses from millennial interviewees, and it is this demographic sector of the audience to which this chapter finally turns.

The millennial experience economy

As already outlined in the Introduction, recent surveys conducted in the United States, United Kingdom and Australia have established that the millennial generation is more inclined to acquire experiences and memories of an event than they are to invest in tangible objects. The 2016 Harris Group survey found that 78 per cent of millennials would rather spend their disposable income on an experience or event than on a physical object, and over 82 per cent had participated in a range of live experiences, such as concerts, festivals and the performing arts, in the previous year.[27] These statistics resonate with some of the millennial interviewees who discussed attending pop-up cinema events,

which accounted for 54 per cent of the interview sample. One commented 'Warwick Castle made the perfect backdrop for the evening, it looked really good when we posted the photos on Instagram' (Interviewee #11; A2, Q5). For this interviewee, who watched *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets* with a childhood friend, the social dimension was twofold, in that she socialized at the event and simultaneously shared photos on social media during it, thereby facilitating further social interaction. In this scenario, it was the interviewee's social interaction that crossed the live/mediatized divide, an occurrence which is increasingly integral to the millennial generation. As *The Guardian* journalist Mark Sweeney observes,

> The so-called Instagram generation are much more about buying an experience, not a product. . . . it has always been the case that an experience was going to sport, a gig or something like that. Now the experience economy has transcended that to every part of life from theme parks and pop-ups to experiences within retail, festivals and escape rooms.[28]

The Harris Report concludes that it is precisely this ability to share live events online that is driving the millennial hunger for experiences; nearly 69 per cent of this generation experience FOMO (fear of missing out) because 'in a world where newsfeeds and social media broadcast what friends are experiencing, the fear of missing out propel millennials to show up, share and engage: a driving force behind the experience economy'.[29] This was evident among the millennials interviewed for this study, many of whom discussed sharing photos of their experience online.

This cultural phenomenon of the millennial experience economy is increasingly being studied by market analysts and business studies academics, who predict it will be a key factor shaping the future economy of the global north (Seligman 2019: 9). An Australian survey of the millennial experience economy by marketing entrepreneurs Big Red Group similarly predicts that 'as this generation increases its buying power, the economy will continue to see a rising tide when it comes to demand for experiences . . . this generation of digital natives are putting off major purchases' and are 'choosing instead to travel and build a "wealth" of meaningful experiences'.[30] Interestingly, Big Red Group's CEO, David Anderson, describes an experience as a moment when 'all five senses are firing, and a synapse snaps – like a camera – creating a memory'.[31] In directly equating experiences with memories, and articulating the association between the two through the analogy of a camera, Anderson neatly articulates

the discourse around the millennial generation's preference for experiences over objects and their use of social media platforms to share these moments.

Conclusions: An intergenerational experience culture?

The experiential pop-up culture in the UK has developed in a number of specific ways over the last ten years, and a hierarchy of exhibition models has emerged within this sector. The qualitative material and secondary data analysed here do not set out to provide definitive characteristics of this sector, but instead interrogate how audiences experience these events through the identification of discursive patterns in the 'talk' generated. This points to a number of intersecting factors, centred around sociability, nostalgia, seasonality and economic considerations, which are discussed in relation to both high-end productions and, likewise, low-budget experiences. Whereas the interactive component is central to perceptions of liveness in responses to the Secret Cinema Presents events, interviewees discussing the low-budget screenings focus more frequently on the sociability and communality of the experiences and the fact that they are outdoors. This made the experience of watching a film feel 'live' even though the main form of entertainment was wholly mediatized. Interestingly, the Secret Cinema interviewees also discussed social interactions as a part of their enjoyment of the set, in that it was their connectedness with others that brought it alive. However, several research participants distinguished between this form of social interaction and a night out 'at the pub', which was not the same; in this respect, outdoor cinemas offered the interviewees a unique event or experience more akin to going to the theatre. The implication here is that themed or augmented cinema experiences constitute a live event or special outing that is comparable to the theatre and that Auslander's distinction between cinema (as mediatized) and theatre (as live) has been largely eroded.

While there was a higher percentage of millennial respondents interviewed for this chapter (54 per cent) than the average across the study (44 per cent), it is evident the older gen X interviewees also find immersive pop-up experiences highly enjoyable. A key trait emerging from this qualitative material, then, is a discussion of the experiences as opportunities for intergenerational familial bonding. This suggests that, while these experiences are highly popular with millennials, they can be characterized as intergenerational as much as they can be characterized as generational.

There are three ways that the economic conditions created by the global north's neoliberal culture can be understood to facilitate the experiential pop-up cinema industry: first, in terms of the interstitial urban spaces created by austerity politics, transformed by some exhibitors into pop-up sites; second, in producing a destabilized, deregulated economy that favours short-term investments and entrepreneurial business models; and third, in the positioning of audiences as consumers, particularly with the high-end experiences where costs facilitated feelings of frustration and a sense of being the victims of opportunistic exploitation. However, while these characteristics of neoliberal culture contribute to the growth of the pop-up exhibition sector, they do not account for the complexity of their economic models, which often draw on a mixed funding model and a mutually beneficial relationship with the local tourist industry; this will be explored further in Chapter 4.

Notes

1 Lisa Williams offers an account of the launch event for online film magazine *Electric Sheep*, which unfortunately includes a typo for the date which should read '16 December 2007' not '2008': http://www.electricsheepmagazine.co.uk/features/2008/01/09/making-cinema-magical-again-secret-cinema- launch/

2 The Secret Cinema-Disney partnership was announced in January 2020, reported at: https://www.campaignlive.co.uk/article/disney-partners-secret-cinema-create-global-immersive- experiences/1671958; Media coverage of developments in immersive television can be found at: https://www.theguardian.com/business/2019/sep/29/experience-economy-peaky-blinders-friends-stranger- things (accessed 16 February 2020).

3 For example, Secret Cinema refer to their productions as 'immersive cinema experiences' at https://www.secretcinema.org/ (accessed 16 August 2020).

4 In 2015 *The Empire Strikes Back* was the forty-eighth highest-grossing film of the year, in 2017 *Moulin Rouge!* was sixty-first, in 2018 *Blade Runner* was sixty-forth and *Casino Royale* was the thirty-fifth highest-grossing film of 2019. See https://www.boxofficemojo.com/intl/uk/yearly/?yr=2015&p=.htm (accessed 12 February 2020).

5 http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf (accessed 20 September 2019).

6 Atkinson and Kennedy provide a detailed outline of the differences between these two categories in the introduction to *Live Cinema*, 2018: 4; Martin Barker provides

an audience study of live streaming in the exhibition sector in *Live to your Local Cinema*, 2012; the Live Cinema website also provides a similar definition: http://livecinema.org.uk/about/what-is-live-cinema/ (accessed 20 September 2019).

7 For example, Steppinout Movie Nights, founded in 2016, organizes pop-up screenings in many Indian cities: https://www.facebook.com/steppinoutmovienights/

8 For example, see this article on the rise of pop-up hotels, which references the influential Harris Report: https://www.siteminder.com/r/trends-advice/hotel-travel-industry-trends/rise-popup-hotels-alternative- room-options/ (accessed 12 January 2020).

9 Taken from the Live Cinema Conference report, comment made by Jade Desumala of Rooftop Cinemas: https://www.academia.edu/31352368/Live_Cinema_Conference_Report (accessed 3 September 2019).

10 Statistics on the demographic profile for Live Cinema in the UK can be found at: http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf. The sample of interviewees for this chapter was composed of fourteen female and twelve male participants (none identified as non-binary); six from generation Y, fourteen millennials, four generation Xers and two baby boomers; twenty were university educated, two were still studying and four finished their education aged eighteen.

11 See the review of Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back* by Catherine Hudson at http://www.juniormagazine.co.uk/days-out/review-secret-cinema-presents-star-wars-the-empire-strikes- back-family-day-out/20518.html.

12 Statistics taken from Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) p. 5, found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).

13 While this might be industry speculation, it has been reported fairly widely: https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/heat-vision/secret-cinema-tackle-disney-movies-immersive- experiences-1272343; https://www.cityam.com/secret-cinema-signs-deal-with-disney-for-immersive-film- productions/ (accessed 3 February 2020).

14 Interview with Fabien Riggall in Dezeen, found at: https://www.dezeen.com/2018/09/05/interview-secret- cinema-fabien-riggall-new-film-experience/ (accessed 13 January 2019).

15 Promotional material taken from the Backyard Cinema website found at: https://www.backyardcinema.co.uk/winter-night-garden/ (accessed 17 July 2019).

16 For examples, see https://heatworld.com/entertainment/trending/best-winter-pop-up-cinemas-christmas/ and https://www.designmynight.com/london/whats-on/halloween-film-screenings-in-london (accessed 16 December 2018).

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18 Found at: https://justlittlechanges.com/2018/11/the-hierarchy-of-giving/ (accessed 16 December 2018).
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21 Discussed at https://www.anglotopia.net/british-entertainment/brit-tv/british-christmas-a-history-of-the- snowman-by-raymond-briggs/ (accessed 12 January 2020).
22 https://memoirsofametrogirl.com/2018/12/09/the-snowman-experience-review-backyard-cinema-winter-wonderland-immersive-screening-2018/ (accessed 23 February 2019).
23 http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf
24 http://livecinema.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Live-Cinema-Report-2016-web-res.pdf
25 See https://www.boxofficemojo.com/intl/uk/yearly/?yr=2015&p=.htm for details of UK box office for 2015 (accessed 12 March 2016).
26 https://www.radiotimes.com/news/2015-06-12/secret-cinema-the-empire-strikes-back-review-what-theme-parks-were-always-supposed-to-be/ (accessed 12 March 2016).
27 Statistics taken from Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) p. 2, found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).
28 Taken from the *Guardian* article 'Boom for Experience Economy as Hit TV Shows Enter Real World' by Mark Sweeney, found at: https://www.theguardian.com/business/2019/sep/29/experience-economy-peaky-blinders- friends-stranger-thing (accessed 22 February 2020).
29 Statistics taken from Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) p. 5, found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).
30 Taken from the Big Red Group's 'The "Experience Economy": Riding a Rise Tide' (2019) p. 14, found at: https://www.thebigredgroup.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/The-Experience-Economy-Riding-a-rising- tide-white-paper-by-the-Big-Red-Group.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).
31 Ibid, p. 1.

2

Virtual reality and immersive technologies

Remember, concentrate on the moment. Feel, don't think, use your instincts.
Qui-Gon Jinn, *Episode 1: The Phantom Menace,* 1999

Introduction

This chapter investigates the rapid market expansion for immersive cinematic experiences using virtual, augmented and mixed reality technologies. It examines audience responses to these experiences using three case studies: *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire* (The Void 2017), the Taiwanese cinematic virtual reality (CVR) feature film *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2019) and the Canadian animation *Draw Me Close* (Jordan Tannahill 2017). These three case studies illustrate the spectrum of experiences available in this burgeoning sector of the immersive entertainment industry. Qualitative methodologies are employed to investigate user responses to these technologically driven experiences, framing them within existing conceptual debates surrounding presence, empathy and agency/interactivity. These are examined within both broader theoretical frameworks around liveness simultaneity, and public discourses problematising interactive VR technologies in which users 'actively shape their own experiences' as addictive, antisocial and potentially harmful.[1] A primary focus of this investigation, therefore, involves a sustained emphasis on what I am terming participatory VR, and the social characteristics of virtual experiences.

While the use of VR technology within the film industry can be dated back to *The Lawnmower Man* (Brett Leonard 1992), it was when Oculus started to develop the new, lighter Rift headset in 2012 that the sector began to expand at a significant rate.[2] In the last decade film festivals in the global north, such as Tribeca and Sundance, have frequently showcased the intersection between virtual reality and cinema, and thus the relationship between the two has

become increasingly mainstream.[3] However, despite these developments in both technological innovation and distribution circuits, it has been argued that we have still not yet reached the point of medium invisibility, and that discourses surrounding VR remain firmly focused on the problematic relationship between the apparatus and the body (Golding 2017; Blackman 2019). This qualitative study of responses to the three chosen case studies also therefore considers the extent to which user accounts reflect issues centred on the technological apparatus, and how important this is to their experiences.

Broadly speaking, virtual reality refers to computer-simulated immersive experiences generated via the use of headsets, which substitute a user's physical body in the real world with a virtual first-person perspective belonging to someone else. However, as VR technologies have evolved and produced a wider range of cultural practices and applications, an increasingly diverse set of distinctions has emerged. The most commonly used terms at the time of writing are 'virtual reality' (VR), 'augmented reality' (AR) and 'mixed reality' (MR) experiences. Whereas VR experiences involve complete immersion into a virtual environment, AR involves the overlay of virtual content onto the real-world environment, as has been popularised by the *Pokémon Go!* phenomenon. MR (sometimes known as hybrid reality) provides a further alternative in which virtual content is overlaid on to the real environment and is simultaneously anchored to it through the use of haptic enablers. The MR format creates the potential for greater interaction between the virtual and real-world environments; this is investigated in the *Draw Me Close* case study in this chapter. A further category that has recently emerged is that of CVR. CVR is a technological development which enables individual users to experience artificial worlds in 360°. Unlike more established forms of VR, the user's ability to move autonomously within the virtual world is restricted to their ability to choose an angle from which to view the scene. Although there is some dispute as to whether or not 360° videos can be classified as VR, they increasingly are in both the worlds of fiction and journalism, as noted by Watson (2017). CVR therefore offers a different form of immersive experience to more established interactive VR technologies, and these will be discussed in the case study investigating audience responses to *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2019).

The rapid expansion of the VR industry has been accompanied by the emergence of a diverse and often contradictory field of academic research examining audience engagement with VR technologies. The wide range of scholarly disciplines now focused on investigating VR technologies includes computer science, engineering, medicine, media studies, psychology and

philosophy, thus illustrating the recent intersection of academic research with commercial enterprise in the sphere of media education. Industry expansion has been enabled, in part, by large-scale government investment in the sector across the global north, which in turn has facilitated the development of research units focused on VR technology at key academic institutions.[4] Throughout the 2010s, cultural policymakers in the global north have increasingly turned their attention to developing the immersive and interactive media industries. In the UK, Peter Bazalgette's *Independent Review of the Creative Industries* (2017) placed a specific emphasis on the development of immersive and augmented media industries, outlining key recommendations on how the creative industries should underpin the UK's future economic growth and arguing that 'government should ensure the UK builds a reputation as the most highly skilled nation to produce screen-based content that exploits these technologies. This includes direct investment into VR/AR research and extending the highly successful UK Games Fund' (Bazalgette 2017: 6). The report highlights the necessity for different groups of experts across the media industries and education sectors to work collaboratively across film, theatre and music to compete in the 'global race' to become key players in this sector at an international level; this can be achieved by nurturing geographical areas with 'a strong cultural, heritage and sporting offer, enhancing the attractiveness of locations to live and work and acting as an accelerator for regeneration' (Bazalgette 2017: 16). The report resulted in a funding call fielded by the UK Research Councils in 2017/18, and in September 2018, £80 million was allocated across nine creative clusters identified in the UK.[5] The funding call has, in turn, facilitated financial assistance for a broad range of VR, AR and MR projects across the UK, thereby accelerating the growth of this sector and impacting on the development of the experience economy. The direction of UK cultural policy around the immersive media industry thus can be understood as building on earlier instrumentalist policies established under New Labour around the creative industries, which were rooted in Thatcherite neoliberalism facilitate (Garnham 2006; Belfiore 2012; Hesmondhalgh et al. 2015). Although this chapter is being broadly positioned at the commercial end of the experiential cinema spectrum, the three case studies investigated here point to the complexity of funding possibilities available to many creatives developing VR experiences. The investment being made in these technologies by some governments in the global north establish that there is a high possibility that what might appear to be a commercial model of VR entertainment, such as the National Theatre co-production *Draw Me Close*, is also the recipient of public sector funding.

Theorizing and investigating the virtual experience

This overview of scholarly work on immersive cinema identifies some of the key theoretical frameworks that have developed in relation to VR, AR and MR. In particular, it focuses on the concepts of presence, empathy and agency/interactivity as approaches for understanding and interpreting audience experiences of these technologies. Additionally, this chapter considers a range of recent empirical studies and data generated by research on the uptake and use of VR, AR and MR and problematises the way in which participatory and social forms of immersive cinema have been understood as being distinct and separate from technologically enabled forms of immersion, such as those typical to VR experiences.

One of the most frequently employed concepts for analysing VR experiences is that of presence (Biocca 2015; Slater and Wilbur 1997; Diemer et al. 2015; Lee 2004; Lombard and Jones 2015; Steuer 1992; Witmer and Singer 1998). However, the concept of presence has been discussed in relation to cinema as far back as the mid-twentieth century. In 1951, Andre Bazin wrote an essay refuting claims that cinema could not evoke the presence of an actor in the same way that theatre could (Bazin 1967: 97). His observation formed part of a broader valorisation of cinema in relation to theatre, through an argument hinging on the technological advantage of cinema 'thanks to the artificial proximity provided by photographic enlargement' (Bazin 1967: 98). The role of technology has, then, long been central to scholarly discussions of the concept of presence, and so it is perhaps not surprising that this concept is regularly invoked in relation to VR experiences. As the concept of presence has been widely adopted across a range of academic fields of enquiry relating to VR, it has consequently been defined and employed in a number of divergent ways. Indeed, computer scientists Lombard and Jones argue that the haphazard and often contradictory manner in which the concept of presence has been taken up 'threatens to inhibit our progress in understanding presence phenomena' (Lombard and Jones 2015: 13). Rather than adopting a position on these conflicting uses of the concept, this overview maps out some of their commonalities and identifies the ways in which they are relevant to the case studies discussed in this chapter. Presence is most frequently employed as a concept for gauging the extent to which a participant feels present in a virtual environment (Slater and Wilbur 1997; Diemer et al. 2015). In an early empirical study designed to measure presence

in virtual environments, Bob Witmer and Michael Singer define presence as 'the subjective experience of being in one place or environment, even when one is physically situated in another' (Witmer and Singer 1998: 225). This definition has since been expanded on by, among others, communications scholar Frank Biocca, who suggests that 'the sense of presence, be it fragile and fleeting or sometimes deep and traumatising, is the construct used to describe, measure, and sometimes evaluate and design and optimise systems that provide that ability' (2015: 2).

While these basic definitions differ slightly in emphasis, their broad understanding of what presence is does not vary greatly. The concept of presence is further subdivided by Kwan Min Lee, who identifies a range of discrete subcategories. These include telepresence (spatial presence), self-presence and social presence (Lee 2004). Telepresence can be understood as 'the extent to which one feels present in the mediated environment, rather than in the immediate physical environment' (Steuer 1992: 75) and is often what is meant by the more general usage of the term 'presence', as outlined earlier. This understanding of presence is measured by how vividly the user experiences the environmental and spatial properties of the mediated environment, rather than their physical one. Lombard and Ditton argue that an indication of strong telepresence is that people should no longer be aware that their experiences are being mediated through technology (Lombard and Ditton 1997). Self-presence, in comparison, does not focus on the relationship with the environment but is instead measured by how vividly someone feels connected to their virtual body, emotions or identity. Finally, social presence concerns the relationship with another co-present sentient being within the virtual environment. As an integral part of shared virtual environments, social presence is discussed in relation to the case studies on *Hold Me Close* and *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire* as a characteristic of participatory VR.

A key point of consideration here is the parallels that emerge between the concepts of presence and simultaneity, or liveness, and how they are employed to communicate a cinematic 'experience'. In the first instance, they appear to be diametrically opposed, in that presence, in the context of VR experiences, is by definition a mediatised state. However, the desired effects of presence and liveness/simultaneity bear much in common. Returning to Barker's observations on his 2001 audience survey, he concludes that for audiences who valued live theatre, 'it feels natural and inevitable that screened images should leave you "distanced", while staged ones make you feel part of the event' (Barker 2003: 26).

If the measurements used to characterise these states are those of 'distance' and 'closeness', then the experience of presence in a VR environment is more akin to Auslander's intimate conceptualisation of liveness than it is to the 'distance' of the mediatised screen image; VR is, in its conception, an attempt to eradicate that distance. A key observation of this chapter, then, is that technologically driven experiences of presence within virtual cinematic worlds, that successfully achieve their objective, render the live-mediatised discourse around traditional screen media redundant.

Research on virtual environments conducted by social scientists is less likely to use laboratory controls and more commonly acknowledges wider social and cultural factors. Witmar and Singer's 1998 quantitative survey of 152 US college students attempts to measure presence experienced within a virtual environment in relation to eighteen key factors. One of these factors is 'meaningfulness of experience', which refers to the relationship between the VR experience and the participant's individual disposition and background. However, the majority of the factors Witmer and Singer use to measure presence relate to sensory perception, forms of control, interface design and so on. Perhaps not surprisingly, one of their key findings is simply that participants who experienced simulator sickness symptoms reported less presence than those who did not. This type of study highlights the limitations of a purely quantitative approach to research in this field. In certain respects, then, qualitative research conducted within this field appears to offer a more effective method for understanding participant engagement with VR technologies.

A second key focus that emerges in discussions of VR, AR and MR technologies is that of empathy. In 2015, VR was described as the 'ultimate empathy machine' which enables people to viscerally experience anything from another person's point of view (Milk 2016). Indeed, a number of scholars and cultural commentators have claimed that virtual experiences can enhance empathy levels among users (Jones 2017; Sanchez-Laws 2017), while others dispute these claims (Bollmer 2017; Hassan 2019). Hassan argues that VR experiences merely offer 'a sophisticated camera apparatus that produces an integrated spectacle; a capacity to stupefy through an immersive representation' (Hassan 2019: 15), and that empathy cannot be achieved merely through the evolution of a more sophisticated technological apparatus. This argument will be explored in relation to the three case studies examined in this chapter, each of which employs VR, AR or MR technologies in a different way to achieve an immersive effect on its participants. Taking into

consideration the broad range of research currently being undertaken on VR, it is perhaps not surprising that the findings of empirical studies conducted across diverse disciplinary contexts and using different methodological approaches have produced conflicting results. Studies undertaken in the field of psychology, for example, are most frequently conducted using strict laboratory controls and measure participant responses within these controlled conditions.

Some of these studies have investigated the effect of immersive technologies on emotional responses to films. In 2010, Visch, Tan and Molenaar (2010) conducted a psychological experiment in which two types of emotions were measured in relation to an immersive cinematic experience and found that both types of emotional response were intensified by high levels of immersion. They concluded that 'the results are explained by suggesting that highly immersive cinema has its impact on a basic dimension of emotion, namely arousal that underlies both types of emotions' (Visch, Tan and Molenaar 2010). However, psychological studies which have been conducted outside of laboratory conditions have produced more complex and nuanced sets of findings. Educational psychologists gathering empirical data on VR use within a pedagogical context have concluded, for example, that 'for a variety of reasons, including brain development and life experiences, adolescent responses may be very different than those of adults with whom content is play-tested' (Castaneda et al. 2018: 459). Indeed, the differences between laboratory-controlled tests and observational research conducted in naturally occurring settings invariably highlight the need to develop methods for gathering empirical data that both acknowledge and factor in 'real-life' experiences, and broader social and cultural contexts.

Findings of research conducted at Stanford University focus on participant subjectivity and issues around distraction due to weaknesses in the design. Herrera et al. (2018) suggest that there is lack of empirical evidence underpinning claims that VR is a more effective method of eliciting empathy than more traditional perspective-taking media (Herrera et al. 2018). Perhaps not surprisingly, claims that VR technologies function as an 'empathy machine' have been strongly critiqued within the field of media and cultural studies. In her *Five Theses on Virtual Reality and Sociality* (2018), Deborah Levitt highlights some of the issues around the conceptualisation of empathy within these claims. Levitt contends these claims are problematic in the way that they 'appeal to a sameness of perspective where the otherness of the other is excluded. We need

rather to affirm a version of empathy that embraces alterity, that is, that includes an awareness of the other's otherness' (Levitt 2018: n.p.). Similarly, Lynda Joy Gerry's research on VR and empathy identifies a range of definitions around the concept, arguing that 'while empathy may involve overlap, sharing, or merging, it is crucial to preservation of the self-other distinction in order to differentiate one's own emotions from that of a target' (Gerry 2017: 12). Gerry contends that forms of empathy which maintain the self-other distinction facilitate a more accurate reading of the other person's psychological and emotional state. Furthermore, Gerry advocates the development of perspective-taking virtual reality, also known as virtual alterity, rather than VR experiences involving avatar embodiment.

A third concept often discussed in relation to VR, AR and MR is that of agency/interactivity. This focus is unsurprising given the frequent association of passive media consumption with physical inactivity in the context of cultural policy documents and public discourse.[6] This often results from a problematic conflation of activity and interactivity which fails to observe the basic definition of interactivity as a two-way communicative process. Marie-Laure Ryan's theoretical framework for analysing levels of interactivity in digital storytelling offers a useful five-tiered approach which she calls 'the interactive onion' comprised of (i) peripheral interactivity, whereby the narrative is framed by an interactive interface which does not impact on the story itself; (ii) interactivity affecting narrative, in which the material of the story is predetermined, but its presentation is variable; (iii) interactivity enabling variations within a predetermined story, in which the user has a role in the story, but the system retains overall control of the narrative trajectory; (iv) real-time story generation, when the material is partly generated by the system and partly by the user and (v) meta-interactivity, in which the user is directly involved in creating new dimensions and layers of the story (Ryan 2011: 37–59). This framework for assessing degrees of interactivity and agency is useful for identifying and evaluating different forms of VR experience and the way users experience them.

Scholarship on interactive documentaries (i-docs) also offers pertinent theoretical frameworks for approaching research into the development of immersive VR experiences. Experiments analysing interactivity in relation to films date back to research carried out on interactive documentaries (i-docs) and *The Aspen Movie Map* (Lippman 1978), which Judith Aston and Sandra Gaudenzi cite as the first attempt to digitally document and create an interactive experience (Aston and Gaudenzi 2012: 126). In tandem with the growth of

the VR sector more broadly, Gaudenzi observes an exponential growth in the production of interactive documentaries from the mid-2000s onwards (Gaudenzi 2013: 28). Gaudenzi proposes four modes of interactive documentary (the conversational, the hypertext, the experiential and the participative), which bear several similarities with Ryan's interactive onion (Gaudenzi 2013: 69).

In rethinking how interactive, participatory and social forms of immersive cinema have been conceptualised as being distinct and separate from technologically enabled forms of immersion, such as those typical to VR experiences, this chapter problematises previous observations I have made about the concept of immersion (Pett 2016). To date, VR experiences have often been characterised as highly individualised, static forms of mediatised entertainment. In *Live Cinema*, for example, Atkinson and Kennedy sketch out a 'participation to immersion' continuum, which positions an 'experience community' at one end, and the 'immobile body' within an 'immersive technology' at the other (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 10–11). This is a distinction I have previously made myself (Pett 2016) and one that has been argued by scholars such as Recuber, who contends that 'immersive cinema emphasises technical achievement to the detriment of social and artistic relevance, and embeds a passive consumerist ideology within the spaces of contemporary cinema-going' (Recuber 2007). Furthermore, government reports on immersive technologies discuss the impact of VR on users' social lives, reporting loneliness, isolation and a 'withdrawal from real life'.[7] The three case studies, *Secrets of the Empire, The Deserted* and *Draw Me Close*, will therefore be employed to investigate these conflicting claims around audience engagement with VR, AR and MR cinematic technologies and to shift the research focus on user experiences of participatory VR.

Audiences for VR, AR and MR experiences

The audiences for VR, AR and MR cinematic experiences were investigated by gathering qualitative data in the United Kingdom and the United States between 2014 and 2018. The material includes 14 interviews, an auto-ethnographic account and 226 reviews. The interviews were conducted with attendees who were contacted either at the exhibition site, or shortly afterwards via social media, and were selected to provide a cross section of respondents in terms of age, gender and educational background.[8] The sample is composed of seven male and seven female interviewees; 14 per cent are gen Z, 36 per cent are millennials,

36 per cent are gen X and 14 per cent are baby boomers. The interviews are semi-structured, allowing interviewees to digress around particular topics if they wish to (appendix 3), and each lasted approximately thirty to forty-five minutes. The analysis of the third case study, Jordan Tannahill's *Draw Me Close*, offers an auto-ethnographic study. As a one-to-one MR experience, *Draw Me Close* does not have a conventional audience of multiple participants, but a series of individual partakers of the experience; an auto-ethnographic methodology therefore offers a pragmatic approach for investigating this theatrical MR experience. Several media scholars have argued that auto-ethnographic approaches offer an appropriate method for researching spatial experiences (Roberts 2018: 7; Garner 2019a: 5), with the investigator adopting the identity of 'the researcher-as-bricoleur' (Roberts 2018: 3). The virtual assemblage of animation, theatre, haptic enablers and audio commentary in the case study *Draw Me Close* could therefore be understood as positioning me as researcher-as-virtual-bricoleur. As a methodological approach, this raises valid questions around the subjectivity of the analysis; however, because the design of the *Draw Me Close* experience is highly subjective and personalised, I argue that it requires this type of methodological approach. To offset this subjective analysis, discussion of reception materials in the form of online reviews posted by other audience members are also considered in this case study.

Case study one: The Void's *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire*

Commercial forms of virtual cinematic entertainment have been visible and accessible within the space of theme parks for significantly longer than they have at film festivals and cinemas. In 1998, Disney opened DisneyQuest, an indoor interactive media centre located in downtown Orlando and featuring many of their early VR experiences, such as *Aladdin's Magic Carpet Ride* and *Pirates of the Caribbean: Battle for Buccaneer Gold*. The 1990s also witnessed a new generation of smaller, technologically driven entertainment centres, exemplified by the Cinetropolis in Connecticut, which was replicated in the United States, Japan and locations across the global north (Williams and Hobson 1995; Griffiths 2008). Whereas established theme parks were typically situated in out-of-town locations, these smaller entertainment centres were developed in urban locations and capitalised on VR technologies as their key visitor attractions. Although many commercial VR experiences from the 1990s have now closed, they have

been superseded by a new generation of successful VR tourist attractions, such as *The Wizarding World of Harry Potter* at Universal Studios, Orlando, replicated in Osaka and Hollywood.

The Void, founded in 2016, is a US-based MR franchise that creates VR experiences using a combination of head-mounted displays, motion tracking and various haptic, audio and olfactory enablers. These enablers mean that users can walk around within the virtual environment and interact with various aspects of the physical space, in what is marketed as a 'hyper-reality experience'.[9] This hypertextual form of VR illustrates Ryan's second level of interactivity, in which the material of the story is predetermined, but its presentation is variable. However, *Secrets of the Empire* offers a more embodied experience than static VR experiences in which participants are seated in a chair and stimulated with visual information that does not match their physical environment. The haptic enablers are used to enhance presence, and their promotional tagline declares that 'you don't just experience The VOID, you're in it',[10] thus drawing on concepts of presence that are integral to analyses of VR.

In 2017, The Void announced their collaborative *Star Wars* project with ILMxLAB, the immersive entertainment wing of Lucasfilm and Industrial Light and Magic, and *Secrets of the Empire* was launched in tandem with the release of *Rogue One* (Gareth Edwards 2016). The experience initially opened in two venues, and the reviews were generally favourable, leading to a roll-out expansion to other venues; by 2019, The Void's *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire* had opened in multiple US locations (Anaheim, West Edmonton, Glendale, Las Vegas, Orlando, West Plano and Santa Monica), as well as in Toronto, and Genting, Malaysia. A temporary installation also opened for twelve weeks in London, in December 2017. This case study combines a reception analysis of 226 reviews, sourced via the Nexis database, with six interviews conducted with visitors to The Void's *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire* experience.[11] It does not set out to be a representative survey of user experiences for the attraction but instead offers a number of insights into the ways participants engage with, appreciate and critique this MR addition to the *Star Wars* universe.

The design of the *Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire* experience facilitates a collaborative and social experience by grouping participants together in teams of four. These groups are set an assignment to recover Imperial intelligence via a video message briefing from Cassian Andor (Diego Luna), in which the team is informed about Imperial cargo on the molten lava planet of Mustafar. Their mission is to retrieve this cargo, which 'is vital to the rebellion's survival',

and means that they have to adopt an undercover disguise, as storm troopers. Central to this assignment, and the *Secrets of the Empire* experience, is the instruction to participants to 'act Imperial'. A headset and haptic enablers are then fitted to each participant, and they enter the virtual world in their storm trooper identities. The design of the immersive experience, which foregrounds teamwork and group participation, suggests that technological developments are addressing and successfully circumnavigating issues of social isolation raised in cultural policy contexts and are already offering participatory VR experiences.

The role played by Diego Luna in *Secrets of the Empire* is significant for several of the interviewees and imbues the experience with a textual legitimacy. One interviewee reported that he 'got really excited when Diego Luna appeared and told us our mission . . . that was when it felt real, that we were entering the *Star Wars* universe' (Interviewee #32; A3, Q4). Others expressed similar sentiments and found the entry point of the experience particularly memorable; this echoes the findings discussed in Chapter 1, which establishes 'the Narnia moment' point of entry into many experiential cinema events the most memorable part of the experience. Their enjoyment of this aspect of the *Star Wars* narrative world also implies that the star presence in the experience generated a form of authenticity for the *Star Wars* fans engaging with it. Visual Effects Supervisor at ILMxLAB, Ben Snow, reveals that this was a key consideration in the design, explaining that 'in keeping with our goal of creating an authentic experience that seamlessly matched the look and feel of the *Star Wars* films, a crucial element in the development of the project was Alan Tudyk (K-2SO) and Diego Luna (Captain Cassian Andor) reprising their roles from *Rogue One: A Star Wars Story*'.[12] These findings echo research conducted by Abby Waysdorf and Stijn Reijnders on fan experiences at *The Wizarding World of Harry Potter* (2018), which found that visitors were reassured by J. K. Rowling's involvement in the theme park. Waysdorf and Reijnders argue that 'if we think of the park as a cultural creation or medium, it opens up the potential for a legitimate encounter with the story-world. The park is accepted as a valid adaptation' (Waysdorf and Reijnders 2018: 179). The validity of *Secrets of the Empire* is more complex, in that some long-term *Star Wars* fans question Disney's ownership and direction of the franchise (Proctor 2019). However, for the small sample who were interviewed for this study, Disney's involvement is not a significant factor in their appreciation of the experience; the consumer choice they have already taken, to visit a Disney-owned attraction, arguably filters out any anti-Disney *Star Wars* fans from this study.

As a textual feature, this differentiates *Secrets of the Empire* from other VR experiences inspired by Hollywood blockbusters. In her study of VR cinema and stardom, Sarah Thomas observes that

> in much Hollywood-derived TVR content, the sense of 'stardom' is often removed, even in paratextual connections to films with strong star identities, such as *Blade Runner 2049*, *The Martian*, *Ghostbusters*, *John Wick, Rocky/Creed* and The Marvel Cinematic Universe (amongst others), which create VR adaptations similar to first-person POV video game adaptations. Seemingly, a star is a disruptive or incompatible textual element; VR is about the immersion of the 'I', and there is no 'I' in the (necessary otherness) of film stardom. (Thomas 2019: 458–9)

This analysis thus highlights a key difference between *Secrets of the Empire* and other VR experiences inspired by Hollywood content, indicating that perhaps in this respect it has more in common with VR experiences located at theme parks.

Many of the online reviewers and interviewees focused on the MR dimension of the experience and the successful way it employs haptic enablers to coordinate the virtual landscape with the physical environment. In this respect, the appreciation of the immersive qualities of the experience was clearly linked to overlapping forms of presence:

> If you get shot, the chest piece you're wearing vibrates, giving you an instant warning that you might want to take cover. The immersion also extends to the playing area, with special effects such as jets of warm air making you feel like you're really in a volcanic landscape. The entire experience was like the grandest round of paintball I've ever played, with the blend of VR and practical effects totally blurring the line between the game and reality. (Suttun 2017: n.p.)

This review highlights the success of *Secrets of the Empire* in facilitating a strong sense of both telepresence and self-presence. The reviewer's description of the haptic enablers, such as the air jets, illustrates how the virtual experience simulates the physical sensations of the narrative environment, both in terms of the sensations of the fictional body and the verisimilitude of the landscape. The level of attention to detail, and the consistency of this detail throughout the experience, was commented on by several of the interviewees, who thought it 'was very intense and evocative' (Interviewee #33; A3, Q4) and 'all of your senses are stimulated throughout, there are smells, sounds, blasts of heat, it just feels very real' (Interviewee #34: A3, Q4). Several commented on the moment they saw the blasters lined up on the wall and the accurate match

of the virtual experience of reaching out to take one with the haptic sensation of picking it up.

Many of the reviews of *Secrets of the Empire* focus on these haptic and olfactory features of the experience and their ability to generate a sense of presence for the participants. In the six interviews I conducted, this was frequently linked to an appreciation of the 'authenticity' of the *Star Wars* universe. There is a connection made by *Star Wars* fans between the sense of presence achieved in their experience of *Secrets of the Empire* and the perceived authenticity of the attraction as an aspect of the *Star Wars*. One interviewee explained that

> I did the *Star Wars* experience in Glendale and it was amazing, really mind-blowing and much better than I had anticipated. The excitement of actually walking around the planet and taking part in a mission. Everything about it was convincing, the droids, the blasters, the stormtrooper outfits, it feels like you're in *Star Wars*. (Interviewee #34; A3, Q1)

Here, the sense of both presence and agency is framed by the interviewee's *Star Wars* fandom. Other interviewees discussed the pleasure of being 'transported to a galaxy far, far away' (Interviewee #32: A3, Q1) or expressed the desire 'to stay in that universe for much longer' (Interviewee #35: A3, Q1). This is not dissimilar to the form of fan engagement with fictional worlds created by Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, in which fans enter into a pop-up recreation of Tatooine (Pett 2016, 2019). The intensity generated by this MR experience is, then, far more akin to emotional affect rather than to a form of empathy.

The degree of presence and authenticity described by these interviewees is also evaluated alongside an appreciation of the agentic qualities of *Secrets of the Empire,* in terms of the game-playing elements it offers to participants. These qualities were also discussed by a reviewer for *The Verge*, who offered a description of the experience that focused on the successful mapping together of the virtual and physical aspects of the immersive environment:

> When I waved my hands in front of my face, there they were, clad in the white-and-black gloves of a stormtrooper. Moments later, when I stood on a skiff approaching the Imperial facility, I felt the heat from the lava below, while the smoky smell of Mustafar's atmosphere filled my nostrils. Later, when engaged in a firefight with stormtroopers, I felt a sharp haptic buzz whenever I caught a stray blaster bolt – not painful, but not exactly pleasant, either. (Bishop 2017: n.p.)

One of the recurring points of discussion among the interviewees that did not feature so strongly in the online reviews of *Secrets of the Empire* was the focus on

the sociability of the experience. All six of the interviewees attended the attraction with friends or family members and commented on this aspect of their experience. One opined that 'it is something I think works best with friends, I would definitely recommend going as a special outing, for a birthday or celebration, it was good value entertainment' (Interviewee #36; A3, Q3), while another commented, 'I took my mother-in-law and nieces with me and we had a blast. It's like crossing laser tag with VR, everyone loved it, you don't have to be a *Star Wars* fan and have all the fan knowledge beforehand' (Interviewee #37; A3, Q3). These testimonies infer that VR is not the insular and antisocial form of entertainment that it is often perceived to be, suggesting parallels with reviews of Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, in which participants discussed it as being just as enjoyable for first-time viewers of the film as it was for committed fans (Pett 2019: 174). The intergenerational aspect of both these *Star Wars* experiences suggests that one-off events designed to offer a more immersive or interactive experience than simply watching a film at a conventional cinema are often highly sociable occasions.

Case study two: Festival circuit CVR in *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2017)

Taiwanese film director Tsai Ming-liang is known on the international festival circuit as the 'master of slow cinema' (Bitel 2019). *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang 2017) is a VR collaboration between HTC Vive, Art Cinema and MSI, first presented at the Venice Film Festival in 2017. The data analysed for this case study was generated in April and May 2019, following a series of high-profile events staged in London to celebrate Ming-liang's work. These were located at venues including Tate Modern and Asia House, London, in conjunction with the Taiwan Film Festival, which was held in the UK for the first time in 2019. The film was presented in 8K, rather than the 4K format screened in Venice. This case study draws on my own auto-ethnographic experience of watching the film, along with material from eight interviews conducted with audience member who attended the same screening, and a number of online reviews and comments made on social media.[13]

The Deserted was screened from 5 to 8 April at a pop-up cinema located in the basement of Asia House, London. The fifty-five-minute long feature film was screened seven times a day within a carefully designed space which accommodated approximately twenty audience members. Unlike many film festivals, there was no

cafe, store or other pop-up facilities situated around the screening space; it was, quite simply, a basement room filled with swivel chairs, headsets and computers. Prior to the screening, audience members waited upstairs in the foyer of Asia House. There were no refreshments, leaflets or other paratextual items to offer guidance or prepare the viewers for this cinematic experience. In the case of the screening I attended, the audience members waited in silence and did not converse with each other. This hushed reverence was suggestive of an alternative, or certainly an art house, form of cinematic experience. In this respect, even though the film was watched in a screening room with other audience members, there was very little sense of it being a communal experience. Even before the screening began, those attending appeared to have retreated into their own imaginations.

The quiet, insular behaviour of those attending the screening at Asia House reflects the tone and pace of the film, which facilitates an inward, meditative form of audience engagement. *The Deserted* offers an intimate portrayal of a day in the life of a Taiwanese man who appears to suffer from a chronic neck condition. It takes place in a derelict tenement building situated within a lush, rural Taiwanese setting. There is no dialogue, and the characters we follow remain nameless to the audience, with no biographical detail offered to us at any point of the narrative. Unlike other VR, AR and MR attractions, this is not a first-person experience. The audience member is an invisible spectator with a 360-degree view in every direction, experienced from a fixed point within each scene. The sense of realism is representational, then, rather than experiential, producing an element of voyeurism suggested through witnessing these scenes of domestic intimacy. The CVR technology differentiates *The Deserted* from first-person virtual narratives, in that it does not offer an agentic experience for the audience members and, in this respect, can be mapped onto Ryan's most basic level, that of peripheral interactivity, whereby the narrative is framed by an interactive interface which does not impact on the story itself.

Several of the interviewees commented on this almost voyeuristic quality of the film. One reflected that 'we are looking into these worlds, but we are not a part of them' (Interviewee #38; A3, Q1). While initially this did not feel uncomfortable to those who were interviewed, the degree of intimacy evolved throughout the film and this produced more varied responses. The first part of the film follows the central character in the morning, being watched over by an older woman as she prepares some food, and later we observe these two characters gardening in a lush, tropical environment. One interviewee commented that they were 'moved by the intimacy of the ordinary domestic rituals' and 'liked the

slow pace of the morning scenes, it was like the antithesis of a Hollywood film' (Interviewee #39; A3, Q6). However, at another unspecified moment, we see the male character in a plastic bathtub, cradling a large white fish which appears to be his pet. In an instance of narrative development, we later witness an intimate encounter in the bathtub, as it appears that the fish transforms into a beautiful woman who embraces him and initiates a sexual encounter. One interviewee commented that this felt 'awkward, a jarring sense of closeness, being in the water with the naked man and his fish' (Interviewee #40; A3, Q3). The use of CVR is interesting here, in that by positioning the viewer within the bathtub, rather than looking on from the outside, they are confronted with the innate voyeurism of the cinematic experience.

While there is no dialogue in *The Deserted*, the film is full of evocative, multidimensional sounds which were discussed by most of the interviewees. One remarked on 'the intensity of scuffing shoes on hard concrete floor, and the chirruping and humming of birds and insects outside' (Interviewee #39; appendix 2, Q3) and another said they appreciated 'the sounds of a thunderstorm brewing followed by heavy, theatrical torrents of rain splashing on concrete . . . then forming pools inside the tenement building' (Interviewee #42; A3, Q3). This illusory haptic sensation led some of the interviewees to describe the experience as 'feeling completely encapsulated by the landscape, and at that point the sense of immersion was complete, I thought I could almost reach out and touch the plants' (Interviewee #44; A3, Q3). Several noted that there are moments when the plants seemed to almost spring into the viewer's lap, and there was a tangible sense of being immersed in the lush, Taiwanese landscape. Another of the interviewees commented that 'when it started to rain, and it was splashing onto the window ledges, I almost hallucinated water spraying on to my face. It was that vivid' (Interviewee #40; A3, Q3). This suggests that when the visual and aural senses are intensely stimulated in this way, they start to project other sensory experiences which are not actually part of the VR design. In this case study, the sense of presence is therefore enhanced through the stimulated imagination of the viewers. In her review of the film, Elena Gorfinkel reports that it is 'eerily haptic' and 'entices the viewer into a unique photogenic (VR-genic?) reverie, as wind shakes green fronds, rain gushes into open windows, steam fogs the air and light beams dapple walls' (Gorfinkel 2019). It is significant, then, that while there are no haptic enablers built into the design of this VR production, the intensity of the visual and aural stimulation is so vivid that for some audience members, the experience evokes the sensation of touch.

While at some points within the film this audio-visual intensity and intimacy clearly complemented Ming-liang's slow meditative style of cinematic storytelling, at other times, such as when the camera is positioned within the main character's bathtub, it was experienced as spatially disorienting. Some of the interviewees discussed the sense of disengagement they experienced when they were within the water and yet not able to experience any haptic sensations of it. At these moments, the disconnect between the audience member's body and their audio-visual awareness disrupted the sense of telepresence. One interviewee describes this experience as 'frustrating' and added, 'I wanted to smell and to touch. I found the audio-visual emphasis of the experience oddly restrictive, in a way that I never do with a regular cinema-going experience' (Interviewee #42; A3, Q2). The degree of presence experienced by the audience members interviewed for this chapter was therefore quite uneven throughout the duration of the fifty-five-minute long film and reflected some of the issues Grau and Sandifer both highlight around technological erasure of emotional investment.

There was some discussion in the reception of the film regarding the extent to which VR did or did not suit Ming-liang's established signature style of long takes. In an interview, the director draws attention to the ways in which he had to adapt his cinematographic style to fit with the format, explaining that 'the VR camera has certain restrictions, in that you have to maintain a certain distance, otherwise you'd get distortion. Once I'd discovered the space, and understood the 360-degree concept, it became more about regenerating the idea of how people participate in the scene' (Ming-liang in *Thrift,* 2019). The composition and storytelling potential offered by 360 VR format is thus both restrictive and enabling in different ways.

The increased awareness offered through the 360-degree vision also produced a range of emotional responses. For some, this was complementary to Ming-liang's slow, meditative style of cinema, and enabled them to appreciate the detail and texture of the mise-en-scène. One interviewee was almost ecstatic in their appreciation of this, describing it as 'a revelation. This has changed cinema for me. The texture of the film was so powerful, I felt overwhelmed by melancholia' (Interviewee #45; A3, Q6). Gorfinkel also discusses an emotional response to *The Deserted*, posing the rhetorical question:

> One wonders if a VR experience can make one cry? Tsai answers in the affirmative, as this particular virtuality summons a nostalgic desire for home.

> As rain dramatically pours and gushes in an unexpected sex scene, the sound of nature's throbbing persistence floods the senses and assails the emotions. (Gorfinkel 2019)

These feelings of nostalgia and desire are not suggestive of VR's potential as an 'empathy machine', however. Instead, Ming-liang uses the intensity offered by VR technology to stimulate a more nuanced, reflective set of emotions.

Others were intrigued by the possibilities the technology offered, noting, for example, 'the scene in which the older woman walked away, down the road. Then I turned around, and there was a woman in white standing at the tenement window, I don't know how long she had been there. That was interesting, when multiple characters appeared at the same time in one scene' (Interviewee #41; A3, Q3). Another interviewee noted that the 360-degree vision created both 'a sense of an incredibly expansive world in the outdoor scenes, and also one of intense claustrophobia in the scenes shot in small spaces, such as when the woman in white had her head against a wall' (Interviewee #45; A3, Q3). This aspect of the virtual experience was one that all of the interviewees discussed in a favourable way, and there was no mention of motion sickness, headaches or other unfavourable physical conditions that are sometimes associated with VR cinema.

The noise coming from within the real-world viewing space never entirely disappears. Another audience member had shoes that clatter on the hard floor every time they swivel their chair around to view the scene from a different angle; at one point, something drops from someone's pocket and clangs on the floor. The sense of a dual reality is almost always present. Four of the interviewees discussed factors that disrupted the immersive viewing experience. One observed that 'although it's 8k technology, it was still quite pixelated, so I was a bit disappointed with the quality of the film' (Interviewee #40; A3, Q2), and another commented that 'the picture was not as sharp as I expected, at times it felt like looking through a finely meshed net' (Interviewee #43; A3, Q2). The static exhibition space also clearly had limitations and challenged some of the audience members, who felt restricted and uncomfortable because of the headsets. In this respect, the nascent character of VR cinema means that there is no established viewing protocol and associated expectations for this kind of experience. Indeed, while I was having my headset fitted, I overheard another audience member expressing surprise and dismay when he saw the screening space, as he had mistakenly thought it was a traditional film screening; after a

brief discussion with the festival organizers, he decided not to stay and watch the film. These responses suggest, as Golding argues, that CVR is still very much in its infancy and remains preoccupied with the relationship between the apparatus and the body.

These responses to *The Deserted* map out a different set of issues around CVR and its potential to immerse viewers into a cinematic world, highlighting the limitations evident around this emerging technology and audience expectations of the virtual experience. It also correlates more clearly with Atkinson and Kennedy's 'participation to immersion' model of engagement, in that it offers a solo VR experience 'in which the viewing and immersed body is largely immobile, acted upon and enclosed by the technological apparatus and taken by and immersed in the cinematically rendered environment of VR' (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 10). However, this case study also reveals the potential of this CVR technology to facilitate an innovative and deeply evocative form of storytelling. Much longer in duration than the *Star Wars* experience, the intensity of the sensory qualities produced by *The Deserted* was equally memorable to those discussed by the *Secrets of the Empire* participants, despite the absence of haptic enablers. These findings indicate not simply an appetite for immersive storytelling among contemporary cinema-goers but also how effectively these technologies can be employed within different genres and modes of immersive narrative.

Case study three: Mixed reality storytelling in *Draw Me Close* (Jordan Tannahill, 2019)

The third case study in this chapter provides the opportunity to consider a different form of virtual storytelling. The characterization of the virtual experience as immobile and non-participatory is being challenged by a new generation of MR immersive experiences which combine VR technologies with elements of theatre and performance. *Draw Me Close* (2019) is a short immersive experience created by Canadian playwright and film-maker Jordan Tannahill, in collaboration with the National Theatre (NT) and National Film Board Canada (NFB). The concept for the production was developed at a Virtual Reality Lab co-hosted by the NT and NFB in 2016, with the purpose of exploring

and advancing the creative language of VR storytelling. The autobiographical narrative of *Draw Me Close* explores the relationship between a mother and her son, following the mother's diagnosis of terminal cancer. As a production, *Draw Me Close* fuses together elements of theatre, animation and VR using the Orion motion capture system and an HTC Vive headset. This enables the audience member to experience a live, animated world while simultaneously being guided around a physical set by actress Tamzin Griffin, who plays Tannahill's mother. The movements of the actress are translated into the virtual world using motion capture while she engages with the audience member on the physical set. It is a one-to-one experience, as only a single audience member can play the part of Jordan in each performance.

In the UK, the production of *Draw Me Close* ran from 21 January to 2 February 2019 in a small studio at the Young Vic Theatre, London. Although the £15 ticket prices were relatively inexpensive for the London theatre scene, the 'high culture' venue, geographical location and individual entry times nevertheless made this a relatively exclusive form of immersive experience. As a regular, middle-class theatre-goer, this did not present me with any cultural or economic barriers, though these socio-geographical constraints clearly raise issues around accessibility and inclusivity for this type of immersive experience. Prior to this, earlier versions of *Draw Me Close* had previewed at the Tribeca and the Venice film festivals. The UK production was marketed as a 'unique experience' and 'an intimate encounter',[14] thus echoing the promotion for many of the experiential cinema experiences in Chapter 1. This illustrates the way that discourses around the concept of an 'experience' found in marketing materials are strikingly similar for both 'high art' theatrical productions and more popular experiential attractions aimed at a mass market.

Prior to entering the studio space for *Draw Me Close*, participants are guided into a cubicle where they discuss aspects of the production with a stage assistant and sign a consent form, which agrees to physical contact with the actress during the performance. Following this, they remove their shoes and another stage assistant then fits on their headset. These preparations offer an intimate and physical alternative to the Narnia moments that are more typical of the commercial forms of pop-up cinema discussed in Chapter 1. Instead of the theatrical spectacle of, for example, entering Tatooine via a simulated space shuttle journey, these highly individual preparations are primarily psychological in nature and function to reinforce an agentic participatory experience. The quiet and more contemplative physical entrance point to the

immersive space is deliberate and characterizes what Tannahill is aiming to achieve with the production, which he positions as an alternative to other VR experiences:

> It seemed like a lot of the pieces were predicated on the spectacle of the tech itself and the spectacle of being there – plunking oneself in the Jungle, the Calais refugee camp, or plunking you down underwater. It felt a little facile I suppose. (Tannahill in Heathman 2019)

In this respect, then, *Draw Me Close* is positioned as artistically antithetical to some commercial VR experiences, like *The Void,* which are predicated on spectacle. Entering the narrative space wearing the VR headset, the participant is immediately immersed within the animated world created by artist Teva Harrison's illustrations. These black-and-white line drawings recreate Jordan Tannahill's childhood home and are not dissimilar to Sheila Graber's animation for the BBC television series *Paddington* (1976). One reviewer suggests that this animation style offers an appropriate medium for 'reflecting the sketchy nature of memory' (Brooks 2019). The associations it generated for me were of childhood nostalgia, informality and domestic intimacy. 'Go on, open the door,' says a welcoming voice. Reaching out for the front door handle, the participant encounters the physical properties of the set for the first time. These physical properties have been constructed as haptic enablers to match the VR world. Audio effects are designed to further enhance the sense of presence the haptic enablers create. These are particularly effective when, for example, a car pulls up outside the house and the actress playing the mother enters; here, the sound design successfully produces a sense of audio perspective, as first the car engine, and subsequently the footsteps of the actress, draw increasingly closer.

One of the most effective interactive elements of the production design involves the participant drawing on some virtual paper placed on the floor. I drew a cat, and the actress playing the mother drew a bird for the cat to chase. The motion capture technology then enabled this image to be replayed at the end of the performance to create a highly personalized sense of narrative completion, and in this respect *Draw Me Close* exemplifies Ryan's fifth level of interactivity, meta-interactivity, in which the user is directly involved in creating new dimensions and layers of the story. This sequence demonstrated the potential of VR storytelling as an interactive experience that facilitates a form of agency on the part of the participant, in terms of the actions they are able to perform, how

they interact with the space and structure the experience, and how this shapes the narrative outcomes.

Although hugely effective for the main part, there are moments in this production when the synchronization between the virtual and real worlds is not perfectly matched, and this creates a distraction and diminishment of presence. While *Draw Me Close* offers an interesting case study in terms of the potential for VR technology to create emotional intimacy, it also raises questions around the effectiveness of first-person narratives within immersive storytelling. The central character, occupied by the audience member, is male. In many respects, the dialogue is written to circumnavigate a gendered perspective. The mother's lines are frequently not gendered, and to achieve this, they are directed at the participant, with lines such as 'you asked me' or 'you were scared'. The narrative thus develops around the audience member regardless of the extent to which they empathize with the emotions which are being projected onto them by the actress. This potentially creates an emotional dissonance, as was my experience, and troubles the extent to which the participant should perform alongside the actress. The positioning of the audience member within an intimate, emotionally charged narrative therefore has the potential to be either moving, if it resonates with the participant's personal experience, or somewhat discombobulating if it does not. There is a conflict, therefore, between the constructed emotional reality of the character and the individual history and frames of reference of the audience member inhabiting that character.

Although the running time for *Draw Me Close* is advertised as close to an hour, the immersive performance is closer to thirty minutes. Following this, the participant is invited to remain within the studio space and watch the next performance. This facilitates a greater appreciation for the individualized nature of each performance. The audience member who entered the studio after me was a close friend, whose own father had recently died of cancer. This meant that the performance had an affective resonance and the narrative developed in a different way to my own, thus illustrating that it was not an entirely scripted process. There was also a gendered element to this resonance, as the bedroom within the animated set was designed to reflect the culturally gendered tastes of a young male. For me, this was a distraction in that it provoked an internal adult critique of gendered taste cultures (why should sci-fi be for boys, etc.), which was at odds with the narrative position I was trying to inhabit, that of a young boy.

Witnessing the subsequent performance illustrated current research focusing on the position of the audience, and on the concept of agency as an ability to

make choices and, therefore, to make changes, as a transition from viewers to 'interactors' (Gaudenzi 2019). This position is variable especially in relation to (1) the position of the user-audience, (2) the space of action (3) the freedom to act in relation to the rules of action. In these respects, *Draw Me Close* offered a more sophisticated, interactive and agentic design than the other virtual experiences. However, the downside of this enhanced agency was that it enabled me to reject aspects of the text I was uncomfortable with; hence, I did not interact with the actress as fully as my friend whose biographical profile was better matched to the character we were both inhabiting. In this respect, even though I admired the actress' performance, the VR experience did not function like an 'empathy machine', and my experience reflected Levitt's problematization of 'empathy machine' claims, in that my sense of otherness towards the character I was playing inhibited my overall experience. In this way, as Levitt contends, the VR experience appealed to 'a sameness of perspective' that excluded participants without those shared characteristics (Levitt 2018: n.p.). These experiences echo Marie-Laure Ryan's observations that the most complex forms of interactive design are not necessarily the most effective, and 'there are consequently good and bad solutions, success and failure, entertainment and boredom on all layers of the interactive onion' (Ryan 2011: 60).

Conclusions

As an emergent form of immersive cinematic experience, qualitative research has only recently started to develop in relation to VR, AR and MR forms of experiential cinema. This small-scale study offers a starting point for investigating the kinds of experience they offer and argues that participatory VR experiences can be effective in facilitating social interactivity and intergenerational bonding. The findings also suggest that the interaction of human emotions with virtual technologies is highly complex and, as Gerry (2017), Levitt (2018) and Herrera et al. (2018) all propose, would benefit from a more sophisticated affective design that can accommodate different emotional and psychological perspectives. This also underscores the need for qualitative methodologies to investigate these emergent technologies, rather than the large-scale laboratory-style experiments that fail to account for individual dispositions and personal biographies.

This chapter also suggests that the desired effects of presence and liveness/simultaneity bear much in common, in that they are intended to draw you

as close to the experience as possible. Indeed, when VR is fully successful in eradicating the distance between the user and the virtual world, then the live-mediatized discourse around traditional screen media becomes redundant. The user responses to *Secrets of the Empire* illustrate the significance of haptic enablers in creating an embodied presence in the virtual world and reveal how effectively this can be combined with social presence in participatory VR. However, even without haptic enablers, responses to *The Deserted* illustrate how an experience of presence can emerge in CVR through the stimulated imagination of the audience. *Draw Me Close* offers the most fully embodied form of presence through the intimate MR combination of theatre, animation and haptic enablers, yet this experience also poses significant storytelling issues in its highly gendered narrative design. These findings, though not in any way representative of audience engagement with VR storytelling, point to the complexities of successfully designing a VR or MR experience that resonates with a broad audience and the significance of issues around sameness and alterity that emerge with interactive first-person narratives.

The case studies also suggest the potential these technologies have in creating participatory VR experiences and indicate that this nascent form of storytelling is only just beginning to establish its own language and parameters. As with pop-up cinema experiences, these participatory forms of VR also facilitate intergenerational interaction with the technologies, and this is one of the key values identified in relation to *Secrets of the Empire*. Indeed, this case study suggests VR experiences such as these not only are appreciated by millennial pleasure-seekers but can be situated within a broader cultural shift towards 'roaming audience'. The responses to the *Star Wars* VR experience and *The Deserted* also highlight the way audiences continue to perform taste preferences in relation to mainstream and art-house cinema, in the form of fandom for the former and a preoccupation with aesthetics in response to the latter.

Notes

1 This is outlined in the introduction to the DCMS's 2015 Report on *Immersive and Addictive Technologies*, found at: https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184602.htm (accessed 24 February 2020).

2 Oculus VR was bought by Facebook for $2 billion in 2014. The commercially successful Oculus Rift headset was launched in 2016, leading to a swift expansion of the VR industry.

3 See information at https://www.tribecafilm.com/immersive and https://www.sundance.org/vr (accessed 6 February 2020).
4 These include the Virtual Human Interaction Lab at Stanford University (founded 2003) and the Experimental Virtual Environments (EVENT) Lab for Neuroscience and Technology at the University of Barcelona.
5 These were selected from a shortlist and announced here: https://ahrc.ukri.org/newsevents/news/r-d- investment-set-to-provide-step-up-for-creative-industries/#ref1
6 For example, see the UK government report *Immersive and Addictive Technologies*: https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184604.htm#_idTextAnchor003
7 'Psychosocial Harms of Immersive Technologies' in the DCMS's 2015 Report on *Immersive and Addictive Technologies*, found at: https://publications.parliament.uk/pa/cm201719/cmselect/cmcumeds/1846/184602.htm (accessed 24 February 2020).
8 The sample was 50 per cent male, 50 per cent female (none of the participants identified as non-binary or other); the age range was 14 per cent gen Y, 36 per cent millennial, 36 per cent gen X and 14 per cent boomer; 79 per cent were educated to university (UG) level and 21 per cent had A levels or an equivalent qualification.
9 https://www.thevoid.com/ (accessed 3 April 2019).
10 Ibid.
11 The reviews span from August 2017 to May 2019 and were generated with the search term 'Star Wars: Secrets of the Empire'. The interviewees were recruited via social media and were interviewed between December 2018 and April 2019.
12 https://aixr.org/insights/behind-the-award-winning-secrets-of-the-empire-experience/ (accessed 12 September 2019).
13 The Taiwan Film Festival conducted their own audience feedback survey after the film, so it was not appropriate for me to conduct my own survey at the same time.
14 These quotations are taken from the promotional video available at https://www.youngvic.org/whats- on/draw-me-close

3

Live installation art and participatory cultures

I've seen things you people wouldn't believe. Attack ships on fire off the shoulder of Orion. I watched C-beams glitter in the dark near the Tannhäuser Gate. All those moments will be lost in time, like . . . tears in rain. Time to die.

Roy, *Blade Runner,* 1982

Introduction

This chapter investigates experiences of immersive and participatory films within the institutional context of art galleries. The ascendency of the moving image within the art world has been notable since the early to mid-1990s (Balsom 2013a: 11; Elsaesser 2016: 124). In the UK, this relationship was consolidated in 2018 when all four of the Turner Prize nominations were artworks in the medium of the moving image.[1] The forms moving image take within this cultural context vary greatly, from documentaries screened in gallery cinemas to installation art and found footage montages such as Christian Marclay's *The Clock* (2010). While many of the case studies already discussed within this book examine the transformation of screen media into live events, Marclay's cult montage almost reverses this trajectory. *The Clock*, a live art installation that cannot be watched online or purchased for domestic consumption, is exhibited in a manner that replicates a conventional cinema space. However, it exists only in the form of a hard drive operated in tandem with a computer program, which synchronizes the projection of the film with the time zone the exhibition space is located in. As a simultaneously live and mediatized art installation, *The Clock* offers an unusual instance of experiential cinema, and this is the key reason it forms the primary case study in this chapter.

While the primacy of film and video installations within art galleries is a relatively recent phenomenon, there is a long history of the moving image

within the museum space (Griffiths 2003, 2008; Wasson 2007, 2011). Haidee Wasson argues that, in the early twentieth century, institutions such as New York's Metropolitan Museum of Art introduced film 'in order to simplify the experience of art and the museum' and provide a welcome respite from 'museum fatigue' (Wasson 2011: 180). Wasson's observations highlight issues around visitor engagement and inclusivity and draw on long-established discourses around film as a middlebrow or popular art form that requires less cultural capital and intellectual labour to be appreciated than, in this case, fine art (Bourdieu 1984: 271). These debates surrounding cultural capital are pertinent to the analysis of *The Clock*'s popularity as an art exhibition, which I return to later in this chapter. The tradition of housing cinemas within art galleries continues to the present, with MoMA New York and Tate Modern London being among the many museums and art galleries to promote designated film auditoriums with busy schedules.[2] *The Clock,* however, is installed within a carefully designed exhibition space rather than a pre-existing in-house auditorium, and this chapter examines how the specificity of this space is central to the participants' experiences of it.

The investigation is framed by a consideration of cultural policy around social inclusion within public art galleries, with an emphasis on the British context and visitor responses to Tate Modern's exhibition of Christian Marclay's *The Clock* (2010), which ran from September 2018 to January 2019. Although *The Clock* might not, at first glance, appear to be participatory art, it has developed a cult following, and its twenty-four-hour screenings regularly attract long queues and unusually high visitor numbers. In her analysis of *The Clock*, Julie Levinson argues that

> The experience of viewing *The Clock* is a performative one. The audience's performance begins with an inevitably long wait for admission. Marclay's film has been a cultural phenomenon among followers of film and of contemporary art, so at most of its screenings, audiences have had to endure long lines before being admitted to the theater. (Levinson 2015: 106)

Levinson locates the performative and immersive qualities of spectatorship for *The Clock* as occurring within the institutional space surrounding the exhibition as much as within the exhibition itself. Similarly, Erika Balsom suggests that it is this element of her analysis in which the visitor experience is most clearly understood as being immersive and participatory (Balsom 2013a). This chapter therefore investigates and analyses the experience of visitors to *The Clock* as 'event art', paying equal attention to the experiences recounted both *inside*

and *outside* of the exhibition space. Through this analysis, I argue that *The Clock* demonstrates an appetite for cultural events that reconfigure or subvert established viewing protocols for watching films across a wide range of cultural spaces that includes the formal environment of the gallery space.

Immersion, inclusion, participation and the gallery screen

The increased prominence of moving image installations within the art world has provoked a range of scholarly debates examining the relationship between film, video and the gallery space (Elwes 2001; Fowler 2004; Beugnet 2013). From the outset, these discussions have focused on the interactive character of installation art and its dependence on audience engagement (Bourriaud 2002; Bishop 2005, 2012; Rush 2007). While installation art has only become highly visible within the contemporary art gallery in the last three decades, the artworks themselves often date back much further than the institutions housing them. Bill Viola's *The Vapor* (1975), for example, forms part of the permanent collection located at the MAXXI Museum, Rome, which opened in 2010. Now over forty years old, *The Vapor* mixes live images of the spectator(s) with a pre-recorded performative video of Viola. Images, sounds and smells are combined to encourage spectators to immerse themselves in the exhibition space and interact with the exhibition.[3] In this way, *The Vapor* fuses Viola's historically filmed act with the present moment inhabited by the gallery visitors and exemplifies installation art's long-term preoccupation with the spectator-image relationship.

Claire Bishop situates the art world's most recent 'social turn' within the context of two previous historical moments: the European avant-garde circa 1917 and the 'neo' avant-garde of the late 1960s. What these movements have in common, Bishop contends, is their political context, in that 'each phase has been accompanied by a utopian rethinking of art's relationship to the social and of its political potential – manifested in a reconsideration of the ways in which art is produced, consumed and debated' (Bishop 2012: 3). As Bishop observes, film and video were important artistic mediums for the neo-avant-garde artists of the 1960s and 1970s, such as Andy Warhol, Dan Graham and Bruce Nauman. In several respects, this generation of installation artists was broadly poststructuralist in their insistence on the presence of the spectator as a means to 'activate' the meaning of the artwork (Bishop 2005: 128). Similarly, Nicholas

Bourriard argues that participatory art relies on social negotiation, and therefore produces a performative response with a social impact; it is socially engaging (Bourriaud 2002). Bishop and Bourriard both emphasize, then, the active role of the participant in these experimental and often politicized artworks.

Theoretical analyses of the role played by digital, handheld technologies are also significant in scholarship on participatory and immersive art and frame Marclay's work within a specific cultural tradition. Michael Rush reinforces the discourse positioning installation and video art as inherently political by setting up a binary between commercial cinema and the mid-1960s 'visual communication revolution' facilitated by the introduction of handheld video technology. Rush contends that 'video, once viewed as the poor cousin of cinema, soon became a significant medium itself in the hands of artists, documentary film-makers, choreographers, engineers, and political activists who saw it as their ticket into the hallways of influence' (Rush 2007: 7). This valorization of the video artist is frequently framed as being oppositional to mass media. In *A History of Experimental Film and Video*, for example, A. L. Rees argues that

> Video gives the artist direct access to image manipulation and production. It is also cheaper, an important consideration for those who are self-funded with the aid of limited grants and commissions. They are less anxious about video and digital media as such than about the social, cultural and economic applications of high technology. The desire not to be swamped by mass media culture is a principled and not a reactionary objection. In this sense, the post-film media provide points of resistance for artists to the bland new world of 'infotainment'. (Rees 1999: 113)

Rees's valorization of digital media and its potential to challenge mass media culture in the global north reflects a high/low culture binary that typifies scholarship on experimental video art. Marclay's reworking of mainstream film and television media in *The Clock* is therefore significant in the way it intentionally disrupts these established taste distinctions. Steven Jacobs argues that when compared with film and video installations of the 1960s and 1970s, the contemporary vogue for video installations is significantly different from their predecessors in terms of their spatial and aesthetic structure (Jacobs 2010: 152). While Bishop, Rush and Rees all highlight the significance of the socio-political heritage of video art, Jacobs foregrounds the ways in which technological developments have transformed the use of moving image within the gallery space

and consequently, he argues, the fundamental character of the contemporary museum space. A similar argument is made by film scholar Thomas Elsaesser, who contends that contemporary art galleries have become part leisure complex, with a significantly different spatial arrangement to traditional art museums (Elsaesser 2016). Elsaesser suggests that such institutions are now a part of the tourist industry, and their popularity rests, in part, on the way in which they have accommodated the moving image; in this respect, the moving image has transformed and spectacularized the museum space. These arguments are pertinent to the exhibition of *The Clock* at Tate Modern, which mimicked a cinema screening and witnessed rowdy, inebriated visitors queuing all night within the gallery space.

Spatial determinism in the gallery space

A number of scholars within the overlapping fields of film studies and art history subscribe to various forms of spatial determinism in their analysis of the relationship between audiences/spectators and the art gallery space (Elwes 2001; Fowler 2004; Beugnet 2013). Catherine Elwes argues that the gallery offers moving image installations a space that is 'no longer constrained by cinema schedules and a fixed viewing position, spectators are now free to determine the length of exposure to the images and can enter into a more physical and more intimate exchange with the work' (Elwes 2001: 47). In this way, Elwes suggests that the gallery space facilitates a form of agency and individualized interaction with cinema that is suppressed by the conventional theatrical exhibition of films. This argument is also made by Catherine Fowler, who contends that the semiotics of the gallery's 'white cube' offers a spatial alternative to the 'black box' of the cinema. Fowler argues this is achieved by the way the gallery space 'does away with the illusionist confines of the cinema auditorium to invite a variety of reactions to its moving images' (Fowler 2004: 331). Both Elwes and Fowler thus attribute a set of 'high art' qualities to the gallery space that enable the visitor to engage with moving image in a more agentic and intellectual manner. Film theorist Adrian Martin also proposes a form of spatial determinism in his use of the term *dispositif*, which he uses to explain the way in which every medium and art form possesses a set of conditions that shape the way it is experienced. However, in his discussion of cinema's move into the gallery space, Martin argues that the fluidity of the gallery space does not facilitate a more agentic,

sophisticated form of engagement, as suggested by Elwes and Fowler. Instead, he contends that

> There is the fact of the ubiquitous distraction of the modern spectator in the generally ambulant, take-it-or-leave-it, whimsical setting of an art gallery. Cinema depends, as many have argued, on the locked-in, sat-down position of its average (or ideal) viewer – in place for the start of the film, and (hopefully) still there at the end. The fixed duration and linear unfolding of a film matters, and this is precisely what the situation of the gallery cannot guarantee – that is, unless it completely overturns the normal protocols of art exhibition. (Martin 2014: 185)

Martin's assessment of the cinema auditorium hinges on the conventions of mainstream cinema exhibition practices (a fixed running time for the film and a linear narrative). *The Clock* is an interesting case study in this respect, in that it possesses neither of these qualities and yet Marclay stipulates that it is exhibited in a way that mimics the conventions of cinema's black box. *The Clock* thus subverts the protocols of the art exhibition, but not in the way Martin suggests. This raises interesting questions about how visitors to an art gallery respond to both the textual construction of *The Clock* as a twenty-four hour found footage montage and the familiar conventions of the exhibition space housing it.

Scholarly discussions of spatial determinism and the art gallery space also draw on a set of debates that have been fuelled by the digitization of cinema production and exhibition. They are frequently framed within a wider discourse around celluloid obsolescence and the 'death of cinema' (Jacobs 2010; Beugnet 2013). For those who attribute an elevated form of audience engagement to the gallery space, the marketization of public art galleries is framed as an aberration. Martine Beugnet, for instance, references a paper given by Jacobs in which he laments the way that present-day museums have become 'machines designed for the quick and efficient circulation of large numbers of visitors' (Jacobs in Beugnet 2013: 200). Beugnet summarizes that

> In the now classic debate on absorption-versus-distracted reception, the modes of display characteristic to the gallery or museum space were initially presented as a productive alternative to cinema's traditional dispositif. Where conventional cinema had seemingly betrayed the consciousness-raising potential that the early theorists had associated with the medium of the moving image, video art appeared as an antidote, its reception in galleries and museums comparing positively to the absorbed – read: passive – experience offered to spectators through the theatrical release of classic feature films. (Beugnet 2013: 200)

Beugnet argues that the physical space of the art gallery facilitates a 'consciousness-raising potential' that is not enabled by conventional cinema, thus facilitating an agentic, reflexive response among gallery visitors. Like Elwes, Fowler and Martin, Beugnet raises questions around the significance of these spaces and their ability to influence visitor responses to art exhibitions. These arguments are considered in relation to the empirical data gathered on visitors to *The Clock* analysed later in the chapter.

Art galleries, moving image and cultural policy

The emphasis placed on access, participation and inclusion by many British cultural institutions can be understood within the broader framework of UK cultural policy across the last two decades (Garnham 2005; Belfiore 2012). The twenty-first century has seen funding of the arts sector in the UK largely dominated by a form of economic instrumentalism (Belfiore 2012). While this can be traced back to the shift towards a free-market economy that took place in the 1980s under the Thatcher government, under New Labour the development of a more entrenched form of economic instrumentalism was accelerated (Garnham 2005; Belfiore 2012). Nicholas Garnham argues that this is evidenced by changes that can be observed in the language used in policy documents, in which public spending starts being referred to as an 'investment' (Garnham 2005: 16). Likewise, Eleonora Belfiore suggests that the legacy of New Labour can be understood as 'an entrenchment of the Thatcherite shift from state to market', and the evolution of what she calls a form 'defensive instrumentalism' (Belfiore 2012). Evidence of how pervasive this form of economic instrumentalism has become in the art world can be observed in the March 2010 publication of the manifesto 'Cultural Capital: A Manifesto for the Future' launched by a number of high-profile arts institutions and endorsed by large placards created by British artists Tracey Emin, Michael Craig-Martin and Damien Hirst, and which carries the slogan 'You can bank on culture'.[4] The manifesto thus specifically conceptualizes value as economic rather than social or cultural. Hadley and Belfiore argue that this shift towards economic instrumentalism has led to a co-opting of participatory art and notions around social inclusion by the neoliberal governance of many art institutions:

> The defining crisis of UK cultural policy has resulted from attempts to combine, articulate and actualise ideas associated with both democracy and culture. Issues

> of, definitions for and projects to address access, participation, engagement and inclusion abound. (Hadley and Belfiore 2018: 218)

This ideological shift in arts governance is exemplified by many contemporary arts organizations, such as Tate Modern. Tate Modern opened in May 2000 and was housed in the former Bankside Powerhouse on the South Bank in London. From the outset, the language of neoliberal instrumentalism, much favoured by New Labour, was employed to justify funding for the new gallery. In their submission to the Millennium Commission, the Tate Gallery trustees stated that

> At the heart of the capital, it will establish a new landmark and an outstanding public space for the nation and enhance London's position as a world center, bringing cultural, social and economic benefits to millions of people in the nation as a whole.

The first two objectives stated in the *Tate for All: Diversity Action Plan to 2015* (2013) are to ensure that the institution's 'audiences are representative of all sections of society' and that 'access to [Tate's] sites and Tate's digital media is open to all' (Tate 2013: n.p.). The policy of social inclusivity is clearly central to Tate Modern's identity as an art gallery. More recently, an independent study conducted at Tate Modern with mental health users who participated in a community arts-based programme at the gallery concluded that such programmes can facilitate a substantial improvement in well-being and mental health among participants (McKeown et al. 2015: 32). While austerity Britain has seen a significant reduction in arts budgets at the level of local authorities, this decrease in spending is not entirely even. London boroughs have purportedly experienced the largest cuts of 19 per cent in the period of 2010–15 (Harvey 2016: 10).

At the same time, academic research has informed an emergent form of instrumentalism that specifically champions the arts as a means to address public health issues (McKeown et al. 2015). This policy shift has played out in the UK across a local, regional and national level. Prestige art galleries, such as Tate Modern, have been as actively involved in providing community-based arts programmes as the grassroots and smaller local organizations. Indeed, this has been central to the institution's remit since the gallery opened in 2000 and 'tried to establish a positive connection with the disadvantaged community of London's Bankside' (Belfiore 2002: 103).[5] Issues around inclusivity and audience engagement within the gallery space have frequently been addressed through the promotion of film, video and moving image installations. In addition to the permanent cinema auditoriums and IMAX screens located at many museums

and art galleries, institutions are now frequently the sites for pop-up screenings hosted by established cinema exhibitors.[6] In the UK, the Ashmolean Museum in Oxford is host to Picturehouse Cinema's pop-up season during the summer, while Luna Cinema has an ongoing arrangement to stage pop-up screenings at the Natural History Museum in London.

However, it is not just established exhibitors that are holding late and overnight screenings at museums and art galleries. Extended video installations such as Douglas Gordon's *24 Hour Psycho* (1993) and Christian Marclay's *The Clock* (2010) also attract large visitor numbers and reflect the increasingly important relationship between galleries and moving image installations. These attempts to broaden the inclusivity of the gallery space in the late twentieth- and twenty-first centuries have inevitably attracted critiques. In his discussion of Tate Modern, art historian Terry Smith argues that 'in its efforts to create a museum of modern art that is approached through a celebration of crowd-pleasing, spectacular contemporary art, it has become a delighted but concerned victim of its own success' (Smith 2009: 66). The crowd-pleasing popularity of Tate Modern is also discussed at length by Grayson Perry in *Playing to the Gallery* (2014). Perry wryly observes:

> My nickname for the Tate Modern is the cult entertainment store. This comes from a shop that sells comics and film merchandise. The shop is called Forbidden Planet and underneath its sign it describes itself as the 'cult entertainment megastore'. This seems an oxymoron to me. If something is cult, I assume it only appeals to a few cognoscenti, like art used to. How could it support a megastore? Now, when I go to art galleries, I'm very often aware of their brand identities. I can feel like I'm having a branded aesthetic moment. (Perry 2014: 88)

Smith and Perry's respective critiques highlight the neoliberal instrumentalism that characterizes the operational strategies of many cultural institutions across the global north; in an attempt to justify their cultural value, art galleries such as Tate Modern adopt branding strategies and similar corporate tactics as a means to increase their footfall and raise their public profile. This instrumentalist culture informs the institutional and cultural context for this small-scale audience study of visitor responses to *The Clock*.

Passing time with Christian Marclay's *The Clock*

The Clock is formed from a complex interweaving of found footage from film and television using conventional continuity editing techniques. Marclay and

his team of six research assistants edited together a disparate mass of material that foregrounds time-keeping and clock-watching, though this focal point is sometimes referenced in a fairly oblique fashion.[7] The sound editing, for which Marclay collaborated with Quentin Chiapetta, is particularly effective in creating bridges between the clips, as is the use of match-on-action, reaction shots and cutaways. While this chapter does not offer any in-depth textual analysis of *The Clock*, it is worth noting that the moving image collage draws heavily on mainstream narrative cinema (and some television) and that particular actors (Tom Cruise, Nicolas Cage, Humphrey Bogart, Robert de Niro, Robert Redford and Bette Davies, to name a few) make multiple appearances. Certain genres dominate (thrillers, westerns and action films), and Marclay has himself acknowledged in an interview that one research assistant was fired for including too much horror.[8] Overall, *The Clock* produces a predominantly white, heteronormative history of cinema and television and, perhaps unsurprisingly, for a largely male artistic team, there are comparatively few female actors making multiple appearances. However, the textual qualities of *The Clock* have already been discussed by a number of other film scholars and art historians (Krauss 2011; Fowler 2013; Levinson 2015; Russell 2018). This chapter focuses instead on the ways in which visitors engage with the exhibition.

The research discussed in this part of this chapter draws on four principal sources of data as a means to analyse visitor experiences at Tate Modern's exhibition of *The Clock*. First, it analyses the findings of an online quali–quantitative survey which captured 452 responses from visitors to *The Clock* at Tate Modern (appendix 4).[9] Second, it draws on a set of twelve semi-structured interviews conducted with people who participated in the survey and volunteered themselves to be interviewed; these interviews were designed to enable participants to discuss their responses to the open-ended questions on the survey in greater depth. The participants were selected to represent a cross section of the demographic sample who responded to the survey (appendix 4, figures 2–4). Of the twelve interviewees selected for the study, six identified as female and six identified as male; five were millennials, three were gen Z and four were baby boomers; eleven out of twelve were educated to university level, and one was finishing their A levels; this cross section was representative of the overall survey sample and suggests a higher level of education than the national average.

Third, the chapter draws on my own participant observations made during three visits to the exhibition, including the twenty-four-hour screening in December

2018; these are integrated throughout the analysis. Finally, the study makes references to the many professional and citizen-critic reviews of *The Clock* available online. As with previous case studies, the intention is not to offer an extensive or definitive portrait of visitors to *The Clock*. Instead, the study maps out a set of insights into the way visitors interpreted the film and experienced the exhibition space. These are framed using quantitative data that establishes a demographic profile of the respondents, which, for the purpose of this case study, provides a useful context for interrogating some of the claims outlined earlier regarding the significance of the gallery space in shaping responses to art exhibitions.

The Clock has been exhibited in over twenty major art galleries around the world since it was first screened at White Cube, London, in autumn 2010.[10] While the specific dimensions of these gallery spaces and duration of the exhibition vary from one institution to another, certain aspects surrounding the screening conditions of *The Clock* are stipulated by Christian Marclay and his studio.[11] These include the use of a darkened auditorium, the dimensions of the screen and the white IKEA sofas provided for visitors to sit on. As an installation, *The Clock* is thus designed to imitate a cinema auditorium. However, as a twenty-four-hour video installation that runs on a loop, *The Clock* also distinguishes itself from mainstream cinema, in that spectators enter and leave the auditorium at their own time of choosing, rather than at the beginning or end of the film. In its attempt to invoke certain principles of the cinematic apparatus while simultaneously challenging the normative time-bound theatrical experience, the exhibition design of *The Clock* is complex, and this raises questions as to how the audience experience it. In this respect it functions much more like an art installation. Catherine Russell argues that *The Clock* 'deliberately invokes certain principles of the cinematic apparatus' but simultaneously challenges the normative time-bound theatrical experience so that 'the spectator on the white Ikea sofa is acutely aware of their own present- time, as their seat-mates come and go, and as they stifle hunger pains and wonder if they will catch the last train home or not' (Russell 2013: 245). In both raising and confounding visitor expectations, *The Clock* provokes many questions about the experience of engaging with the moving image within the gallery space.

When Tate Modern acquired *The Clock* in 2012, director Nick Serota commented that it was 'a further example of Tate's commitment to important media installations' and to 'sharing the work with audiences across the world while also allowing the organisations to share expertise and raise the visibility of artists working in film and video'.[12] *The Clock*'s status as an art exhibit is of key

significance both to the monetary value of the film within the art world and to its 'cult' status with cinephiles and museum visitors. The labour involved in the creation of *The Clock* (six assistants working for three years) means that its production could not be justified without the realistic anticipation of an adequate market. As Marclay has himself stated, *The Clock* provides something 'accessible and pleasurable', thus justifying the price tag for galleries and making it viable within the art marketplace.[13] In this way, Marclay deliberately challenges the elitist views espoused by scholars such as A. R. Rees who valorize high art's opposition to mainstream culture and intentionally disrupt the cultural capital of the sanctified gallery space. One of the aims of this study, then, is to evaluate the extent to which visitors to *The Clock* experience it as pleasurable and accessible, as Marclay intended, or whether they too oppose this disruption of the gallery space.

Despite his intentions to create an installation that is pleasurable and accessible, Marclay's conditions for the sale and exhibition of *The Clock* both capitalize on and frame this aspect of the film's (in)accessibility, generating an aura of exclusivity expected of cult film texts. *The Clock*'s crossover status as both an art installation with a cult following and an 'accessible and pleasurable' crowd-pleaser, therefore, makes it a particularly interesting case study of moving image within the gallery space. This is evidenced in Erika Balsom's account of *The Clock*'s exhibition at the Power Plant, a contemporary art venue in Toronto. The Power Plant promoted *The Clock* using a poster of people queuing up to watch the video installation, which Balsom analyses as follows:

> Line up here, as people have lined up before you in New York, London, Boston, and Los Angeles. Be prepared to wait; the experience of this artwork is about temporality in more ways than one. Long queues are normally the property of nightclubs or iPhone launches, not gallery installations. But the queue for *The Clock* fulfils the same function as the queue outside the Apple Store: it endows an experience with an aura of exclusivity and thereby heightens its appeal. (Balsom 2013: 178)

Balsom highlights the mass consumer appeal of Marclay's installation and the incongruity of this within the 'high art' environment of an art gallery, offering a straightforward equation of *The Clock*'s exclusivity with its continued desirability. This appears to contradict assessments offered by other academics such as Amy Sergeant, who argues that *The Clock*

> is entirely dependent on the materials and methods of mass culture (cinema and television) and, given what has been observed above, we may no longer say that

> its exhibition in a gallery contradicts any ambition to reach a popular audience. Apart from its extraordinary length, there is nothing about *The Clock*, separated from its screening environment, which requires its installation in a gallery as opposed to a conventional cinema.

In this respect, Sergeant's assessment of the relationship between audiences and exhibition spaces for *The Clock* is diametrically opposed to those of Beugnet, Elwes and Martin. The continued popularity of *The Clock* supports Sargeant's argument that it could be screened in a conventional cinema, and the use of Tate Modern as an exhibition space for *The Clock*'s most recent exhibition is considered in this chapter. Yet despite Sergeant's accurate observation regarding the composition of *The Clock* from the materials of popular media, it is very rare for a mainstream film to be twenty-four hours in duration, and thus Sergeant elides the inherent tensions of *The Clock* in the way it occupies the spaces of both popular and high culture.

Queues, boos and booze: The educated masses

Given Tate Modern's commitment to inclusivity, the demographic profile of visitors to their exhibition of *The Clock* is significant. One of the striking characteristics of the sample of visitors I gathered was their level of education, which is substantially different from the national average (appendix 4, figure 4). Ninety per cent of those who responded to the survey were university educated, which is more than double the national average, and of these 47 per cent of the overall sample had a PhD or other postgraduate qualification. Even considering the rising numbers of younger people gaining postgraduate qualifications in the UK, this is still over four times higher than the national average of approximately 11 per cent.[14] Of those who were not educated at university, the majority were still doing their A levels. Only 2 per cent of the sample had a professional qualification obtained outside of the HE sector, one of these being a professional watchmaker. The survey was not circulated via my social media networks in order to avoid skewing the sample, so this is very much a reflection of the visitor profile for *The Clock* at Tate Modern. These findings problematize the spatial determinism advocated by various film studies scholars already outlined. The data suggests that rather than the gallery space facilitating a more agentic and intellectual response to moving image artworks, as argued by Elwes and Beugnet, it is far more plausible that art galleries simply attract a higher proportion of

highly educated visitors who are trained to analyse and engage with cultural forms using the intellectual capital acquired through education.

While the exhibition of *The Clock* attracted visitors of all ages to Tate Modern, there was also a higher concentration of younger people. 28.1 per cent of the sample were aged sixteen to twenty-five and 32 per cent were aged twenty-six to thirty-five, while only 2.6 per cent were over sixty-five (appendix 4, figure 2). This was, I suggest, partly due to the attraction of the all-night screening, and in this respect, the four-month-long exhibition of *The Clock* at Tate Modern witnessed similar scenes to those observed by Erika Balsom at the Power Plant in Toronto. Balsom argues that

> *The Clock* provides the institution with an opportunity to stage a public relations event by remaining open overnight to exhibit the work in its entirety. It would be easy to see this occurrence as an instance of the artwork by its nature forcing the institution to change its hours, thus engaging in a kind of subversive challenge to the normal state of affairs. But it would be more accurate to say that institutions gladly organize such extended viewing hours because it offers an opportunity to advertise a special night time event. *The Clock* provides the museum with an opportunity to reach out to a young demographic through the staging of events that take place long after the elders have gone to sleep. (Balsom 2013: 185)

The appeal of a unique all-night event in generating an aura of exclusivity was also evident in many of the responses to the survey at Tate Modern. Several of the responses to question twelve reflected on the carnivalesque atmosphere of the twenty-four-hour screening and the novelty of being at the gallery overnight. One respondent explained that 'I mostly enjoyed watching it "out of hours" at the Tate' (S#211, Q12), implying that this was the key attraction of the exhibition, while another observed 'we queued for nearly three hours, but it was completely brilliant to be here with my friends, being in the queue also made it an amazing experience' (S#130, Q12). Another commented that 'the queue was a bit long, but actually I quite enjoyed it and it definitely heightened my expectations of the film. I'm not sure I would have had such a fun experience if we'd just strolled in!' (S#399, Q12). The twenty-four-hour screening also attracted older audiences. One of the interviewees was a 68-year-old woman who was attending with her son, and who spent a long period of time sitting on a seat outside the exhibition watching the queue during the early hours of the morning. She explained, 'I love seeing so many people in the gallery at night, it's very exciting, I wish this happened more often. I'm pleased there are so many young people

here' (Interviewee #46; A2, Q7). A regular visitor to the gallery, this interviewee illustrated that the appetite for experiences that renegotiate the established protocols of the exhibition space is not restricted to a younger demographic.

All of these comments underscore the quality of uniqueness associated with visiting an art installation in these atypical conditions. The novelty of being inside the gallery 'out of hours' transformed the visit to see the exhibition into an 'experience'. Comments such as these imply an unexpected commonality between this case study and those discussed in previous chapters of this book, staged by commercial, pop-up cinema exhibitors. The contextual space of the screening – or, in this case, the exhibition – was as much a part of the experience as the moment at which they finally watched the film. These responses also correlate with academic analyses of the spectatorship of *The Clock*, such as those made by Levinson and Balsom. While the data analysed thus far points to the significance of the exhibition space in shaping visitor experiences of *The Clock*, it also highlights the subversive aspect of Marclay's requirements for staging the exhibition. In challenging the conventions and established protocols of the art gallery space, Marclay produces (and then replicates at art galleries around the world) a unique experience in which participants occupy the live/mediatized divide for prolonged periods of time before engaging with a film that encourages them to reflect on this.

Although the survey did not directly ask visitors about their experience of queuing, it was a subject that was frequently commented upon. However, these comments varied in tone and were not universally celebratory, instead of reflecting the fluctuating environment of the gallery space while I was observing it. On the three occasions I visited the exhibition, the queue for *The Clock* was mainly contained within the foyer on level two of the Blavatnik Building (formerly the Switch House, which opened in June 2016), and it took less than half an hour to get in. However, the three twenty-four-hour screenings of *The Clock* saw queues winding down two flights of stairs and snaking out of the building, where some people waited in the rain. The second twenty-four-hour screening, which took place on the first weekend of December 2018, witnessed the longest queues of all three of these events. While the overnight exhibitions team tried to manage visitor expectations, there was a growing sense of clamour and frustration as the queue barely moved throughout the evening, and people gradually became aware that they were going to miss out on seeing the midnight sequence and other elusive nocturnal sections of the film. As the night progressed and the downstairs bar stayed open, the number of inebriated visitors in the

queue also increased, as did the boos (when Tate staff reminded them of queue protocol), cheers (when the queue moved), singing and general revelry. As one visitor commented on Twitter,

> Just left @Tate Modern's 24-hour screening of The Clock, went in at ten and watched it till seven. Everybody was so excited to be there the queue was like a party. It's great of course. So many clever, elegant edits. (@mrphoenix, December 2)

The all-nighters provided a clear illustration, then, of gallery protocol being disrupted. In her comparison of the different exhibition spaces offered by art galleries and cinemas, Balsom writes:

> The movie theater is a mass cultural space of boisterous entertainment and clandestine eroticism. The anonymous relationality, the darkness, the giganticism of the screen, the imperceptible rhythms of the flicker emanating from the projector – all these elements serve to buttress the powers of the film itself, consolidating the spectator's attentive fascination and engrossment. The protocols of the gallery space are strikingly different. The light level is higher and the visitor wanders at will, perhaps speaking to a companion. The activity is endowed with a sense of cultural respectability, even erudition, and tends to lack the absorptive capacity of the cinema. (Balsom 2013: 39)

Here, then, at the twenty-four-hour exhibition of *The Clock*, many of the visitors fully embody the boisterous behaviours associated with the cinema, transgressing the protocol of the gallery and drawing ire from the gallery attendants, and indeed, from some of the other visitors.

Other responses implied that some visitors were slightly less positive about the queue and the rowdy behaviour of the other visitors, making comments such as 'I didn't like the lack of organisation at the all night screening, it all got quite chaotic and that spoilt my enjoyment' (S#77, Q12). Some opined that 'more sofas were needed' (S#172, Q12) and 'more seating, I've been five times and never gotten to see midnight' (S#78, Q12). This frustration with the queue also manifested in the form of requests for a more formal and exclusive admission process. One respondent suggested 'an overnight screening for *Clock* aficionados only (5+ visits) would be nice' (S#110, Q12) while another requested 'loyalty cards' for repeat visitors to the exhibition. The physical conditions of the gallery space, together with the specific requirements stipulated by Marclay's studio for exhibiting *The Clock*, thus functioned to highlight the cultural capital and sense of entitlement among some of the exhibition visitors. These responses

reveal a further way in which visitors to *The Clock* tried to negotiate with the conventional installation of the design. As the exhibition increasingly began to resemble queues for mass consumer goods, there were attempts among certain visitors to assert their cultural capital. They positioned themselves as committed visitors to the exhibition, who demonstrated this through the investment of their time, and thus demanded privileged status from the gallery. There is an irony here, as many art galleries, including Tate Modern, encourage this sense of privilege through the promotion of annual subscriptions that provide membership to those who can afford it. Tate Members are granted access to special events, designated spaces within the gallery and non-ticketed entry to the major exhibitions. However, *The Clock* is always exhibited as a non-ticketed event because Marclay and his team never sought or obtained copyright to use the clips. Thus, this highly exclusive exhibition is open to all on a first-come-first-served basis that frustrates those visitors accustomed to the gallery's system of privileged membership.

These attempts to renegotiate the admissions process, along with the booing and inebriated rancour, reveal one set of ways in which visitors negotiated a response to the installation design of *The Clock*. However, there were other aspects of their behaviour that imply the installation design produced a culturally learnt response acquired from years of watching mainstream cinema. Sixty-eight cent of visitors stayed at the exhibition site for an average one to two hours per visit, indicating that they might have reproduced patterns of consumption associated with the length of an average commercial film. While this was not the case with all of the visitors (and I observed some who fell asleep on the sofas and stayed in the exhibition space for prolonged periods of time), it is notable that the average visit to the exhibition mimicked that of conventional outing to their local cinema. Even during the twenty-four-hour screening (and allowing for comfort breaks), only 1 per cent of visitors surveyed remained at the exhibition site for sixteen to twenty-four hours. At the other end of the spectrum, in the sample I took, none of the respondents ticked the 'under 30 minutes' box for their length of stay. What this data suggests is that although online reviews and blogs illustrate the cult-like devotion *The Clock* has inspired, those with passionate and dedicated relationships with the installation are outnumbered by those who engage with it like any other cinematic event, albeit a more unique and unusual one than a regular cinema outing. As one interviewee observed, 'it was something a bit different and we enjoyed that. I'm not sure I could watch the whole thing, but I did really enjoy the part I saw' (Interviewee #47, A2, Q7).

This measured form of appreciation for *The Clock* is, I argue, more common than some of the impassioned blogs discussed in other scholarly assessments of visitors to the exhibition (Levinson 2015), and it is important not to overlook this level of engagement.

Other elements of the exhibition design also produced a high level of discussion among the survey respondents. Marclay's specifications for the layout of the auditorium, including the number of white IKEA sofas, elicited a number of responses. As already noted, some complained that there were not enough sofas, and there were people standing at the back of the auditorium throughout most of the observational visits I made. Some commented on other visitors 'taking up a whole sofa or sitting in the middle, which is just really selfish' (S#67, Q12) and noted that 'I would have liked my own seat, like a proper cinema' (S#220, Q12). Others who were more complementary about the sofas noted their comfort, observing that 'it's like our local art house cinema' (S#300, Q12). These responses suggest that for many visitors the exhibition space functioned very much like a conventional cinema, albeit an independent one rather than a multiplex. In this respect, participants in this survey did not, as Levinson has argued, feel that the 'widely spaced couches . . . evoke museum benches more than movie seating' (Levinson 2015: 107).

Overall, analysis of audience data on the exhibition design reveals the complexity of visitor responses to the staging of the installation. Though often oppositional in their response to the queue, the data also suggests how influential the apparatus of mainstream cinema is, in that many visitors adopted audience protocols and behaviours that are not often associated with the space of the art gallery.

Watching *The Clock*

Christian Marclay has spoken on numerous occasions about *The Clock*'s intended meaning as a *memento mori*. In interviews given at the time of *The Clock*'s opening exhibition at White Cube, London, Marclay explained that 'I see the piece as a giant *memento mori* (reminder of mortality). Perhaps that's why I embarked on it – because I turned 50. Maybe I'm having a mid-life crisis and thinking about time and how little time is left.'[15] A few years later, in March 2012, he made another similar comment, that 'the burning cigarette is the twentieth-century symbol of time. As a *memento mori*, we used to show a

candle, but a cigarette is so much more modern. Yet it's the same thing – you see time burning' (Marclay in *The New Yorker,* March 2012). Indeed, Marclay has referenced the intended meaning of the film multiple times, highlighting the significance of the dynamic between the intended meaning of *The Clock* and the potential response from visitors. For this reason, the survey included a question on Marclay's intended meaning, asking respondents whether or not they had interpreted *The Clock* along these lines, and this subject was later developed during the interviews. One of the interviewees responded to this question as follows:

> Yes. It was intense . . . you are thinking about the construct of time, of the preciousness of each moment, and yet simultaneously, sort of at the same time you are aware of losing time as you watch the film. So, then you're wondering how long to stay, or whether you should be doing something else [*laughs*], or does it even matter, really, when all moments become lost in time anyway? So, the *Blade Runner* bits were particularly apt, I thought, the whole thing was a bit like 'tears in rain', but for 24 hours. (Interviewee #48; A2, Q7)

Although none of the survey respondents or interviewees actually used the term *memento mori*, many of them discussed concepts of impermanence and the passing of time, making comments such as 'I was thinking about the passing of time, but in quite a pleasant way, just thinking about the inevitability of it' (S#109, Q8). Another observed that 'it made me reflect on time passing, yes, of it sort of slipping away' (S#336, Q8). Others offered replies that, in part, were suggestive of the kind of meditative response Marclay alludes to:

> To begin with, I was, like, oh yes, I know that one, I know that one. But then, after a while, that part of my brain switched off and I just went with it, I was lulled into the rhythm of the footage, and that's why I think the editing is so clever. It creates a reflective space. I think I was alternating, then, between admiring the editing, especially the sound bridges, and enjoying the experience of being lulled into it. And even though they were broken, disjointed images, the editing kind of smoothed them over . . . it turned them into a sequence that was very addictive. I hadn't expected it to be so compelling, I suppose. I thought I would only watch it for about half an hour, but I stayed much longer. (Interviewee #50; A2, Q7)

This interviewee demonstrates the way that meaning fluctuates during the viewing experience, often resulting in the coexistence of both reflective and mundane thoughts at the same time. While it is possible that this might have been prompted by reading some of the many interviews with Marclay

available online, there was clear evidence that for some of the visitors, *The Clock* did, indeed, produce the response Marclay had intended. This response is also interesting in the way it describes being 'lulled into the rhythm of the footage', echoing Catherine Russell's arguments that *The Clock* is intrinsically Benjaminian in its construction and effect on spectators. Russell contends that the 'experiential dimension of *The Clock* is exemplary of what Walter Benjamin describes as innervation: that property of cinema that harnesses the body through the senses, bringing the mechanical and the human into a very close encounter' (Russell 2018: 156). This experiential encounter between humans and machines creates a phantasmagoria, or in Russell's reading of *The Clock*, a 'phantasmagoria in ruins' (Russell 2018: 157). In the case of this interviewee, they perceive the 'broken' images as being compelling and addictive due, in part, to the quality of the editing. Other respondents to the survey make similar comments, such as 'it reminds me of watching the sea, oddly compelling' (S#009, Q8) and 'I liked the dreamy quality, the transitions from one clip to the next that were both unexpected and yet made complete sense' (S#412, Q6). The mechanical process of remixing and editing the footage thus produced an almost mesmeric response from some of the exhibition participants, who clearly enjoyed the phantasmagorical qualities of *The Clock*.

Other patterns of response were also prominent in this data set. Many of the respondents and interviewees discussed their appreciation of the way *The Clock* mirrors the rhythm of the working day. The sequences that were most frequently commented upon included those showing people going to work, during their lunch hour, and the end of the school day. These aspects of *The Clock* do not sound especially compelling, and yet the way they are editing together elicited much admiration. One interviewee said, 'I loved the mininarratives around key parts of the day, like going home from school, it was very clever. Also, I was thinking about making my own journey home after leaving the gallery, and yet felt drawn to keep on watching and see what was next' (Interviewee #51; A2, Q7). Another respondent 'liked the way it captured the rhythm of the day and turned it into a narrative, but then would move on to something really unexpected' (S#402, Q6).

These respondents demonstrated a tendency identified by Levinson, who observes that 'our conditioning as movie viewers makes us long for a narrative logic and causality that are not there. This is both frustrating and fun. We persist in trying to keep up with the ever-changing flow of images, story fragments, characters, and timepieces, but in *The Clock* it is impossible to predict what

comes next' (Levinson 2015: 103). This unpredictability was, for some, one of the factors that encouraged them to continue watching. What is significant about these responses to the perceived/lack of narrative in *The Clock* is that although several respondents discussed the way they tried to locate a narrative, it was notable that none of them complained absence of one.[16] Indeed, there was no evidence in this data set of visitors to the exhibition who did not enjoy it, or who articulated a negative response, which makes it an unusual case study among the others in this book, and in the field of audience research more broadly.

A significant number of the interviewees, however, had quite different articulations of the meaning *The Clock* held for them. Quite frequently, they used the language of film experts and demonstrated a higher than average level of knowledge about film-making. One interviewee replied:

> I'm not sure it was a profound experience, but I was impressed by the editing and intrigued by the range of films and television programmes used. Some genres, like westerns, thrillers and dramas, seemed to feature more heavily than others. It made me feel slightly wistful. (Interviewee #52; A2, Q7)

Overall, responses divided fairly evenly between those who reflected on the passing of time and those more interested in editing and other aspects of cinematic construction. Also evident throughout many of the interviews was a sense of nostalgia or wistfulness. One interviewee spoke of 'just feeling increasingly nostalgic about cinema, really, all these wonderful films, some I've seen and some I haven't. It made me reflect on the marvel of cinema, and in that sense, it was really quite uplifting. Not a meditation on death at all' (Interviewee #53; A2, Q7). These reflections on the archival qualities of *The Clock* are also found in some of the professional reviews. Writing in *The Guardian*, Jonathan Jones describes it as a 'chronicle of cinema' and notes that 'the longer you watch it, the more addictive it becomes'.[17] These responses again reflect Catherine Russell's Benjaminian analysis of *The Clock* in *Archiveology* (2018), in which she positions artists who produce montage film works as archiveologists whose films 'acquire meaning through their usefulness and their ability to awaken, stimulate, or attune the viewer's belief in their indexicality. They are not to be taken for granted but to be recognized as passages into the past' (Russell 2018: 98).

There were also a number of responses that discussed the type of clips selected in *The Clock* and some that weighed up the genre of films Marclay and team drew from. One noted that 'there were a lot of Hollywood films and I would have liked to have seen more use of independent and avant-garde cinema. But maybe

people don't look at their watches so much in those films' (S#098, Q8). Another said, 'although the films were varied and there was a lot of classical cinema, which I enjoyed, I would have liked to have seen more films from other parts of the world' (S#161, Q12). In their articulation of a specific form of cultural capital, these responses illustrate a type of audience engagement linked to the cultural expectations of the gallery space, which Catherine Russell suggests 'foregrounds a crucial tension in film aesthetics between genre cinema and the avant-garde and art cinemas' (Russell 2013: 244). Other respondents complained that 'it was so heteronormative. Obviously, Hollywood cinema is like that and these were old films, but so much of it was interaction between straight couples, and queer cinema did exist in the twentieth century' (S#167, Q12). These comments regarding genre were the closest that there were to negative responses to the actual film, rather than the exhibition space. Marclay has openly discussed the way that the footage was selected, explaining that 'it's very much about what was available in London during those three years that I was making *The Clock*. And a lot of British movies were featured because they were available. And, of course, if the action happens in London, you're pretty sure there's going to be a Big Ben shot.'[18] However, he has also discussed his decision to fire an assistant that focused too heavily on the horror genre, indicating that there were strategies in place regarding content and how this would shape the overall tone and structure of *The Clock*.

Conclusions

The cultural offer of *The Clock* is not typical of art installations more broadly, and in this respect, I am not drawing any conclusions about the increased popularity of the moving image as an art form. What this case study does demonstrate, though, is an appetite for cultural events that reconfigure or subvert established viewing protocols for watching films across a range of cultural spaces, including the institution of the art gallery. While this desire to upend conventional audience protocols has long been acknowledged and analysed in the cultural sphere of the midnight movie or, more recently, through the success of exhibitors such as Secret Cinema, it is less frequently considered in this particular cultural context. The data also suggests that an interest in, and inclination towards, this kind of experience extends beyond the established audience for cult and alternative cinema. Although the twenty-four-hour screenings were highly successful with a younger, hipster

audience, the wider interest in *The Clock*, and the intergenerational range of visitors it attracted, resonates with other case studies in this book. While this case study does not offer definitive evidence, it also implies that a process of cultural conditioning has occurred, whereby the majority of visitors to the exhibition watched *The Clock* for approximately the duration of a mainstream film. This conditioning is also evident in the way some respondents express middlebrow taste cultures when evaluating the source of the footage selected by Marclay and his assistants, and in the way, some visitors demanded the exclusive conditions normally guaranteed with their Tate membership. Thus, the case study indicates that while *The Clock* might challenge existing audience protocols associated with specific high art institutions and spaces, cultural conditioning and established traditions continue to inform audience behaviour.

Notes

1 These were *The Long Duration of a Split Second* (Forensic Architecture), *Tripoli Cancelled* and *Two Meetings and a Funeral* (Naeem Mohaiemen), *BRIDGIT* (Charlotte Prodger, winner) and *Cemetery of Uniforms and Liveries*, *Autoportrait* and *How Long* (Luke Willis Thompson).

2 https://www.tate.org.uk/visit/tate-modern/starr-cinema; https://www.moma.org/collection/about/curatorial-departments/film

3 These details form part of an auto-ethnographic account of visiting this installation in November 2018.

4 A discussion of this can be found in the April 2010 NMDC (National Museum Directors' Council) newsletter: https://www.nationalmuseums.org.uk/news/newsletters/?item=15

5 Tate Modern's commitment to the local community is also evident in the establishment of their community garden, a participatory art project open to those living in SE1: https://www.tate.org.uk/visit/tate-modern/tate-modern-community-garden

6 For example, see https://www.ashmolean.org/event/pop-up-cinema or https://www.nhm.ac.uk/events/pop- up-family-cinema.html (accessed 12 February 2020).

7 The 2018/19 Tate Modern exhibition of *The Clock* credits the following as research assistants: Ed Atkins, Philip Beeken, Andrew Gibbs, Joanne Kernan, Ryan MacLean and Paul Anton Smith.

8 Marclay discusses this with Peter Bradshaw in an interview published in *the Guardian*, 10 September 2018: https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2018/sep/10/christian-marclay-the-clock-tate-modern-london

9 Quotations from the survey are referenced by 'S' and the numbered respondent, followed by the question number. For example, a response to the first question would be S#01, Q1.

10 *The Clock* was first shown in London at White Cube Mason's Yard, 15 October 2010 to 13 November 2010, followed by Garage Center for Contemporary Culture, Moscow, Russia (2011); Los Angeles County Museum of Art, Los Angeles, CA (2011–12); The Israel Museum, Jerusalem, Israel (2011); Centre Pompidou (2011); Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, MA (2011); National Gallery of Canada, Ottawa, Ontario (2012); Museum of Contemporary Art, Sydney, Australia (2012); David Rubenstein Atrium, Lincoln Center, New York, NY (2012); Kunsthaus Zürich, Zürich, Switzerland (2012); The Power Plant, Toronto, Canada (2012); Museum of Modern Art, New York (2012–13); Wexner Center for the Arts, Columbus, OH (2013); San Francisco Museum of Modern Art (2013); Winnipeg Art Gallery, Canada (September 2013); Walker Art Center, Minneapolis, MN (2014); Centre Pompidou, Paris France (2014); Art Gallery of Alberta, Edmonton, Canada (2015); Martin-Gropius Bau, Berlin, Germany (2015);Los Angeles County Museum of Art, Los Angeles, CA (2015); Museum Berardo, Lisbon, Portugal (2015); Museum of Fine Arts, Boston, MA (2016–17); Contemporary Arts Center, presented by Prospect New Orleans, New Orleans, LA (2016); Instituto Moreira Salles, Rio de Janeiro, Brazil (2017); Tel Aviv Museum of Modern Art, Tel Aviv, Israel (2018) Tate Modern, London (2018–19).

11 Tate Modern confirmed in an email (31 October 2018) that this was also the case with the 2018/19 exhibition of *The Clock* in London.

12 Nicolas Serota interview in 'Tate buys timeshare in Christian Marclay's Clock' by Maev Kennedy, published in *the Guardian*, 1 February 2012: https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2012/feb/01/tate-buys- christian-marclay-clock

13 See Balsom (2013: 188–9) for an account of Christian Marclay in conversation with Michael Snow at the Power Plant Centre for Contemporary Art, Toronto, 5 November 2012.

14 It is difficult to get precise figures on this, as demonstrated by this 2013 article in *The Guardian*: https://www.theguardian.com/education/2013/feb/07/rising-number-postgraduates-social-mobility. Recent figures published by the National Office for Statistics suggest that 42 per cent of the British workforce were graduates in 2017: https://www.ons.gov.uk/employmentandlabourmarket/peopleinwork/employmentandemployeetypes/article s/graduatesintheuklabourmarket/2017#steady-increase-in-the-number-of-graduates-in-the-uk-over-the-past- decade

15 Interview with Christian Marclay quoted in the article 'Watching the Clock, Minute by Minute', by Vincent Dowd published by the BBC online. Found at: https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-11692234 (accessed 10 May 2019).

16 This is notable when compared to other experiences of conducting audience research on mainstream cinema, in which negative comments about the narrative being unsatisfactory in some respect are regularly made.

17 Review by Jonathan Jones published in *The Guardian* on 11 September 2018. Found online at: https://www.theguardian.com/artanddesign/2018/sep/11/the-clock-review-christian-marclay-tate-modern-london (accessed 22 April 2019).

18 Interview with Christian Marclay in *The Art Newspaper*, September 2018, found at: https://www.theartnewspaper.com/news/christian-marclay-on-the-clock (accessed 30 April 2019).

Part Two

Participatory cultures of resistance and the alternative experience economy

4

Experiential cinema in a rural context

You are invited to spend an hilarious weekend in the English countryside.
Withnail and I, 1987

Introduction

Despite the 'spatial turn' in film studies, which resulted in greater attention being paid to exhibition spaces and social practices (Maltby, Stokes and Allen 2007; Hallam and Roberts 2014), empirical research into audiences for live or experiential cinema tends to focus on metropolitan film-going cultures and practices (Atkinson and Kennedy 2016, 2018; Crisp and McCulloch 2016; Harris 2016; Pett 2016). Audience research investigating rural and outdoor cinema exhibition of this kind is relatively scarce and, most frequently, examines the drive-in experience (Levitt 2016; Nowell 2016; Taylor 2017; Church 2020). This chapter investigates the under-researched area of participatory and immersive cinema within a rural context, identifying some of the recent developments within the UK and contextualizing this trend alongside similar exhibition practices in Australia, Indonesia and the United States. It identifies three economic models of rural immersive cinema in the UK and offers a comparative analysis of these with the urban and metropolitan pop-up experiences discussed in Chapter 1. Through this analysis, I argue that both a commercial experience economy and an alternative, grassroots experience economy coexist within a rural, non-theatrical exhibition context.

A number of recent surveys produced by non-profit organizations based in the UK have revealed a significant level of activity in the non-theatrical rural sector in Britain in the period from 2014 to 2019.[1] Cinema for All (formerly the British Federation of Film Societies) recently estimated that there were approximately 1,071 community cinemas or clubs in the UK and that 33 per cent

of these are rural.[2] This development has been driven by a range of technological innovations that have, in turn, facilitated a marked growth in mobile, non-theatrical forms of film exhibition (Aveyard 2016: 2), together with a piecemeal set of funding initiatives that have had a significant, if uneven, impact on rural film-going cultures in the UK.[3] These include funding and equipment from a range of initiatives such as Cinema for All, the Film Audience Network, the BFI (British Film Institute)'s Neighbourhood Cinema Scheme (now closed), the Independent Cinema Office and the Big Lottery Fund.[4] Several of these funding schemes were initiated following the publication of a 2005 report commissioned by the BFI, which highlighted some of the benefits of the local and rural exhibition sector, noting that

> the wide range of positive impacts local cinemas have on their communities. The venues foster a sense of place and provide a focus for the local community, whilst enhancing local cultural life through the provision of mainstream and/or specialised film. The cinemas play an important social inclusion role, reaching out to otherwise underserved elements of the local population. They enhance learning opportunities through links with local schools and colleges, improving the skills and knowledge base of the community.[5]

Since then, a number of funding initiatives have contributed to a marked development in this exhibition sector. Newspaper reports regularly highlight the exponential growth of the DIY, pop-up sector in the UK (Jamieson 2011; Hayes 2016; Smith 2016) and eulogize over the pleasures of heading out of the city to enjoy one of the many bespoke cinematic experiences taking place across the UK every summer. Hayes's report, in particular, points to a growing interest in participatory cinema and a significant increase in such screenings outside of metropolitan areas. These specialist, short-run or one-off screenings form part of an emerging culture around non-traditional cinema exhibition in the UK, ranging from themed nights in village halls to highly commercial, interactive productions of blockbuster films.

To take these reports as evidence of a sector that is flourishing with the continued support of public funding, however, would be misleading. This chapter therefore examines the growth in rural immersive cinema-going in three distinctive ways. First, at a grassroots level, where initial funding has often stimulated activity in under-resourced parts of the country, but this has not been sustained, and rural community cinemas are frequently struggling to maintain their programmes. Following the closure of the BFI's Neighbourhood

Cinema scheme, only 13 per cent of respondents to a Cinema for All survey said they had found an alternative source of funding for their equipment.[6] Second, in the context of the heritage sector, which benefits from a mixed funding model and a mutually beneficial relationship with the local tourist industry – these market forces frequently combine to create an eclectic range of seasonal cinematic experiences at desirable or oddball out-of-town locations. And third, through an examination of the upmarket, boutique event sector that markets itself at those with a disposable income looking for a luxury rural break-with-a-difference. These three aspects of rural experiential cinema all illustrate different funding models operating within the contemporary experience economy and are characterized by both anomalies and a number of significant commonalities.

Rural cinema-going: An overview

Research into the cultures of rural cinema-going has, until recently, been fairly sparse. In 2014, Julia Hallam and Les Roberts identified a 'disproportionate skew' among film historians towards research on metropolitan cinema-going cultures (Hallam and Roberts 2014: 1). There are a few notable exceptions to this pattern, such as the studies of rural Australian audiences (Walker 2008; Bowles 2011; Aveyard 2011), Kathryn Fuller-Seeley's edited collection *Hollywood in the Neighbourhood* (2008), which includes four chapters focused on rural North American cinema-going history, Rebecca M. Alvin's 2008 study of the micro-cinema movement in North America, and Meers, Biltereyst and Van De Vijver's memory study of cinema-going in rural Belgium (Alvin 2007; Meers, Biltereyst and Van der Vijver 2010).

However, this disproportionate focus on the metropolitan in the field of cinema-going studies has, in recent years, been remedied by the recent publication of a number of key books foregrounding the rural experience: Karina Aveyard's *The Lure of the Big Screen* (2015) and the publication of two edited collections, *Cinema Beyond the City: Film-going in Small Towns and Rural Europe* (Thissen and Zimmerman 2017) and *Rural Cinema Exhibition and Audiences in a Global Context* (Treveri Gennari, Hipkins and O'Rawe 2018). Aveyard's study provides a detailed portrait of rural cinema-going in contemporary Britain and Australia, while the two edited collections set out to identify the 'commonalities and anomalies in the rural experience' by offering a rich and diverse range of studies into rural cinema-going cultures, both

historical and contemporary (Treveri Gennari, Hipkins and O'Rawe 2018: 18). Taken together, these studies are significant in the way they establish the diversity and breadth of non-metropolitan cinema-going cultures, as well as many of the recurring characteristics of rural audiences pertinent to this chapter, such as resourcefulness, an anti-commercial sentiment and a strong community ethos. Other recent studies have further bolstered this set of scholarly developments, such as Jamie Terrill's 2019 study of rural cinema-going in Wales and the various publications produced by the AHRC project *The Major Minor Cinema Project: Highlands and Islands Film Guild, 1946-71,* by Sarah Neely, Nalini Paul and others. Collectively, these publications have been effective in shining a light on a hitherto under-researched area and repositioning the rural experience as fundamental to the study of cinema-going cultures. This chapter therefore builds on an emergent field of study by investigating the development of immersive cinema-going cultures in a rural context; it develops a number of observations set out in an earlier publication (Pett 2018) through a qualitative study of audiences and participants of rural experiential cinema in the UK between 2014 and 2019.

While recent developments in the study of rural cinema-going cultures have been flourishing, there is relatively scant research on immersive cinema-going in this context. Parallels can be found in Alvin's study of the micro-cinema movement in North America, which traces the emergence of small community-led cinemas across the United States over the last twenty to thirty years (Alvin 2007). Alvin documents the makeshift theatres which have spread across a wide range of communities in the United States, in alternative spaces like tractor-trailers, cafes and bars, church basements and even health clubs. Like many of the events discussed in this chapter, the micro-cinema movement offers a communal cinema experience, characterized by the exhibition of low-budget, non-commercial films in alternative community spaces. The characteristics Alvin identifies have also been observed in rural cinema cultures in parts of Asia. In his study of the layar tancap tradition of mobile cinema exhibition, Ekky Imanjaya describes the popularity of low-budget films in rural parts of Indonesia. Imanjaya's study describes a travelling programme of films being screened in outdoor public spaces within rural Indonesian communities, usually between dusk and dawn; he notes that these all-night exhibition practices frequently facilitate rowdy, interactive behaviour among audiences (Imanjaya 2016: 84). An informal, communal screening culture combined with the absence of a designated auditorium area are two of the key features that are common, then, to both rural cinema exhibition spaces and those frequently employed to stage

immersive film events; both are characteristic of the way non-traditional cinema exhibition facilitates the de-centring of the film text and offers an alternative screen experience economy.

Cultural policy in the UK's non-theatrical rural sector

The availability of funding and government subsidies plays a central role in the development of rural film exhibition and community cinemas in the UK, and historically, this has compared favourable to parallel sectors elsewhere, such as in Australia (Aveyard 2015: 39). In the last decade, rural and community cinemas in the UK have benefited from a number of funding initiatives coordinated by national agencies that support the arts. In 2013, the BFI launched its Neighbourhood Cinema Fund (NCF) as part of the Film Forever programme, which operated from 2012 to 2017.[7] The NCF received £2 million from the National Lottery and was instrumental in providing support for rural cinemas around the UK in the form of equipment, promotion and marketing advice.[8] Several of the rural exhibitors discussed throughout this chapter were recipients of funding from this source, enabling them to buy their own equipment and become established in remote rural communities. However, the way cultural policy affects the UK non-theatrical sector across the last twenty years has been inconsistent in terms of the types of funding it offers. It is important, therefore, to outline the shifts in cultural policy and the types of rural and community subsidies they offer, as these shape and influence the character of non-theatrical cinema-going cultures within the UK.

The types of funding scheme and government subsidies available within the sector have undergone some key shifts in recent years; this was most notable when the BFI adjusted the focus of its agenda in 2017 to favour funding specific types of programming which were linked to their wider strategic priorities. This new strategy foregrounded the promotion of independent British and specialized films, rather than investing in community exhibition on the basis of the social benefits it can deliver.[9] Concurrent with this shift in the BFI's priorities, a number of short-term funding initiatives were launched, and these have successfully mobilized the local, non-metropolitan experience economy, frequently taking the form of programmes developed to engage with cultural heritage. This trend is exemplified by the BFI's Britain on Film project, a collaborative initiative between the BFI and the UK's thirteen national and regional film archive

launched in July 2015. Britain on Film's *Coast and Sea* project, which ran from May to September 2017, forms the main case study in the later section of the chapter, which examines the heritage aspect of the experience economy.

A further complication in assessing the growth and value of the non-theatrical exhibition sector in a rural context is the funding it receives from commercial sources, particularly when the event being organized creates an opportunity to promote tourism within the local area.[10] In this context, pop-up cinema and film festivals both share the potential to intersect with the tourist industry in multiple ways, primarily through their ability to attract visitors to a specific geographical location, thereby generating customers for the service and hospitality sectors and creating a range of potential retail opportunities. As Connell, Page and Meyer note, 'the visitor attraction sector harnesses and develops unique products and experiences to entice visitors, as well as to the wider destinations in which they are located' (Connell, Page and Meyer 2015: 283). These attractions can include pop-up screenings, the projection of film clips, such as archival footage, in public spaces and the organization of collaborative events in partnership with local festivals or other celebrations. In her study of film festivals in Glasgow, Maria Velez-Serna highlights the mutually beneficial relationship between festivals and the tourist industry, observing the playful way they 'blend media consumption and place-based tourism' (Velez-Serna 2018: 103). This is also evident in the data gathered on the heritage experience economy, discussed later in this chapter.

The rapidly evolving landscape for funding the non-theatrical sector within the UK can be understood within broader changers in arts funding, which have witnessed a series of shifts in emphasis and focus since the 1980s. The Thatcher government is widely acknowledged to have facilitated a turn towards instrumentalist cultural policies predicated on the grounds of the social and economic advantages (Vestheim 1994; Belfiore 2002: 94–6). This strategy evolved under New Labour governance (1997–2010) towards a focus on benefits, such as greater social inclusion, that the arts were perceived to facilitate (Hesmondhalgh, Oakley, Lee and Nisbett 2015: 36–7). However, the austerity politics introduced by the coalition government (2010–16) saw a 16.6 per cent reduction to local authority expenditure on art and culture under the coalition government of 2010–16 (Harvey 2016: 3). Subsequently, there has been a further shift in the instrumentalist focus of culture policy towards the current preoccupation with the health benefits the arts can offer; these measures have been met by a renewed attempt to validate the wider social benefits of the arts, in the form of an All-Party Parliamentary Group (APPG) report titled 'Creative

Health: The Arts for Health and Wellbeing' (2017). In his summary of the report, co-chair Lord Howarth argues that

> the arts can help keep us well, aid our recovery from illness and support longer lives better lived. The arts can help meet major challenges facing health and social care: aging, long-term conditions, loneliness and mental health. The arts can help save money in the health service and social care. (Howarth 2018: 26)

While this could be interpreted as the latest example of instrumentalism on the part of the British government, the APPG have been active in trying to diffuse such critiques, stating that they 'have no desire to ignite another flare-up in the chronic and sterile altercation between the proponents of art for art's sake and those who justify public intervention at least in part on the basis that the arts confer benefits on society. We believe that it is the validity of art itself that can lead to better health and wellbeing' (All-Party Parliamentary Group 2017: 5). The current focus of cultural policy on health and well-being is evident in funding initiatives developed by the UK Research and Innovation (UKRI), such as the Lifelong Health and Wellbeing strategy, or the more recent call for research into Health and Context.[11] What these different funding schemes and their attendant strategies and priorities point to is an ongoing lack of reliability and consistency with respect to funding in this sector. The fluctuating character of funding for the community sector within the UK means that this aspect of rural immersive culture is unstable and subject to constant change. The transitory character of this sector has two key implications for this study; first, that it makes it difficult to identify and chart the characteristics of rural immersive cinema; and second, that themed or one-off seasonal events are frequently staged as a way of raising funds for less well-attended programmes within the rural and community circuit.

Locating the non-theatrical rural space

Scholarship examining the significance of the exhibition environment in the cultural ecology of the rural non-theatrical sector emphasizes the intersection of the social and spatial (Aveyard 2015; Thissen and Zimmerman 2017). Aveyard highlights the importance of cinema as a social space and meeting place within Australian rural communities, frequently in terms of what it offers an alternative to, focusing on the significance of film culture for women as an alternative to

'the boorish atmosphere of the local pub' (Aveyard 2011: 298). Likewise, for teenagers the cinema space offers an attractive environment that 'can represent social freedom, one which lends a sense of purpose to "going out" and provides a welcome contrast to the aimlessness, and sometimes destructive, alternative pastime of hanging around in public parks or streets' (Aveyard 2011: 298). Aveyard's study of rural cinema audiences in Australia and the UK also establishes that the community cinema sector has grown significantly over the last two decades. She notes three key factors contributing to this trend: rural policy, rural socio-economic conditions and technological (Aveyard 2015: 138). Of particular relevance to discussions of rural immersive cinema are Aveyard's observations on the importance of social interaction and cooperation within these communities:

> For audiences, the quality and quantity of interpersonal interactions that occur around local cinemas are often very important. Confirming the social nature of cinema-going, the vast majority of respondents to the written audience surveys I conducted in Australia and the UK indicated that they usually watch a movie in the company of another person . . . cinemas can provide forums for conversation before and after the film screening, which can lead on to other activities. (Aveyard 2015: 138)

Just as there are many forms of rural participatory cinema, ranging from village hall productions to nationally advertised events, so too do the exhibition spaces for these events vary greatly. Picnic Cinema, based at Eden Arts in Cumbria, has staged immersive events in a wide range of impressive historical locations. Themed evenings such as these are much more typical of rural participatory cinema events at a grassroots level. However, while they seem to have little in common with grander and more commercial productions held at castles and country houses, they nevertheless share one important common feature: they are non-traditional auditorium spaces, and in this key respect, they differ from participatory film screenings at urban venues such as the Prince Charles Cinema in London. Information provided by Cinema for All on effective community exhibition strategies suggests that rural cinemas experimenting with non-traditional seating arrangements and themed evenings are exemplary models for successful exhibition.[12] One of these is West Side Cinema in Orkney, Scotland, whose experimentation with informal exhibition practices are valorized by Cinema for All as follows:

> While traditional tiered seating may offer a comfortable viewing experience, West Side found it to be restrictive when it came to the social side of cinema.

> With this in mind, the committee settled on a cabaret style, round table, candle – lit set up – creating an intimate environment which encourages interaction between audience members . . . the organizers have found that the sharing of food and drink encourages communication between audience members, and helps create a convivial atmosphere. (Cinema For All 2014)

This report suggests that, unlike the 'reverential silence' of the Prince Charles Cinema patrons observed by Crisp and McCulloch, attendees of the rural West Side Cinema engage in convivial conversation and demonstrate an appreciation for the communal exhibition environment. These community values are at odds, then, with the cultural capital displayed by cinephiles engaged in alternative exhibition cultures within a metropolitan context. A broader report on community cinema in Scotland also notes audiences' growing appreciation of themed evenings and the atmosphere of community screenings, which they feel provides 'a magical quality that no other cinema experience can compete with . . . there is a sense of being part of something adventurous and cool' (Social Value Lab/Regional Scotland 2016: 17). In her study of Australian and British rural audiences, Aveyard also observes that rural cinemas are 'sites of consumption where commercial imperatives are set aside in favour of ideals centred on cultural and social enrichment and community advancement' (Aveyard 2015: 128). While it is clear that immersive cinema staged within urban settings can facilitate significant social interactions, what Aveyard highlights in this discussion is the importance of an altruistic, anti-commercial sentiment among many rural cinema-goers. This contrasts strongly with her findings on cinema-going in metropolitan areas, where 'the quality of the films and the exclusivity of the cinema release window are considered crucial factors in attracting patrons' (Aveyard 2015: 144). These findings are also echoed by audience research on drive-in screenings (Levitt 2016; Church 2020). In his historical research on the American drive-in experience, David Church suggests that 'drive-ins were first promoted for their novelty, convenience, and family-friendly ambiance, especially appealing to viewers who might otherwise feel marginalised in "hardtop" (indoor) theatres – such as the young, disabled, non-white, female, obese, or parents with young children' (Church 2020: 217). The combination of lower ticket prices, on-site playgrounds for children and other facilities meant that drive-in culture was more inclusive and, Church argues, appealed to 'blue-collar audiences' (Church 2020: 217). Linda Levitt's study of the

renaissance of drive-ins in the Los Angeles area suggests that this culture has continued to the present day. She notes that

> being outdoors in open space eases some of the constraints of social decorum that traditionally dictated behavior in an indoor theater. This openness is enhanced by socializing and entertainment before the screening, which evoke a more party-like atmosphere and recall the customs of drive-ins with their accompanying playgrounds, entertainment areas, and extensive snack offerings. (Levitt 2016: 221)

The significance of the inclusive informality of the drive-in space therefore suggests a strong correlation between the screening environment and more sociable forms of cinema-going that facilitate intergenerational audience interaction.

Levitt's research on the popularity of cult contemporary films at outdoor screenings identifies another characteristic of this trend in US film exhibition. In particular, Levitt argues that 'where cinema audience members have been irate over the behavior of other moviegoers, especially those who do not hesitate to use smartphones while the movie is playing, outdoor movie audiences talk, sing along, and shout out lines of dialogue during the film. These behaviours are not only acceptable, they are desirable' (Levitt 2016: 232). This analysis of the contemporary drive-in experience positions it as a nostalgic experience capitalizing on pleasures associated with movie-going in the past, such as 'community spirit'. The study is relevant in that it implies that audience expectations around behaviour during the screening of the film are very closely linked to the exhibition environment, thus reinforcing observations made by Barbara Klinger on the differences in audience behaviour when films are shown in art-house and drive-in locations. Klinger notes that art-house cinemas 'recommend an observant and deferential mode of viewing, associated with overt aesthetic experience, while drive-ins include a host of "unaesthetic" distractions associated with family life and courtship, from squalling infants to backseat romances' (Klinger 2006: 19). The distinction Klinger draws underlines the clear correlation between the spaces of art-house and drive-in cinemas and the modes of viewing films.

While this overview of academic and commercial research investigating this emerging area of film exhibition is focused primarily on US studies, it clearly indicates that whereas traditional theatrical environments facilitate conservative, text-centric modes of film spectatorship, drive-ins, outdoor spaces

and community settings are more likely to enable social interaction between audience members, which is often intergenerational; these differences are further exacerbated by the contrasting cultural values of urban cinephiles and rural film-goers. A key strand of investigation, then, is whether the distinction in audience protocol observed by Klinger and others has become manifest in the difference between immersive cinema (whether high-end urban pop-up or low-budget rural events) and conventional cinema screenings, in designated auditoria with fixed seating.

Audiences for rural cinema in the UK

This study employs a range of primary and secondary sources, including twelve interviews, three industry reports and thirty-four newspaper articles, to investigate how and why immersive and experiential cinema has developed within rural contexts and cultures in the UK. The interviews were conducted using the same question schedule as was employed with the other pop-up or temporary events, exhibitions and festivals (appendix 2), and the semi-structured approach enabled respondents to expand on specific characteristics of the rural environment. The interviewees were contacted either at screenings or via exhibitors involved in the Community Screen Network and were selected to represent the audiences at the exhibition sites. For this reason, there are significantly more baby boomer interviewees discussing community screenings, while the millennial and generation x interviewees are predominantly discussing their experiences of Picnic Cinema events.[13]

The grassroots sector: Collaborative and community rural networks

The growth of participatory and immersive cinema exhibition in the grassroots or community sector is a largely undocumented culture. 'Grassroots cinema' is a term more frequently used in relation to community video projects, often aimed at facilitating technological and creative access to videomaking apparatus for marginalized communities (Wong 1998; Mayer 2000). There is less discussion of the culture and influence of grassroots organizations within the film exhibition sector; Aveyard describes grassroots film exhibitors as 'community cooperatives,

film societies and small-scale entrepreneurs' who 'typically operate on a part-time, not-for-profit basis and as such can be described as sub-commercial' (Aveyard 2015: 3). Access to technology is central to developments within this sector, and the focus of research in this field has frequently shifted to examining the significance of online participatory cultures (Burgess and Green, 2013). Indeed, Bert Cammaerts argues that alternative and community media has been overlooked and displaced by an overemphasis on the significance of the internet, contending that

> The overemphasis on the internet and the neoliberal culture it tends to promote have also led to a more pronounced focus on individuals as alternative 'produsers', as free labourers, as activists and advocates, with less attention being paid to the collective dimensions and internal structures. Ideal-type alternative and particularly community media distinguish themselves from commercial and public service media among others by a bottom-up and grassroots ethos, by horizontal and participatory structures and by their embeddedness in strong democratic cultures. (Cammaerts 2016: 3)

Thus, Cammaerts advocates the need for more research focusing on the enduring significance and role of non-digital media and real-world communities (Cammaerts 2016: 1–2). This sentiment partly echoes the discourse around demediatization and simultaneously reflects the suspicion rural audiences often demonstrate towards new technologies. Similarly, Nico Carpentier highlights the significance of collaborative organizations that use a range of media to advocate their end goals and call for further research in this area that positions community media as a link between state and market (Carpentier 2016: 5). This research on immersive cinema in a rural, grassroots context can therefore be positioned within this broader recognition of the ongoing cultural role played by collaborative and community film exhibition models.

A number of recent regional and national surveys conducted across the UK indicate that there is a thriving grassroots sector.[14] One survey published by Bigger Picture Research in 2014 proposes three different models of community-run exhibitors: volunteer-run community cinemas, mobile and rural network venues, and mixed-use venues.[15] These types of grassroots organizations are typical of the membership of CSF, a collective of community cinemas formed in 2016 to represent the interests of this disparate and geographically remote group exhibitors.[16] While the members of CSF are relatively young, their level of activity indicates that non-theatrical cinema-going has become increasingly popular in the UK.[17] The Forum's 2017 report establishes that approximately

6,500 screenings took place across almost 750 different locations around the UK; these screenings generated 339,770 admissions and generated a box office totalling over £1.5 million. Their ethos is stated clearly by Community Screen Forum in their literature, where they explain that their activities are 'guided by recognition of the importance of film as a cultural experience, but also by the crucial role screen experiences can play in enhancing social engagement and connection, and supporting the vitality of communities around the United Kingdom'.[18] The emphasis here on affordable, communal experiences is echoed in other accounts of rural immersive screenings. It is the focus on accessibility and social inclusion in the design of these events that marks them out as being almost antithetical to big-budget metropolitan models like Secret Cinema.

The significance of collaborative organizational structures is often key to the success of rural exhibition, and this is why immersive film screenings work so effectively in rural areas. An interviewee who attends a local community cinema in rural Cornwall once a month highlighted the importance of the social network the facility provided for her:

> I only get out about once a week now, when a neighbour comes to pick me up. . . . I can't walk very far these days. So, it's lovely to go out to the cinema club, it's the only time I go out in the evening. We get picked up and taken there and back, which is nice. I don't mind what we watch, or if I've seen the film before. It's more about the before and after, catching up with people and seeing some familiar faces. Sometimes there's a theme, special food or people dress up, which is fun. (Interviewee #58; A2, Q1)

For this attendee, the primary purpose of the local cinema is social, and in this respect, it provides a vital service for elderly members of the community who are no longer able to drive or walk long distances. Other interviewees talk about their reluctance to go out at night alone, and the importance of walking with volunteers or local community members to the hall where the films are screened. In these ways, the model of rural cinema-going is frequently built on intergenerational forms of social interaction that extend beyond familial social structures; unlike many of its counterparts in the commercial sector, the organization of grassroots exhibitors thus actively addresses issues of social and cultural exclusion by providing a transport service for isolated members of the community and is broadly inclusive in its structure.

These findings reflect existing research on rural cinema-going, which contends that it is primarily driven not just by social behaviour but by a community ethos.

Aveyard's research establishes the voluntary, non-commercial characteristic of the sector, which is also discussed in Francois Matarasso's study of Creative Arts East's rural cinema organization (Matarasso 2014; Aveyard 2015). An additional characteristic of rural cinema-going culture revolves around a particular set of ideological values. Aveyard observes that rural cinemas are 'sites of consumption where commercial imperatives are set aside in favour of ideals centred on cultural and social enrichment and community advancement' (Aveyard 2015: 128). While it is clear that immersive cinema staged within urban settings can facilitate important social interactions, what Aveyard highlights in this discussion is the importance of an altruistic, anti-commercial sentiment among many rural communities. This contrasts strongly with her findings on cinema-going in metropolitan areas, where 'the quality of the films and the exclusivity of the cinema release window are considered crucial factors in attracting patrons' (Aveyard 2015: 144).

Aveyard's findings thus resonate with those of Rebecca Alvin, who notes that micro-cinemas in North America 'bring with them the promise of a communal cinema experience, showing films with virtually no marketing campaigns, no stars, and no budgets' (Alvin 2007: n. p.). Whereas attendees of Secret Cinema events are issued with complicated instructions on the costume and props they will need to engage in the experience, participants at rural immersive events are encouraged to adopt a budget, DIY approach to costume and participation. This also reinforces the voluntary, non-commercial characteristic of the sector, as discussed in Matarasso's study of Creative Arts East's rural cinema organization. Matarasso notes that

> rural touring has always been run by volunteers. It is estimated that promoting groups contribute 100,000 hours of voluntary time each year in organising their events. In truth, people probably give much more time than this to setting out chairs, making teas and cleaning up afterwards: there is no line to separate 'volunteering' from mucking in. The thousands of theatre, music and film evenings that take place in villages across England would be far too expensive to put on without all this help. Only people's willingness to invest themselves in their community makes it possible. (Matarasso 2014: 90)

Many rural film exhibitors that run on a voluntary basis belong to a parent organization, such as Creative Arts East, or a network of similar organizations that can offer support with aspects of the organization that are more costly. These typically include a scheme for hiring equipment, marketing support,

training for volunteers, advice about funding and discounted insurance. All of these elements of rural cinema exhibition are difficult to manage, but once they are in place, most communities do not encounter difficulties in recruiting volunteers.

While the ethos of community cinema-going often facilitates a de-centring of the significance of the film text, some of the interviewees discussed the importance of the film when attending a sing-along screening of *The Sound of Music* in their village hall. One expressed her delight that the event attracted a wide range of young and old participants, noting, 'it was such a pleasure to see people come together of all ages . . . children and grandparents singing and enjoying a night out together. Wonderful. It wouldn't have been the same if we hadn't all known the film' (Interviewee #59; A2, Q2). This was also the aspect of the event the interviewee considered to be 'live'. Another recalled a sing-along screening of *Mary Poppins* which 'was great fun because we all knew the words of the songs, it meant everyone could join in' (Interviewee #60; A2, Q5). Film genre is key to the interactive element of many low-budget forms of immersive rural cinema-going, and musicals provide a low-cost option for getting everyone involved. While many sing-alongs are promoted by larger, urban cinemas, local rural exhibitors have also followed suit. One interviewee recalls, 'we had a sing-along screening of *Mamma Mia!* for a neighbour's hen night at the village hall. Everyone knew the songs and dressed up as different characters from the film, it was a hoot' (Interviewee #61; A2, Q5). This interviewee said it was the 'dressing up and singing that made it feel "live, like a group performance of the film"' (Interviewee #61; A2, Q5).

Themed food and refreshments can also provide a relatively low-cost option for rural immersive screenings. One interviewee remembered attending a summertime screening of *The Lunchbox* at her local cinema and being served Indian food as part of an immersive event, noting, 'it was much livelier than an ordinary screening, the food was delicious . . . provided by a local restaurant. It made the whole thing more of an experience, I remember the food as much as the film' (Interviewee #63; A2, Q5). Summertime screenings are often highlighted by the interviewees as being more memorable and enjoyable. One notes that 'it's a lovely way to make the most of the good weather, to take a picnic and go to the outdoor screenings in the park. You don't want to stay in and watch the telly when the weather is that good' (Interviewee #64; A2, Q4). Although not all outdoor screenings offer more than the opportunity to watch a film outside, many rural exhibitors take advantage of the environment to create

a more distinctive cinematic experience, and in this respect, there is a parallel between the commercial and non-profit sector.

Reports on other outdoor rural screenings indicate they are popular with families and attract large audiences for that reason, particularly during the school holidays. Other immersive film exhibitors argue this is true of immersive film experiences more broadly. Fabien Riggall, founder of Secret Cinema, contends that 'kids go crazy over immersive theatre, and the Secret/Future Cinema concepts are inspired by films from our own childhoods' (Riggall/Edwards 2014). One interviewee describes the attraction of Picnic Cinema as 'a special night out with your friends. Hanging out, doing something different rather than just sitting in a pub' (Interviewee #65; A2, Q2), while another explains, 'it's all about who you go with. I went with my daughter and her partner and we had an amazing time. The film was something we've always bonded over anyway, but this was a bit special, it was my treat' (Interviewee #66; A2, Q2). A notable feature of the rural immersive sector, then, is a tendency for participants to attend from across a wider age range than has been evidenced in the commercial sector, and for different generations of a family to attend an event together; the intergenerational aspect of community cinema-going in rural areas thus mirrors the characteristics of commercial and high-end pop-up cinema discussed in Chapter 1.

The question of audience demographics has been a long-standing issue for rural cinema exhibitors in the UK, Australia and elsewhere. The rural cinema sector has acknowledged that their audiences tend to be constituted of older people, with a high percentage of retired attendees. In her study of rural audiences in the UK and Australia, Aveyard notes that 'while Village Screen cinemas do well in catering to the older rural audiences, to date they have had limited success in attracting younger patrons including families' (Aveyard 2015: 125). Part of the issue for some rural film exhibitors is that multiplexes in local towns offer not only a wider range of current releases but also the opportunity for teenagers to have a night out with peer groups, away from the watchful eye of their parents. However, the playful appeal, physical stimulation and outdoor locations frequently involved in immersive cinema productions have contributed to a more alluring prospect for younger audiences than the more conventional rural cinema cultures. Alongside Picnic Cinema's immersive productions, for example, they advertise 'dancing', 'shenanigans', 'discos' and 'tomfoolery' as key attractions at their events.[19] An interesting development in the phenomenon of immersive cinema within a rural context, then, is the focus on young people,

families and intergenerational social activity, and in this respect it is an emergent culture which reflects many of the characteristics established in relation to the American drive-in (Alvin 2016; Church 2020).

The growing interest that gen Z and millennials are taking in immersive and experiential cinema also complicates broader analyses of film consumption that have emerged in the twenty-first century. In his discussion of the 'post movie-going epoch', Robert C. Allen asserts that 'not only has the principal site of the experience of cinema in the US been relocated from 15,000 theaters to hundreds of millions of domiciles, the character of the experience of cinema has undergone a profound generational change' (Allen 2011: 42–3). It certainly cannot be contested that there has been a dramatic shift, primarily due to technological developments such as VCR, DVD and the internet, in the places and platforms used for contemporary film consumption. However, what is interesting about Allen's description of the domestic film-viewing habits of his daughter's generation – walking around, eating, dressing up as characters, acting out favourite sequences, social interaction with other generations and so on – is that he could describe an immersive cinema event. In Allen's summary of all the off-putting aspects of conventional cinema-going for young people, he neatly outlines many of the characteristics of formal film consumption that immersive film exhibitors attempt to eschew:

> Seated upright in chairs bolted to the floor, limited in the range of comestible accompaniments to criminally overpriced popcorn, candy and soft drinks, discouraged from talking, singing or walking around, unable to pause, fast-forward or replay, deprived of director's commentary track . . . my daughter understands cinema as a textually disintegrated phenomenon experienced through multiple and unpredictably proliferating sites and modalities. For her, the experience of cinema has always been decentred and fissiparous. (Allen 2011: 43–4)

Allen's observations about the viewing habits of younger consumers being 'decentred and fissiparous' resonate with recent calls to rethink methodologies for investigating cinema-going practices to incorporate strategies for observing media use across a range of platforms and non-theatrical environments (Aveyard 2016; Couldry 2012; Hill 2020). The culture of immersive and participatory cinema thus offers a relevant and pertinent development in this context, in that the design of the events themselves frequently involves a range of mobile viewing practices.

The heritage sector: Experiential tourism and place-making practices

While funding for community cinema equipment and marketing have become harder to obtain since the BFI's *Neighbourhood Cinema* programme ceased operating in 2017, other funding initiatives have come to the fore.[20] Several of these have successfully mobilized the local, non-metropolitan experience economy and are funded by programmes developed to celebrate various forms of cultural heritage. One example of this is the BFI's *Britain on Film* project, a collaborative initiative between the BFI and the UK's thirteen national and regional film archive launched in July 2015. The broad aims of the *Britain on Film* project are to promote the heritage of British cinema by digitizing thousands of films. An offshoot of this endeavour is to circulate and exhibit these heritage films via a number of focused initiatives, such as *Rural Life*, a season of over 100 screenings that took place in villages and country shows across Britain in 2016, and *Coast and Sea*, a season of films screened throughout the summer of 2017.[21]

The *Coast and Sea* project ran from May to September 2017, during which time it facilitated the organization of 4,078 screenings across 169 locations along the UK's coast, reaching an audience of approximately 108,559.[22] The events were developed to raise the profile of British archive film and the newly digitized archive produced by the *BFI's Unlocking Film Heritage* digitization programme. To achieve this, some took the form of immersive experiences which incorporated the screening of archival film footage in unusual settings. In East Anglia, archival footage was screened along the Norfolk and Suffolk coast at locations including Happisburgh lighthouse, in a programme titled Screen-on-Sea, which received match funding of £6,000 from three local councils (Jarvis 2018). One interviewee who attended Screen-on-Sea said, 'I really enjoyed seeing the historical footage of local areas, I'd never seen it before. The setting was important, it made it more enjoyable, I probably wouldn't have gone into a dusty archive to watch it' (Interviewee #66; A2, Q4). Many of these heritage screenings integrate live components such as music, performance and costume in ways that reflect their geographical location and its heritage, functioning as a local tourist experience economy. In these respects, this form of rural immersive cinema-going has marked similarities with transmedia tourism (Garner 2019a, 2019b) in that specific geographical spaces and media texts are heightened in relation to each other, to produce a unique spatially and temporally bound experience.

In Scotland, the *Coast and Sea* project delivered six live cinema events featuring musical performances which accompanied silent archive films of the fishing and coastal industries. One screening in Leith included beatbox artist Jason Singh performing a live solo vocal accompaniment to *Drifters* (1929), a film about the local fishing industry.[23] The economic models for these live events frequently combine public funding (from the BFI) with commercial investment, or in some cases saw the BFI funding matched by either the Arts Council or local councils. The BFI report on *Coast and Sea* also reveals that the age range of those attending was very diverse, with the events attracting a broad age range including both the very young and the elderly (Jarvis 2018). As with the tourist industry, seasonality is an issue with many of these initiatives, and the summer months provide the best opportunities for both industries. This data reinforces the findings of other case studies that establish the cross-generational appeal of experiential cinema, as discussed in Chapter 1.

For some working in the community sector, there is an inclination to view post-crash cultural politics as an opportunity to move beyond being positioned as 'the third sector' and become a more prominent player, working together with other stakeholders. Ingrid Burkett frames the neoliberal concepts of self-reliance, autonomy and entrepreneurship as positive attributes, arguing that

> in a neoliberal policy environment, 'self-reliance' is framed as a narrow cul-de-sac which affords community organizations very few opportunities.
>
> However, it does offer a broader and more progressive vision for community organizations, though it is not one that can be delivered from above or implemented using funding agreements or policy structures. It is one that must begin from within organizations themselves and engages with all the dimensions of self-reliance rather than being limited to economic self-reliance. (Burkett 2011: 119)

Burkett argues for a repositioning of self-reliance as a community ethos rather than an individualistic neoliberal principle, thus sidestepping the stereotypes of either the 'lone wolf' entrepreneur or the inherently progressive community collective. This is demonstrated by the localized events forming the *Coast and Sea* programme.

The BFI scheme is not the only one in the UK offering funding to pop-up exhibitors with an interest in local heritage and the tourist industry. Brett Lashua's research on a pop-up cinema at Marshall's Mill in Yorkshire illustrates that other funding resources are available in relation to regeneration schemes

within the heritage industry. In this context, pop-up cinemas are developed as part of broader local regeneration schemes. Lashua describes the pop-up cinema staged in the temporary space of a former flax mill in Leeds, UK, a building awarded Grade II listed status by English Heritage in 1989. The event was developed by a team of academics and an architect/urban activist based in Marshall's Mill and screened the film *Happy* (2011, Roko Belic) as part of the UK Green Film Festival in May 2012. In this way, the event mobilized audience interest via a number of significant causes, namely environmental issues and local regeneration, and Lashua notes that there was a celebratory atmosphere. On-site catering included a draught beer van, a barbeque and a cake stall run by students to raise money for an international volunteering trip. In his description of the experience, Lashua observes that 'to some extent, the film was not even the point of the event: there was a festive, street party atmosphere as people made use of a space that would otherwise be dead at that hour' (Lashua 2013: 131). Lashua uses the case study of the Marshall's Mill pop-up cinema to argue in particular for the development of less culturally elite ways of interpreting cultural policy around heritage and regeneration in areas of economic deprivation. Drawing on the Faro Convention Framework, Lashua argues for the democratization of the cultural heritage sector in a way that centralizes the role of the public, rather than one that privileges the knowledge and views of heritage experts.

Heritage sites have also increasingly provided the space for site-specific immersive theatre experiences. Kirsty Sedgman's study of National Theatre Wales' first season of site-specific performances in 2011–12 considers the spatial politics of performances where participants are allowed to navigate their own way around the designated space:

> By affording the potential for locational relationality, performances may invite their audiences to enter into a personal course of discovery, constructing their own version of location by forging imaginative connections. To put it differently, this is a process of getting one's own bearings within a site – and its sedimentary layers of history, memory, narrative – rather than being told where to stand. (Sedgman 2017: 174)

Sedgman's study highlights some of the benefits of site-specific experiences that allow participants to wander at will and construct 'their own version of location'. What defines the cinematic equivalences of these site-specific theatrical experiences is that the part of the event in which participants 'roam free' is structured around the consumption of food and alcohol, and thus they acquire a more carnivalesque tone.

These immersive events, part-funded by organizations such as the BFI, the Arts Council and English Heritage, illustrate the way cultural policy informs and sustains the tourist experience economy at a regional and local level, and reflects shifting patterns in the exhibition of experiential cinema within a rural context. It suggests a 'heritage model' of immersive cinema, whereby public funding for heritage initiatives is combined with either local public funding or commercial investment to produce experiential events that attract tourists and boost the local economy. These localized hybrid events, often coordinated to take place alongside regional festivals and events, create a heritage experience economy that is particularly successful in the summer months.

The boutique sector: Upmarket shenanigans and fan tourism

The specificity of outdoor locations is particularly important for immersive screenings that coordinate the environment with a textual aspect of the film being screened, such as those organized by Picnic Cinema. Founded in 2011, Picnic Cinema is seasonal programme of pop-up outdoor cinema screenings that runs from June to September every year. Like the localized heritage experience economy, these pop-up events attract tourists and visitors from outside of the local area. As an initiative developed by regional arts centre Eden Arts in Cumbria, Picnic Cinema is supported by funding received from the Big Lottery Fund and Arts Council England. However, any profit made by Picnic Cinema screenings is reinvested to fund Eden Arts more low-key rural project, Remote – an initiative that enables rural communities to put on cinema screenings in their village venue. In this respect, even though it has the veneer of an upmarket, boutique exhibitor, Picnic Cinema forms part of a local economic structure that provides under-serviced areas with a community cinema service.[24]

However, unlike many rural exhibitors that organize low-budget experiential events, Picnic Cinema is relatively commercial, in that tickets sell for approximately £40 and events are staged at high-profile locations such as Muncaster Castle. In this respect, from a consumer perspective Picnic Cinema has more in common with Secret Cinema than with many of the smaller rural exhibitors. Events are characterized by dressing up, camping at the venue overnight, engaging in activities such as quizzes and games. Project manager Brioney Cartlidge explains the ethos of Picnic Cinema as 'having fun, being able to enjoy yourself, meet different people and generally get into the spirit of the

night. We give out sweets, badges, prizes and last year we decorated people's faces with glitter, or custom temporary tattoos . . . the events have more of a festival feel that a cinema.'[25] The carnivalesque tone of these events is particularly effective for one of Picnic Cinema's most popular and long-running events, their annual screening of *Withnail and I* (Bruce Robinson 1987) at Crow Crag in Cumbria, the location used as Uncle Monty's holiday cottage in the film. One interviewee who attended Picnic Cinema's *Withnail* event said:

> *The Withnail and I* experience is all about the setting, the Cumbrian countryside. It's overlooking Sleddale Wet, so you can enjoy the views and the fresh air as well. It was like a mini holiday for us, really . . . and then the actual event was put together brilliantly, it was like a big party where you got to watch your favourite film with a bunch of friends with the same sense of humour. We made loads of new friends! (Interviewee #67; A2, Q4)

Another interviewee discussed her enjoyment of the event, recalling that

> watching *Withnail & I* at the real Crow Crag was one of the best immersive screenings I've attended. It was so much fun seeing the film with other people who appreciated it as much as I did, and actually laughed and interacted with the film. I went with my mum, who is also a big fan, and after the film we stayed up dancing, it was very sociable. (Interviewee #68; A2, Q2)

The *Withnail and I* immersive experiences also attract a loyal following of fans of the film. One explained that 'I've made the pilgrimage up to Crow Crag quite a few times now, it's one of my favourite films, so it's a bit special. The live factor is seeing it with other people' (Interviewee #65; A2, Q5). In describing his experience as a 'pilgrimage', this participant and others who identify as fans exemplify what has been variously theorized as film tourism (Beeton 2005), media tourism (Couldry 2000), cult geography (Hills 2002) and fan pilgrimages (Reijinders 2010). Existing scholarship in this field has examined the affective relationships that specific places offer to fans as alternative sites of media consumption, particularly when a favourite television series or film franchise has ended. The interviewees who indicate they have an affective relationship with Crow Crag discuss details of the film, quote dialogue and take photographs of themselves in specific locations. For one interviewee, watching *Withnail and I* at Crow Crag also involved 'lots of booze, for an authentic *Withnail* experience, so the Picnic Cinema crowd were perfect companions'. For this participant the event was 'live when it came alive and we had a big party' (Interviewee #68; A2, Q5).

The social dimension of these gatherings, heightened by the carnivalesque ethos of the organization, is a key component of the experience which is identified and valued by participants. When asked what the most important aspect of the event was, one interviewee stated bluntly, 'it's more about meeting people and socialising than about watching the film' (Interviewee #66; A2, Q2). However, the social dimension of the Picnic Cinema events can draw complaints from some participants. One interviewee noted that 'towards the end of the evening some people had been drinking too much and were making a lot of noise, and that spoilt it a bit for me. Overall, though, I thought it was an excellent night out' (Interviewee #69; A2, Q4). These interviews confirm, then, that whereas traditional theatrical environments often facilitate conservative, text-centric modes of film spectatorship, drive-ins, outdoor spaces and community settings are more likely to enable social interaction between audience members, and that is often the key allure of experiential cinema.

The case study of Picnic Cinema is significant in that it illustrates how rural and provincial exhibition sites for contemporary experiential cinema are not always developed for local audiences. Boutique festivals and specialist gatherings staged outside of metropolitan areas attract thousands of visitors to immersive and participatory film events every year and are continuing to grow in popularity. The Ilfracombe Film Festival in Devon and the Keswick Film Festival in Cumbria, for example, both offer exclusive, one-off augmented screenings. These events are often developed as a means to raise capital for the festivals they are linked to, thus functioning in a markedly different way to the DIY, anti-commercial cinemas that serve local film-going communities in the United Kingdom, United States, Australia and elsewhere (see Chapter 5). Other venues, such as Carlton House in Yorkshire, stage one-off participatory screenings of mainstream films to attract tourists during the holiday season. These developments in the experience economy offer an alternative model of film tourism to the established forms of tourist engagement with fictional places derived from popular film franchises such as Harry Potter. Christina Lee argues that such locations function as 'affective, liminal spaces where the tourist anticipates and partakes in the transformation of sights/sites' (Lee 2012). In this respect, the conceptual frameworks established around fan tourism (Hills 2002; Reijinders 2010; Garner 2016) are combined with those on site-specific screenings and the 'mobility turn' (Wilkie 2012; Velez-Serna 2017) to create a framework for empirical analysis into the ways in which tourists and visitors from outside of the locale engage with augmented screenings in non-metropolitan locations.

Conclusions

This investigation of contemporary developments in immersive cinema exhibition within rural contexts points to some of the key characteristics of the evolving non-theatrical exhibition sector, and commonalities between these cultures and the pop-up experiences discussed in Chapter 1. First, the comparative analysis across three distinctive economic models of exhibition reveals rural immersive film cultures to be highly diversified in terms of the scale, design and exhibition. However, despite this diversification, the shared characteristics of alternative screening spaces enable a distinctive form of mobile, interactive audience behaviour which appears to be markedly different to that witnessed at conventional theatres and auditoria, and has much in common with the American drive-in. A second characteristic of some rural participatory screenings is an anti-commercial, DIY sentiment found at a grassroots level which promotes events on the basis of inclusivity, as opposed to the exclusivity that is common to productions by Secret Cinema and other high-end immersive exhibitors; this will be discussed further in Chapter 5 in relation to the ethos of Scalarama. Finally, there is some evidence that rural immersive cinema can offer an effective way of attracting cross-generational audiences, both familial and community-wide, in a way that more traditional rural cinema-going cultures have not experienced in recent decades. In these respects, this small-scale study indicates a significant development within the landscape of contemporary cinema exhibition, and one that echoes the findings on pop-up cinema in Chapter 1.

The shared characteristics between urban pop-up culture and the rural immersive are multiple, and they suggest the distinction in audience protocol observed by Klinger and others between art-house and drive-in audiences (focused on class, taste cultures and audience behaviour) has become manifest in the distinction between immersive cinema (whether high-end urban and boutique extravaganzas, or low-budget, DIY rural events) and mainstream cinema screenings in designated auditoria with fixed seating.

Notes

1 This report is provided by Community Screen Forum (CSF), which was set up in 2017 to represent organizations that promote, support and enable community

screen experiences in rural and under-serviced parts of the UK. Members include Arts Alive, Flicks in the Sticks, Carn to Cove, C Fylm, Creative Arts East, Village Screen, Driftwood Cinema, INDY Cinema Group, Live & Local, Big Picture Show, Moviola, Cine North, NEAT Flicks, FilmLincs, Open Cinema and Regional Screen Scotland. While not all organizations are exclusively rural, collectively they are the largest organization to represent the rural film exhibition sector in the UK. For further information, please visit https://www.uea.ac.uk/community-screen-forum/home

2 See data provided at https://cinemaforall.org.uk/about-cinema-for-all/about-the-sector/community-cinema- important/ (accessed 2 February 2020).

3 The correlation between technological developments and the buoyancy of this sector is a historical one. Writing in *Sight and Sound*, Amanda Randall discusses how the drop in cost of 16 mm and portability of equipment enabled development of community cinema and film societies in post-war Britain (Randall 2016).

4 https://cinemaforall.org.uk/about-cinema-for-all/; https://www.independentcinemaoffice.org.uk/advice-support/; https://www.tnlcommunityfund.org.uk/funding/grants/0030008084 (accessed 2 February 2020).

5 https://www.bfi.org.uk/sites/bfi.org.uk/files/downloads/uk-film-council-impact_of_local_cinema-2005-pdf (accessed 30 February 2019).

6 Information found at: https://cinemaforall.org.uk/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Survey-Report-2018-final-1.pdf (accessed 30 June 2019).

7 https://www.screendaily.com/news/bfi-launches-2m-neighbourhood-cinema-fund/5063932.article (accessed 5 January 2020).

8 As above; https://cinemaforall.org.uk/apply-bfi-neighbourhood-cinema-equipment-fund; https://www.independentcinemaoffice.org.uk/advice-support/useful-exhibitor-resources/key-organisations/ (accessed 5 January 2020).

9 See https://www.bfi.org.uk/about-bfi/policy-strategy.

10 For example, see the schemes facilitated by the BFI's Britain on Film programme: https://www.bfi.org.uk/britain-on-film (accessed 8 April 2019).

11 For details of these funding initiatives, see https://mrc.ukri.org/research/initiatives/lifelong-health- wellbeing/ and https://esrc.ukri.org/funding/funding-opportunities/ukri-gcrf-health-and-context-call-for- proposals/ (accessed 4 September 2019).

12 Cinema for All is the trading name for the British Federation of Film Societies (BFFS), formed in 1946. More information about the organization can be found at http://cinemaforall.org.uk/

13 In the interviewee sample for this chapter, there are eight female, four male participants; eight boomers, two generation X and two millennial participants. Six are university educated, and six left school after O or A levels.

14 'Rural Community Film Exhibition in Wales' by Bigger Picture Research. 2014. https://filmhubwales.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/08/Rural_Comm_Exhib_R

eport_FINAL.pdf; 'Factsheet 1: Community Cinema Networks' https://www.uea.ac.uk/documents/12814720/0/Fact+Sheet+1_July_18.pdf/697ce293-82dd-9324-9de9- 6122be6681d8; 'Your Cinema, Your Community' found at: http://www.socialvaluelab.org.uk/wp- content/uploads/2016/10/Local-Cinema-Report-FINAL-for-web.pdf (accessed 23 January 2020).

15 'Rural Community Film Exhibition in Wales' by Bigger Picture Research. 2014. https://filmhubwales.org/wp- content/uploads/2019/08/Rural_Comm_Exhib_Report_FINAL.pdf.

16 https://www.uea.ac.uk/community-screen-forum/home (accessed 20 January 2020).

17 Screen Machine is the oldest network among CSF members, established in 1998, followed by Flicks in the Sticks (1999) and Moviola (2001). Other networks are less than ten years old.

18 This statement is taken from a factsheet published by Community Screen Forum, found at https://www.uea.ac.uk/documents/12814720/0/CSF+Fact+Sheet+2+high+res.pdf/792f3036-57d6-42bc-aad8-02547a22f9d0 (accessed 12 May 2019).

19 See the website at http://picniccinema.co.uk/ for further details of their marketing strategies.

20 For example, the BFI's Britain of Film project can be found at: https://www.bfi.org.uk/britain-on-film (accessed 8 April 2019).

21 Further details of the Britain of Film project can be found at: https://www.bfi.org.uk/britain-on-film (accessed 8 April 2019).

22 Data taken from 'Report and Audience Evaluation for UK Wide Archive Screening Events May–October 2017'.

23 Details can be found at https://www.filmhubscotland.com/projects/archive/britain-on-film/ (accessed 23 January 2020).

24 Information taken from Eden Arts website, found at: https://www.edenarts.co.uk/blog/the-picnic-cinema- experience (accessed 13 May 2019).

25 Interview taken from Eden Arts website, found at: https://www.edenarts.co.uk/blog/the-picnic-cinema- experience (accessed 13 May 2019).

5

Cinephile activism and rituals of resistance

Introduction

This chapter investigates the recent development of experiential and expanded cinema events organized by activist exhibitors in the UK and Thailand. While recent research on participatory media and political activism has frequently focused on the digital sphere (Jansson 2017; Jenkins et al. 2016; Milner 2018), other scholarly perspectives have examined how digital culture intersects with real-world communities and social movements (Wessels 2018), or have queried the role of digital media in the distribution of alternative, counter-hegemonic content altogether (Cammaerts 2016: 1–2). This chapter focuses on the intersection of participatory forms of cinephilia with political activism, investigating how exhibition sites screening alternative and specialist films are increasingly attracting activist exhibitors and audiences in relation to two case studies: the Scalarama film festival held every September in the UK and the cinephile culture associated with Scala cinema in Bangkok.

Founded in 2011 as a tribute to the Scala Cinema (London's infamous cult film venue), Scalarama is a month-long programme of alternative film at a hundred cinemas and venues across the UK. It aims to celebrate the communal aspect of film-going by creating 'fervent experiences' for its participants (Scalarama 2018).[1] Scalarama thus fuses together the legacy of the cult film circuit's valorization of quirky and obscure cinema with the millennial generation's enthusiasm for unique, participatory experiences. Existing scholarship on cult cinema has interrogated the multiple ways that technological developments over the last two decades have facilitated a significant shift within this cultural sphere (Sexton and Hills 2015; Hills 2015). This shift has, on the one hand, augmented the collectability of cult films and associated paratexts, and produced a vibrant culture of domesticated cult fandom (Geraghty 2014; Walker 2014; Egan 2015; Wroot and Willis 2017). However, this chapter argues that it has simultaneously

given rise to a renewed focus on, and commitment to, the social, communal and participatory characteristics of alternative film cultures. By mapping out the characteristics of Scalarama as a descendant of the cult film exhibition sector, in which it is often the quest for a collaborative, non-commercial experience that demarcates it as distinctive from the mainstream cinema-going experience, I contend that an anti-neoliberal sentiment characterized by inclusivity, diversity and low-budget DIY economics has reconfigured alternative film culture for the millennial generation.

While there is a well-established tradition of participatory and experiential forms of film exhibition and reception in the global north, it is less well established in the global south. However, the historic Scala cinema in Bangkok has offered one exception to this trend, providing a popular focal point for cinephiles and cult film connoisseurs. Although the two case studies illustrate very different economic and material models of film exhibition, both Scalarama in the UK and Scala cinema in Bangkok share significant commonalities: both attract cinephile patrons and political activists (though this manifests in dissimilar ways due to differences in the political climate and culture), and both are committed to programming alternative cinema and live events designed to facilitate participatory audience behaviour. Through an analysis of the primary and secondary data gathered on these two organizations, this chapter argues that cinephile cultures and specialized, participatory forms of film exhibition can facilitate a lively, dissident space where contemporary forms of political engagement thrive and activist cinema is sustained and promoted, thus constituting an alternative experience economy.

The empirical data analysed in this chapter is drawn from a number of sources. First, through a set of twelve interviews conducted with organizers and patrons of the two case studies, Scalarama and Scala, Bangkok, including the co-founder of Scalarama, Michael Pierce. Second, through analysing a set of eighteen interviews with exhibitors who organized events for Scalarama 2018.[2] And finally, through the use of two industry reports on the independent film exhibition sector in the UK. The discursive analysis of these primary and secondary sources offers insights into this emergent aspect of the exhibition sector from the perspective of both the industry and the audience; this, in turn, enables an examination of how the distinction between these two groups becomes blurred within the context of the alternative experience economy. The data analysis is framed by approaches drawn from the fields of sociology and cultural studies and reconsiders the relevance of countercultural and subcultural

theories in understanding this emergent aspect of the non-theatrical exhibition sector.

Revisiting the midnight movie phenomenon: Subculture or counterculture?

Film curator Michael Pierce (along with co-founder Phil Wood) initially conceived the seven-week 'Scala Forever' season of film screenings in 2011 as a tribute to the Scala cinema (London) and were inspired by the programming, atmosphere and ethos of the former cinema. Aware of the historical significance of the midnight movie format, and the role these screenings had played in establishing the cult reputation of films such as *Night of the Living Dead* (George A. Romero 1968), *Pink Flamingos* (John Waters 1972) and *Eraserhead* (David Lynch 1977), Pierce had already recreated a similar experience at the Curzon Soho in London. Live audience interaction and participatory practices are well-established characteristics of cult film reception, from the stylized rituals of *Rocky Horror* screenings (Austin 1981; Middlemost 2014: 38–64; Wood 1991) to the sensory novelty of Odorama scratch 'n' sniff cards distributed at the viewings of cult favourite *Polyester* (John Waters 1981) and the ironic comedic pleasures of *The Room* (Tommy Wiseau 2009). Communal activities such as dressing up, reciting dialogue and engaging in rehearsed responses have, historically, provided cult film audiences with an intensely social, intimate and embodied form of engagement with film texts. Scholarship exploring audience behaviours associated with cult cinema has established that participatory acts of resistance to supposedly anodyne, mainstream cinema-going practices have characterized cult film audiences for almost fifty years.

Cult film scholarship over the last two decades has tended to analyse audience behaviour within the theoretical framework of Pierre Bourdieu's influential study on taste cultures, *Distinction: A Social Critique of the Judgement of Taste* (1979), and subsequent scholarship extending this thesis (Sconce 1995; Thornton 1995). This approach frequently focuses on hierarchies of membership within these subcultures, which are often derived from a sense of exclusivity. While this was certainly the case with the New York midnight movie scene of the late 1960s and 1970s, and also with London's Scala Cinema in the 1970s and 1980s, the ethos of the Scalarama festival discussed throughout this chapter is, conversely, one of inclusivity and accessibility. As a preface to discussing Scalarama's 'cinema

for all' communal sentiment, this chapter will briefly revisit scholarship on subcultures and countercultures as a way of framing its ideological position as both a movement and festival.

The midnight movie phenomenon epitomizes many of the characteristics of cult cinema as it emerged in the late 1960s, in terms of its alternative exhibition practices, eclectic programming and unusual audience behaviour. An important feature of the subcultural exclusivity attributed to cult film audiences relates to notions of 'liveness', 'being there' and what are more frequently associated with theatrical modes of spectatorship. Carter Moulton speculates that for cult fans attending a midnight movie, the

> construction of subcultural togetherness begins merely by showing up at the 'once-in-a-lifetime' event . . . which denotes a level of commitment; it may indeed involve the hour of midnight (a commitment to stay awake), the price (a commitment to pay), the duration (a commitment to endure), the logistics (a commitment to research and plan ahead) or the location (a commitment to travel. (Moulton 2020: 210)

In addition to the emotional and economic investments required to attend midnight screenings, there are other characteristics that they share with the 'liveness' of theatre performance. In his study of cult audience behaviour at screenings of *The Rocky Horror Picture Show* (Jim Sharman 1975), Robin Wood frames his analysis of ritualized participatory performances with a discussion of how the film had assimilated theatrical characteristics of the play it was adapted from. In this way, Wood argues that *Rocky Horror* violated a 'long-standing convention for film narrative to efface all trace of the spectator's presence' (Wood 1991: 162). In these respects, midnight screenings of *Rocky Horror* share many of the characteristics of contemporary immersive theatre in that they intentionally break the 'fourth wall'.

The distinction between subcultures and countercultures is most frequently explained in relation to class (Clarke et al. 1975/2003: 60). However, one factor complicating this distinction is their diachronic trajectory and, quite frequently, the way in which characteristics of these cultures become co-opted into the dominant or mainstream culture over time. It is for this reason that countercultures and subcultures are both frequently understood to be generational. Clarke et al.'s definition of a counterculture as being one characterized by a tendency to explore 'alternative institutions' to the dominant culture is pertinent in relation to alternative non-profit model of cinema exhibition illustrated by Scalarama.

The exclusivity associated with the midnight movie circuit is not limited to specific New York venues of a particular era. Very often, this 'members-only' ambiance has been associated with the physical exhibition spaces of the alternative exhibition sector, such as American grindhouse venues offering midnight screenings of cult movies, and the rep circuit in the UK. These venues were often characterized by a clandestine atmosphere, as film-maker John Waters recalls in relation to the Scala cinema, located in the downmarket location of King's Cross, London, that 'it was like joining a club, a very secret club, like a biker gang or something. I remember the audience was even more berserk than any midnight show I had ever seen in America.'[3] In characterizing the raucous, performative behaviour of audiences at the Scala as 'a very secret club', Waters pinpoints one of the defining characteristics of cult cinema-goers at the venue. The intimate, communal bond between them, restricted to a finite number of cinephiles with access to the geographical location, made this an exclusionary, secret subculture. Similarly, cultural commentator Mark Pilkington recalls that 'the Scala is remembered for its often carnivalesque atmosphere . . . the Scala was an attitude: it was DIY and glamour, rock 'n' roll and post-punk, hippy, beatnik and biker, transgressive, decadent and *décharné*. It was serious and fun' (Pilkington 2011: n.p.). Scala cinema founder Stephen Woolley argues that 'those guilty pleasures have become mainstream entertainment' (Woolley 2018: n.p.). Indeed, Matt Hills identifies a distinctive 'mainstreaming discourse' evident in a range of scholarly work on cult cinema which focuses on a perceived erosion of subcultural capital via the digitization of rare forms of media:

> Instantaneous, 'easy', and accessible to all: these are the clarion calls of what I am identifying here as scholar-fans' mainstreaming discourse, where technological developments are presumed to dilute cult's subcultural capital. (Hills 2014: 104)

Thus, although the programming of the Scala Cinema, London, provided the inspiration for Scalarama, in certain respects it can be understood almost as its antithesis; while the Scala was an exclusive, members-only-styled club, Scalarama is characterized by an inclusive, 'broad church' ideology.

Scalarama and a new counterculture?

The parallels between the countercultural movement of the late 1960s and the 2018 season of Scalarama were intentional, in that the festival was celebrating the

fiftieth anniversary of the social protests of 1968 in the global north. Several other arts-orientated initiatives also marked this anniversary in the UK: the BFI Film Audience Network ran a season of films titled 'The Uprising: Spirit '68', which was augmented by a fund that regional film exhibitors could apply for in order to get involved in celebrating the cinematic legacy of the period. The website encouraged film-makers and exhibitors to draw the connections between the 1960s counterculture and contemporary resistance movements, stating that

> the late 60s saw the birth of 'identity politics' as we now know them, with civil rights and Vietnam protests in turn helping to pave the way for Black Power, radical feminism and the gay liberation movement. These strands carry powerful resonances with today, while there are striking similarities and contrasts to be found in the debates over race and immigration (from Powell to Brexit) and social housing (from Ronan Point to Grenfell).[4]

A similar initiative run on a smaller scale throughout the summer of 2018 was 'Revolt, She Said', a touring film programme supported by the Independent Film Office and curated by the queer feminist film collective Club des Femmes.[5] Inspired by a number of anniversaries (100 years since the Suffragettes' campaign for the (partial) women's vote), 'Revolt, She Said' celebrated intersectional, queer and feminist cinema inspired by the 1968 counterculture with the explicit aim to counter the mainstream masculinist narrative of 1968. These overlapping film initiatives, which took place across the summer of 2018 in the UK, provide a discursive context for the Scalarama season in September of that year. A set of twenty interviews conducted with exhibitors involved in the 2018 season of Scalarama, and the qualitative data these interviews offer, create a snapshot and starting point for interrogating the extent to which Scalarama has reinvented alternative film culture for the millennial generation. In particular, they offer insights into the extent to which the festival has evolved into an anti-neoliberal culture characterized by inclusivity, political activism, diversity and low-budget DIY economics. Each of the distributors interviewed were asked the same six questions. The third of these questions was 'tell us what Scalarama means to you' and the responses reveal a number of significant patterns about the festival participants.

First, the majority of exhibitors explained what Scalarama meant to them in terms of community, inclusivity and diversity.[6] On the one hand this referred to the larger film community taking part in the festival across the UK. For example, Cinetopia, an exhibitor based in Edinburgh, responded that 'It's nice to feel part of the larger UK-based film community in celebrating DIY screenings across

the country!' However, the notion of community was also discussed in their context of their local cinema-going community. Another Scottish exhibitor, ISO Design, explained this at some length:

> There's such a community feel to the whole thing. It's inclusive and supportive and really enthusiastic about all the events taking place. There are no limits to what can be screened which makes it such an exciting festival to be part of, it feels quite rebellious in a way. It's so important to have diverse programming which reflects a wide variety of identities and perspectives, and Scalarama does just that. (Ciara Dunne, ISO Design)

The pronounced emphasis on community and inclusivity articulated by the exhibitors establishes a marked departure from the exclusive club culture that characterized the Scala and other venues on the cult cinema circuit. However, the focus is more than simply an attempt to bring people within one locale together for a night out. The organizational structure of the festival is also inherently collaborative and power-sharing rather than hierarchical. Exhibitors choose their own films, and in this respect, it is markedly different from the BFI programme and funding scheme. While the website offers comprehensive guidance on setting up a screening, from funding to programming to marketing, the exhibitors remain independent of the festival and are unified simply by the shared programme.

Scalarama founder Pierce explains the vision he has for the festival as follows: 'we think Scalarama should be crowdsourced in the end because, ultimately, we need to liberate it so that everyone can do it.'[7] Several of the exhibitors style themselves as collectives, and the emphasis on collaboration across the whole organization means that it has more in common with arts collectives of the late 1960s and early 1970s than it does with other commercial film festivals.

A second pronounced pattern within the interview data is an emphasis on feminist and queer activism among the exhibitors. Over 50 per cent of those interviewed were women, and the Scalarama's ongoing collaboration with its sister organization, Directed by Women, reinforces the umbrella organization's commitment to promoting a feminist agenda. Edinburgh-based exhibitors *Reel Girl Film Club* explain their feminist agenda for organizing the screening as being twofold, in that they 'want to screen films by women film-makers to a wide audience, to celebrate the achievements of women who are working in what is a male-dominated industry. And secondly, to show realistic and diverse representations of women on screen and to explore their different stories and perspectives' (Sarah Nisbet, Reel Girl Film Club). This twofold objective is

echoed by other female distributors. Others also articulate the desire to create a safe communal space, such as *She's En Scene*, who explain that 'our mission is to create spaces where women can watch, discuss, debate and create films in empowering environments'. Similar sentiments are echoed by LGBTQ+ exhibitors, such as *Liverpool Pride* who actively campaign against homophobia and transphobia. Pierce contends that inclusion and promotion of female exhibitors within the festival is key to its success, and that the regional groups that have been most successful have had an even gender balance among the organizers: 'It's interesting, I haven't done any in-depth analysis of this, but I think the Scalaramas that have an even gender split between exhibitors have somehow got that glue and have carried on.'[8]

In these ways, the interviews conducted with the twenty exhibitors reveal two significant patterns: first, a marked shift away from text-centric forms of cult and community cinema to a communally structured organization that sets out to support (rather than compete with) each other; and second, a politically aware agenda focused on promoting the rights of minority groups. These characteristics illustrate Nico Carpentier's analysis of collaborative organizations and social movements that employ a range of media to advocate their end goals. Scalarama has received funding from the BFI and therefore exemplifies the economic model Carpentier describes in that they facilitate local community exhibitors and thus act as a link between state and market (Carpentier 2016: 5). In this respect, this chapter argues that they function as an alternative experience economy, employing a non-profit model to leverage state funding as a means to support a range of community exhibitors, including those with an activist agenda.

Playwright David Edgar contends that the recent insurgence of political activism among students and young people in the UK owes much to the uprisings of 1968 and their legacy, arguing that

> what happened last summer [2017] was not about a year in politics; it was about a decade in which the 1960s compound of social emancipation and anti-capitalism had been renewed. Jeremy Corbyn's 600,000-strong model army clearly owes much of its size and strength (and social media nous) to the activist movements which emerged in 2011: the Day X protestors against the student fee hike; the schoolkids protesting the abolition of the Education Maintenance Allowance; Occupy and UK Uncut. (Edgar 2018: 141)

Edgar identifies three characteristics that demonstrate this renewed activism and countercultural potential in the UK. First, that they are all youth movements.

The 2017 election saw a 20 per cent increase in young voters (Ipsos Mori). Second, in style and substance, movements such as #Me Too and #Black Lives Matter echo the form and content of the late 1960s and revisit their feminist and civil rights agendas with a renewed vigour. Third, in that the protestors of the 1960s and the 2010s were both opposed by the state.

There is a long tradition of writers and thinkers on the left who have argued that radical politics can be invigorated and energized by forms of cultural collectivism, such as festivals and raves. Such cultural forms, Jeremy Gilbert argues, can promote a 'collective joy' that is effective in 'overcoming the alienating individualism of capitalist culture'.[9] This ethos informs the politics, arts and music festival *The World Transformed*, which has run in tandem with the annual Labour Party Conference since 2016 and is part of what Gilbert describes as 'acid Corbynism', a movement with 'a radical democratic agenda promoting a vision of a twenty-first century socialism based on principles of co-operation, collaboration and experimentation. A key feature of the counterculture, psychedelic culture and the New Left . . . was always the attempt to find new forms of non-hierarchical, experimental, creative collectivity' (Gilbert 2017). The evolution of new forms of creative collectivity, alongside a celebration of countercultural experimentation of the 1960s, formed a significantly broader context and backdrop for the 2018 Scalarama season.

The Scala cinema (London) and Scalarama: De-privileging the cult text?

The midnight movie circuit offered one way of rejecting straight culture, through a collective dismissal of accepted taste cultures and a valorization of 'bad objects'. When J. P. Telotte mapped out the cult film experience in 1991, he argued that the 'privileged texts' beloved by cult film audiences were comparable with the sacred texts of religious cults (Telotte 1991: 1). Mathijs and Sexton argue that a textual approach is only one of four ways that cult cinema can be understood, noting that cult film studies tend to 'concentrate on specialized subgenres and formats (such as the giallo, anime, martial arts, vampire movies, sleaze movies)'. Key to their definition of cult cinema, though, are films 'that are situated at the margin of the mainstream' (Mathijs and Sexton 2011: 8). Defining films in relation to 'the mainstream' is always problematic, given the continuously shifting nature of the concept. However, the significance of the oppositional

character of cult cinema texts (in relation to the mainstream) is now considered through the lens of Scalarama. In particular, this section maps the fading import of the marginality of the individual cult text in relation to the increasing value of the agenda, or manifesto, informing the Scalarama programme.

The first Scalarama season, 'Scala Forever', launched in 2011 with over sixty-five screenings at thirty-two different venues across London. The flyer for the event was designed by Mike Leedham, who had created the original Scala publicity. One of the Scala cinema's signature films, the pornographic black comedy *Thundercrack!* (Curt McDowell 1975), featured in the 'Scala Forever' season and was screened at the Horse Hospital in Bloomsbury. Pierce describes the experience of organizing the first season as 'a real history project, we made a commemorative book and we interviewed people, and it was just really nice because we had its blessing'.[10] The legacy of the mid-twentieth-century midnight movie tradition, including its eclectic programming, thus strongly informed Pierce's early vision for Scalarama and the relationship between the Scala cinema and Scalarama was foundational. In terms of its geographical location 'Scala Forever' was also informed by its namesake, in that it was an exclusively London-centric phenomenon, financially supported by Film London. Pierce explains that 'I wouldn't say it's the child of the Scala, I think there's a little bit of a generational difference, so I don't know if it's the nephew or the niece, or adopted child, I don't know what it is, but it is related'.[11] In many respects, then, the Scalarama festival originated as an homage to the Scala cinema. Indeed, this relationship with the Scala cinema continues, with a fortieth anniversary celebration and book launch for Jane Giles's *Scala Cinema 1978-1993* being one of the more heavily publicized events in the 2018 Scalarama calendar.

In 2012, Scalarama expanded beyond London to include collaborative exhibition partners in Manchester, Brighton, Newcastle, Edinburgh and Birmingham with a season aptly named 'Beyond Scala'. It was at this point that the organization began to evolve into a more distinctive event characterized by the impetus to celebrate the community film sector across the UK. 'Scala Beyond' was launched with a manifesto, which was republished annually for the following two years:

1. Fill the land with cinemas.
   Cinemas can be bars, cafes, libraries or schools. They can be under motorways, on boats, in petrol stations, or on the move. If you can't find your cinema, start it.

2. Ask yourself why do we want to share?
   Show it. This is our strength.
3. Cinema is not just the film.
   Everything around it matters. Create an experience.
4. Judge for yourself.
   Good and bad are redundant. High art, low trash, critic's choice, family favourite. All films are valid if you believe in them.
5. Your audience are your guests.
   Find your audience and engage them.
6. Respect the double bill.
   And honour the All Nighter.

(Scalarama manifesto 2012–14)

The introduction of the manifesto in 2012 signalled the organization's evolution into something more significant than merely a tribute season of screenings: it was developing the characteristics of a movement, and adistinguishing feature of this movement was inclusivity. In expanding the scope of the festival nationwide and creating a shared programme, 'Scala Beyond' was exhibiting the characteristics of a cultural movement. The emphasis on exhibition and audiences makes the 'Scala Beyond' manifesto unusual in relation to other film manifestos, which are more commonly focused on issues of form.

Despite this development, the 2012 programme still pays homage to many films associated with the cult circuit, and this continued with the launch of Scalarama in 2013. In 2014 Scalarama hosted a number of scratch 'n' sniff 'Odorama' events in conjunction with screenings of John Waters' *Polyester*. This was favourably received by the critics, who applauded Scalarama's 'sense of community and fealty'.[12] Screenings of films such as *Polyester* that are strongly associated with cult cinema are also popular with audiences who want to revisit memories of their own past and capture a retro-cult nostalgia. Sarah Atkinson and Helen Kennedy discuss the re-release of *Polyester* in this context, suggesting that it plays on the film's original release and experimentation with innovative technologies of the 1980s:

> The 2014 redistribution of *Polyester* and the recreation of Odorama represent both a celebratory engagement (to mark its thirtieth anniversary) and a nostalgic moment of a failed and thus amusing cinematic innovation, which is imbued both in the diegesis of the filmic text and in its collective mode of reception. Its status as a 'cult film' object is also reaffirmed through its repackaging and

> reconsumption by a contemporary cult-cine-literate audience on a 'so bad, it's good' premise. (Atkinson and Kennedy 2018: 12)

Evidence of *Polyester*'s 'cult object' status is established by online discussions of the film, such as a comment thread beneath an article about Odorama and the 2014 re-release of the film.[13] Contributors trade comments and memories which reveal an aura of exclusivity associated with being at original screenings of the film. Claims made include ones such as 'I was at the world premiere at the Charles Theater in May 1981 when Waters and Divine arrived in a horse-drawn carriage which pulled up to the entrance to the flash of cameras like a 30s Hollywood opening'.[14] These displays of subcultural capital demonstrate the ongoing interest in cult cinema and its embodied manifestation through such assertions.

In her analysis of the programming of the Glasgow Film Festival, Lesley-Ann Dickson argues that 'festival programmers find themselves responding to shifts in cultural consumption signalled by the experience economy wherein cinemagoers are becoming more inclined to experience film in event contexts and experiment with unorthodox screening environments' (Dickson 2018: 100). However, while the programming of Scala Forever, Scala Beyond and the first two Scalarama seasons in 2013 and 2014 demonstrates many of the characteristics of cult cinema, they also reveal an important shift taking place that distinguishes the festival from the culture of the Scala cinema and similar cult venues. In 2013, the festival was crowdfunded for the first time. In addition to a core programme curated by the festival organizers, there was also an open programme. Pierce and Wood explain in their Kickstarter video that this is 'much like the Edinburgh fringe. Anyone can take part in this regardless of experience, you just need to submit your event via our website. We don't take any cut of your box office, or charge a submission fee. All money goes directly to the organisers.'[15] In this respect, then, the launch of Scalarama in 2013 reveals that a transformation had taken place that had two key features: a cultural manifesto and a pledge to inclusivity. In several respects, then, while the Scalarama film festival has clearly emerged out of the cult cinema circuit, it has also differentiated itself from it in these two key ways.

Ideologies and technologies: A collaborative community

As the festival organizers explain on their website, 'Scalarama is by everyone, for everyone, everywhere, with DIY in its veins. There's no cost to being involved, and we hope you find new activities, venues and friendships wherever you live.'[16]

It is this inclusivity, and the open invitation offered by the organizers to all exhibitors (mainstream and independent) to participate that now characterizes the festival and demarcates one of the key features that differentiate Scalarama from the ethos of its namesake, the Scala. Pierce explains his concept for the festival, saying, 'I want it to be like Christmas for cinemas, in that no one starts Christmas (although everyone tries to start it earlier each year), it just happens, and towns know they're going to spend money on Christmas lights because it's connected to the coming winter.'[17]

The programming for Scalarama is developed by Cinema Nation, a community interest company that negotiates collective deals with distributors and offers ideas and support for the third sector. This aspect of the organization facilitates the distribution and exhibition for some marginal aspects of cinematic heritage that may not be legitimized by the education system or consecrated by the commercial sector. In 2015 the Scalarama programme began to diversify away from more traditional cult film fare and instead started to highlight specific themes, which Pierce explains as responses to 'trends over the last five years'.[18] Scalarama founder Michael Pierce explains that inclusivity and diversity are key features of the festival programming and that this is reflected in the annual calendar of events:

> It's a really useful metaphor, that calendar, to show that we've all got various film tastes, and we can't be pigeon-holed into having only one cinema that we go to, or one experience, or one type of film. You can have a variety, a mixed diet of films, and that's what I want to champion, because it provides a real measurable shift of people becoming cinephiles or getting into film, and it is possible.[19]

Pierce explains that one of the central objectives of Scalarama is to facilitate the broadening of film taste among film-goers and draws a parallel with what Spotify has done for musical taste to illustrate this point. In this respect, then, the festival is significantly different in its conception of the culture of cult cinema in the era of the Scala. These included Project 51, an initiative to discuss representation on screen, which in 2015 focused on female film-makers and characters. This project was curated to tie in with the international movement #DirectedByWomen, which takes place every September. One of the central characteristics of Scalarama, and a principle way in which the festival defines itself as being distinctive from the historical cult film culture analysed by Telotte and others, lies in the way the eclecticism of the programme has evolved in this particular direction.

The exhibition model developed by Scalarama also differs from that of the Scala cinema in other ways. Pierce observes that the exclusivity of the former cult cinema was partly sustained by a markedly competitive programming ethos, and that in this respect Scalarama offers a significantly alternative model. Pierce recalls that 'the Scala was really competitive, they had *Thundercrack!* and they wouldn't let anyone else show it. That was their bread and butter, in a way, and they wouldn't let anyone else have the print. It was limited.' By contrast, Scalarama runs an 'open door' policy, which facilitates independent and community film programmers to put on events and collaborate in putting the festival together. While an anti-commercial sentiment has always characterized this aspect of the cult cinema experience and predates the contemporary vogue for DIY and pop-up cinema, it has clearly become more pronounced within the organization of festivals such as Scalarama.

Technological changes in film distribution and exhibition have impacted on the cult film and festival circuit in a complex set of ways. The competitive business model developed by independent cinemas like the Scala became obsolete with the advent of digital media and the internet, as illustrated by the discussion of *Thundercrack!* Indeed, Stephen Woolley, the former programmer at the Scala cinema, attributes the closure of infamous cult film venue in 1993 to the rise of home media. However, the impact of digital media and the internet has also transformed cult and alternative film distribution in other ways, with the closure of video stores and smaller venues that support independent cinema. It is this shift in the distribution and exhibition sectors that forms one of the significant forces driving recent developments in the community cinema, or non-theatrical, sector. E. W. Nikdel argues that home media detracts from the communal aspect of cult, and this partly explains the development of audience interest in brands such as Secret Cinema (Nikdel 2017: 112). In this respect, new technologies function to transform cult cinema in a different direction to the one identified by Matt Hills (2015). Hills argues that a generational nostalgia for older forms of cult cinema, particularly the exclusivity of the midnight movie exhibition circuit, has facilitated a 'retro' subcultural capital among older cult film enthusiasts. This nostalgic cultism, Hills suggests, perceives the accessibility of digitized cult media, via streaming and the internet, as a factor that diminishes its subcultural capital. Similarly, Scalarama founder Michael Pierce suggests that 'I think it's a response as well, things are being lost with the rise of the internet. Things like local cinemas and video shops, where you had a local culture that was accessible almost on every high street.' However, one of the facilitators of

the new expansive direction taken by the festival is the development of digital technologies, which opens up new possibilities to low-budget, independent exhibitors.

Non-theatrical spaces: A 'cinephilia of sociability'

A final characteristic revealed by the data set is the use and importance of non-theatrical screening spaces. Some exhibitors, such as the *Strangest Things Film Club*, operate out of a living room in a domestic house. Others hire ordinary venues, such as bars, or more unusual spaces, such as Dunvegan Castle. Pop-up culture also forms a significant aspect of the exhibition culture, and some venues are chosen because they are appropriate to the screening, such as the use of the Old Fire Station in Leeds for a screening of the Firefighters Story: 100 Years of the Fires Brigades Union. The eclecticism of the exhibition spaces underscores the DIY culture and shift away from commercial exhibition practices that the festival represents.

However, not all of the exhibitors epitomize this ethos. Some of the films are screened in established art-house cinemas, and one exhibitor boasts that 'we have just opened a £6 million extension with a sexy new café bar'. While the experience economy model, as theorized by Pine and Gilmore, is explicitly neoliberal in character and is often fundamentally at odds with the DIY aesthetic of community and cult cinema, this is not always the case. There are many examples of 'cult' film exhibitors that have monetized the subcultural capital associated with alternative cinema-going cultures, such as Secret Cinema, the Prince Charles cinema and venues like the Square Chapel Arts Centre in Halifax that appeal to an affluent market with a significant disposable income. While such organizations claim to respond to their customers, there is a clearly demarcated economic hierarchy and transaction involved, and in many respects, they embody Pine and Gilmore's argument that co-creation should be controlled. In their reflection on the original 1999 text, Pine and Gilmore respond to the criticism that they fail to acknowledge the role of co-creation in the formation of experiences with the statement that they intentionally focus much more on the 'stager of experiences.' .

The fifteen interviewees who contributed to this research were recruited via social media and had mainly attended events in London, Leeds, Manchester and Glasgow during Scalarama 2018.[20] One discussed her experience of a

Women's Animation event in Leeds as 'amazing, this was a real box of delights. Innovative, funny, we laughed, we cried, we learned . . . it made me feel so alive, that's what I loved about it' (Interviewee #70; A1, Q7). This participant drew on discourses around authenticity linked to her affective response to the event. Another interviewee who attended the same event reflected on why she valued it, observing, 'I'd stopped going to the cinema, to the multiplex, because it was just so sterile and manufactured, and all the films all seemed the same. This was something different, it was new, original, it made me think. That's what I want from cinema now, I'm tired of mindless entertainment, I definitely want a more meaningful experience' (Interviewee #71; A1, Q7). These responses imply a perceived value around the extent to which the event, and in this case, the films, provoked a strong reaction, be it emotional or intellectual. Others also defined their appreciation of the event in relation to mainstream entertainment and Hollywood blockbusters that were variously described as 'mindless' and 'predictable'. In certain respects, then, these audiences for Scalarama events echo the sentiments of cult film audiences established in many other surveys. However, this was also inflected with an appreciation of the event's focus on women animators and what was perceived to be a celebratory feminist agenda. One interviewee said, 'it's important this work gets screened, women filmmakers have been marginalised for too long, and it was good to see them getting the audience they deserve' (Interviewee #70; A2, Q3).

Another concurred, stating that 'I'm mainly here because it was important for me to support the cause' (Interviewee 71; A2, Q7). This implies that alongside an interest in intellectually stimulating non-mainstream films, this group of participants were, to different degrees, politically motivated in their rationale for attending the Scalarama event in Leeds.

In her review of the 2016 season of Scalarama, Maria Velez-Serna concludes that 'while all exhibitors are careful about the technical conditions of their screenings, it is clear that overwhelming cinematic spectacle is not what they are after. This is a cinephilia of sociability rather than form' (Velez-Serna 2016: 143). Velez-Serna's assessment reflects the changing character of Scalarama, as it has increasingly adopted the characteristics of an umbrella organization for a community of smaller exhibitors, including those with an activist inclination. This 'cinephilia of sociability' reinforces the significance of communal, collective action that characterizes both Scalarama and the second case study in this chapter, the Thai cinephile community associated with Scala in Bangkok.

Cinephile activism and experiential film culture in Thailand

The final part of this chapter examines the culture of cinephilia and live performance associated with Scala cinema in Bangkok. The nature of the political landscape in Thailand means that cinephile activism necessarily takes a very different form to the kind observed at film festivals and other cultural events in the global north. Since the military coup in 2014, Thailand has been governed by an increasingly authoritarian regime. While the country has witnessed multiple military coups since 1932, Chris Baker argues that the 2014 coup was different in that the junta did not install a civilian government to appease popular opinion, but instead 'installed themselves at the apex of the political system, and appointed four of their own number as prime minister and other key posts in the cabinet. Although the cabinet included some civilians, this was clearly a military government of a kind not seen in over 40 years' (Baker 2016: 389–90). The threat of punitive action from the military junta, articulated clearly by Apichatpong Weerasethakul in a 2015 interview and discussed later, means that activist behaviour necessarily has to adopt a covert character. Film-makers, performance artists and other members of the arts community therefore express their political views primarily through experimental art forms, and cinema-goers with politically active leanings frequent the standalone film theatres and similar venues where those with dissident views tend to congregate.

A key issue for the film community in this political climate is that of censorship. Thailand's laws regarding film censorship date back to the introduction of the Film Censorship Act of 1930 and are well known for their prohibitive stance (Musikawong 2007: 253). More recently, the Film Censorship Act of 1930 was replaced by the Thai Film and Video Act (2009), which authorized the state to ban the release of films that could 'undermine or disrupt social order and moral decency, or that might impact national security or the pride of the nation'.[21] These stringent censorship laws have accelerated the evolution of Thai piracy culture, which Ramon Lobato argues have in turn functioned to stimulate a 'nascent cinephile film culture in Thailand' (Lobato 2012: 83), thus exemplifying the productive potential of film regulation identified by Annette Kuhn (1984). While opponents to Thailand's political regime are unlikely to voice their views directly, standalone cinemas such as Scala and the Bangkok Art and Film Center offer spaces where cinephile and anti-censorship groups can gather.

One of the most prominent and vocal of these groups is the Free Thai Cinema Movement, which formed in 2007 in response to the censorship of

internationally celebrated Thai film-maker Apichatpong Weerasethakul's *Syndromes and a Century* (2006). The movement forms part of an unofficial network of film-makers and arts organizations opposed to Thailand's censorship laws[22] and who attempted to mobilize against the proposal of new restrictions in the Film and Video Act of 2008.[23] Although unsuccessful in preventing the 2008 Act being passed, the movement gathered momentum again after the Thai government banned the political film *Shakespeare Must Die* (Ing Kanjanavani 2012), on the grounds that its representation of a political student protest might pose a national security threat.

A key member of this movement is Apichatpong Weerasethakul, who has a long-standing struggle with film censorship in his home country. Apichatpong's films explore issues that are 'underrepresented in the Thai official history, such as homosexuality, immigration, military violence and film censorship' (Promkhuntong 2016: 73). He first became entangled with the Thai film censors when two scenes from his second feature film, *Blissfully Yours* (2001), were cut before it received theatrical release in Thailand (Suwanpakdee 2016: 49). Following this, his 2006 film *Syndromes and a Century* was banned when the Thai censors took objection to scenes showing behaviour that was considered inappropriate, such as a monk playing a guitar. In a 2015 interview for *Film Comment*, Apichatpong discussed the situation in Thailand since the 2014 military coup, explaining that 'it feels like living there [in Thailand], it is more and more difficult for me to express things, and to see friends being detained, being put in jail – almost like [I'm] waiting for my turn'.[24] He goes on to describe how artists are blacklisted and jailed until they sign an agreement that they will not engage in political activity, 'otherwise, you will be prosecuted and your financial assets will be frozen. Two performance artists were put in jail for a year, two years, and they're still there now. You don't know much about this outside Thailand.'[25] It is for these reasons, Apichatpong explains, that he decided it was necessary to change the title of *Cemetery of Splendour* (2015), which was originally entitled *King of Splendour*.

The emergence of a prohibitive state censorship regime in Thailand has resulted in the expression of political dissent taking an increasingly experimental cinematic form. Loredana Paracciani has observed the growing significance in standalone cinemas and art-house venues for screening festivals and films that offer an alternative to the mainstream:

> The lack of spaces for consuming a variety of screen culture is in fact one of the key issues. . . . the Thai Short Film and Video Festival, for instance, initiated in

> 1997 by the Thai Film Foundation, is one of the playgrounds for independent filmmakers to show their works, including short experimental or documentary films, touching upon a variety of social issues, and subjects such as cultural minorities and marginal groups.[26]

Venues such as Scala and the Bangkok Art and Film Center therefore became central to the continuation of Thailand's alternative film scene and its potential to provide artistic space for those with minority views or from marginalized cultures.

In 2008, a collective of film-makers including Apichatpong, Tsai Ming-liang and Wang Bing curated an interactive video installation, *Black Air*, as part of the 'New Dragons Inn' section of the 'Exploding Cinema' programme at the Rotterdam Film Festival. Promkhunthong observes how the collective's use of censored footage provokes questions around film-making, authorship and censorship:

> The design and content of *Black Air* allows the collaborators and audiences to assert their political views towards a specific local event. The work features clandestine footage of 'the Thai army killing demonstrators' from the 'Takbai incident' in the South of Thailand in 2004. By presenting 'censored' images, the collaborators argue against the violence upon Muslim ethnic minorities in Thailand and military censorship. (Promkhunthong 2016: 111)

The exhibition of *Black Air* at the 2008 Rotterdam Film Festival underscores the precarious position Apichatpong and other Thai film-makers occupy within their home country. Ingawanij and MacDonald observe that in the early stages of Apichatpong's career, he struggled to establish himself in Thailand and was frequently better received at international festivals than he was at home. In Thailand, however, they note that 'he was known as a talented filmmaker by a small cineaste circle in Bangkok, clustered around the short film festivals and the national film archive' (Ingawanij and MacDonald 2010: 126). In the early years of the twenty-first century, then, political activism in Thai film culture circulated in the form of experimental and alternative films exhibited at festivals, both internationally and at home in Bangkok's standalone cinemas. Central to this form of political activism was a cinephile culture, and it is to the activities facilitated by this group of Thai cinephiles that this chapter now turns.

Live at the Scala in Bangkok

This chapter now considers Thai cinephile culture and the role it plays facilitating experiential and alternative film culture. This experiential culture is frequently

associated with Scala, a standalone film theatre in Bangkok which opened its doors in 1969 and announced its closure in June 2020.[27] Named after Milan's Teatro alla Scala, Scala is an independent, thousand-seater cinema located at Siam Square in the city centre and is designed by Thai architect Jira Silpakano, who created 'a uniquely Thai composite of tropical art deco and 1960s Thai modern' (Jablon 2019: 100).[28] While live performance is not a regular feature at Thai cinemas, Scala has provided an exception to this rule and has regularly attracted a cinephile audience through its alternative screening programme and special events such as Live at the Scala (2013) and the recurring Silent Film Festival, organized by the Thai Film Archive. The diverse programming and cinephile culture associated with Scala and other independent cinemas in Bangkok formed part of a nascent cinephile culture in Thailand, which partly arose in relation to a number of specific institutions screening 'alternative movies' (Boonsri 2019: 145).

The early cinephile scene in Thailand can be traced back to the 1970s, when institutions such as the British Council, the Goethe-Institut, the Japan Foundation and the Alliance Francais provided sites for cinephiles to gather and watch alternative screen film programmes (Boonsri 2019: 146). These developments led to a group of Thai cinephiles collaborating in the development of the Thai Film Archive (TFA), established in 1984 to promote and preserve cinema for the Thai public.[29] The TFA has since played a significant role in fostering cinephile culture in Thailand by hosting annual festivals such as the Silent Film Festival hosted by Scala, a regular event which includes live music and performance. Boonsri identifies two generations of Thai cinephiles: the first generation, already discussed, whose interests were facilitated by specific institutions, and the second generation who exchanged knowledge and information online, through message boards, blogs and later on Facebook. The availability of video recording devices meant that the second generation also began to produce commentaries, promote festivals online and later organize screenings (Boonsri 2018: 155). The curatorial labour undertaken by this second generation of cinephiles invites parallels with the cinephiles involved in Scalarama and similar film collectives in the global north.

Like other independent cinemas and art venues in Bangkok, Scala has also functioned as a focal point for alternative culture and political activity, though this manifested in a very different manner to the kinds of political activism that are common to the global north and exemplified by the exhibitors associated with Scalarama. Before the announcement of the cinema's closure in the summer

of 2020, Scala was the city's last remaining single-screen movie theatre, and as such, offered an eclectic programme of films and live events not found at other theatrical venues in Bangkok.[30] Programmes included vintage, retro and art-house films, and the cinema was frequently home to boutique festivals and one-off specialist screenings. In 2019, for example, the Scala hosted the annual Silent Film Festival organized by the TFA, offering screenings of rare silent films, such as *Fight for the Matterhorn* (Germany, 1928), *Filibus* (Italy, 1915) and *Shiraz: A Romance of India* (UK/Germany/India, 1928). The festival incorporated elements of live performance, such as a set played by Korphai Band, a Thai band that play both Thai and Western instruments, whose music accompanied the screening of *Fight for the Matterhorn*. One attendee of events at the Scala explained, 'if you don't want to just watch blockbusters and mainstream releases, the Scala shows some alternative and rare films. It's not just the films doing well on the international festival circuits, there's a really quirky mix of old and new, b-movies, stuff you can't watch anywhere else in Bangkok' (Interviewee #72; A2, Q5). In this way, the Scala's eclectic mix of classic and contemporary films is comparable to the programming ethos of Scalarama.

In addition to offering a programme of independent and historical films not found in mainstream Thai cinemas, the Scala also had a reputation for holding live events. One notable example of an event drawing together cinema and live performance and installation was the 2013 micro-festival *Live at the Scala,* which was *s*ponsored by the British Council Thailand and Forest Fringe, a non-profit art collective.[31] *Live at the Scala* promoted itself as a 'ground-breaking event' that included live performances, interactive art video installations and enactments of scenes from films that were all 'connected by the theme of "cinema"'.[32] Performances were provided by a roster of Thai and British stand-up and performance artists, including B-floor, Messy Project Space, Brian Lobel, Dickie Beau, Dujdao Valhanapakorn Booonyai, Gob Squad, Messy Sky Magazine, Nana Dakin, Richard DeDomenici and Tim Etchells. These acts, described as 'daring and unconventional' in one review, included a durational dancing marathon by Brian Lobel, who 'set up shop in the theatre's ground-floor lobby and staged a three-hour performance of dances from famous movies' (Kwai 2013). Other performances included Bangkok-based artists Messy Floor Space, who showcased 'rare documents, books and an in-house library to stimulate collaboration, intervention and artistic exchange'.[33]

Unlike many of the makeshift venues used for staging experiential film events in the UK, *Live at the Scala* aimed to utilize and showcase the unique

space of the historical building, 'chiefly the spacious lobby, with its art-deco frieze, sweeping stairway and chandelier'.[34] In this respect, the event had more in common with the specialist screenings staged at stately homes, castles and similar upmarket venues discussed in Chapter 4. Audience interaction with the live performers was a central feature of Live at the Scala. One interviewee who attended described a highlight as 'getting involved in a re-enactment of a Western, I had to pretend to shoot someone and they got covered in ketchup. An excellent night out!' (Interviewee #72; A2, Q7). Another reported, 'dancing along with some of the performance acts, the setting really made it because of Scala's beautiful architecture and the big staircase. By the end of the evening I felt a strong connection with the rest of the audience, it wasn't like a regular night out at the cinema, something completely different and quite magical' (Interviewee #73; A2, Q7). Comments such as these made about Live at the Scala suggest that the social interaction and sense of community fostered by the event was one of its key attractions for audience members. This is further reflected in the British Council's report on the event, which highlights the experiential qualities of the performances and notes that they 'extended beyond traditional theatrical performance, the audiences were given an opportunity not simply to see a range of works but to explore the building, and enjoy a fascinating and subversive celebration of cinema, live performance and the Scala itself'.[35] Liveness was also a theme explored by some of the performance artists and in this respect the event shared many of the experiential qualities of the immersive culture discussed in Chapters 1 and 4, such as simultaneity and interactivity.

The local reception of *Live at the Scala* focused on the re-enactment of *Bangkok Traffic Love Story* (2009) by Richard DeDomenici, the 'world's most unconvincing ladyboy' and the event finale featuring queer performance artist Dickie Beau, 'who with clown white pantomime face make-up, tight black outfit and long hair . . . lip-synced a telephone conversation by a horny housewife to her husband. It was likely the most explicit language uttered in the auditorium of the Scala.'[36] These accounts establish the parallels between the exhibition culture at Scala in Bangkok and the experiential culture of Scalarama, where LGBTQ+ exhibitors such as Liverpool Pride stage events that actively campaign against homophobia and transphobia. The event further contributed to Scala's growing relationship with the LGBTQ scene in Thailand, which dates back to the release of the LGBTQ coming-of-age film *Love of Siam* (2007), which was partly shot at Scala and had a wide regional impact. Following the success of *Live at the Scala*,

Richard DeDominici made a second re-enactment of *Love of Siam,* which was shot at Scala and prominently features the cinema interior, thus cementing the cultural status of Scala within the LGBTQ community.[37] Although necessarily covert in nature, the cinephile activist scene associated with Scala thus mirrors the culture of Scalarama in both its curation of alternative cinematic events that include live performance and in its support and promotion of the LGBTQ community.

Conclusions

The two alternative film exhibition cultures discussed in this chapter offer a number of insights into the development of cinephile activist exhibition cultures within two very different political contexts. Despite many of the distinctions between these two cultures, such as their relationship to designated cinema buildings and their potential to explicitly articulate a political manifesto, there are also some striking commonalities. Both the Scalarama festival in the UK and the culture surrounding Scala cinema in Bangkok indicate a growing political and subversive character within their cinephile audiences. These cinephiles value collaboration, collective action and inclusivity. While still broadly cinephile in outlook, the emphasis of Scalarama has shifted away from an interest in exploitation film culture and towards the support of activist exhibitors such as *Reel Girl Film Club*, *She's En Scene* and *Liverpool Pride*. Exhibitors such as *Liverpool Pride,* for example, actively campaign against homophobia and transphobia. In summary, over 50 per cent of those interviewed for the 2018 season were women, and Scalarama's ongoing collaboration with its sister organization, *Directed by Women*, reinforces the umbrella organization's commitment to promote a feminist agenda.

The parallel exhibition culture located at the Scala cinema in Bangkok also hosts participatory, cinephile events, and, like many independent art-house exhibitors in Thailand, has an agenda in aiming to circumnavigate and oppose state censorship of cinema. The *Live at the Scala* event in 2013 illustrates a progressive, inclusive culture celebrating LGBTQ rights. Both case studies also exemplify collaborative and curatorial cultures that enhance collective agency among younger film audiences and promote social responsibility alongside live, interactive cinematic experiences. These collaborative initiatives contrast with the 'lone wolf' entrepreneurial business models characteristic of the mainstream

experience economy, discussed in Chapter 1. In these respects, I argue that these contemporary cultures of cinephile exhibition in the UK and Thailand facilitate a subversive space where diverse forms of political engagement are endorsed, and activist cinema of varying kinds is supported by a like-minded community, thus constituting an alternative experience economy.

Notes

1 Reference taken from https://scalarama.com/about/ (accessed 16 September 2018).
2 Reference taken from https://scalarama.com/?s=meet+the+exhibitors (accessed 16 September 2018).
3 Interview with John Waters published in *The Guardian*, 31 July 2011. Found at: https://www.theguardian.com/film/2011/jul/31/scala-cinema-london (accessed 16 September 2018).
4 See BFI Audience Network brief found at: http://spiritof68.org.uk/
5 'Revolt, She Said' also received financial support from the BFI Spirit of '68 fund.
6 Eighty per cent of the exhibitors who were interviewed framed their answer to this question in terms of 'community' and 'bringing people together'.
7 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
8 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
9 Jeremy Gilbert, 'Psychedelic Socialism' in *Open Democracy*, 22 September 2017. Found at: https://www.opendemocracy.net/jeremy-gilbert/psychedelic-socialism (accessed 18 September 2018).
10 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
11 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
12 Phil Hoad in *the Guardian*, 2 September 2014: https://www.theguardian.com/film/filmblog/2014/sep/02/scalarama-film-festival-scratch-n-sniff-seats
13 Comment thread on the *Dangerous Minds* website, found at: https://dangerousminds.net/comments/the_nose_knows_john_waters_brilliant_odorama_gimmick_in_polyester
14 Ibid.
15 Taken from Kickstarter video found at: https://www.kickstarter.com/projects/729405182/scalarama-2013
16 Taken from the Scalarama website (2018). Found at: https://scalarama.com/about/

17 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
18 Interview with Michael Pierce by Duncan Carson on 14 July 2015. Found at: https://www.independentcinemaoffice.org.uk/filling-the-nation-with-cinemas-with-scalarama/
19 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
20 The sample was composed of seven females and eight males; two generation Y, eight millennials and five gen X participants. Twelve were university educated, and three finished their education at eighteen.
21 See Kong Rithdee, 'Thailand Passes Controversial Film Act', found at: https://variety.com/2007/film/news/thailand-passes-controversial-film-act-1117978081/ (accessed 15 August 2019).
22 https://www.smh.com.au/entertainment/movies/critical-of-thailands-censorship-visionary-filmmaker-apichatpong-weerasethakul-is-looking-to-latin-america-20160321-gnmzhs.html (accessed 15 August 2019).
23 http://thaifilmjournal.blogspot.com/2013/05/free-thai-cinema-movement-returns-with.html (accessed 14 August 2019).
24 Taken from an interview with Nicolas Rapold, 'Cannes Interview: Apichatpong Weerasethakul', *Film Comment*, 1 June 2015. Available at: http://www.filmcomment.com/blog/cannes-interview-apichatpong-weerasethakul/ (accessed 25 May 2020).
25 Ibid.
26 https://culture360.asef.org/magazine/between-industry-and-experimentation-moving-images-thailand/
27 Closure of Scala was announced by several English-language Thai news outlets, for example, at: https://thailand-construction.com/bangkoks-historic-scala-cinemas-51-year-run-said-to-end/ (accessed 5 June 2020).
28 Online articles do not concur on the number of seats in the cinema, with different accounts offering figures of 900, 1,000 and 1,200 (accessed 14 August 2019).
29 The Thai Film Archive was originally known as the National Film Archive. For a fuller explanation of the Thai Film Archives' aims, see http://www.fapot.org/en/about.php?mid=50 (accessed 17 August 2019).
30 For further details about the cinema, see 'Scala's Got Soul' found at: https://www.bangkok101.com/scalas-got-soul/ (accessed 14 August 2019).
31 Online articles do not concur on the number of seats in the cinema, with different accounts offering figures of 900, 1,000 and 1,200: https://forestfringe.co.uk/project/live-at-the-scala-bangkok-2013/ (accessed 14 August 2019).
32 References taken from https://forestfringe.co.uk/project/live-at-the-scala-bangkok-2013/. Other details of *Live at the Scala* can be found at: http://www.thebigchilli.com/news/scala-cinema-bangkok (accessed 15 August 2019).

33 Report taken from the *Bangkok Post*, found at: https://www.bangkokpost.com/lifestyle/whats-on/25531/micro-festival-live-at-the-scala (accessed 15 August 2019).
34 Observation made in a review of Live at the Scala in *Thai Film journal*, found at: http://thaifilmjournal.blogspot.com/2013/02/live-at-scala-remakes-bangkok-traffic.html (accessed 17 August 2019).
35 Report found at: https://www.britishcouncil.or.th/en/programmes/arts/past-projects/2013-2014/live-scala (accessed 17 August 2019).
36 Observation made in a review of Live at the Scala in *Thai Film journal*, found at: http://thaifilmjournal.blogspot.com/2013/02/live-at-scala-remakes-bangkok-traffic.html (accessed 17 August 2019).
37 The two re-enactments can be found here, along with reviews published in the Thai press https://thereduxproject.com/bangkok (accessed 12 September 2019).

6

Cosplay, crossplay and immersive identities

You are more worthy to wear the armour of elf-princes than many that have looked more comely in it.

The Hobbit, J. R. R. Tolkien

Introduction

The final chapter of this book shifts the focus from live to lived media through an investigation of the embodied experience of cosplayers. It examines a spectrum of cosplay practices, at both specialist events and in everyday contexts, and considers the extent to which they share significant characteristics with the other experiential forms of media discussed in this book. This investigation takes three lines of enquiry. First, it considers the experiences of everyday cosplayers and the practice of Disneybounding (Brock 2017; Winge 2019). Everyday cosplay is a contentious issue with some scholars, who argue that cosplay is 'akin to performance art' and not simply a matter of 'dressing up' (Norris and Bainbridge 2009: 1). In this chapter I suggest that the extent to which the cosplayer physically inhabits and mimics the character, through gesture and attitude, can reflect but is not necessarily a conclusive indication of their mental or emotional investment in the practice. Second, this chapter investigates how the cultural practice of cosplay negotiates the live/mediatized divide discussed throughout this book, both economically and experientially. Finally, there is an interrogation of activist cosplay through an analysis of crossplay and gender-bent cosplay, which considers the significance of reinterpreting characters' gendered identities through these practices. This discussion explores the extent to which these practices facilitate gender fluidity among practitioners, thereby creating a space of solidarity and shared resistance. While recent feminist studies of fan-industry power structures have usefully explored contemporary issues

in this field, facilitating a move away from androcentric concerns (Scott 2019), this chapter contributes to research on marginalized experiences within cosplay cultures (Hutabarat-Nelson 2017; Nichols 2019) and argues that crossplay can be understood as a political practice in three distinct ways.

The data gathered for this small-scale study is analysed using theoretical frameworks drawn from gender studies and fan studies and employs a mixed-method approach; this includes participant observation at a number of fan conventions, qualitative audience research in the form of twelve interviews with cosplayers and crossplayers in the United Kingdom and the United States, and secondary accounts provided by cosplay bloggers online.[1] My position in researching this culture is not auto-ethnographic, as I have only cosplayed in non-specialist contexts such as Secret Cinema events. This is unusual within the world of cosplay research, where most of the researchers are aca-fans who practice cosplay (Brock 2017; Hutabarat-Nelson 2017; Lamerichs 2012; Nichols 2019; Scott 2015). The 'insider' position offers many advantages in terms of access to data and the lived culture, but also brings with it the potential for bias, as acknowledged by Theresa Winge (2019: 20). As a relative 'outsider', I have primarily observed cosplay culture at fan conventions and in everyday contexts. One of the key issues in engaging in research from this position is the potential to pathologize or 'other' the culture being studied, which this small-scale study attempts to avoid. However, the advantage of this approach, and my rationale for including cosplay culture as one of the six sites of audience/participant engagement within the sphere of experiential cinema, is the opportunity it affords to consider an embodied perspective within the discussion of immersive experiences analysed in this book. In this way, the primary intention is to build a multifaceted and inclusive study of experiential media cultures.

The interviewees were mainly recruited via social media, and all were based in the United States or the United Kingdom.[2] There is no established statistic for the demographic profile of cosplayers worldwide, and the interview sample does not therefore claim to be representative but has aimed to recruit from as broad a socio-demographic profile as possible within the constraints of the project. The sample was composed of five male, five female and two non-binary participants; two were generation Z, seven were millennials, and three were generation X; ten were university educated and two left education after school; finally, eight were US-based, and four were UK-based. The interviews were semi-structured and followed a different set of questions (appendix 5) to the schedule used with the case studies investigated in the other chapters.

Everyday cosplay: Immersive identities in domestic and virtual contexts

The popularity of cosplay at international fan conventions and specialist events has become a much-discussed topic in mainstream media throughout the global north.[3] The 2019 San Diego Comic-Con, for example, attracted approximately 135,000 attendees from over 80 countries and generated an estimated $149 million for the local economy.[4] The increased visibility of mainstream conventions such as these has generated speculation in the popular media about reasons for its growing popularity[5] and has focused scholarly attention on the booming cosplay economy (Scott 2015; Winge 2019). As cosplay has become a more prominent feature of mainstream culture, it has frequently been linked to a widespread resurgence in the practice of 'dressing up' (Boumaroun 2017; Vaclavik 2018; Wild 2019, 2020), which Keira Vaclavik argues is evidenced in the popularity of events such as World Book Day,[6] when children attend school dressed as their favourite fictional character (Vaclavik 2019). While character-based fancy dress is perhaps most conspicuous on World Book Day in the UK, there are equivalences across the global north, such as Read Across America Day.[7] These developments, in turn, have been interpreted by some scholars as a form of 'everyday cosplay' (Brock 2017; Boumaroun 2017; Affuso 2018).

While scholarship on cosplay culture is most frequently positioned within the broader field of fan studies (Lamerichs 2011, 2018; Scott 2015, 2019; Zubernis 2020), more recently Ellen Kirkpatrick (2015) and Nettie Brock (2017) have both argued that cosplay is not exclusively a fan practice restricted to the arena of specialized events, such as fan conventions and celebrations. Kirkpatrick highlights the way that many costumers do not self-identify as fans, while Brock's work on Disneybounding as a subset of everyday cosplay positions it within a framework of childhood nostalgia (Brock 2017). Both Kirkpatrick and Brock extend scholarship on cosplay beyond the spaces of fan conventions and gatherings where the cultural practice has become normalized, and Kirkpatrick argues that 'cosplay can thus be reconceptualized as a spectrum of intersecting behaviours rather than as a limited fan practice' (Kirkpatrick 2015: n.p.). As a broadly inclusive study, this chapter follows their lead by including primary data gathered on everyday cosplay.

Brock's research on everyday cosplay is notable for the way it explores the phenomenon of domestic cosplay within the private sphere. Her study examines the practice of Disneybounding, in which Disney fans wear regular clothing

that emulates their favourite Disney characters. The motivation for engaging in this practice, Brock argues, is to connect with Disney fandom and to 'relive their childhood Disney memories' by extending it into their everyday lives (Brock 2017: 301). One prominent social media influencer in the world of Disneybounding, Leslie Kay, contends that the appeal of the practice is that 'it uses clothes to recreate the outfits of your favorite Disney characters without being costume-y. You could go to school or the mall in a Disneybound and not get pegged for being in costume.'[8] Similarly, in her discussion of the practice, Theresa Winge explains that Disneybound Bambi, for example, is easily accomplished 'by wearing light brown clothing and a scarf with white dots, or Disneybound Mickey Mouse wears high-waist red shorts and black t-shirt with white socks and yellow tennis shoes' (Winge 2019: 169). Disneybounding thus offers some practitioners and fans a low-key, discreet form of cosplay that avoids attracting too much attention.

One interviewee identifies the appeal of Disneybounding as being the creative adaptation of clothes she already has in her wardrobe, explaining, 'I like the fact that I'm transforming ordinary clothes, dresses I already have and that are part of my personal style. But then I create a twist and add an element of the character I'm trying to bound as. Not everyone will get it, it's mainly just for other Disney fans' (Interviewee #91; A5, Q3). She later clarifies that the responses from these other fans can be either real-world interactions or on Instagram and Tumblr. This interviewee illustrates, then, how the practice is derived from her Disney fandom and offers a creative means of communicating with other fans, frequently reinforced through social media. I suggest it also positions Disneybounders as craft consumers and producers (Campbell 2005; Cherry 2016; Scott 2015). In their consumption of materials and the production of costumes, Disneybounders demonstrate a significant degree of creativity and capital. Brigid Cherry's study of feminine handicrafting contends that female fan cultures and female handicrafters have been devalued, both within fan studies and within fan cultures themselves (Cherry 2016: 35). Following on from this, there is some evidence that female Disneybounders interviewed for this study felt similarly devalued by certain elements of the cosplay community who told them it 'wasn't real cosplay'(Interviewee #92; A5, Q7).

Although Kirkpatrick argues persuasively that the spectrum of cosplay culture should include those who do not necessarily identify as fans, in the context of Disneybounding culture and the interviews conducted for this

small-scale study, the participants' fandom was a key driver in their everyday cosplay practice. Elizabeth Affuso contends that the appeal of branded fan products, particularly make-up, is that they facilitate 'forms of fan wear for people who might not feel comfortable wearing a branded t-shirt or performing cosplay' (Affuso 2018: 187). Many of these everyday cosplayers connect online via Tumblr or YouTube to share their practices with other fans, thus indicating that even though these practices appeal to fans who are reluctant or uncomfortable attracting public attention, the social aspect of the culture is nevertheless highly significant. One Disneybounder based in the United States who makes YouTube tutorials about her costumes explains that 'it isn't for money, it's because I love the characters and the creative process, plus I get lots of positive feedback from other fans who appreciate what I am sharing and say it inspires them to try it out in their everyday life' (Interviewee #93; A5, Q7).

Nicole Lamerichs observes that discussion around the design and production of homemade costumes forms a key aspect of cultural capital exchanged on cosplaying forums and sites (Lamerichs 2018: 202) and argues that 'the community is crucial to the development of costuming skills. The process of sewing the costume and guaranteeing its authenticity is therefore very important' (Lamerichs 2018: 202). This YouTuber interviewee emphasizes the high degree of fan interactivity within Disneybounding culture, and her perspective resonates with the handcrafting practices of grassroots community cinema groups who work collaboratively to produce costumes and props for immersive cinema screenings. In this respect, they share some of the common characteristics of an alternative experience economy that locates itself outside of the parameters of manufactured consumer culture.

However, not all Disneybounding takes place within domestic or virtual contexts. Rebecca Williams' study of theme park fandom, for example, considers how Disney theme parks offer Disneybounders 'moments of paratextual-spatio play where transmedia expansion of existing Disney narratives becomes possible via the fans' material presence' (Williams 2020: 27). While the practice of Disneybounding within theme parks has partly evolved as a means to circumnavigate the restrictions around wearing a full costume, Williams argues that they also facilitate a haptic fandom that includes posing for photos in specific places, eating foodstuffs related to the character and other similar activities that enable them to 'negotiate the self, character/text and the physical space of the theme park itself' (Williams 2020: 199). This suggests that Disneybounding in

these contexts is likely to facilitate a more immersive form of engagement with the character or text than similar practices in less specialized spaces.

Kirkpatrick's argument that cosplay includes a broader spectrum of practices accommodates the increased visibility of cosplay at events organized by Secret Cinema, as I have already discussed in relation to Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, where cosplay culture is integrated into the immersive design of the event (Pett 2019). In this respect, unlike the cosplay culture found at fan conventions that is frequently valorized for being highly individual and artistic, the cosplay practice at Secret Cinema is inscribed as compulsory by the organization, and attendees are provided with individual guidelines on how to put their outfits together. These research findings imply that the iconic familiarity of characters from the *Star Wars* universe makes them instantly recognizable even to those with little fan knowledge, and thus facilitates a 'cosplay-for-all' scenario (Pett 2019: 175). Indeed, the repeated discussion of cosplay in the reviews of Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back* implies that the experience of inhabiting or encountering these familiar characters at close quarters offers a significant pleasure among those attending the event. Part of this enjoyment, as discussed in Chapter 1, is the opportunity it affords *Star Wars* fans to 'step into' the fictional world of their childhood (Pett 2016: 158). This is also evident in events staged by similar organizations, such as the practice of dressing up as fictional characters at drive-ins.[9] As with Disneybounding, there is a strong correlation evident here between cinematic nostalgia and the cultural practice of dressing up as a means to augment engagement with their fandom and enhance the range of experiences offered by the event.

While theme parks and Secret Cinema events offer very specific contexts for everyday cosplay, research into the expanding experience economy also indicates that dressing up and posing in costumes in unusual or photogenic locations is an increasingly popular activity across the global north and among millennials. James Seligman observes that 'in Japan for example there are retail outlets that cater for millennials looking for a whacky experience and it comes at a premium price. Selfies and video of millennials dressed up as famous movie characters (*Star Wars*) [and] handling exotic rare animals are just a few examples' (Seligman 2019: 6). This observation implies that for millennials, the notion of everyday cosplay has become increasingly normalized by selfie culture and the opportunities to curate personal identity through social media platforms. Lynn Zubernis'discussion of the growth in cosplay culture echoes Seligman's perspective, in that she suggests that 'the increased popularity of cosplay may be

a result of the constant feeling of being "seen" which is part of modern culture' (Zubernis 2020: 263); again, this 'performed culture' is strongly associated with the millennial generation.

This broader spectrum of everyday cosplay extends the practice beyond the domestic sphere to include social and communal spaces, such as schools, theme parks and public leisure facilities, where cosplayers can interact with non-cosplayers. Lauren Boumaroun argues that experimentation with these costumes in everyday contexts allows 'young consumers to appropriate the visual identity of fictional characters for their own self-expression' (Boumaroun 2017: 647). Other studies conducted by psychologists have asserted that while cosplayers 'might be assumed to have personality characteristics of venturesomeness, sensation-seeking, and sociability . . . during in-person interviews with cosplayers, many cosplayers report that they are shy when out of costume, and that engaging in cosplay allows them to be more outgoing than their usual selves' (Rosenburg and Letamendi 2008: 1). This research implies that cosplay can function as a temporary retreat from a constructed social role or identity that is being forced upon someone. This perspective is articulated by an interviewee who explains that 'Disneybounding helped me develop my identity without feeling I was constantly being sidelined. It made me bold' (Interviewee #82; A5, Q4). As Theresa Winge contends in her analysis of cosplay culture, 'the costume both conceals and reveals the multitudes of entangled identities, leaving the cosplayer to perform according to the parameters often established within the visual communication of the costume' (Winge 2019: 56). Winge suggests that testimonies such as these reveal how significant the practice of cosplay can be when practitioners are experiencing discomfort around normative cultural expectations relating to gender, race, sexuality or body image. Winge also argues that cosplayers 'both emphasize and become the Other with the specific characters they embody by virtue of their costumes and portrayals of characters in the socially constructed environments of conventions or related events. Moreover, the ways race, ethnicity, and size manifest in cosplay portrayals (costumes and performances) visually communicate the Other' (Winge 2019: 57). In making these arguments, Winge offers a specific interpretation of cosplay practices as inherently empowering in terms of their potential to navigate cultural restrictions relating to identity. Thus, for introverts, everyday cosplay allows practitioners to negotiate social situations without the kind of social anxieties they experience when they are out of costume.

Another interviewee likens the experience of everyday cosplaying to becoming a superhero, explaining that the foundation of cosplay is 'an act of defiance against societal norms. Defying society, defying reality, defying our own limitations, being a cosplayer is akin to a superhero changing into their superhero costume, its freeing you from the mortal coil, its freeing you from being a civilian, from being a side character, its allowing you to embrace something so much bigger than yourself' (Interviewee #85; A5, Q4). The cosplayer-as-superhero is a well-used feature of cosplay discourse that captures the potential the practice has to facilitate a meaningful shift in the way the performer conceives of their own identity. However, not all cosplayers articulate this kind of experience. Another interviewee explains that

> what's interesting is when you link it to introvert versus extrovert, a lot of introverts take refuge in cosplay, whereas I am very much an extrovert, and so for me it's just pushing my boundaries and embracing the performance, and challenging myself to step outside of myself. I never saw it as a refuge or an escape necessarily, it was just an extension of being able to explore different personalities. (Interviewee #80; A5, Q6)

This interviewee demonstrates a well-developed awareness of how cosplayers are discursively constructed, and her experience of cosplaying is very focused on self-realization and the pleasure she derives from it.

These interviewees therefore demonstrate the diverse ways that cosplayers immerse themselves into their performative identities, and the range of experiences these generate within everyday contexts. For part-time cosplayers at the casual end of the cosplay spectrum, there is an overlap with the experiences described in Chapter 1; some of these practitioners enjoy engaging with a much-loved object of fandom and revisiting a childhood nostalgia. However, everyday cosplay is not simply a case of low-key enjoyment of a fan text or character. Many everyday cosplayers and Disneybounders enjoy interacting with other fans online and in real-world scenarios, using cosplay to facilitate social relations. For other everyday cosplayers, the practice enables them to renegotiate aspects of their identity and their interactions with other people in an empowering way. The recent development of everyday cosplay, and more seemingly low-key forms of fan engagement with costume, does not therefore correlate with a lesser form of emotional or social engagement with the practice, as argued by Norris and Bainbridge (2009). Rather, as Kirkpatrick asserts, it facilitates a broad spectrum of intersecting behaviours that vary according to the social context and practitioner.

Locating cosplay performances across the live/mediatized divide

Cosplay practices straddle the live/mediatized divide through their embodied reworking of characters from fictional media worlds. Kirkpatrick acknowledges 'the mimetic and diegetic qualities permeating cosplay', through observing 'the simultaneity of the performance of cosplay, of the real and the fictional, the cosplayer and the source character' (Kirkpatrick 2015: n. p.). This coexistence of the real and the fictional within cosplay practice can also be understood as both a heightened proximity to the mediatized performance and simultaneously as having negotiated a spatial distance from it, as the cosplayer extracts the 'performance' from its original mediatized source and reconfigures in within a live communal, public space. One cosplayer who regularly crossplays as Jayne Cobb from *Firefly* discusses this process, explaining:

> Jayne is like one of my most successful and popular cosplays, because of how much I commit to it, because you take people into the game with you. As you're playing a character, you're building a small environment around yourself, you are doing the play of cosplay, and so when someone is interacting with you, they step into your environment, they become a part of it. With Jayne, if I was pretending to be aggressive, maybe there would be like another character, a military character, and they'd go 'my gun's bigger than your gun', that type of thing, it was hilarious because I'm 5'2, so there was this humorous aspect to it, and people were attracted to that, people wanted to be a part of that, and then that just kind of fuelled my adrenaline, and the role of the character, and I started getting more outrageous and louder, and just playing the character deeper. (Interviewee #86; A5, Q2)

Having established a live performance space, this cosplayer discusses the way she then facilitates interaction with other cosplayers and members of the public. In this instance, cosplay becomes a participatory culture as much as an act of individual embodiment. In many cases, these performances are then remediatized and circulated online in the format images, videos, gifs and so on (Lamerichs 2018: 202). This circuit of adaptation across the live/mediatized divide provides another example of the cultural practices of the millennial experience economy, discussed in Chapter 1.

The millennial generation has been characterized by marketing analysts in terms of their desire to share experiences via mobile devices, apps and social

media platforms as they are happening.[10] Seligman argues that this cultural practice enables a form of instant gratification for the user and that 'the more unique the experience, the higher the satisfaction level is to the "owner" of the experience shared' (Seligman 2019: 2). The Jayne cosplayer recalls the first time one of her cosplay images received significant online attention, remembering,

> it was viral on Tumblr, and it was incredible to have people react to you, because when you're by yourself, it feels great and that's one thing, it's fulfilling in itself, but when you're out you give people joy, and you see that you are a cause of joy, and humour and reactions in people, like there's nothing like it, it's just so incredible, it's absolutely a connection that you have with people, so that element elevated it to a level that . . . up to that point, I had no idea that's even possible. (Interviewee #86; A5, Q4)

Here, the pleasures of the cosplay experience are amplified by interacting with other Tumblr users. This reciprocal relationship, enacted across the live/mediatized divide, reveals the performative exchange with an audience to be central to the cosplayer's pleasure. In some respects, the highly individual form of self-expression cosplay enables, together with the unique visual and aesthetic attributes of the costuming, makes it an ideal cultural practice to facilitate the form of experiential gratification identified by Seligman (2019: 2). However, in this case the cosplayer is not simply seeking a favourable response to their own image, but to a performative identity intended to be comedic; in this respect, then, the sharing of experiences via social media does not demonstrate the 'vanity of Western millennials' that Seligman attributes to these cultural practices (Seligman 2019: 3). This case study is therefore illustrative not just of the embodied circuits of live/mediatized social exchange within cosplay culture but also of the complexities of the millennial experience economy; it reveals the psychological nuances of these cultural practices, which I argue are too frequently stigmatized by market analysts and cultural commentators as instances of narcissism.[11]

This case study also illustrates the process of remediatization, whereby the images are once again translated into live cosplay. The interviewee describes her cosplay of the meme version of Thranduil from *The Hobbit*, known as Thranduil Party King.[12] The circulation of the meme online illustrates the way certain performances move across the live/mediatized divide multiple times. Kirkpatrick similarly observes that characteristic of cosplay practice can be understood as 'embodied translation, that through these processes both cosplayer and

character become lost and recreated in translation' (Kirkpatrick 2015: n.p.). The interviewee's subsequent (re)production and performance of Thranduil Party King functions as a live interpretation of a mediatized performance (in itself a reworking of a fictional character from a book); this example thus illustrates the multi-layered negotiation of the live/mediatized divide that characterizes many cosplay cultures.

The extent to which cosplay can be understood as an inherently creative cultural practice, and one that encompasses the possibility of interpreting and reworking mediatized characters as live performance, is a contested discourse among scholars and the cosplay community (Bainbridge and Norris 2013; Kirkpatrick 2015). Bainbridge and Norris define cosplay as the practice of 'embodying the character, providing an accurate and authentic experience in terms of body features and behaviours as much as dress' (Bainbridge and Norris 2013: 3). However, many cosplayers dispute the need for accuracy as being integral to cosplay practice. One interviewee argues that 'it's such a creative expression, and that's the core of it, it's a creative expression, and really, if anyone has issues with it, that is just them projecting their own conservatism, their own insecurities, like the need to control another person and limit their autonomy' (Interviewee #83; A5, Q4). This cosplayer is particularly assertive about her sexual agency when cosplaying and is in part responding to public discourses surrounding the sexualization of cosplay culture, discussed later in this chapter.[13]

Another interviewee adopts a different stance when discussing her relationship with the characters she cosplays, explaining that there are two key factors that drive her performances. The first, she explains, is 'my absolute love for the character, whether it's an original character or a character that's already been established, like I absolutely subscribe to the idea that cosplay is an homage', and the second is her desire 'to perform for people, that's a big driver, performing for people' (Interviewee #81; A5, Q4). For this cosplayer, the creation of the character as an homage of the original mediatized performance is indicative of a strong affective relationship which she categorizes as 'love'; as Joel Gn observes, it is 'the consumption of the image that becomes a pleasurable, embodied experience' (Gn 2001: 584). The mimicry involved in this cosplayer's performance has some resonance with Auslander's argument that 'the general response of live performance to the oppression and economic superiority of mediatized forms has been to become as much like them as possible' (Auslander 2008: 7). However, this interview data also illustrates how a mimetic impulse can be driven by an affective response to the mediatized form, rather than inhabiting the binary

of oppressor and oppressed. Auslander's implication of an oppositional power structure between the two cultures (live and mediatized) is thus not evidenced by the data gathered on the cosplaying community. Although his analysis is often nuanced, the competitive, conflictual way Auslander characterizes the relationship between live and mediatized cultures of performance is problematic when applied to the cosplay community; this is partly due to the alternative economic framework cosplay culture operates within, in which distinctions between performers and audiences have become blurred.

In contrast to the cosplay community, Auslander's examples of live and mediatized culture operate within the same commercial fields, thus competing for the disposable income of the middle classes who seek to be entertained within the experience economy. While many cosplayers circulate on non-professional circuits, those who monetize their performances and become professionals exploit an alternative economic model that spans the live/mediatized divide, using live spaces in tandem with simultaneous online remediation of them to promote themselves as a consumable product.[14] For successful cosplayers who market their services at mainstream fan conventions in the United States, it is estimated they could earn approximately $52,000 a year.[15] In these cases, the cosplayer's (sub) cultural capital becomes embodied, and 'the subculturalist's body (in terms of internalised knowledge and objectified bodily display) thus becomes significant to the performance of subcultural capital' (Hills 2010: 89). This (sub)cultural capital is then translated into economic capital in the case of the professional cosplayer, who charges for their appearances (live performances) and online materials (mediatized performance). In this respect, I argue professional cosplay culture illustrates a fluid, contemporary form of entrepreneurialism within the experience economy, embodying the entrepreneurial tactics associated with the neoliberal experience economy discussed in Chapter 1.

Crossplay and gender-bend cosplay as cultural resistance

Existing scholarship on the cultural practice of cosplay has most frequently drawn on Butler's concept of performativity as a means to explore the relationship between the character and the cosplayer (Lamerichs 2011; Norris and Bainbridge 2009: 4; Winge 2019: 159; Nichols 2019). These analyses have contended that costuming culture offers a safe creative space in which to explore the boundaries between fictional and non-fictional identities. While cross-

dressing is a centuries-old cultural practice, the origins of cosplay in relation to popular culture are often disputed, with some scholars tracing it back to North America in the 1930s while others locate it in Japan (Winge 2019: 3). The performativity of the practice means the cosplay has also been understood as 'not simply the fannish act of dressing up, but rather the act of "queering" gender roles and stepping outside heteronormative behaviours through the assumption of fictional identities' (Norris and Bainbridge 2009: 4). Indeed, Mountfort, Peirson-Smith and Geczy argue that

> cosplay itself fits into a general definition of queer. For queer – which like all such terms relating to class, race and identity are porous, hotly debated and contested – is not limited to signify being gay or lesbian, but embraces all the variants of identity types that do not comply with, or are indifferent to, what queer studies calls 'heteronormativity'. (Mountfort, Peirson-Smith and Geczy 2019)

Here, cosplay culture is conceptualized as inherently queer and broadly oppositional to heteronormative culture in the way it undermines social norms and is grounded in bodily difference.

Some cosplay scholars have, however, challenged the established Butlerian approach to interpreting cosplay and performativity. Joel Gn, for example, argues that Butler's approach fails to account for the social and interactive dimension of cosplay conventions, thus making it an incomplete theoretical perspective for understanding cosplay culture (Gn 2011). Gn poses the question of whether cosplay 'is indeed an exemplification of gender as performance, does it re-enact an ideal of the gender dichotomy or is it 'gendered' by a series of visible markers which, as iterated by Butler (1990: 10), constitute a discursive effect brought about through a convergence among culturally and historically specific sets of relations?' (Gn 2011: 586). Gn contends that cosplayers and their audiences interact primarily with the identity of the character cosplayed, rather than with the identity of the cosplayer, and that analyses of gender identity are hence better directed as fan relations with the character, rather than as a reflection on the cosplayer and their gender identity.

Despite these critiques of Butlerian approaches to theorizing cosplay, many scholars continue to investigate its emancipatory practices within the liminal spaces cosplay offers. Notably, the practice of male-to-female crossplaying, a subset of cosplay, is frequently valorized as a challenge to hegemonic cultural norms (Leng 2014: 89–90). In this context, Winge contends that cosplay offers the opportunity to negotiate constructions of gender, sexuality and identity,

arguing that 'many cosplayers attempt to defy the confines of their own corporeal bodies in favour of the fantastic characters' (Winge 2019: 159). However, some empirical studies investigating the emancipatory spaces conventions offer to cosplayers from marginalized groups are not so celebratory in their analysis (Ramirez 2017). In his qualitative study of two large US comic book conventions, Manuel Ramirez argues that cosplayers are capable of both subverting and reinforcing social marginalization, contending that 'while cosplay and comic book conventions may be perceived to promote inclusion and acceptance, some social actors with minority status remain obligated to perform acts of subversion in the midst of persisting marginalization' (Ramirez 2017: 3). Ramirez's case studies suggest that social and cultural capital within cosplay culture at fan conventions continue to be stratified along boundaries of race and gender.

Forms of cultural resistance have been analysed as key characteristics of fan cultures since the early 1990s when Jenkins and the first wave of fan scholars published their early work on fan cultures (Jenkins 1992; Bacon-Smith 1992). Recent research has indicated that there has been growing evidence of cosplay being employed as a form of resistance to hegemonic gender norms (Hutabarat-Nelson 2017; Nichols 2019; Mountfort, Peirson-Smith and Geczy 2019). Scholarship within the field contends that cosplay is 'a phenomenon that destabilizes the gender binary – its active practice promotes the production and interpretation of gender as being within a spectrum for cosplayers and their audiences alike' (Hutabarat-Nelson 2017: v). 'Crossplay', 'gender-bending' and 'gender-flipping' are all terms used within cosplay communities to describe a range of cosplay practices that have become increasingly more visible throughout the last decade at fan conventions. 'Cosqueer' and 'cosgay' are also terms appearing with increasing frequency in the context of online cosplay forums, but that are not yet widely used (Mountfort, Peirson-Smith and Geczy 2019: 234). My interest in the practice began when I observed gender-bend cosplay at a *Star Wars* convention in 2015 (Pett 2016b). Alongside the investigation of the cultural and political implications of everyday fandom, this research therefore also examines crossplay and gender-bend cosplay as potentially subversive cultural practices within the alternative experience economy.

A range of scholarship on crossplay has recently emerged in tandem with increased visibility of the cultural practice. Research has investigated the popularity of male-to-female (M2F) crossplay in Japanese fan cultures, for example, where it is known as *otoko no ko,* a cultural practice in which boys crossplay and pass as female characters (Levin, Ling and Zhao 2017). For these

specialized communities, participation in crossplay culture is associated with inhabiting safe spaces and engaging in cultural practices with like-minded people.

Hutabarat-Nelson argues that

> the growing prevalence and acceptance of crossplayers and gender-bend cosplayers demonstrates an increased willingness to isolate a body's sex from the gendered cosplay performance. In this way, the form of gender deviance facilitated and encouraged by cosplay and crossplay work constructively towards an understanding of sex and gender as separate concepts in line with current trends in feminist and queer studies. (Hutabarat-Nelson 2017: 23)

Hutbarat-Nelson thus highlights the significance of gendered cosplay in contributing to cultural work on promoting inclusivity around gender and sexuality in a wider cultural context. Similarly, Kirkpatrick highlights the emancipatory potential of superhero cosplay and crossplay in the way it can transcend gender binaries and 'allow us to begin reimagining identity and therefore begin reimagining ourselves in ways that perhaps more adequately or satisfactorily reflect our experiences in subjectivity . . . the superhero genre and cosplay performance also offer other ways of conceiving, representing, and living in identity, ways not regulated through systems, structures, and binaries but instead welcoming of ambiguity and plurality' (Kirkpatrick 2015: n.p.).

The importance of the practice of crossplay and gender-bend cosplay is also articulated by the cosplayers themselves. One crossplayer explains that 'I respect the entire gender spectrum and I like how cosplay, specifically, allows everyone to express gender in such a flexible way, it's one of the core cultural aspects of cosplay, which makes it so empowering' (interview #80: A5, Q5). In destabilizing gender norms, this crossplayer then explains that they do not seek to eradicate concepts of gender, but to complicate them and facilitate a cultural environment where gender can be understood and considered with greater awareness. As Gackstetter Nichols observes, gendered cosplay also affords female practitioners the opportunity to inhabit and experiment with a wider range of character types:

> Female gender-bending cosplayers often feel a resonance with both the look of, and the values of strong, combative and violent characters. Since many find that the array of choices in their favourite media is again 'not exactly a wide open field', these women work creatively to expand their choices. Looking within their preferred fandoms, women feel empowered to use violent or strong canonically male characters as templates to communicate specific aspects of their

> aspirational personality, without feeling as if they need to represent themselves as male. (Nicholls 2019: 10)

The cultural offer of inhabiting a strong or violent character has a strong appeal for many female crossplayers, who feel it is culturally unacceptable for a woman to display these characteristics in the context of everyday life. Another female crossplayer I spoke to explained that 'as a cis gendered white woman, I feel I have very little outlet for aggressive or violent behaviour. If I display these characteristics in my daily life, I become vilified and outcast in my social network. Crossplay offers a huge release for me, to chance to inhabit a persona that allows me to breathe' (interviewee #86; A5, Q6). This interview was notable for the way that the interviewee intimated that she felt as though aspects of her personality were being repressed by the cultural restrictions of the heteronormative society she inhabits.

Online discussions of crossplay culture among practitioners also frequently indicate a desire to celebrate the potential crossplay has as an artistic practice that destabilizes normative gendered boundaries. For example, Matt Baume (2017) writes that

> crossplay generally refers to a person wearing a costume that is different from the wearer's own gender; 'gender-bending' or 'gender-flipping' usually means that the gendering of the costume itself has been changed. In practical terms, that means that geek conventions are now more open than ever to costumes that reflect the artist's own curiosity about gender. This has transformed cosplay into an art form, broadening opportunities for personal investigation and elevating the playful act of dress-up into political performance. These cultural shifts match recent political advances for the queer community; as legal equality is expanding for LGBTQ people, so too are opportunities for self-representation. (Baume 2017: n.p.)

Baume's 'insider' assessment of the cultural value of crossplay culture, then, interprets it as political in a performative sense. Similarly, some academic studies have also focused on crossplayers' mutual desire to reveal the socially constructed nature of gender roles and, more often, to challenge normative expressions of masculinity. Emerald L. King's research, for example, has studied cosplay culture with the groups *Older Cosplayers New Zealand* and *Melbourne Cosplay Community*. King's findings suggest that for some trans- or non-binary cosplayers, assuming the guise of another character offers a safe space and an escape from their own gender issues. King argues that the appeal of cosplay and

crossplay for many of these participants is the safe environment it provides for people to experiment with their gender identity (King 2015).

An online interview with cosplayer and disability rights activist Jay Justice further underscores this argument and offers some insights into her crossplay practice. Justice explains that 'there is a lot of pressure in the cosplay community to be a look-alike, but if you're a heavy-set person, or non-binary, you might not resemble any character. It's more important to find someone you enjoy playing.' She goes on to argue that creativity within cosplay practice is often bound up with the cosplayer's own gendered identity, more specifically their identification as non-binary. In the creative economy of cosplay, additional value is also placed on the appropriation and subversion of corporate imagery. Denver-based cosplayer Kaai Santerelli sets out to specifically make a statement with his work:

> All of my friends were doing male versions of Captain America. Somebody said something about how they were 'butching up' their version, so I went the opposite way. I can be Captain America in a frilly dress. (Santerelli in Baume 2017: n.p.)

Santerelli's crossplay as a feminized Captain America thus functions as a political performance that directly challenges gender norms and can be interpreted as an example of what José Muñoz has termed 'disidentification' – a process which enables those outside mainstream culture to reject the racial and gendered norms by transforming them for their own purposes. Drawing on queer theory, disidentification involves recycling or rethinking encoded cultural meanings. Its aim is to deconstruct cultural norms in a way that exposes the encoded message's exclusionary structures and simultaneously reworks it to account for, include and empower minority identities. In this respect, disidentificatory practices like crossplay use majority culture as raw materials for representing a disempowered identity politics that has been rendered invisible.

The practice of butching up or feminizing versions of popular characters has also been combined with the practice of crossplay mash-ups. In this respect, parallels can be drawn between Muñoz's process of disidentification and what Henry Jenkins has described as 'textual poaching' (1993). Drawing on the work of Michel de Certeau, Jenkins argues that fans are active producers of meaning, constructing their own culture from borrowed materials as a means of cultural resistance. Indeed, the overlap between this aspect of queer theory and fan studies has already been written about by, among others, Alexis Lothian (2008) in relation to *Stargate: Atlantis*. One notable example of crossplay mash-up culture is Snowba Fett, the creation

of Amber Arden, a costume designer who feminizes the *Star Wars* character of Boba Fett using aspects of Snow White's costume. However, like Jay Justice, Amber Arden has professionalized the practice and charges fees to appear at conventions. While this illustrates the stratification of cosplay culture and the coexistence of both a grassroots community and a highly professional subset of cosplayers who charge for appearances, Scott argues this is a relatively small subcategory of cosplay culture (Scott 2015: 147). In this respect, then, these crossplayers' practices are very different from the DIY, anti-commercial practices described by Jenkins and other fan scholars. There is clearly, therefore, a broad economic spectrum of ways in which cosplayers gender-bend well-known popular characters.

Non-professional crossplayers are more likely to discuss their practice specifically in terms of their own gender identity. One interviewee, who identifies as non-binary, explains that they enjoy crossplay because

> crossplaying lets me explore my gender identity in a creative way, that's why I like it. There are no questions asked and everyone loves it, they really appreciate it when you put the effort in. Fan conventions are safe spaces for me, I feel really comfortable there, one day I'm a female character like Leia and then another day I'll cosplay a male character. And for me, that's been completely normalised now, it's just like totally normal there. (Interviewee #85; A5, Q2)

This articulation of why they enjoy crossplay so much hinges on the gender fluid nature of their crossplay and a communal performance of this. Fan conventions offer a collective space in which the alternation of male and female personas has become normalized (and even professionalized by cosplayers like Arden and Justice). Analysis of fan culture as providing this kind of collective cultural space goes back to Fiske's work on Madonna fans in *Reading the Popular* (1989), where he argues that fan spaces offer 'the beginning of a sense of solidarity, of a shared resistance, that can support and encourage progressive action on the micro-social level'. In this respect, the cosplayers who frame their performance as art or professional labour are nevertheless contributing to a collective culture that resists normative gendered behaviour. This small-scale study of gender-flipped reinterpretations of characters' gender identities through crossplay culture thus reveals both the ways in which it facilitates gender fluidity and aspects of political performance among practitioners, but also the degree to which this has been professionalized for commercial purposes.

This chapter now turns to consider the socio-political uses of crossplay and gender-bend cosplay, highlighting the political dimensions of these practices.

Focusing first on 'bearded Leia' costuming, I investigate the extent to which *Star Wars* crossplayers intentionally subvert and challenge normative gendered behaviour within the public sphere. One interviewee identified himself as being a 'straight white guy, I'm married with two kids' (Interviewee #87; A5, Q1). He discussed his practice of crossplaying as a 'bearded Leia', explaining, 'I've always really liked the gold bikini outfit. It's how you get the most attention . . . a lot of men whistle and cat call when they see me, it's great, and then when I turn around, sometimes they get a real surprise. That's the best part. I love all of those reactions from straight guys' (Interviewee #87; A5, Q6). One element of this crossplayer's practice, then, is that it offers not merely an opportunity for self-expression; it provides a means to challenge normative gender identities within the public space of fan conventions. He suggests that this public performance is as important as the desire he has to experiment with his own gender identity, stating that 'the beard is an important part of the costume, it really makes the costume, people either love it or hate it' (Interviewee #87; A5, Q4).

When asked what the range of reactions from those attending the conventions was like, he recalls that they were

> mainly very positive reactions, people laugh and mainly they want to have their photo taken with me. I have had a couple of angry reactions, I guess sometimes they are embarrassed, it's hard to tell . . . if they catcall and think I'm a woman before they get a good look. I can pass as a woman from behind, that's why I enjoy it so much. (Interviewee #87; A5, Q4)

There is a sense, then, in which this crossplayer uses his crossplay practice to 'call out' and shame heteronormative forms of sexual harassment within the public sphere. In this respect, it can be argued that crossplay practice moves beyond 'the personal as political' and becomes a form of political activism. Norris and Bainbridge also draw this conclusion in their study of the Haraju2girls cosplayers in Australia; they summarize that 'unlike other fannish dressing-up, cosplay is closer to drag. We would argue that it is not merely an act of becoming a particular character or marking out a particular alignment, but of disruption. This is the "play" in "cosplay", a play with identity and, more often, a play with gender identity' (Norris and Bainbridge 2009: 2).

While some crossplayers frame their practice within a self-reflexive acknowledgement of their own exhibitionism and desire for attention, others articulate the experience in different ways. Another bearded Leia is more explicit in his articulation of the political aspect of the performance, stating that 'when

I'm at conventions then, yeah, it is all quite light-hearted, we're just having a bit of a laugh. But when I wear the costume outside, out on the streets, it's totally different. Sometimes I get badly harassed. I think it's important though, to challenge people and call them out on their bad behaviour' (Interviewee #88; A5, Q4). Here, the cosplayer is describing a more confrontational and politicized form of crossplay that directly challenges the prejudices of majority culture, and this practice more clearly maps on to that of other fan activists. In this respect, these research findings position this study alongside scholarly work on fan activism by Jenkins and Shresthova (2012), Jones (2012), Jenkins et al. (2016), and thus reflect a broader trajectory within scholarship in the field of fan studies.

A female crossplayer reflects on some of the differences male and female practitioners encounter engaging in crossplay. Identifying as a cis-gendered female, she discusses her experiences of crossplaying as Jayne Cobb from *Firefly*:

> [Jayne] is probably, like, the epitome of what you expect in a typical, masculine, cis-gendered man, and I went full crossplay . . . 'So, Jayne, in the show [Firefly] he's kind of like your typical . . . he objectifies women. He's very, like, awkwardly flirtatious, he expresses aggressive masculine traits, and so, with being that, I was a lot more forward when I would see female cosplayers. Nothing inappropriate, ever because that's never a line I will cross, but his behaviour was different where, like if he was posing if someone asked for a picture and they happen to be, like, super-attractive or in a particular outfit, then Jayne get really awkward and shy, and it was never anything when he was rude towards them, but he was reacting to a very pretty person, yes.' (Interviewee #86; A5, Q4)

Although she is talking in the third person, the cosplayer is discussing her own performance as the character of Jayne in this interview. She analyses how the performance takes on a coy and flirtatious character when she interacts with other females. This crossplay involves a 'full body transformation, and I spoke with his voice, just because I'm 5'2 and Jayne, the actor in real life is, like, 6'2 or something, and so because I was so far from what the character actually is, I had to work even harder to portray [him], so it was every little thing, mannerisms, voice, reaction, everything' (Interviewee #86; A5, Q2). She goes on to acknowledge and reflect on the differences between male and female crossplay:

> There's a difference between a masculine body fitting into feminine costume than a feminine body fitting into masculine costume . . . I so respect and

> acknowledge the courage and the power that masculine-expressing men embracing the feminine have, it's such an important thing to see, it's such a refreshing thing to see. It's nice because it's so very clear, and you cannot confuse what they are doing, whereas with feminine-expressing bodies, if we want to make that statement, we have to go so much further to defy the gender binary, because people are so much more comfortable with a woman dressing as a man. (Interviewee #86; A5, Q5)

However, crossplayers' desire to transgress normative gender binaries has been problematized by scholars including Rachel Leng, who argues that the practice is, more frequently, an expression of fan creativity and a bid for cultural capital, which thus undercuts its subversive potential (Leng 2014: 106). Indeed, several online crossplayers with prominent social media profiles that were interviewed for this study insisted that their crossplay practice is entirely artistic in nature and 'not about gender politics'. One male-to-female crossplayer, for example, explains that 'although crossplay is a big part of my life, I see it as an artistic form, it allows me to express my individuality and be myself' (Interview #89; A4, Q5).

However, this statement can, in itself, be construed as a political position through its reactionary stance. Thus, the practice of crossplay opens up opportunities for both progressive political activism and a reactionary retreat from the sphere of gender politics. These responses to gender politics can also be framed within a political context, then, in that their reactionary stance is an implicitly political one.

One of the more contentious discourses in cosplay culture that frequently generates a toxic environment online is the discussion of sexualized costumes and harassment at fan conventions. This discourse has received considerable traction in the popular media where, perhaps unsurprisingly, female cosplayers have been stigmatized for wearing 'sexualised' costumes.[16] While some cosplayers are condemnatory of this culture, the majority support the 'cosplay is not consent' campaign to stop harassment at conventions.[17] The interviewees for this study did not have strong views on this debate, though one stated that 'I am probably in the more liberal camp, I mean, sexualised cosplay is someone empowering themselves, expressing their confidence and their love of themselves and their body, and there's a big difference between . . . I just can't take the condemnation of sexualised cosplay seriously, when characters as so overtly sexualised in media anyway' (Interviewee #90; A5, Q7). Views such as these suggest that while the debate frequently becomes inflamed on social media, in real-world exchanges

viewpoints are generally more moderate. Another interviewee downplays the public discourse around gender and sexuality at fan conventions, stating,

> the one thing, though, about the gender expression that, I don't know if this is a negative or a positive, really, but it's also a very safe space for gender expression because it is very easy for people just to assume it is for humorous intent. It's positive because it means people won't experience any kind of negative or toxic response, but it's negative in that people won't see it as a serious statement. (Interviewee #89; A5, Q5)

Sexualized cosplay is discussed by Maria Patrice Amon in her three-year study of the subversive potential of Disney cosplay at fan conventions and cosplay gatherings. Amon concludes that the 'uncanny visual representation of children's characters on the corporeal bodies of adults destabilizes innocence and resituates it as a process of deviance' (Amon 2014: n.p.) While the interviewees for both this study and that conducted by Amon are in no sense representative of the wider cosplay community, the contrasting perspectives they offer on the subject of sexualized costumes and harassment suggest a significant distinction between discourses generated on mainstream social media and real-world experiences of fan conventions.

Conclusions

The spectrum of cosplay practices considered here reveals it to be both a complex and potentially subversive cultural practice, and yet simultaneously an increasingly mainstream one. Discourses around cosplay at immersive cinema events, like Secret Cinema's *The Empire Strikes Back*, reveal that the appeal of cosplay can extend beyond the dedicated fandom associated with big conventions. While not the everyday cosplay described by Nettie Brock, there is nonetheless a sense in which events such as these introduce people to cosplay, often for the first time, and capitalize on a form of childhood nostalgia. These participatory practices share some common ground with the studies of crossplay communities, and indeed my own observation of cosplay at the *Star Wars Celebration Europe* in 2016 illustrates the way in which dedicated cosplayers and crossplayers often share the same space as those participating in the practice for the first time, acknowledging what Cochrane describes as a 'one-off' experience of 'extra-terrestrial roleplay'.

While the choice of words used by this participant ('roleplay' and 'dressing up') implies a distancing of themselves from the more fannish practice of 'cosplay', with its implications of commitment and dedication, not all everyday cosplayers frame the practice in these casual terms. Some of the everyday cosplayers interviewed for this book revealed high levels of emotional commitment, personal empowerment and pleasure derived from online interaction with other cosplayers. The increased popularity and visibility of everyday cosplay, and more seemingly understated forms of fan engagement with costume, does not therefore correlate with a diminished emotional or psychological form of cosplay practice.

The analysis of cosplayers negotiating the live/mediatized divide illustrates the complex way they mediate and remediate their performances on and offline. Cosplayers 'make real' mediatized performances and characters at live events, then subsequently remediatize and recirculate these live performances online, and in some cases, the images are once again translated into a live performance as in the case of Thranduil Party King discussed in this chapter. This study also suggests that amateur cosplayers who handcraft their costumes and focus on the pleasures of their performative identities and interactions with other cosplayers form part of an alternative experience economy that locates itself outside of the parameters of manufactured consumer culture; professional cosplayers, by way of contrast, monetize their performances and thus embody the entrepreneurial tactics associated with neoliberal experience economy.

The evidence analysed in this qualitative study of crossplay practitioners also suggests that within a contemporary context, cosplay can be understood as a political practice in three distinct ways. First, in the sense that crossplay facilitates the performance of non-binary and gender-fluid identities and allows practitioners to experiment within a safe space, providing solidarity and the potential for collective action. Second, the case study of the bearded Leia crossplay indicates that the political dimension of this practice extends beyond the performative and functions as a form of political activism that challenges heteronormative forms of sexual harassment within public spaces. However, the mobilization of cosplay by a range of activist practitioners has also, as Suzanne Scott notes, brought with it an unwelcome backlash:

> The past decade has been marked by growing fan activist efforts surrounding issues of diversity in media production cultures, and pushback from mostly cisgendered, heterosexual, white male fans who views these efforts developments

> as an unwelcome of 'political correctness' and 'SJWs' (a pejorative term deployed by anti-feminist, racist, homophobic or transphobic commentators online to disparage 'social justice warriors') into geek and fan culture. (Scott 2019: 2)

This ongoing conflict between progressive cosplay culture and the regressive pushback from cis-gendered, heterosexual white males reflects wider cultural issues around gendered harassment that, despite the impact of the #MeToo movement, continue to dominate mainstream culture in the global north. Third, in the instance of the crossplayers who frame their practice as art or professional labour, and refute the notion that it constitutes a political statement, I argue that this reactionary response is, in itself, a political statement. Hence the range of crossplay practices observed in this small-scale study reveals the transformative potential cosplay has within a broader cultural context.

Notes

1 The reception study consists of twenty-seven newspaper articles and forty-six online reviews, all of which were published between March 2015 and April 2016. The range of online reviews includes articles from mainstream sources, some of which were also published in print format (such as the *Radio Times* and *Metro* reviews), as well as blog posts from fans and other online reviewers. The interviews are with crossplayers from the United Kingdom and the United States; their identities have been anonymized and they have self-selected pseudonyms.

2 There is no established statistic for the demographic profile of cosplayers worldwide, though they tend to be relatively young and fall with the millennial or gen Z categories, as this is a culture that has been significantly popularized over the last two decades in the global north.

3 For example, recent articles on New York Comic-Con found at: https://www.cnbc.com/2018/10/08/new- york-comic-con-is-bigger-than-ever-brings-more-than-100m-to-nyc.html and London Comic-Con found at: https://www.independent.co.uk/life-style/cosplay-economy-dressing-up-comic-fantasy-a8105171.html (accessed 9 September 2019).

4 Figures taken from https://visitsandiego.com/2019/07/breaking-down-comic-con-2019-numbers (accessed 12 September 2019).

5 For example, see https://theconversation.com/the-cosplay-economy-how-dressing-up-grew-up-86575 (accessed 12 September 2019).

6 Examples of cosplay culture facilitated by World Book Day can be found here: https://bookaid.org/support-us/world-book-day/world-book-day-dress-up/ (accessed 20 February 2020).

7 https://www.readacrossamerica.org/about-read-across-america/ (accessed 13 September 2019).

8 Leslie Kay is the founder and owner of the Tumblr *Disneybound* site and is interviewed in the Huffington Post: https://www.huffingtonpost.co.uk/entry/disneybounding-ideas-for-disney-lovers_n_59e5185ce4b02a215b325a30 (accessed 9 June 2020).

9 Media reports on the revival of drive-ins during the summer of 2020 focus on screenings of 'nostalgic' films from the 1970s and 1980s such as *Grease* and *Back to the Future*, and on audiences dressing up: https://www.itv.com/news/utv/2020-06-03/drive-in-cinema-raises-funds-for-covid-19-research/ (accessed 9 June 2020); https://www.tatler.com/article/drive-in-cinemas-open-up (accessed 24 June 2020). See also report on drive-in cinema for *The One Show*, broadcast on BBC1 23 June 2020, https://www.bbc.co.uk/iplayer/episode/m000kc1v/the-one-show-23062020 15.10-19.25 (accessed 24 June 2020).

10 This generational behaviour is discussed at length in the following reports: Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf, Eventbrite's 'The Experience Movement: Research Report' on 'How Millennials are Bridging Cultural & Political Divides Offline' (2017) found at: https://www.eventbrite.com/l/millennialsreport-2017/ and Big Red Group's 'The "Experience Economy": Riding a Rise Tide' (2019), found at: https://www.thebigredgroup.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/The-Experience-Economy-Riding-a-rising-tide-white-paper-by-the-Big-Red-Group.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).

11 Examples of this reductive way of analysing millennial culture can be found here: https://www.dailymail.co.uk/sciencetech/article-7033111/Millennials-Gen-Z-really-snowflakes.html; https://www.telegraph.co.uk/women/womens-life/11265022/Selfie-obsession-are-we-the-most-narcissistic-generation-ever.html (accessed 13 February 2020).

12 An explanation of the origin of this meme can be found here: https://www.motionpictures.org/2013/12/meeting-of-the-memes-j-r-r-tolkiens-21st-century-film-fandom/ (accessed 19 September 2019).

13 For examples of this public discourse, see 'The Patreon Problem: Is Cosplay Becoming Overly Sexualised?' found at: http://www.themagicrain.com/2017/08/the-patreon-problem-is-cosplay-becoming-overly-sexualized/ or Benjamin Verheiden's article 'Cosplay: The New Front Line on Sexual Objectification' found at: https://sundial.csun.edu/149996/opinions/cosplay-the-new-front-line-on-sexual-objectification/ (accessed 26 September 2020).

14 Professional cosplay is discussed in the Hustle article 'Meet the Girls Making a Living from Cosplay' found at: https://thehustle.co/meet-the-girls-making-a-living-from-cosplay (accessed 14 September 2020).

15 A low day rate for appearances at conventions is $75 to $300, but 'top cosplayers' can earn between $50,000 and $100,000 for appearances, and additionally charge $10,000–20,000 for extra modelling jobs, according to *The Hustle*: https://thehustle.co/meet-the-girls-making-a-living-from-cosplay (accessed 14 September 2020).

16 See, for example, https://www.costumecollection.com.au/blog/when-cosplay-is-too-sexual/ (accessed 12 September 2019).

17 https://www.mic.com/articles/185079/how-the-cosplay-is-not-consent-movement-changed-new-york-comic-con (accessed 12 September 2019).

Conclusions

The experiential turn in cinema

This first chapter of this book began by observing that the temporally limited character of film exhibition lends itself well to the ephemeral spaces of pop-up culture. The worldwide closure of cinemas and prohibition of public gatherings in response to the global pandemic declared in early 2020 not only underscore this impermanence but also invite a reconsideration of the established thinking underpinning many of the case studies investigated in this book. Pop-up cinema culture, frequently predicated on social interaction, has swiftly been reconfigured within virtual spaces or, more notably, as the drive-in experience.[1] The 'austerity urbanism' (Peck 2012) which partly facilitated pop-up culture has now been superseded by a pandemic-driven recession.[2] The accepted wisdom that fixed auditorium seating constitutes the conventional norm for cinema exhibition has, unthinkably, been upturned and replaced by a renewed interest in non-theatrical screenings.[3] The nascent culture of virtual cinema has been transformed overnight into the 'new normal' and catapulted from the margins of the cultural industries to their epicentre.[4] Concepts of liveness have radically shifted and formed new hierarchies of value within many virtual spaces, where synchronous streamed events have acquired an elevated status and can command higher ticket prices than mere recordings of live events.[5] Like many other film festivals, Scalarama has gone online, while the Scala cinema in Bangkok announced it would permanently close its doors in July 2020 'due to financial losses during the pandemic'.[6] There will doubtless be many other developments in relation to these case studies that will emerge in the coming months and years. Yet despite these seismic (if temporary) shifts in established industry norms, what both mainstream and experiential film industries now share is a significant economic threat to their survival. This historical study of immersive cinema culture between 2014 and 2019 therefore highlights a number of significant characteristics within the experiential sector that acquire a new resonance and potential for the (post-)pandemic film industry.

The five-year period analysed in this study coincided with a marked upturn in conventional cinema attendance in the pre-pandemic global north. In the UK, the annual box office admissions for 2018 were 177 million, the highest they had been since 1971, while in the US attendance was up 7.4 per cent with 1.3 billion tickets sold.[7] While it is often perceived that aspects of the entertainment sector compete with each other for business, this is not necessarily the case, and a thriving box office can also be indicative of good overall health across the exhibition sector.[8] A 2015 report on the rise of event cinema in the UK concluded that there was no evidence to imply that growth in this sector would diminish the returns of regular cinema exhibition.[9] Instead, it surmised that 'for some, event cinema is considered a new art form in itself: an alternative way to experience performances that complements the original art form rather than competes with it. There is no evidence to suggest that film or theatre audiences are being displaced by event cinema.'[10] Although this report focuses primarily on live-streamed events rather than immersive cinema, it indicates a sustained audience demand for one-off or bespoke performances or screenings to supplement regular viewing habits in the pre-pandemic era. Indeed, the partnership between Secret Cinema and Disney announced in January 2020 kindled speculation that studios were 'increasingly interested in signing deals with immersive cinema outlets as they look to draw additional revenue from old films, and the general consensus is that both the immersive media industry and the broader experience economy will continue to expand'.[11] The experiential turn in the exhibition therefore flourished in tandem with an equally buoyant box office for the established industry; these two are not mutually exclusive and in the (post-) pandemic context are becoming increasingly harder to differentiate. Knowledge of the emergent characteristics of this experiential turn is therefore central to understanding how these intersecting industries might evolve in the near future.

The audience experience

The concept of liveness is central to this study, but what does it mean to the audiences, users and practitioners interviewed for this book? A 2015 BFI report suggested while audiences continue to equate liveness with theatre, that in relation to cinema-going it is 'associated more with having a shared experience with other audience members'.[12] While this study expands on the findings of this report rather than upturning them, it also complicates the basic premise of

the BFI report by investigating liveness in relation to events that blur the long-standing divide between theatre and cinema; through investigating a culture that frequently fuses two or more art forms, this book troubles the basic assumptions about what constitutes the different sectors of the creative industries.

In Chapters 1 and 4, interviewees' experiences of pop-up cinema indicated that, for them, liveness involved *attending a special event*, usually as a social activity and as opposed to 'staying in'. Audience responses to Christian Marclay's *The Clock*, a mediatized art installation that can only be experienced by 'going out' to a specific gallery space further reinforces this conception of liveness. The implication of these responses is that themed or bespoke cinema experiences constitute a live event or special outing that is comparable to theatre-going and that Auslander's distinction between these two 'competing' forms of entertainment (Auslander 2008: 6) is now clearly redundant. While the development of theatre streamed live to the cinema complicates this distinction, the lockdown culture of theatre streamed live to home entertainment devices has troubled it even further, and clearly calls for further research.

In VR experiences, liveness or simultaneity also manifests as presence, the sense of being actually present in the virtual world; VR, AR and MR experiences are thus assessed by participants in terms of how vividly and convincingly they are able to accomplish this. The emphasis on simultaneity is also evident in online forms of cosplay culture and social media interactions that are synchronous with live events; this synchronicity of live interaction across multiple media platforms offers a heightened experience for many of the cosplayers interviewed. Some cosplay practice also illustrates a live interpretation of mediatized performances, revealing the multi-layered negotiation of the live/mediatized divide that characterizes many contemporary media cultures.

Liveness in the era of social media, VR and synchronous streamed events therefore becomes a multifaceted, highly differentiated concept. Live, in the context of a media event or programme, no longer simply means synchronous and can potentially refer to a live recording, a streamed event or a repackaged text with live paratexts, to list a few variants.

While the experience of 'liveness' or simultaneity is central to audience evaluations of immersive media, this study indicates that it is frequently articulated as a form of social interactivity or sense of connectedness. Although the impressive, big-budget sets of Secret Cinema Presents productions feature in some interviewees' responses, these are invariably framed within a discussion of the social interactions they encountered while engaging with these sets. Seventy-

eight per cent of the interviewees associate the social dimension of immersive cinema-going as the characteristic they most frequently discuss in the context of the 'live' experience. In this way, experiential events offer an alternative form of social media that could be described as 'sociable media'. This is often articulated in terms of attending events with family members or close friends, and many of these events, particularly in the community sector, facilitate cross-generational interaction.

While the commercial end of the pop-up market attracts a younger audience profile than the non-profit end, there is a striking similarity in the way audiences value the sociability and communal aspects of events at both ends of the economic spectrum. This pattern of response extends to include descriptions of VR experiences, attendance of exhibitions in art galleries and cosplay practice.

Finally, many of the discussions around experiential cinema also articulate heightened emotional responses. While a degree of excitement is perhaps not surprising at a one-off or unusual event, an element of these affective responses responds to manufactured signifiers of nostalgia. In many of the experiences, this is partly embedded within the text but can also be provoked by responses to seasonal signifiers and other prompts associated with childhood or adolescence. A further aspect of this nostalgia is sustained fandom for a film or franchise like *Star Wars* or *Harry Potter*. These six sites of audience engagement reveal that fan cultures play a significant role in this sector, whether through the practice of repeat viewing (facilitated by pop-up culture), the fan tourism evidenced through Picnic Cinema's staging of *Withnail and I* or the fandom for particular fictional characters integral to the embodied practices of cosplay and crossplay.

The discursively constructed experience

One of the primary objectives of this study was to identify and analyse how the concept of an 'experience' is being discursively constructed and circulated in the wider contexts surrounding developments in the exhibition sector. This was undertaken through an analysis of marketing materials, film industry reports, online reviews, lifestyle blogs, cultural policy documents, marketing reports and manifestos within the non-profit sector. Through analysis of these materials across the six sites investigated in this book, a complex and multilayered understanding of how these discursively constructed notions of 'experience' intersect and circulate within the screen experience economy emerges.

A key discursive framework emerging from this analysis centres on the notion of 'memory-making'. This discourse is apparent in the design of commercial immersive experiences, such as those operated by Secret Cinema Presents or Backyard Cinema's *Snowman Experience*, where photographers are available to 'capture the moment' for customers, thereby accentuating the unique nature of the experience. These photographic opportunities are heavily monetized and frequently themed; at *The Snowman Experience*, for example, a photographer captures the participant in a flying pose, fully immersed in Raymond Briggs's much-loved fictional world. Surveys and literature produced by marketing analysts also clearly articulate this discourse. Marketing gurus Big Red Group advise that 'living a meaningful, happy life is about creating, sharing and capturing memories earned through experiences that span the spectrum of life's opportunities', and that 'experiences are better when shared on social media'.[13] As discussed in Chapter 1, these marketing analysts unequivocally associate experiences with memories, offering advice on how best to capitalize on this market trend. The memory-making discourse is also apparent on alternative lifestyle websites which encourage ethically minded consumers to give 'experiences' as gifts, as exemplified by concepts such as 'the Hierarchy of Giving'. This consumer guide, published by the ethical consumer website *Just Little Changes*,[14] advises visitors to 'give memories' as presents (which in practical terms translates as event tickets, experience days and memberships). Here, the emphasis is again on one-off, bespoke and unique experiences having greater value than the acquisition of tangible objects.

Some of the marketing materials for the individual case studies similarly echo the notion of prioritizing experiences over tangible objects, and of 'living in the moment'. The promotional tagline for The Void, for example, declares, 'You don't just experience The VOID, you're in it',[15] thus drawing on concepts of presence that are integral to analyses of VR. One primary way in which the concept of 'experience' is discursively constructed and promoted, this book argues, is as a 'living in the moment', or 'seize the day' philosophy. This discourse of valuing lived encounters over material objects and of living in the moment is also implicit in Christian Marclay's philosophical explanation of *The Clock* 'as a giant *memento mori*', albeit in the form of a slightly morbid perspective on this discursive construct.[16] This *carpe diem* philosophy foregrounds the idea that every moment of life is precious and is therefore not to be squandered on experiences that lack any intrinsic quality.

Linked to the concept of memory-making, a second discernible discourse present in the marketing materials for commercial pop-up events revolves around the notion of adventure. Secret Cinema promises a world of 'encounters, adventures and discoveries', while Backyard Cinema's use of the Narnia trope of walking through a wardrobe implores you to 'set off on your own adventure!' and 'find a world full of mystery'.[17] This marketing discourse invokes a pioneering ethos, evocative of a nostalgic 'age of discovery'. It is present to a lesser degree in Picnic Cinema's online promotional material, which highlights travelling to 'castles, forests and extraordinary locations' and uses adjectives like 'capers' and 'shenanigans' to evoke a high-spirited sense of adventure.[18] The pioneering discourse is enhanced by the textual qualities of many of the films frequently screened at experiential film events, in which distinctive settings become demediatized and transformed into tangible spaces. In this context, an anti-digital, nostalgic world view characterized by discourses around unplugging (Rauch 2014; Brennen 2019) is aligned with a swashbuckling, pre-digital landscape of forests and castles, beckoning to be explored.

A third and quite specific discursive construct that repeats itself within this study is the association of unique experiences with annual festivals or celebrations, such as Christmas; indeed, Christmas is employed as a shorthand for a special, unique or quality event in several case studies. Backyard Cinema trades on this most directly, drawing on the Narnia trope of 'pushing through the wardrobe' to 'explore the enchanted forest', and promising a 'winter wonderland' where visitors 'navigate the Christmas labyrinth'.[19] Other pop-up cinemas screening Christmas films also draw on similar marketing strategies. While this discourse is highly visible within the commercial sector, it is also present in the non-profit sector. Michael Pierce, founder of Scalarama, invokes Christmas in a similar way when he communicates the specialness of the festival by explaining, 'I want it to be like Christmas for cinemas, in that no one starts Christmas (although everyone tries to start it earlier each year), it just happens, and towns know they're going to spend money on Christmas lights because it's connected to the coming winter.'[20] Although the analogy is partly being used to suggest a form of ritual, it is notable in that it also invokes a sense of celebration and specialness. What is interesting to observe, though, is that these three discursive frameworks around the concept of an 'experience' cut across both the commercial and non-profit exhibitions sectors in the case studies analysed in this book, revealing the way that this discourse has been co-opted and repurposed to support non-profit initiatives.

Locating the experience economy

Analysis of these six key sites of audience engagement within the immersive sector reveals the diverse ways in which the experience economy has been mobilized and adapted by different cultural stakeholders. Most significant to this study is the growth of the millennial experience economy. Identified both by market analysts and cultural commentators, including their own peers, the millennial generation valourize and partake in immersive experiences to a greater degree than older generations do. The primary data collected for this study, though limited in its scope, suggests that sharing live experiences online heightens the appeal of immersive experiences for millennials, but does not entirely replace it. Most of the interviewees discussed posting photos of their experiences on social media platforms, and in the case of the cosplayers, this constituted a fundamental dimension of their practice. The desire to be involved in communal gatherings was also a strong driver, thus confirming the findings of the 2016 Harris Report which concluded that nearly 69 per cent of this generation experience FOMO (fear of missing out).[21]

The twelve case studies also illustrate how economic infrastructures shape and influence audience experiences of cinematic events.[22] While the pop-up cinema sector is thriving in the UK, both primary and secondary data indicate that it generates the highest level of discussion around value for money among audiences. The neoliberal economic climate can be understood to facilitate the pop-up sector in several ways, through the interstitial urban spaces it offers to exhibitors, in producing the economic climate of short-termism that favours entrepreneurial business models, and in the positioning of audiences as consumers. Not surprisingly, it is at high-end ticketed events that audiences become most cynical about 'experiences' being marketed to them. These responses become intensified in relation to overpriced consumables sold in and around pop-up exhibition sites (Atkinson and Kennedy 2016; Pett 2019). By situating audiences as gullible or cynical consumers, they are more likely to focus on these economic constraints rather than the experiential dimensions of the event. However, significant variants of the experience economy offer another perspective on this scenario. While the experience economy is flourishing across the global north, fuelled by discourses encouraging people to 'make memories' and 'live in the moment', a counter experience economy has co-opted the rhetoric around 'experiences' and repurposed it to support activist non-profit exhibitors.

This development, which I call the alternative experience economy, is modelled around a non-profit, communal model of exhibition. Scalarama, discussed in Chapter 5, functions as a collective of inclusive, independent cinephile film exhibitors, often championing a marginalized community, who function outside of the mainstream exhibition circuit. A parallel exhibition culture located at Scala cinema in Bangkok has also hosted participatory, cinephile events and, like many independent art-house exhibitors in Thailand, was aligned to an agenda that opposed state censorship of cinema, via the Free Thai Cinema Movement. This alternative experience economy is therefore characterized by a film exhibition culture that celebrates and supports contemporary forms of political engagement through a community network.

Immersive media and cultural policy

Cultural policy has been instrumental in facilitating and shaping the emergence of immersive and participatory forms of cinema in the global north. First, in terms of the significant government investment made in developing immersive technologies, and the way this has forged new collaborative partnerships between the industry and the academy. In the UK, this became apparent in the *Independent Review of the Creative Industries* (2017), which placed a specific emphasis on the development of immersive and augmented media industries and outlined key recommendations as to how the creative industries should underpin the UK's future economic growth. Central to this vision was the recommendation to develop creative clusters, which facilitated a funding call by the UK Research Councils in 2017/18 with the purpose of allocating £80 million across nine creative clusters in the UK.[23] Public funding for the UK's 'immersive economy', detailed in a 2018 Innovate UK report, 'was 9 times higher in 2016–2017 than in 2009–2010. 3 in 10 immersive specialists benefited from tax incentives in the last 12 months, and 2 in 10 received some sort of national grant'.[24] This manifested in the form of 253 immersive technology projects worth a total of £160 million in UK Research Councils, Innovate UK and EU Horizon 2020 open datasets.

These findings are also significant in relation to discussions around cultural policy. The analysis of available sources of funding for community cinemas in the UK presented in Chapter 4 reveals the extent to which cultural policies have shaped this sector and its intersection with the heritage economy. Grassroots

cinemas have survived at the whim of cultural policymakers, while initiatives such as the BFI's *Britain on Film* have facilitated a heritage-orientated form of pop-up cinema drawn from archival materials. The shift in policy strategy away from sustaining regular community cinema projects and towards the intersection of cinema with tourism and the heritage economy suggests an increasingly neoliberal approach to the funding of this sector. Hadley and Belfiore (2018) argue that the failure to democratize culture comes not so much from a lack of will or the disappearance of cultural democracy, but instead, the issues lie with

> the failure of a mode of implementation, which has variously resulted in a resource-draining physical infrastructure, vested interest (Jancovich 2015), the rise of managerialism and econometrics and a disposition towards hyperinstrumentalism (Hadley and Gray 2017). The question then arises as to both if, and how, cultural policy scholars, arts managers and practitioners should find ways to act upon both the historical base and the potential futures of cultural democracy. (Hadley and Belfiore 2018: 221)

While this diagnosis is persuasive, it overlooks one aspect of cultural participation, namely the participants themselves and their frequently neoliberal inclinations. This is illustrated in Chapters 1, 3 and 6 of this book, in which instances of neoliberal entrepreneurialism, alongside a privileged sense of entitlement to high quality experiences, position exhibitors, performers and patrons within an individualistic neoliberal economic framework, wherein the key priority is their own personal betterment or economic prosperity.

Technological innovations and constraints

Technology both enables and constrains the experiences analysed across the six sites of audience engagement. The reductive binary of live/mediatized performances is revealed to be inadequate as a structuring mechanism for thinking about these experiences. Not only are performances (such as those enacted by cosplayers) mediatized, but they are also, in many instances demediatized and translated into live performance, in the context of Secret Cinema re-enactments. Additionally, many aspects of both live and mediatized performance are remediatized via circulation on social media, thus complicating the situation further. Discourses circulating around demediatization highlight the culture of unplugging (Rauch 2014) advocated by several entrepreneurs as a

way of marketing their organizations; these expose the way experiential cinema is frequently positioned as a cultural alternative to 'staying in'.

Rapid developments in virtual technologies establish the potential for storytelling this sector holds. The qualitative analyses offered on three virtual experiences upend spurious notions about VR as an 'empathy machine' and reveal the creativity in commercial enterprises such as The Void that enable participatory forms of virtual experience. These developments in virtual technologies also form the next stage in the quest to create an illusion of an all-encompassing cinematic space, following on from 3-D and the debates it generated (Grau 2003; Sandifer 2011; Klinger 2011). While the issues identified by Sandifer around conspicuous spectatorship persist in the body-apparatus debate, the evidence presented in Chapter 2 suggests that these are being superseded by increasingly sophisticated technologies around virtual storytelling.

Sites for further research

In selecting six key sites for researching experiential cinema, there are significant areas of audience activity and engagement that have been overlooked. A primary area of activity that overlaps with the study of immersive cinema and is deserving of further research is immersive television. This area offers significant avenues of enquiry, both in terms of interactive television shows such as *Black Mirror: Bandersnatch* and in the development of immersive events such as Secret Cinema's *Stranger Things*. With specialist pop-up screenings of shows such as *Friends* becoming increasingly common, and the emergence of festivals dedicated to popular series such as *Peaky Blinders*, this is an area of investigation which would benefit from further scholarly attention in addition to the excellent recent study by Annette Hill (2020).[25] As already noted, the intersection between television and other home media with theatre and cinema during the 2020 lockdown clearly invites further research, already visible in the publication of work considering the renaissance of television in the era of COVID-19 (Hermes and Hill 2020).

Another significant area that merits greater scholarly consideration is the employment of the term 'experience economy' within cultural policy documents. As Sofie Birch identifies in her 2008 study, the terms 'experience economy' and 'creative industries' are frequently used in similar contexts within

cultural policy documents across a range of different national contexts (Birch 2008). While there exist numerous academic studies of the conception and use of the term 'creative industries' within cultural policy documents (Belfiore 2002, 2012; Garnham 2006; Hadley and Belfiore 2018; Hesmondhalgh, Oakley and Lee 2015), there are relatively few parallel studies on the experience economy, Birch's study offering a notable exception.[26]

A number of other approaches to the subject matter did not receive as much attention as I would have liked. While I have attempted to include a range of case studies from the global north and south, it did not always prove to be straightforward in terms of gathering the data. The inclusion of the Taiwanese CVR film *The Deserted* in Chapter 2 and the case study on Scala cinema in Bangkok in Chapter 5 partly ameliorates this situation; however, future projects on this subject will attempt to shift the focus much more overtly to the global south, which is under-represented in scholarship on this subject. It was comparatively easier to collect data from North America and Canada for Chapters 2 and 6, and a significant number of responses to the survey conducted for Chapter 3 were international, even though the exhibition context was British. That said, the empirical data is clearly skewed to a UK perspective, partly for the reason that it was easier to gather the data and the research was not funded. A secondary point regarding this geographical bias in the data set is that there is currently minimal evidence of an experiential cinema sector in the global south. While this might be due to a lack of awareness or sources, it is also possible that, in the historical period discussed in this book, experiential cinema was predominantly a phenomenon within the more affluent societies of the global north. Whether or not this continues to be the case within a post-pandemic cultural context remains to be seen.

As the media industries attempt to recover from the impact of the COVID-19 pandemic, the potential for further research in relation to the material analysed within this book points in multiple directions. What the six sites of experiential culture investigated here share is a propensity to innovate and adapt established media formats, whether it be through combining theatrical and cinematic conventions, moving beyond established exhibition spaces or experimenting with live and mediatized forms of artistic expression. Surprisingly, the findings highlight more commonalities across the commercial, independent and grassroots sectors than I had anticipated at the outset. Rather than framing this study as another 'death of cinema' moment, what I hope this book achieves is an appraisal and evaluation of a brief epoch in the history of film exhibition

that once again demonstrates the industry's imaginative ability to reinvent itself. While rooted in historical precedents, this contemporary study of the experiential turn in cinema puts the expectations, pleasures and frustrations of the audience centre stage. In doing so, it highlights the coexistence of the well-established pleasures of cinema-going with an unrelenting desire for exceptional, alternative or unique 'experiences'.

Notes

1 In April 2020 Secret Cinema launched Secret Sofa, an online film club that encouraged dressing up and holding themed screenings at home: https://www.secretcinema.org/secret-sofa (accessed 25 May 2020); Luna Cinema and other pop-up exhibitors launched a series of drive-in screenings in the summer of 2020: https://www.lunadriveincinema.com/ (accessed 25 May 2020); https://www.indiewire.com/2020/05/drive-ins-theaters-box-office-future-1202232241/ (accessed 25 May 2020).

2 https://www.imf.org/en/Publications/WP/Issues/2020/06/19/The-Distributional-Impact-of-Recessions-the-Global-Financial-Crisis-and-the-Pandemic-49492 (accessed 20 June 2020).

3 Report on outdoor screenings in Europe: https://www.theguardian.com/world/2020/may/29/demand-is-huge-eu-citizens-flock-to-open-air-cinemas-as-lockdown-eases (accessed 2 June 2020).

4 https://www.mesalliance.org/2020/05/11/vr-ar-seeing-resurgent-interest-during-covid-19/ (accessed 25 May 2020).

5 The Old Vic theatre in London announced it would be live streaming a socially distanced reworking of *Lungs* in the summer of 2020 and pricing tickets the same way as the normal auditorium: https://www.oldvictheatre.com/whats-on/2020/lungs-in-camera (accessed 16 June 2020).

6 https://matchboxcineclub.com/2020/04/12/scalarama-2020-taking-things-online/; https://thailand-construction.com/bangkoks-historic-scala-cinemas-51-year-run-said-to-end/ (accessed 2 June 2020).

7 Figures taken from https://www.theguardian.com/film/2019/jan/22/uk-cinemas-buck-netflix-doomsayers-with-best-year-since-1970 (accessed 2 September 2019).

8 This is discussed, for example, by interviewee #11.

9 'Understanding the Impact of Event Cinema: An Evidence Review' (2015) found at: https://www.bfi.org.uk/sites/bfi.org.uk/files/downloads/bfi-understanding-impact-event-cinema-evidence- review-2015.pdf (accessed 2 September 2019).

10 Ibid.

11 Deal between Secret Cinema and Disney discussed at https://www.cityam.com/secret-cinema-signs-deal-with-disney-for-immersive-film-productions/; Growth predictions for the immersive media industry found at https://www.immerseuk.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/11/The-Immersive-economy-in-the-UK-2019_Report-2-1.pdf (accessed 16 February 2020).
12 'Understanding the Impact of Event Cinema: An Evidence Review' (2015) found at: https://www.bfi.org.uk/sites/bfi.org.uk/files/downloads/bfi-understanding-impact-event-cinema-evidence-review-2015.pdf (accessed 2 September 2019).
13 Taken from the Big Red Group's 'The "Experience Economy": Riding a Rise Tide' (2019) found at: https://www.thebigredgroup.com.au/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/The-Experience-Economy-Riding-a-rising-tide-white-paper-by-the-Big-Red-Group.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).
14 Found at https://justlittlechanges.com/2018/11/the-hierarchy-of-giving/ (accessed 16 December 2018).
15 https://www.thevoid.com/ (accessed 17 July 2019).
16 Interviews with Marclay discussed *The Clock* as a memento mori can be found at: https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/world-europe-11692234; https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2012/03/12/the-hours-daniel-zalewski (accessed 12 April 2019).
17 See https://www.secretcinema.org/history and https://www.backyardcinema.co.uk/winter-night-garden/ (accessed 17 July 2019).
18 https://tickets.tygit.com/shop/groups (accessed 2 September 2019).
19 https://www.backyardcinema.co.uk/ (accessed 2 September 2019).
20 Interview with Michael Pierce by Emma Pett on 15 August 2018, at the University of East Anglia.
21 Statistics taken from Eventbrite's 'Millennials: Fuelling the Experience Economy' (2016) p. 5, found at: https://eventbrite-s3.s3.amazonaws.com/marketing/Millennials_Research/Gen_PR_Final.pdf (accessed 12 February 2020).
22 These are Secret Cinema, the pop-up film sector, Backyard Cinema's The Snowman Experience, The Void's *Secrets of the Empire*, *The Deserted* (Tsai Ming-liang, 2019), *Draw Me Close* (Jordan Tannahill, 2017), *The Clock* (Christian Marclay), the rural pop-up sector, Picnic Cinema, Scalarama, Scala (Bangkok), and cosplay culture.
23 These were selected from a shortlist of twenty-two and announced here: https://ahrc.ukri.org/newsevents/news/r-d-investment-set-to-provide-step-up-for-creative-industries/#ref1 (accessed 16 September 2019).
24 Data taken from Innovate UK report 'The Immersive Economy in the UK: The Growth of Virtual, Augmented and Mixed Reality Technologies' found at: https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/708879/ 18.1137.020_Immersive_Technologies_web_enabled_PDF_lowres.pdf (accessed 22 February 2020).

25 Information taken from *The Guardian* article 'Boom for Experience Economy as Hit TV Shows Enter Real World' by Mark Sweney, found at: https://www.theguardian.com/business/2019/sep/29/experience-economy-peaky-blinders-friends-stranger-thing (accessed 22 February 2020).

26 *The Experience Society: Consumer Capitalism* Rebooted (Steven Miles, forthcoming) may well address some of these issues.

Appendices

Appendix 1: The characteristics of the interview dataset

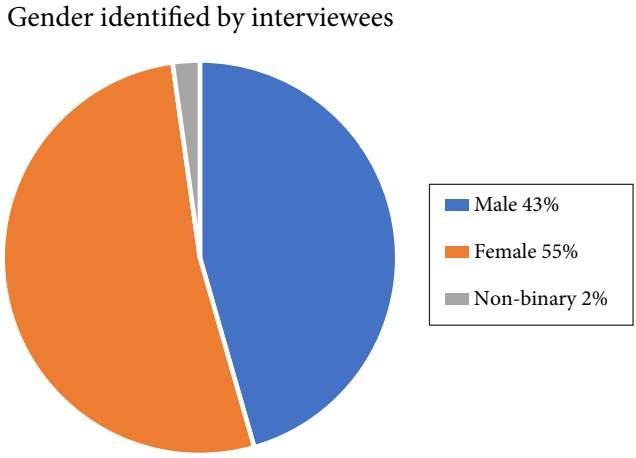


Figure 1 Gender identified by interviewees.

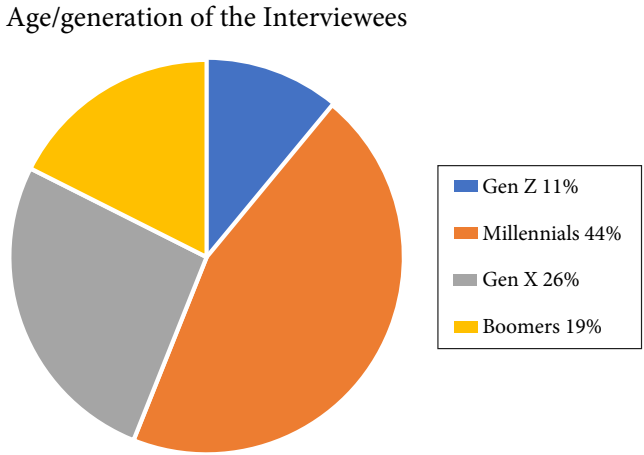


Figure 2 Age/generation of the interviewees at the time of the study.

Key

Generation Z: Born between 1997 and 2012, aged up to 22
Millennials: Born between 1981 and 1996, aged 23 to 38
Generation X: Born between 1965 and 1980, aged 39 to 54
Baby Boomers: Born between 1946 and 1964, aged 55 to mid-70s

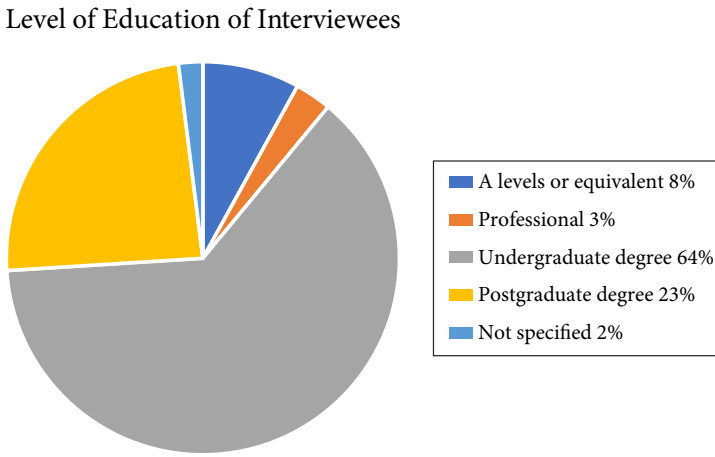


Figure 3 Level of education of interviewees

Appendix 2: Pop-up cinema question schedule

(used to collect qualitative data for Chapters 1, 3, 4 and 5)

1. Which pop-up, temporary or non-theatrical cinema events have you attended, and how did you find out about them?
2. Did you attend the event(s) on your own, or with family/friends? Can you say a bit more about this aspect of the event and what it meant to you?
3. Did you encounter any promotional materials for the event(s)? If so, what kind of response did you have to them?
4. How would you describe your experience of attending a pop-up event?
5. Did you think the event you attended was 'live', and if so, in what way(s)?
6. What did you think about the set and the overall staging of the event? Were there particular elements of it that you did or didn't appreciate? Which aspects did you enjoy the most?

7. Overall, what was the most enjoyable part of the event for you? Can you describe what you enjoyed about it, and how this was different or similar to other immersive events you have attended?

Appendix 3: VR interview question schedule

1. Can you say a bit about which VR experiences you have tried, and how you found out about them?
2. How much time did you spend during the VR experience thinking about the technology rather than the story?
3. Did you attend the experience on your own or as part of a group? Do you think that made any difference to your experience?
4. What do you recall most clearly about the whole VR experience – was there one stand-out moment?
5. If you could change one aspect of the VR experience, what would it be?
6. How would you compare your VR experience in relation to conventional Hollywood films?

Appendix 4: Survey of responses to Christian Marclay's *The Clock*

1. Have you seen parts of *The Clock* before, either at Tate Modern or at another gallery?
   □ Yes □ No
   If yes, how many times? At Tate Modern: _____ At other galleries**:** _____
2. How regularly do you visit art exhibitions, either at Tate Modern or at other art galleries?
   □ Very frequently/weekly □ A few times a month □ A few times a year
   □ Very rarely □ This is my first visit □ Never, I'm only visiting to see *The Clock*
3. How regularly do you go to the cinema?
   □ Very frequently/weekly □ A few times a month □ A few times a year
   □ Very rarely □ Never
4. How long (approximately) did you watch *The Clock* for on this visit?
   □ Under 10 minutes □ 10-30 minutes □ 30 minutes-1 hour □ 1-2 hours
   □ 2-5 hours □ 5-10 hours □ 10-15 hours □ 15-23 hours □ 24 hours

5. How long (approximately) have you watched *The Clock* for in total? (if more than one visit)
   □ Under 10 minutes □ 10-30 minutes □ 30 minutes-1 hour □ 1-2 hours □ 2-5 hours □ 5-10 □ 10-15 hours □ 15-23 hours □ 24 hours
6. Is there a sequence in the film that you find particularly enjoyable, meaningful or memorable? If so, can you explain which sequence it is, and why?
7. How important or enjoyable was it for you to try and identify the individual film clips?
8. Christian Marclay has said that "*The Clock* is very much about death, in a way, it is a *memento mori*." Does this reflect your experience of watching *The Clock*, or does the film have a different meaning for you?
9. How old are you?
   □ Under 16 □ 16-25 □ 26-35 □ 36-45 □ 46-55 □ 56-65 □ Over 66
10. What gender are you?
11. What is your highest educational qualification?
    □ O Level/GCSE □ A Level □ BTEC □ NVQ □ UG degree □ PG degree □ N/A
12. Is there anything else you would like to say about your experience of watching *The Clock* that you have not already discussed?

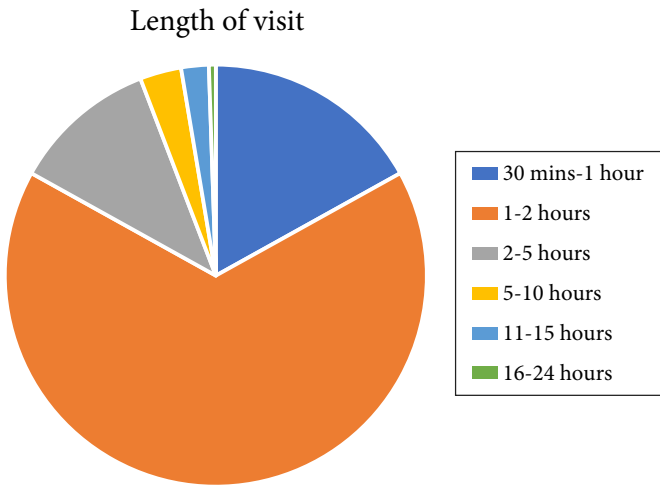


Figure 4 Responses to Q4

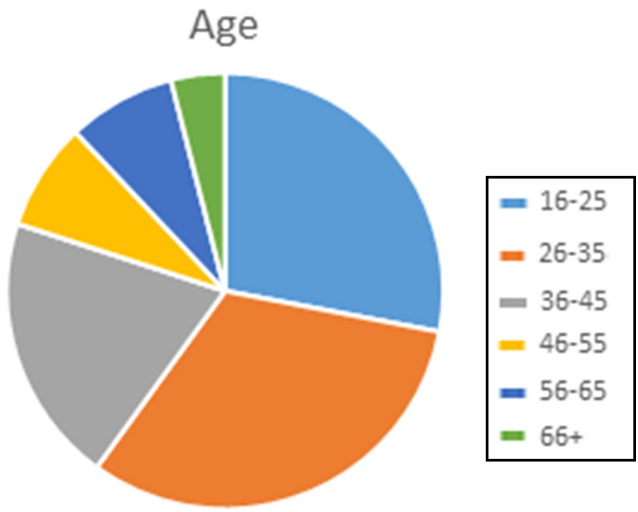


Figure 5 Responses to Q9

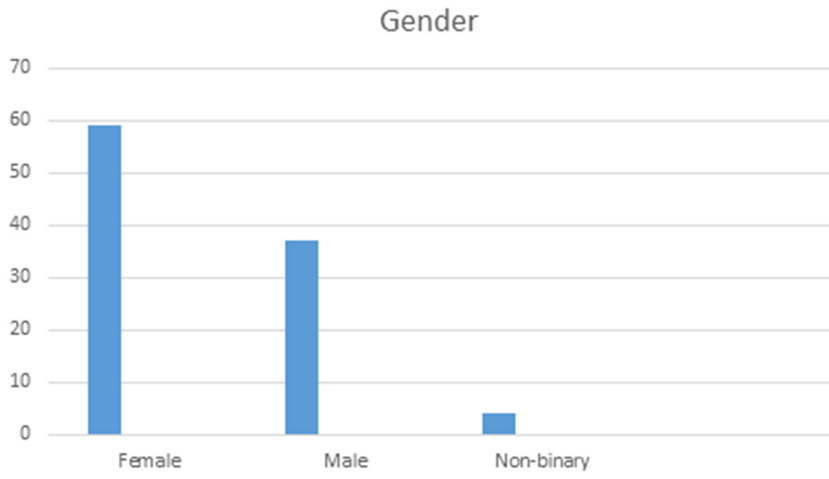


Figure 6 Responses to Q10

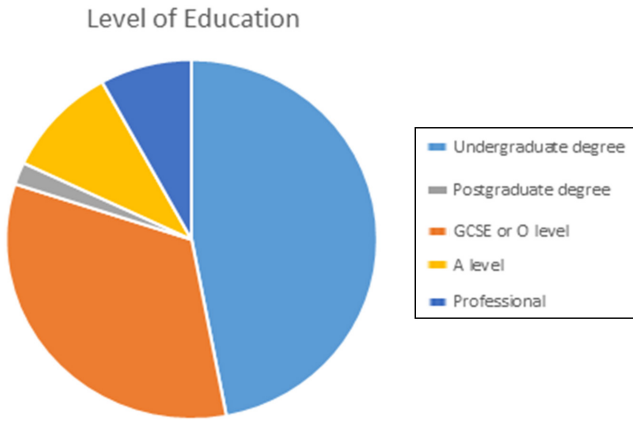


Figure 7 Responses to Q11

Appendix 5: Cos/crossplay interview questions

1. Can you say (approximately, you can just identify a decade if you like) how old you are, which gender you identify as, where you live and what your occupation is?
2. Can you say a bit about how you got into cosplay and crossplay (did you enjoy dressing up as a child, was there a particular fictional world or character that got you started etc.)?
3. How frequently do you cos/crossplay and where? Public/private, cons, other places. Are you with friends or on your own?
4. How important is social interaction when you are cosplaying? What kinds of social interactions do you have? Is there a big difference between the way you interact with other cosplayers and with non-cosplayers?
5. How important are the costumes? Do you make them yourself? Which are your favourites? Do you mix up any characters (e.g. Snowba Fett)?
6. Can you tell me about the characters you crossplay – how do you experience playing characters of a different gender? How do other people respond to you as the character?
7. Is there anything else about your cosplay or about cosplaying culture more broadly that we haven't discussed yet and you would like to talk about?

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